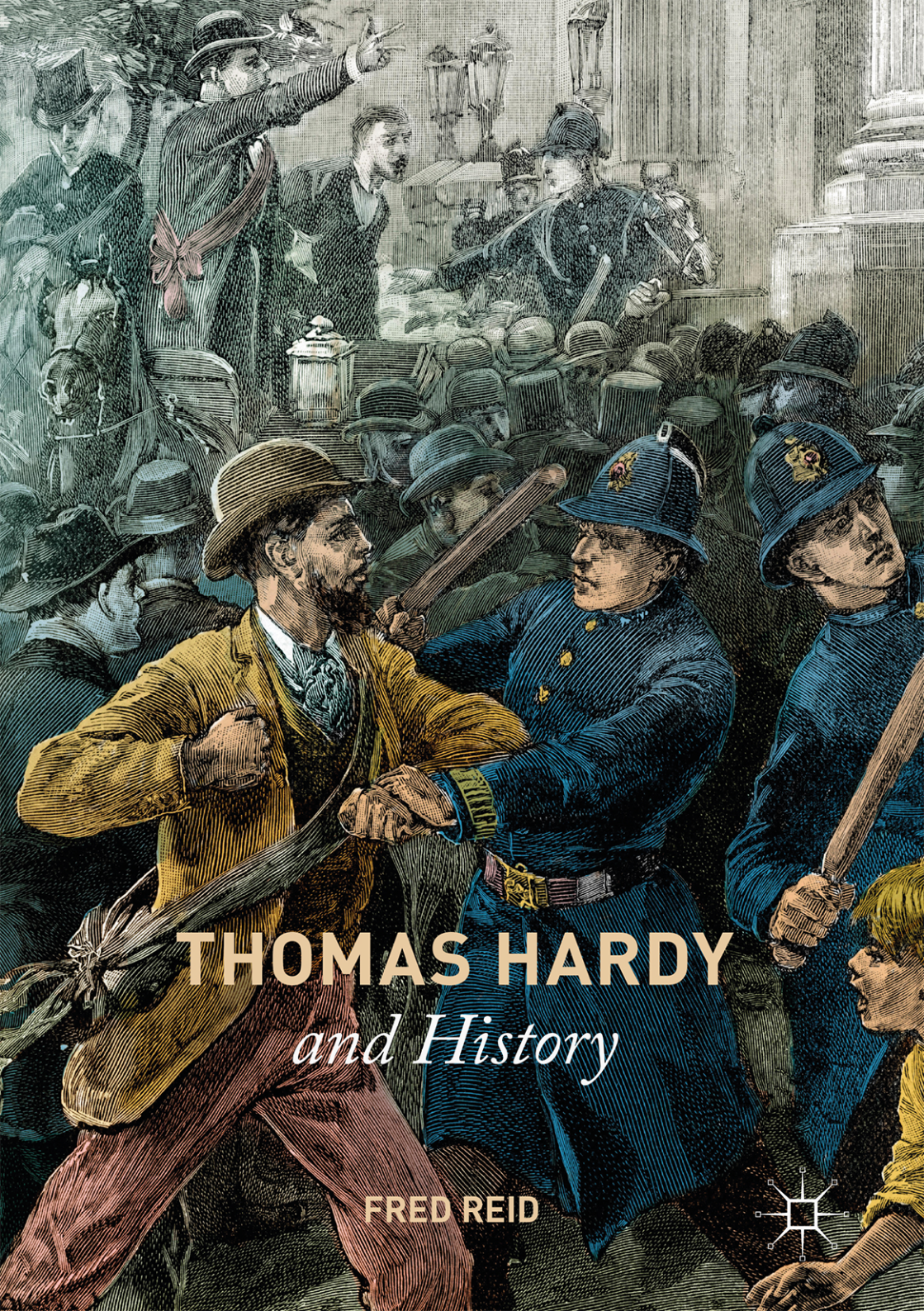




THOMAS HARDY

and History

FRED REID



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For Etta
With love and gratitude

PREFACE

My interest in the relationship of literature to historical inquiry dates from my teenage years. It was crucially stimulated in 1966 by my recruitment to the History School at Warwick University. I then had the privilege of hearing a remarkable series of public lectures given by E. P. Thompson on the 'Romantic' poets in the context of revolutionary Europe after 1789. In that small republic of letters, I was also very fortunate to make the acquaintance of a number of historians and critics committed to this interdisciplinary work. Besides Edward Thompson, I owe a great deal to William and Juliet Dusinberre. Their lifelong friendship and critical example have encouraged me to develop my understanding of what the relationship might be.

The other important stimulus in these Warwick years came from teaching an advanced option, which I was allowed to set up and call 'Problems in History and Literature', with a major focus on Thomas Hardy. I owe a great debt of thanks to the students who collaborated with me in working out the implications of discourse theory for the reading of fictional and historical texts.

In the preparation of this book I have accumulated many other debts, not all of which can be mentioned here. Special thanks must be conveyed, however, to Robin Okey, who has freely shared with me his deep understanding of history and literature during a long and close friendship. In addition, he kindly read the penultimate version of the text and offered many valuable suggestions.

Another long-standing friend from Warwick days, Malcolm Hardman, a distinguished Hardy critic, also made himself accessible for discussion

and helped me, unfailingly and generously, to understand ancient classical quotations and allusions in nineteenth-century fiction.

Particular mention must also be made of the late John Goode of the Warwick English school. While writing his remarkable study, *Thomas Hardy: The Offensive Truth*, he encouraged me to discuss with his students the historical context of Hardy's work and reciprocated by similar participation in my own Hardy course. Though there are parts of this study in which I have felt compelled to disagree with some of his 'revolutionary criticism', that should not obscure the debt I owe him.

Further along the way, Warwick University provided welcome financial assistance with research in the *Dorset County Chronicle*. At a late stage, Phillip Mallett, of St Andrews University and the Thomas Hardy Society, played a crucial part by encouraging me to finish the book and suggested publication outlets, which quickly led to Palgrave Macmillan.

The writings of many other historians and critics have helped me work out the approach taken in this volume and I trust they will all accept my gratitude expressed by the many citations in the endnotes to each chapter. The reading of their works has been one of the chief pleasures of preparing this book.

I am indebted to the staff of several libraries for generous assistance in tracing source materials. Helen Gibson of Dorset County Museum kindly facilitated access to Hardy's annotated copy of Tennyson's 'In Memoriam'. The late Patrick Tolfree, also based at the Museum, read an early draft of my introduction and commented with supportive criticism.

I owe a special debt to the staff of the Country Orders Department of the London Library, who have been untiring in tracing recondite books and articles published in the nineteenth century and beyond. Without their support the book could not have been written.

Any author with a disability must rely on some specialist help. Staff of the British Library and the Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library gave crucial support to access material not available for loan. I must thank four other people for research assistance. Kate Seeley Rahman chased down fugitive articles by Horace Moule. Judith Stinton copied Hardy's annotations to 'In Memoriam'. William Lancaster helped me to search through the *Dorset County Chronicle*. Paul Smith gave indispensable service by correcting the typing and formatting errors in my final text.

I am also indebted to many friends outside academe. The members of Kenilworth Reader Service for the Blind have been indefatigable in enabling access to manuscript and other materials indecipherable by

modern access technology. Robert Jacob was a never-failing source of technical support when my computer went into a sulk, which was very often. It is a pleasure to acknowledge all this help in the confident hope that it will encourage younger blind scholars now struggling with similar difficulties.

Finally, I must thank Ben Doyle, commissioning editor at Palgrave Macmillan, whose support and guidance greatly helped in bringing this volume to completion. In the end, of course, I alone am responsible for any errors or omissions which may remain.

Fred Reid
November 2016

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Introduction: Approaches to Hardy and History

This book is concerned with two deceptively simple questions: what did Thomas Hardy think about history and how does that thinking enter into his fiction? These apparently simple questions require a long and complex answer, which this study will attempt to provide. Here at the outset it is necessary to show how the attempt is related to the radical change in Hardy criticism which began towards the end of the twentieth century. The change was succinctly summarised by Patricia Ingham, herself a distinguished participant in the transition. She observed that Hardy, on his death in 1928, was ‘lionised as the grand old man of literature’ and went on to summarise what this meant: ‘Hardy by now was popularly constructed as the poet of the distinctively English landscape of Wessex and, as a great writer, necessarily the recorder of timeless truths about human nature, giving his works relevance to all periods.’¹ The ensuing generation of literary critics, Ingham went on, was content to produce variations on these themes until the later twentieth century, when they were replaced by ‘a variety of new and disparate approaches’.

Ingham was not concerned directly with Hardy’s ideas about history. Understandably, therefore, she made no reference to the only relevant work by a historian on the topic, Reginald White’s *Thomas Hardy and History*.² The relevance of White’s work to Ingham’s is that it was published on the cusp of change between the two critical generations she described.

White began by observing that Hardy's novels are replete with references to the past life of Wessex, the south-western region of England where he grew up. But he dismissed those realist critics who regarded Hardy as a historian.³ He was not, at least 'not the modern kind of professional historian'. In this White was right. Hardy's fiction does not yield answers to some of the key questions professional historians need to ask about Wessex. They do not tell us, for example, whether the employment of women on threshing machines was increasing or decreasing in the time of *Tess of the d'Urbervilles*. In Hardy's novels we find not the real Wessex, but a ground of imagined history, the representation of the human condition in the totality of past, present and future. As White noted, this was what the nineteenth century knew as 'philosophical history' and its presence in Hardy fiction makes it the work of a 'poet'.⁴

White's work was unfinished at his death and his draft manuscript was published posthumously. It left many questions formulated in ways that seem loose and old-fashioned in light of the transition pointed out by Ingham. Hardy's 'Wessex', for example, was represented as a timeless, unchanging region of England, in which he learned, as he grew up, the 'ancestral wisdom' that pain and suffering were inescapable in the human condition. White, moreover, was vague about the historical discourse to which Hardy's fiction referred, gesturing towards the philosophical radicalism of 'Joseph Arch's England'.⁵ Finally, his view that Hardy was, until his end, committed to hope for humanity would seem questionable to many modern critics. We cannot know how White would have attempted to resolve these issues had he lived. What we do know is that he died without taking stock of the solutions offered by Ingham's second-generation critics.

It is these solutions that I now wish to consider and I will examine three approaches in turn: revolutionary criticism, gender criticism and postcolonial criticism.

1.1 REVOLUTIONARY CRITICISM

Peter Widdowson's *Hardy in History*⁶ was a major contribution to the inter-generational change. Widdowson presented a critique of the 'humanist' critical practice⁷ which had become prevalent in universities after the Second World War. This had been responsible for the widespread appraisal of Hardy's fiction as expressing the essential truth about England. It found in Hardy's 'Wessex' novels the 'true' spirit of the English, who saw

themselves as an organic community, rooted in the values of the rural past and uncontaminated by the class struggles of modern industry and cities. According to Widdowson, humanist criticism was an ideological practice. It produced a myth of 'Wessex' and of 'Thomas Hardy' that was reassuring to the middle and upper classes. Against this myth making, Widdowson championed an alternative practice, 'revolutionary criticism', which had been produced by revision of Marxist literary theory in the twentieth century.⁸ Revolutionary criticism could reveal what humanist criticism masked, the class conventions of literary production to which Hardy had to conform as a writer. These were constituted in the apparatus of the book trade: publishing, selling, purchasing, reviewing and library lending, all of which depended on demand from a middle-class reading public whose expectations were formed by bourgeois ideology. This ideology was in turn produced by the educational apparatus, the ancient universities, where classical literature and Christian theology were taken as the ground of civilisation. Classical forms like pastoral and tragedy were privileged as true to life. The 'Wessex' novels were judged by classically educated reviewers with reference to these patterns and held to represent the universal predicament of humankind.

This ideology in turn concealed the historical formation of capitalist agriculture, which necessarily developed by exploiting rural working people, stripping them of their pre-capitalist rights to the land, reducing them to proletarian wage labour as instruments adjoined to machines. Hardy's novels represent this process at many points, yet humanist criticism insisted on treating them as exhibitions of fate and timeless suffering.

Widdowson indicted Thomas Hardy himself as an accessory in this process of ideological mystification. In *The Life and Work of Thomas Hardy*, a pseudo-biography written mainly by himself for publication under the name of his second wife,⁹ Hardy invented an elaborate fiction to conceal his working-class roots and promote a literary image of himself as a tragic novelist and poet. He fiercely denounced contemporary reviewers who denied him this accolade by attacking *Tess of the d'Urbervilles* and *Jude the Obscure* as propaganda for free love.

The Life, for Widdowson, was yet another myth of Thomas Hardy, resulting from the struggle of a lower-class lad to climb the ladder of success in the capitalist book trade. Hardy's rise involved suppression of some kind of radical outlook, inscribed in his first, unpublished novel, *The Poor Man and the Lady*, which he described as 'socialistic, not to say revolutionary'. Thereafter he represented himself as an apolitical artist,

exclusively concerned with aesthetic problems. What he does reveal of his political attitudes is 'vague'. His thinking about historical causation is 'bolstered by an eclectic and factitious metaphysical myth' of unsystematic conception of a 'neutral and unconscious power (the "immanent will") governing the universe'.¹⁰

In *The Life*, then, Hardy produced a humanist version of himself. Humanist criticism produced an idealised and timeless account of his fiction. Widdowson went on to propose that revolutionary criticism is free to deconstruct these myths and reconstruct another one, as Widdowson wittily dubbed it 'MYTH', an acronym of 'My Thomas Hardy'. This is not a matter of showing that Hardy himself was a 'closet revolutionary' or a socialist, but that 'he can just as well be mobilised on socialism's behalf as he can on the naturalised behalf of liberal humanism'. This is possible because his texts reveal an obsession with 'the alienations of class and gender roles', which permits him to be presented as 'a subversive writer'.¹¹

1.2 GENDER AND CRITICISM

Marxist theories of literature were not the sole stimulus to the radical transition noted by Ingham. Of great significance also, as Widdowson pointed out, was gender theory, developed from Michel Foucault's critique of 'power-knowledge', as constructed in the discourses of the nineteenth-century human sciences.¹² In 1982, Penny Boumelha drew upon these developments in her *Hardy and Women*. She challenged the claim of earlier feminists that Hardy's fiction was misogynistic. On the contrary, Hardy disturbed the misogynistic conventions of classic realist texts, notably the pastoral. Especially in the representation of sexual and marital relationships, his novels resist reduction to 'a single and uniform ideological position'.¹³

He could do this because he was writing novels at a time, 1880–1900, which saw the appearance of 'new woman fiction'. This challenged the ideology of Social Darwinism, which shifted the ideological stereotyping of 'woman' from an older basis in moral to a new basis in biological discourse.¹⁴ The effect was to disturb older plot conventions, based on marriage as the victory of true love.

The disturbance can be seen in the experimental new fiction produced by female writers of the late Victorian decades.¹⁵ They questioned the older assumption that marriage was a happy ending for women. But in so

doing, they fell into the trap of appealing, on biological grounds, to a concept of the 'real' woman, instead of challenging biological science as a discourse of the 'natural', which upheld the old, repressive stereotypes of woman as wife and mother.

In her treatment of Hardy's fiction, Boumelha pointed out that it had been critical of marriage from the first. The 'new woman' fiction emboldened him, however, to be more outspoken, as in his later 'tragic' novels. Rather than simply taking sides with the feminism of the 'new woman' novelists, however, Hardy went deeper into the question. The narrator in *Jude the Obscure*, for example, acknowledges that, even in a free union, the woman would still suffer the disadvantage of child bearing imposed on her sex, 'while the inexorable laws of nature remain what they are'.¹⁶ The novel, however, does not endorse this suggestion of determinism. Hardy challenges his contemporary readers, feminist as well as non-feminist, to ask what alternatives might replace the nuclear family, and offered several suggestions. But he endorsed none of them and *Jude* should be read, like an Ibsen play, as a 'problem novel', opening up questions rather than supplying answers.

In her 1985 introduction to the Oxford World's Classics edition of *Jude*, Patricia Ingham went further. Hardy, she wrote, 'was struggling towards, and sometimes momentarily achieved, beliefs subversive of the whole of society'. Hence the storm of outraged denunciation: 'Contemporary society recognised a revolutionary when it saw one.'¹⁷ It is, Ingham strongly implied, not enough to read *Jude* as a problem novel.

In a later study of 1989,¹⁸ Ingham developed this view by employing post-Saussurean linguistics¹⁹ to suggest that Hardy was a revolutionary writer because he cancelled the signifier of 'womanliness' and subverted the plots of classic realism. In this way he unmasked the effect of Social Darwinism, which made women internalise belief in the 'maternal instinct'.²⁰

The fundamental question which was raised by the critics of Ingham's second generation, then, is whether Hardy's fiction is 'revolutionary' and 'subversive of the whole of society'. In 1988 John Goode,²¹ a formidable practitioner of revolutionary criticism, concluded that Hardy's later novels were certainly subversive, though not revolutionary according to a strict Marxist interpretation. For Goode, 'Though Hardy was not explicitly revolutionary', his narrative strategies subvert nineteenth-century ideologies of progress, even that of 'evolutionary meliorism',²² which he espoused only after ceasing to write novels. Until the writing of his

poem 'In Tenebris', Hardy never let go of 'the recognition that in a world structured on oppression, happiness is always at the cost of somebody else's pain'. What has often been called Hardy's 'pessimism' is, for Goode, the basis of 'a revolutionary ethic', and Hardy's multi-vocal and multi-perspectival strategies of narration require the reader to see that the pain is due to the class and gender oppression of bourgeois ideology. This 'scientific game'²³ which Hardy plays with the reader leads us to negate 'the voice that is law'²⁴ and in this lies its relevance to revolutions that Hardy never foresaw.

1.3 POSTCOLONIAL CRITICISM

This is the final development in Ingham's second generation which I wish to consider before returning to my opening questions. Jane Bownas's *Thomas Hardy and Empire*²⁵ provides the richest treatment of the topic to date. The older criticism, she argued, had masked references to imperialism in the English novel. Drawing on the work of Edward Said,²⁶ Bownas argued convincingly that Hardy's fiction is replete with coded references to imperialism, the exercise of ideological repression by Britain over its colonial subjects. Accordingly, she characterised her book as an 'attempt to reveal the "imperialism" under the surface'²⁷ of Hardy's writing. He challenges 'the concept of the civilised, imperial country bringing conventional, Christian morality to primitive peoples'. In his novels this is done indirectly, by drawing analogies between past and present empires, notably in *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, where Casterbridge 'announced old Rome in every street, alley and precinct'.²⁸ Similarly, *The Dynasts* is 'a work in which the imperialistic ambitions of the emperor [Napoleon] are compared with the equally aggressive expansionist policies of the imperialistic rulers of Britain'.²⁹ Finally, Hardy understood the effects of 'internal colonialism', by which metropolitan elites exercised power over the lives of people in the rural periphery. To this end they constructed ideological representations of working-class people as 'Hodge', in the same way as they constructed stereotypes of subject races in the external colonies. He thus recognised that categories of race, class and gender were 'articulated' around a key connecting word, 'primitive'. This conveyed the 'truth' that 'those who were not of the same gender, race or class as the dominant governing elite were . . . physically and intellectually inferior, both in the domestic and colonial situation'.³⁰

Postcolonial criticism, Bonas concluded, can reveal these coded meanings in Hardy's later writings by placing them 'within the social, cultural and historical conditions in which they were produced'.³¹ Since this was an age of imperialism, he engaged with the issues imperialism raised: 'the conflict between tradition and progress, ideas of the primitive and civilised, the brutality of war and imperial conquest, the unjustness of the class system'. Both in his fiction and in his prose writings, of course, we find 'doubts and...contradictions', but when the writings are thus set in context, 'his belief in the common humanity of mankind...emerges intact'.³²

1.4 HARDY AND HISTORY

There is much to be learned from the foregoing approaches and it is not my intention in this study to undervalue them. I share their belief in a radical Hardy obscured by the older myths and I embrace the lessons they offer in reading Hardy's polysemic texts. My concern is that they provide no answers to the questions at the head of this chapter – what did Thomas Hardy think about history and how does that thinking enter into his fictional writings? These historiographical questions were not these authors' concern. They were examining, explicitly or implicitly, Thomas Hardy in history, not Thomas Hardy and history, where 'history' means 'historical writing'.

To evaluate a writer's ideas about the relationship between history and historical writing, between the past and writing about the past, we have to examine the relationship between theory and historical method. This has been much discussed by writers on historiography.³³ Today nearly all accept the value of theory in the study of the past. Theories of class, gender and imperialism, with which this study is concerned, are valued as conscious attempts at systematic discussion of the meaning of these terms. Yet it is also recognised that for a historian, theory can be a good servant but a bad master. Granted that we study people in the past for the sake of our concerns in the present, we also study them with due respect for their own concerns, which must be understood in the context of their times. Whenever we find Hardy using such words as 'history', 'revolution', 'imperialism' or 'class', we have to remind ourselves that he was doing so in the discursive context of his own time, not ours. Historical method developed since the seventeenth century is a necessary corrective to this kind of present-mindedness.

I am thus concerned to set Hardy in the context of the debate over historical writing which emerged in Britain in the 1860s. It must be acknowledged here that no historian other than White has shown any interest in Hardy's ideas about historical writing (and White's book, as I have shown above, now seems very dated). More recent historians of rural England have been content to draw upon Hardy's fiction for evidence of the way country people thought and felt about the transition to capitalist agriculture from the sixteenth to the nineteenth centuries.³⁴ A notably different approach is that taken by Keith Snell. Regarding Hardy's fiction, somewhat questionably, as almost valueless in this regard, he goes on to argue, more convincingly, that its real historical interest is its concern with changing attitudes to love and marriage among middle-class readers in the late nineteenth century. He shows how the demographic historian can link this evidence to long-run statistical trends. In this, his main point, Snell is undoubtedly correct, though Hardy's interest in history is much wider and it is potentially reductionist to constrain it within the historical sociology of the family.³⁵ Nevertheless, Snell's approach to the theme of love and marriage in Hardy's fiction can be usefully extended, as I attempt to show in my discussion of *Jude the Obscure* in [Chapter 17](#).

To return to Hardy criticism, there is welcome evidence of a renewed interest in historicity. This forms part of what has been called 'millennial criticism'.³⁶ The term indicates a new departure and an approximate date for its commencement. Notable approaches of this type are concerned with Hardy's interest in nineteenth-century philosophies of history. Lennart Bjork, a pioneer, demonstrated that Hardy, at the outset of his career as a novelist in the late 1860s, was reading the Positivist philosophy of history produced in France by Auguste Comte.³⁷ More recently, Andrew Radford has shown that this interest led on to a close study of the nineteenth-century founders of cultural anthropology.³⁸ Phillip Mallet has valuably explored Hardy's combined interest in the writings of Comte, Mill and Schopenhauer.³⁹ Most recently of all, Suzanne Keen⁴⁰ has struck out in a new current, directed at Hardy's interest in the then infant discipline of brain science and the evolution of 'mind'.

Given this trend, what is the justification for my study? My first answer is that it draws attention to a hitherto unexplored gap in the origin of Hardy's interest in philosophical history. This I suggest began in the years 1857–1862. It was then that young Thomas Hardy was introduced to the Liberal Anglican idea of history, which I review in [Chapter 2](#). The intermediary was his friend and mentor Horace Moule. Hardy provided a

cryptic clue to this fact in his pseudo-biography when he wrote that walks in the fields with Moule ‘biased Thomas Hardy still further in the direction of books, two works among those he met with impressing him much – the newly published *Essays and Reviews*... and Walter Bagehot’s *Estimates*’.⁴¹

Moule’s influence on Hardy has not, of course, gone unnoticed in Hardy criticism, but, as I attempt to demonstrate in [Chapter 3](#), his interest in the Liberal Anglican historians of the early nineteenth century has been underestimated.⁴² Its relevance goes far beyond Church of England history or its stimulus to Hardy’s agnosticism. It provided the basis for Moule’s critique of ‘the evils of our era’. I show what Moule meant by that expression by close examination of his essay on the first five centuries of Christian oratory, his poetry and his journalism. These sources, I suggest, have been seriously under-studied. The same is to be said of Walter Bagehot’s *Estimates* and even the better-known *Essays and Reviews*, which I examine in [Chapters 4](#) and [5](#). There I attempt to show how they undermined Hardy’s initial acceptance of Liberal Anglican providentialism.

My interest in these sources, however, goes beyond a concern to plug a gap in biographical and historical writing. This leads to my second justification, closely involved with the overarching theme of this study, that the Liberal Anglican idea of history survived in Hardy’s thought and writing as a substratum even after his loss of faith in Christianity around 1865. I call this a ‘substratum’ because its Christian ethic was overlaid in Hardy’s mind by a radical view of love and marriage. This, I suggest, was the product of Hardy’s acquaintance not solely with Darwinism or the ‘new woman’ fiction of the 1880s, but primarily with the republican movement which burgeoned in English politics from the end of the 1850s. This movement did not only stimulate a critique of monarchy, aristocracy and the nineteenth-century class system, it also mounted an attack on what George Drysdale called the Victorian ‘sexual code’. Drysdale was the author of *Elements of Social Science*, a work justifying free love and birth control, a discourse known at the time as ‘Neo-Malthusianism’. This, I suggest in [Chapter 7](#), is the context in which we may speak of a radical Hardy. Drysdale’s writings led him to reject Auguste Comte’s views on love and marriage, which I discuss in [Chapter 6](#), and prepared him to welcome enthusiastically the poetry of Swinburne.

Drysdale’s sexual radicalism, I further suggest, was for Hardy one end of a spectrum of radical views on the marriage question. The other end was provided by John Stuart Mill, whose writings I consider in the

final chapter of Part I. In his essay *On Liberty*, Mill, like Drysdale, called for freedom for the individual to make experiments in living, especially in the forms of sexual relationship. He stopped short, however, of Drysdale's demand for the abolition of all marriage laws, believing that such relationships would have to be regulated to safeguard the rights of those involved. In Part VI of his *System of Logic*, Mill had allowed for such experiments in relation to 'social science', in effect his own philosophy of history. He rejected the teleology of Comte, on the ground that social science could not be used to predict how human society would be organised thousands of years from the present. But he redefined the term 'teleology' in a way which, as I attempt to show in Part III, Hardy inscribed in his later fiction.

In summary, then, Part I shows that Hardy's reading of these writers provided him with a melioristic idea of history, which conceived progress as an upward cycle of light and dark ages. The Liberal Anglican historians had suggested that the nineteenth century was to be regarded as an age of crisis, which threatened decline into a new age of barbarism unless Christianity could make an accommodation with science. Auguste Comte secularised this kind of philosophy of history, but did not break with its Christian morality. Drysdale criticised Comte in this respect and offered an alternative 'natural religion'. This suggested to Hardy that the accommodation required was with the new science of physiology.

In Part II, I show how Hardy turned to fiction to promote this new accommodation. This was not, I argue, a matter of producing utopian novels, as Comte had advocated and Bjork thought Hardy actually did in the early years of his literary career.⁴³ Rather it was a question, as Hardy himself wrote, of 'putting his satire in edgewise'. Until the end of the Franco-Prussian war, I suggest, Hardy was optimistic that the reform of civilisation was moving upward. The outcome of that war, however, made him more fearful that Europe might be plunged into another cycle of empire, war and revolution, the chief symptoms of a 'late manhood' crisis.

In Part III I show that, after a brief recovery of optimism, brought about by the revival of the Gladstonian Liberal party after 1876, Hardy's confidence in meliorism was once again depressed. *Life and Work* shows that this was due to the defeat of Gladstone's Irish home rule bill of 1886 and the crisis into which British politics was plunged for some years thereafter. It also shows, I suggest, that Hardy interpreted these events as renewed symptoms of the Liberal Anglican crisis of civilisation. Yet he was not pessimistic about society as many have suggested. Rather, he

intensified his efforts to promote meliorism by experimenting with tragedy in fiction. In [Chapters 16 and 17](#), I consider the fruits of this effort, the four ‘tragic’ novels from *The Woodlanders* to *Jude the Obscure*.

In the conclusion to this study, I show that Hardy’s early meliorism survived until the end of his active life as a writer. As he put it in his pseudo-biography: ‘Although invidious critics had cast slurs upon him as Nonconformist, Agnostic, Atheist, Infidel, Immoralist, Heretic, Pessimist . . . they had never thought of calling him what they might have called him much more plausibly – churchy.’⁴⁴

This study, then, goes further than the works of millennial criticism mentioned above. It attempts to show how Hardy made of these philosophical approaches to history a guide to action for dealing with the great historical events and tendencies of his lifetime and how these readings are inscribed in his fiction. It therefore pays closer attention to the work of modern professional historians than most Hardy criticism.⁴⁵

In coming to my main conclusion, I am conscious that I may be thought to have set out to produce some kind of Christian apologetics. It seems necessary, therefore, to state candidly that I have never belonged to any religious confession. I have rather been guided by the sole consideration that contextualisation of Hardy’s work requires scrupulous fidelity to its historicity. Such an approach discloses a Thomas Hardy who was rather different from the Hardy of the second-generation critics. He was neither apolitical nor merely metaphysical about historical causation. He was radical on some issues – very radical on love and marriage. But he was reformist and class collaborationist in his approach to societal change, neither revolutionary nor subversive in the sense meant by post-modernist critics. Nor do I wish to deny that he was a kind of humanist, but his humanism, as I show, was of a qualified character, which still placed confidence in the ‘English’ as the leaders of civilisation. This, I suggest, is the historical Hardy whose ideas about history entered into his writings.

Before inviting readers to test these hypotheses by perusing the following chapters, I should close by acknowledging a difficulty that some may understandably feel. It may seem disproportionate to devote in Part I fully one-third of the book’s length to a discussion of writers who have mostly figured prominently in Hardy scholarship. For this I must offer some justification. First, I trust that readers already familiar with this scholarship will nevertheless discover in these chapters observations on history very relevant to the interpretation of Hardy’s fiction that I offer in Parts II and III. Second, although

the length of Part I may seem somewhat daunting, it is possible to read Parts II and III first, returning thereafter to Part I in order to test my main hypothesis.

As will be clear by now, this is that Thomas Hardy took very seriously the ideas of history he found in these writers. There is, in my view, evidence enough in *Life and Work* to make these links, even in the case of George Drysdale, where it is more circumstantial than Hardy's direct testimony would have been. However that may be, I think I may claim that this study makes a case for reading the fiction in the light of my Thomas Hardy.

That said, final judgement of my approach need not rest solely on the evidences of influence. Influence is very difficult to prove to a high degree of probability. Young Thomas Hardy read fairly widely in books and periodicals during the 1860s and the practice only grew as the decades succeeded one another. Historical inquiry, moreover, can never reveal 'the real Hardy'. In the last analysis, therefore, I make a pragmatic claim for the value of the historical Hardy. My reconstruction shows how, in its absence, many passages in the novels remain obscure. These include, for example, the comparison of Gabriel Oak with Satan. Such passages are rendered more intelligible by reading them in the light of Part I of this study. Through such an approach we gain further insight into Hardy's 'idiosyncratic mode of regard'.⁴⁶

NOTES

1. P. Ingham, *Thomas Hardy* (Oxford, 2003), p. 213.
2. R. J. White, *Hardy and History* (London, 1974).
3. White had in mind here D. Brown, *Thomas Hardy* (London, 1954, 1961), pp. 36, 101ff, and A. Kettle, *Introduction to the English Novel II: Henry James to the Present Day* (London, 1953), p. 49.
4. White, *Hardy and History*, p. 5.
5. White, *Hardy and History*, pp. 15, 7.
6. P. Widdowson, *Hardy in History: A Study in Literary Sociology* (London, 1989).
7. For a critical account of its development, see F. Mulhern, *The Moment of 'Scrutiny'* (London, 1979).
8. T. Eagleton, 'Introduction' to *Jude the Obscure*, New Wessex edn (London, 1896), pp. 9–20.
9. T. Hardy, *The Life and Work of Thomas Hardy*, ed. M. Millgate (London, 1984, repr. with corrections 1989), esp. editor's introduction, pp. x–xviii. Cp. F. E. Hardy, *The Early Life of Thomas Hardy, 1840–1891* (London, 1928) and *The Later Years of Thomas Hardy, 1892–1928* (London, 1930).

10. Widdowson, *Hardy in History*, pp. 149, 150.
11. Widdowson, *Hardy in History*, p. 198.
12. M. Foucault, *The Order of Things: Archeology of the Human Sciences* (London, 2001). For gender theory, see J. W. Scott, *Gender and the Politics of History* (London, revd edn, 1999).
13. P. Boumelha, *Thomas Hardy and Women: Sexuality and Narrative Form* (Brighton, 1982), p. 7.
14. Boumelha, *Hardy and Women*, pp. 16ff.
15. For Boumelha's discussion of the 'new woman' fiction, see *Hardy and Women*, ch. 4, pp. 63–97.
16. Boumelha, *Hardy and Women*, p. 173.
17. T. Hardy, *Jude the Obscure*, ed. with an introduction and notes by P. Ingham (Oxford, 1985), esp. p. xxi.
18. P. Ingham, *Thomas Hardy: A Feminist Reading* (Hemel Hempstead, 1989), pp. 1–8, 61–95.
19. For 'post-Saussurean criticism', see C. Belsey, *Critical Practice* (London, 1980), esp. ch. 1, pp. 1–36.
20. Ingham, *Hardy: Feminist Reading*, p. 95.
21. J. Goode, *Thomas Hardy: The Offensive Truth* (London, 1988), pp. 138–166.
22. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, p. 14.
23. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, p. 13.
24. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, p. 14.
25. J. L. Bownas, *Thomas Hardy and Empire: The Representation of Imperial Themes in the Work of Thomas Hardy* (Farnham, 2012).
26. E. Said, *Culture and Imperialism* (London 1994).
27. Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 1.
28. Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 2.
29. Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 4.
30. Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 5.
31. Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 8.
32. Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 8.
33. The debate over 'paradigms' of historical inquiry is complex. For a defence of the 'Rankean' paradigm, adopted in western academies in the early decades of the twentieth century, see G. Elton, *The Practice of History* (London, 1967). For a balanced account of collaboration with theory in the later decades, see G. Iggers, *New Directions in European Historiography* (London, 1975, revd edn 1985). For postmodern scepticism about historians' claims to 'realism', see H. White, *Metahistory: The Historical Imagination in Nineteenth-Century Europe* (London, 1973). A. Marwick, *The Nature of History* (3rd edn, London, 1989), attempts a robust defence of history as a 'science', as does his debate with White, 'Two approaches to

historical study: the metaphysical (including “postmodernism”) and the historical’, *Journal of Contemporary History*, 30, 1, 1995; see Vol. 30, 2 for White’s ‘Response’. E. P. Thompson, *The Poverty of Theory* (London, 1978), rebuts modernist and postmodernist theories, and works from the tradition of historical materialism to offer an important contribution to a distinctive paradigm which he calls ‘social’ history. I am sympathetic to his claims for the value of ‘literature’ as a source of knowledge in that field, but my approach in this study, as I indicate further on here, is based on the pragmatic philosophy of language, for which see J. Searle, *Mind, Language and Society: Doing Philosophy in the Real World* (London, 1999).

34. See e.g., B. Kerr, *Bound to the Soil: A Social History of Dorset, 1750–1918* (London, 1968); P. Horn, *The Rural World, 1780–1850: Social Change in the English Countryside*, passim; E. P. Thompson, ‘The moral economy of the English crowd in the eighteenth century’, *Past and Present*, 50, 1, 1971, pp. 76–136; reprinted in E. P. Thompson, *Customs in Common* (London, 1991), pp. 185–258.
35. K. D. M. Snell, *Annals of the Labouring Poor: Social Change and Agrarian England, 1660–1900* (Cambridge, 1987), pp. 382ff. For the pioneering discussion of demographic history as an indispensable correlative to literary evidence in historical sociology, see P. Laslett, ‘The wrong way through the telescope: a note on literary evidence in sociology and in historical sociology’, *British Journal of Sociology*, 17, 3, 1976, pp. 319–342. For a correction to Snell’s comment on female labour on threshing machines, see F. Reid, ‘The Dorsetshire Labourer’, P. Mallet (ed.), *Thomas Hardy in Context* (Cambridge, 2013), p. 180.
36. R. Morgan (ed.), *The Ashgate Companion to Thomas Hardy* (Farnham, 2010), esp. pp. 1–22.
37. L. A. Bjork, *Psychological Vision and Social Criticism in the Novels of Thomas Hardy* (Stockholm, Sweden, 1987), pp. 59–78.
38. A. Radford, *Thomas Hardy and the Survivals of Time* (Aldershot, 2003), pp. 1–29. See also M. Zeitler, *Representations of Culture: Thomas Hardy’s Wessex and Victorian Anthropology* (Oxford, 2007), pp. 1–32.
39. P. Mallett, ‘Hardy and Philosophy’, in K. Wilson (ed.), *A Companion to Thomas Hardy* (London, 2009), pp. 21–35.
40. S. Keen, *Thomas Hardy’s Brains: Psychology, Neurology, and Hardy’s Imagination* (Columbus, Ohio, 2014).
41. Hardy, *Life and Work*, p. 37. See also Hardy, *Early Years*, p. 43.
42. H. C. Webster, *The Art and Thought of Thomas Hardy: A Darkling Plain* (London, 1948), p. 37; M. Millgate, *Thomas Hardy: A Biography Revisited* (Oxford, 2004), p. 66; R. Pite, *Thomas Hardy: The Guarded Life* (London, 2006), p. 84.
43. Bjork, *Psychological Vision*, pp. 79–106.

44. Hardy, *Life and Work* p. 406.
45. S. Gatrell, *Thomas Hardy and the Proper Study of Mankind* (Charlottesville, Virginia, 1993), is a notable exception which relates Hardy's fiction to the 'New Imperialism'.
46. Hardy applied this term to his own way of seeing nature as art. See *Life and Work*, p. 235.

PART I

Ideas of History

The Liberal Anglican Idea of History

This chapter introduces the Liberal Anglican philosophy of history, which Duncan Forbes analysed in his pioneering study of 1952.¹ It examines the leading ideas of its practitioners, predominantly Thomas Arnold and Henry Hart Milman. It concludes by tracing the legacy of these ideas in the movement of the 1850s known as the ‘Broad Church’. It thus prepares the way for demonstration, in [Chapter 3](#), that this philosophy of history influenced the writings of Horace Moule: his prize-winning essay on the early history of Christian oratory, his poetry and his journalism of the 1860s. Moule, as I will show in [Chapters 3](#) and [4](#), passed these ideas on to young Thomas Hardy first, as Hardy recalled, in their conversation and further by recommending two works, Bagehot’s *Estimates and Essays and Reviews*, in which leading Liberal Anglicans were both represented and criticised. In the final analysis of this study, these ideas will be shown to form the Liberal Anglican substratum of Hardy’s philosophico-historical thought.

2.1 THOMAS ARNOLD AND THE SOCIAL PROGRESS OF STATES

Arnold was convinced that the history of all civilisations was cyclical rather than linear. He found this ancient idea applied to the history of Rome in *The New Science* of Giambattista Vico² and developed it in an essay on ‘the social progress of states’.³ Duncan Forbes drew attention to the frequent use, in Arnold’s essay and historical writings, of certain metaphors: the ‘childhood’, ‘youth’ and ‘manhood’, the ‘spring’, ‘summer’ and ‘winter’ of society. Such

metaphors referred to the staging of social development which was analogous to the life-cycle of an individual human being. Such 'natural periods' in the history of any nation, he opined, marked its development from 'what I may call a state of childhood to manhood'.⁴

Arnold here was expressing fundamental opposition to historians of the French rationalist tradition. Men like Condorcet⁵ had conceived of the history of civilisation as a mechanistic process, a 'march of mind', proceeding upward in an uninterrupted straight line. Arnold, by contrast, came to think of historical progress as a wavy line, representing the cyclical development of civilisations from the savagery of their childhood to the maturity and rationality of their manhood. As with individuals, the manhood stage passed into decline and ended in death. But this was not the end for states, any more than individuals. Each successive civilisation had been born, like the Phoenix, from the ashes of the old. This was the '*corso*' and '*ricorso*' which civilisation must undergo, in a possibly infinite series. The pattern of progress in human history, therefore, was not linear but cyclical, not mechanistic but organic.

Arnold applied this theory in writing his *History of Rome*. It was unfinished at his death, but the argument was clear in the first two completed volumes.⁶ These demonstrated how the Roman republic had developed from its 'infancy' (I, 59) to the 'manhood' stage, during which the foundations were laid of high Roman civilisation.

The process was driven by class struggle between the 'nobility' and the 'commons'. In a series of revolutionary confrontations, the commons gained and enlarged constitutional rights, thus establishing a social equilibrium which enabled the Republic to withstand the invasion of Hannibal in the Punic war.

Theoretically, as Arnold saw it, this process of inclusion within the pale of the constitution should have continued until only a small minority was excluded 'by...their own ignorance or profligacy' (II, 268ff). This did not happen at Rome and, as Arnold believed, such arrested development had characterised every imperial civilisation thereafter. In the late-manhood stage of social development, he insisted, lay the seeds of the decline and fall of every empire.

This was because, in the late-manhood stage, the nobility and commons fused into a plutocracy, dedicated to the pursuit of luxury by means of war and imperial expansion. Their monopoly of wealth and privilege produced intense class alienation. Notoriously, the manhood stage of the

Roman republic was marked by a tiny plutocracy at the top and a vast proletariat of slaves, captured by foreign conquest, at the bottom. With this went the decay of traditional religion. Few Romans in the age of Julius Caesar sincerely believed in the gods of Olympus. Instead, they worshipped the false gods of materialism and power.

In his 1841 inaugural lecture as Regius Professor of History at Oxford, Arnold overlaid these ideas with a racial theory of universal history. Its 'modern' epoch began, he argued, when the German barbarians over-ran the western empire of Rome. From the perspective of the nineteenth century, the significance of that world-historical event could now be understood. It commenced the role of the Germanic race in spreading the culture of Greece and Rome over the whole world. The records of secular history showed that the English branch of the German race had emerged pre-eminent in the nineteenth century. Arnold extolled the work of 'this great English nation, whose race and language are now overrunning the earth from one end of it to the other'.⁷

Christians, Arnold argued, could not rest content with history that merely demonstrated what actually happened. They had to read the historical record for signs that the English race was fit to complete its part in the fulfilment of God's providence, which promised the Christianisation of the whole world. Considered in this light, the recent history of England, as Arnold saw it, was not encouraging. England after the victory of Waterloo, like Rome after the defeat of Hannibal, was in the depth of a late-manhood crisis of civilisation, threatening it with revolution and collapse.

Arnold took up this problem in his 1842 course of Introductory Lectures on the Modern History of Europe. The story was that of a clash between two principles – empire and liberty. Competition had forced every Germanic nation to ensure its survival by defeating its neighbours in war. Modern history had thus developed into a struggle for the universal domination of a single power over all the rest. As in ancient Greece and Rome, struggle for empire led to class conflict and revolution. France succumbed in 1789. It was revived by Napoleon, who renewed the ambition of empire on an even vaster scale. England had opposed his ambition in the name of constitutional liberty and a titanic struggle ensued, which ended at Waterloo in 1815.

The British government borrowed to finance the conflict. Debt repayment placed intolerable burdens on society: exorbitant taxation and the encumbrance of a vast national debt. The result was popular resistance, Chartism in England and nationalism in Ireland. As Arnold put it, the

popular principle in the British constitution 'went to sleep, abandoned by the oligarchy of land and commerce which the war produced. Dominated by the Tory party, the crown and parliament became the opponents of liberty and a popular movement awoke again to challenge them.'⁸

England, therefore, was facing the confrontation of classes which was the inevitable consequence of imperialism and war. It would, Arnold thought, end in revolution

when the real differences between the contending parties have reached the widest point of separation; when the intermediate gradations in society are absolved in one or other of the two extremes and the state is divided only between the two irreconcilable opposites of luxury and beggary.⁹

Thus Arnold's study of history threatened to lead him to a pessimistic conclusion: 'Can the truths which it teaches us to value,' he asked his Oxford audience, 'be really carried into effect practically, or are we rather cursed with that bitter thing, a powerless knowledge'.¹⁰

As a Christian, Arnold could not rest here. History must be the fulfilment of God's providence. Christians should be agents in its fulfilment. Yet history, ancient and modern, showed that they might be corrupted by desire for luxury and power. The task of the modern historian was to explain how this came about in order to recall Christian statesmen to their duty.

2.2 HENRY HART MILMAN AND TELEOLOGICAL HISTORY

Arnold died before he could develop this Christian teleology further. Meanwhile, his friend Henry Hart Milman had begun doing so in his historical studies of religion, commencing with the history of the Jewish nation.

Milman, no more than Arnold, could yield to historical pessimism. Progress towards Christ's kingdom on earth was guaranteed, all Christians believed, by God's providence, as revealed in the Bible. But how was Milman to combat the atheistic Edward Gibbon, whose *Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire* he acknowledged as the greatest work of history ever written? Gibbon had argued that faith had no place in historical explanation. The decline and fall of the Roman empire could be explained entirely by natural causes, geographical, military and political. Milman accepted this as a great gain for secular history. The

problem was to write history in this way while demonstrating the divine plan working through it. His solution was to employ the ancient Christian doctrine of accommodation. This held that God's plan could not be explained to primitive barbarians who as yet lacked the power of reason. Its revelation had to be accommodated to each stage of a nation's growth from infancy to manhood. The problem of historical writing in the nineteenth century was to show how nations could become conscious of divine providence in purely natural ways.

This was what Milman attempted in his *History of the Jews*. He showed how a new nation had been born in the remote age of barbarism, among a tribe of rude desert nomads, led by a semi-legendary sheik called Abraham. The people fell into Egyptian bondage, from which they were rescued by Moses. Under divine providence, later prophets accommodated Abramic monotheism to the Egyptian institution of a temple priesthood, on which the state of Israel was founded. Consequently, the nation matured into a high civilisation under its greatest kings, David and Solomon, marked by vast trade, opulence and imperial conquest. But these were the symptoms of its late-manhood crisis. The empire under Solomon was destroyed by mammon worship and religious schism, and the Jewish state declined, at last to perish in warfare with the Romans.

In his two books of Christian history, Milman was concerned to show how the new monotheistic faith had grown in western Europe by accommodation, first to the Roman empire and then to the new barbarian invaders. Primitive Christianity had thus developed into a church. Adopted as the official religion of the empire under Constantine, it survived through the late-manhood crisis of the Roman empire to become the religion of the Germanic tribes who overthrew it.

After the fall of Rome, therefore, Latin Christianity in the west had to accommodate itself to a second age of barbarism. It was now the religion of superstitious warlords, steeped in the polytheism of the German forests. It accommodated to these facts, limiting violence through the code of chivalry and the worship of saints, who replaced the local tribal deities. This primitive religion of the western Middle Ages matured with the German nations into the Holy Roman Empire of Charlemagne, only to decay once again into warfare and upheaval.

By God's providence, as Milman understood it, Christianity progressed through this *corso* and *ricorso* of civilisations to emerge once again in a new era of Protestant religion. He died before a projected third book on this

stage could be written as the completion of his project. This would have shown how Protestantism had begun the accommodation of Christianity to an age of reason and science, only to decline once again in the nineteenth century into an age of scepticism.

2.3 THE LIBERAL ANGLICAN IDEA OF HISTORY AS A GUIDE TO ACTION

Arnold led the way in applying this teleological view of history as a guide to action for the recovery of England in the age of revolution. The effects of luxury, class struggle, political faction, scepticism and war could only be overcome, he believed, by the regeneration of the national religion, as instituted in the Church of England. Yet the church's hold over the people had been undermined by the recent discoveries of science and the spread of religious scepticism from Germany. Geology had discredited literal belief in the Genesis story of Creation. German rational criticism was doing further damage to the rest of the Old Testament, and the work of David Strauss was threatening even the New Testament account of Jesus. The faith of moderate men was thus challenged and Christian civilisation undermined. Survival depended not on repression of science, but on a new accommodation with it.

This, as Samuel Taylor Coleridge had urged, should be the task of the national church. Arnold agreed, but thought the Church of England was divided in his own time between two warring factions whose beliefs were at odds with modern scientific knowledge. On the one hand were the Evangelicals, who insisted on the literal truth of the Bible, rejecting the discoveries of science and German rational criticism. On the other was the Oxford movement, which insisted on the historical descent of the Church of England from the primitive church of Apostolic times, equally ignoring rational criticism. Both sides alienated educated men, driving them into the camp of the godless Benthamites or the dissenting sects, who wanted the disestablishment of the church. Were they to have their way, Arnold believed, the chief institution maintaining the bond of sympathy between upper and lower classes would be overthrown. Christian civilisation would come to an end in England and its colonies, and the world would return to a state of barbarism.

Arnold therefore developed a programme to make the Church of England once again, as he termed it, 'comprehensive'.¹¹ Its doctrine and liturgy must be purged of worn-out creeds and practices. The warring

sects could then be reabsorbed into the establishment, under terms which would leave them free to practise their own forms of worship.

Arnold coupled his ecclesiastical policy with a social one. Professions of faith he considered worthless by themselves. Christians who truly believed would be known by their fruits which, for the rich, would be work to improve the lot of the poor. 'I cannot understand', he wrote,

what is the good of a national Church if it be not to Christianize the nation, and introduce the principles of Christianity into men's social and civil relations, and expose the wickedness of that spirit which maintains the game-laws, and in agriculture and trade seems to think that there is no such sin as covetousness, and that if a man is not dishonest, he has nothing to do but to make all the profit of his capital that he can.¹²

The great enemy to all this, as Arnold saw it, was factionalism in church and state. It had ruined the Roman commonwealth and the French monarchy, opening the way to revolution and despotism. Accordingly, he denounced the two extremes in British politics of his day. On one side were the democrats, the English 'Jacobins', baying for manhood suffrage, and the 'godless Utilitarians', pursuing Church disestablishment. On the other were the bulk of the Tory party, opposed to any reform, 'the worst and most selfish part of our aristocracy, with the coarsest and most profligate of their dependents'.¹³ The victory of either would lead to class warfare and revolution, with all the evils that had produced in 1789. The aim of state policy should be to prevent such a catastrophe by ensuring that the 20 million human beings in England should 'have sufficient physical comforts and a share of political rights and some degree at least of intellectual and spiritual cultivation. All these are the just portion of free men.'¹⁴

England, then, as Arnold saw it, would be revived by the re-establishment of its national religion. It might then resume its divinely appointed mission to Christianise the world. To this end, Arnold developed a loose idea of Christian imperialism, which his friend, Julius Hare, advocated more stridently after his death.¹⁵ There could be no war with other powers committed to Christianity and constitutional liberty, but the expansion of despotic Russia must be resisted by an alliance of England and a new France, liberalised by the revolution of 1830.¹⁶ Any revival of Bonapartism across the Channel should be resisted. Arnold was no pacifist but, believing that war was the great enemy of humankind, he looked forward to a time when the progress of Christianity across the world would have eliminated 'exclusive

patriotism', which belonged 'to the follies and selfishness of our uncultivated nature'. The Christian revelation taught men to 'make their sympathies coextensive with their bond of universal brotherhood'.¹⁷

2.4 THE BROAD CHURCH

As we shall see in Part III of this study, all these Liberal Anglican ideas resonated with Thomas Hardy and entered into his satire of English civilisation in the late nineteenth century. What accounts for this continuity is, I suggest, the influence of Horace Moule, who first absorbed the Liberal Anglican idea of history into his own writings, then communicated them to young Thomas Hardy. This is the argument of [Chapter 3](#). Before proceeding with it, however, a word must be said about the Broad Church movement, with which Moule identified.

As the 1850s succeeded the 1840s, the symptoms of social crisis gradually receded. Economic expansion – construction of railways, ocean-going steamships, electric telegraph – revitalised British industry and reduced the pressures of class antagonism. Chartism, though it long survived in the industrial towns, faded as a force in national politics.¹⁸ This opened the way to cautious social reforms favoured by the Liberal Anglican historians. One of these, repeal of agricultural protection, split the Conservative party in 1846 and ensured the dominance of the Whig party for 20 years under Lords Russell and Palmerston.

At the universities Liberal Anglican ideas acquired a following: at Oxford as pupils of 'The Doctor' matriculated from Rugby school, and at Cambridge as the teaching of Julius Hare influenced many undergraduates.¹⁹ In 1850 the Whig Prime Minister, Lord John Russell, set up a reform commission for Oxford University and appointed Arnold's biographer, A. P. Stanley, as its secretary. When its recommendations were implemented by legislation in 1854, parliamentary amendments secured the relief of dissenters and Roman Catholics from the obligation of subscription to the doctrine of the Church of England. In 1856 this was extended to Cambridge. In 1858, Milman's dream of the complete inclusion of Jews in civil society came a step nearer with the abolition of their obligation to swear the Christian oath on entry to the House of Commons.

To the exponents of religious accommodation, it seemed possible that moral and religious progress was once again marching hand in hand with material improvements. But in 1853 they received a distinct indication that the Anglican supporters of traditional doctrine would not give up

without a fight. In that year, F. D. Maurice was forced to resign from his Professorship of Theology at King's College, London, for publishing a book in which he recast Christian theology in non-dogmatic form. Although Maurice never identified completely with the Broad Church movement, he and his writings were widely regarded as part of it.

There were other signs that dogmatic Christianity was alive and on the march. J. H. Newman's conversion to Roman Catholicism in 1845 had weakened the Oxford movement, but it was far from exhausted. In 1853 a militant fight broke out between Tractarians and Evangelicals over the meaning of the communion sacrament. This gave rise to the 'Denison' case, which was pursued through the church and civil law courts until Denison was deprived of his living.²⁰ By 1857 Tractarianism was morphing into Ritualism, a movement to introduce traditional Catholic ornaments and vestments into Anglican services. When the vicar of an east London parish attempted this in 1859, riots broke out between his supporters and his opponents.

Nor was the Evangelical wing of the Church of England silent before the advance of liberal theology. The mathematician and liberal theologian Baden Powell was attacked in its press for his acceptance of modern science and his rejection of biblical chronology. Stanley and Jowett were censured for their liberal interpretation of Paul's Epistles in 1855.

As the 1850s drew to a close, therefore, it seemed to Broad Churchmen like Stanley that the late-manhood crisis of civilisation had been mitigated by further material progress, but moral progress was still obstructed by dogmatic disputes in the church over outworn creeds. Theological disputation and heresy hunting seemed to be reviving within the Church of England. In the 1860s, moreover, industrial unrest again broke out, leading to strikes and agitation for manhood suffrage. This was the context in which Horace Moule produced his writings, to which I turn in the next chapter.

NOTES

1. D. Forbes, *The Liberal Anglican Idea of History* (Cambridge, 1952) is still the best overview on the writings of this topic.
2. G. Vico, *The New Science of Giambattista Vico: Unabridged Translation of the Third Edition (1744) with the Addition of 'Practice of the New Science'*, eds, T. G. Bergin and M. H. Fisch (London, 1948).
3. 'On the social progress of states', Appendix I to Thucydides, *History of the Peloponnesian War*, ed. Thomas Arnold (Oxford, 1830), pp. 615–639.

4. Forbes, *The Liberal Anglican Idea of History*, p. 21, quoting Arnold on 'Social progress of states', in Thucydides, *Peloponnesian War*, ed. Arnold, p. 615.
5. 'Condorcet', in D. Kelley, *Versions of History from Antiquity to the Enlightenment* (London, 1991), pp. 490–496.
6. T. Arnold, *History of Rome, I: Early History to the Burning of Rome by the Gauls* (2nd edn, London, 1840); T. Arnold, *History of Rome, II: From the Gaulish Invasion to the End of the First Punic War* (2nd edn, London, 1840); T. Arnold, *History of Rome, III: From the End of the First to the End of the Second Punic War* (2nd edn, London, 1843).
7. The text of the Inaugural Lecture was repr. in T. Arnold, *Introductory Lectures on Modern History* (London, 5th edn., 1860), pp. 1–34. p. 23.
8. Arnold. 'Social progress of states', p. 634.
9. Arnold. 'Social progress of states', p. 634.
10. T. Arnold, 'Inaugural lecture', repr. in T. Arnold, *Introductory Lectures on Modern History*, pp. 307f.
11. Quoted in T. E. Jones, *The Broad Church: A Biography of a Movement* (Oxford, 2003), pp. 38ff.
12. Quoted in C. R. Sanders, *Coleridge and the Broad Church Movement: Studies in S. T. Coleridge, Dr Arnold of Rugby, J. C. Hare, Thomas Carlyle and F. D. Maurice* (Durham, N.C., U.S.A., 1942), p. 119.
13. Arnold to Bunsen, 6 May, 1833, quoted in A. P. Stanley, *The Life and Correspondence of Thomas Arnold*, D. D. (London, 1852), pp. 279f.
14. Quoted in E. L. Williamson, *The Liberalism of Thomas Arnold: A Study of his Religious and Political Writings* (Alabama, 1964), p. 190.
15. J. C. Hare, *Guesses At Truth, First Series* (4th edn., London, 1851), p. 122f. Hare, it should be noted here, posthumously edited the third volume of Arnold's *History of Rome*.
16. Stanley, *Life and Correspondence*, pp. 531f.
17. T. Arnold, *Miscellaneous Works*, ed. A. P. Stanley (London 1874), p. 276.
18. M. C. Finn, *After Chartism: Class and Nation in English Radical Politics, 1848–1874* (Cambridge, 1993), esp. ch. 2, pp. 106–141. This excellent survey of radical political culture in nineteenth-century England is indispensable to an understanding of Hardy's political development as treated in this study.
19. C. Kent, *Brains and Numbers: Elitism, Comtism and Democracy in Mid-Victorian England* (London, 1978), pp. 10–20. See also T. R. Wright, *The Religion of Humanity: The Impact of Comtean Positivism on Victorian Britain* (Cambridge, 1986), esp. ch. 4, pp. 125–172.
20. O. Chadwick, *The Victorian Church: Part I, 1829–1859* (London, 1966), pp. 491ff.

Horace Moule and ‘the Evils of Our Era’

In [Section 3.1](#) of this chapter I demonstrate that the Liberal Anglican idea of history entered deeply into Horace Moule’s prize-winning essay on the first five centuries of christian oratory (1859).¹ In [Section 3.2](#), drawing on his poetry and journalism, I show how he applied it as a guide to action in addressing the question of progress in mid-Victorian England.

3.1 THE FIRST FIVE CENTURIES OF CHRISTIAN ORATORY

In the preface to his essay, Moule set himself two aims. Both were derived from Liberal Anglican principles. First, he wished to rescue discussion of the writings of the ‘Church Fathers’ from the doctrinal wrangling of Victorian Evangelicals and Tractarians, who used them either to scarify or to celebrate the Church of Rome. His second was more ‘philosophical’, namely to demonstrate the significance of Patristic writings (p. xi) for his own time. As Moule saw it, the Church Fathers at their best sought an accommodation between Christianity and the most advanced ancient philosophy. They thus provided a valuable example to Victorian Christianity, so much in need of accommodation to the rationalism of its own era. Moreover, in their obvious concern to soften the attitudes of the Roman plutocracy towards the miseries of the proletariat, they taught the lesson that the work of social regeneration was far more important than doctrinal disputation. Allowing for differences of time

and place, Moule suggested, the Patristic writings could be read as a guide to action in dealing with the 'moral and intellectual', the 'social and political . . . blots of obvious evil' which defaced alike the Roman and the British empires (p. xi).

Such an approach required the guidance of a philosophical history sympathetic alike to Christianity and progress. For this, Moule relied on Milman's *History of Christianity from the Birth of Christ to the Abolition of Paganism in the Roman Empire*.² In the Liberal Anglican manner, Milman treated the period from the birth of Christ to the establishment of Christianity by Constantine as the final stage in the life-cycle of polytheistic civilisation. Originating in the infancy of humankind, polytheism was a natural form of religion. It had flourished in every nation because it seemed to account for the mysteries of nature by the belief that every phenomenon had its spiritual cause. But, by the end of the Roman republic, the polytheism of the ancient Romans was dying from the scepticism induced by philosophical reasoning. No educated Roman believed in Jupiter, Mars and Minerva, or in the ceremonies by which the augurs claimed to divine their will. Yet man, said Milman, is and always will be a spiritual being. Accordingly, the world was ready for a new religion and, of the many on offer at the time, Christianity prevailed, decisively for world history.

The special contribution of the 'Church Fathers', as Moule saw it, was to apply the techniques of oratory, developed in the Roman civil courts, to defend Christianity as a superior religion, philosophically considered, to the rival systems of Stoics, Neo-Platonists and others. Again and again he quoted extensive passages, translated from their writings, to show how they used the philosophico-historical method to interpret Christianity, revealed in the Jewish scriptures, as the inevitable successor to paganism. In later ages, these works had been frozen by the Church of Rome into 'Catholic science', dogma concerning the nature of the Trinity and so on. By contrast Moule, as a follower of Arnold and Milman, rejected dogmatic truth in favour of an evolutionary view of Christianity as a world religion competing with rival metaphysical views, especially scientific materialism.

The approach flowered in the fourth and fifth centuries, with the writings of outstanding Fathers such as Cyprian, John Chrisostom and Augustine. Moule quoted them to show how they recognised their times as what Liberal Anglicans understood as the late-manhood stage of pagan civilisation. Thus Cyprian:

Now . . . [you pagans] ought to be first made to understand this fact: namely, that the world has grown old, and no longer stands in the same strength that formerly it stood in, nor feels the sinews of that vigorous energy which formerly it felt . . . the world itself is speaking, and bearing witness of its decline in the marks of a general state of decay. (90f)

Chrisostom was quoted extensively to show his Liberal Anglican horror at the alienation of rich and poor in the Roman empire. 'Thou verily countest,' he thundered at his fashionable Antioch congregation, 'so many acres of land; *Masses*. ten, twenty, or more houses; as many baths; one or two thousand servants: and chariots, covered with silver and gold' (143).

Driving home the contrast with the poor, Moule quotes:

Hastening to church, I passed by the public square, and the crossing of the streets. I saw grovelling on the ground so many wretched beings, some maimed, others deprived of sight, others covered with incurable sores, that I felt there was an excess of inhumanity in your neglecting to succour these miserable men. (140)

Looking ahead for a moment, we may compare similar passages written by Hardy about mid-Victorian London, as in *A Pair of Blue Eyes*, where the chariots of the rich parading in Rotten Row are contrasted with the squalor of the poor in the slums behind Henry Knight's chambers.

Returning to Moule's essay, we must note that he gave more space to Augustine than to any other Church Father. In doing so, he ignored the reasons for which Victorian Christians, Protestant and Catholic alike, extolled Augustine: his dogmatic refutations of ancient heretics like Pelagius; and his insistence that the church had a right and a duty to excommunicate heretics. Moule followed German criticism in holding that this rigid dogmatism was characteristic of Augustine in his later years only.³ Such critics argued that Augustine possessed 'a truly philosophic mind as much guided by a desire to form an unbiased conviction as any other of the great philosophers'.

Given what Hardy's more recent biographers have revealed about Moule's personal struggle with alcoholism and sexuality, it is understandable that he dismissed a dogmatism he must have found repressive. Instead Moule embraced Milman's view that the essential value of Augustine is to be found in the universal history propounded in *The City of God*. He pronounced the funerary oration on paganism and a panegyric on Christianity

as the only hope for humankind. Christianity might go through periods of *corso* and *ricorso*, but it could never die. Moule echoed Milman in summing up: 'A new social system had emerged from the ashes of the old; and this system was to go on fighting its way, until the whole world itself has experienced a total change' (168). This being so, Moule conceived it as his task to show how Augustine used oratorical technique to promote this vision.

Set in the context of the Liberal Anglican idea of history, then, Moule's essay on Christian oratory emerges as something more philosophical than an antiquarian rummage through the writings of the Church Fathers. In a 'Postscript', Moule sided with Broad Churchmen in deploring factional strife within Victorian Christianity. His essay should be read, he indicated, as a prologue to a larger study showing how the Church Fathers, at their best, sought to accommodate Christianity to the most advanced philosophy of their time. The German historian Niebuhr, Moule noted, had done something like this for Marcus Aurelius. 'No one who knows his work', the Christian Niebuhr had written, 'can help loving him.' Moule himself nominated Julian the Apostate for similar treatment. That emperor, who tried to reverse the Council of Nicaea by restoring pagan philosophy and religion, was 'a man of extraordinary mind, as everyone must feel who reads his writings' (213).

At their best, Moule suggested, the Church Fathers showed the basic truth held alike by Christians and the great pagan philosophers, that the universe was under the direction of a loving principle which they both imagined as God. At their worst, they spent too much time wrangling over dogma concerning the unfathomable attributes of God and humans: the Trinity, the origin of sin, and the relationship of the spirit and the flesh. This search for and enforcement of a rigid 'catholic science' had weakened the Church of late Antiquity, producing schism at a time when the Christian empire of Rome was threatened by war and barbarism. In his later, doctrinaire period, Augustine had gone even further, forcing a split between Christianity and pagan philosophy. This was the chief evil again besetting the Church in Moule's own time. Broad Churchmen offered a cure by opposing faction fighting and heresy hunting in the Church of England. If Churchmen would repudiate theological disputation and unite in love as Christ commanded, they would surely be the salvation of England, the empire and the world.

At the same time, there were social as well as religious divisions to be overcome, as Moule made clear in his poetry and journalistic writings, to which I now turn.

3.2 TEMPORA MUTANTUR

Horace Moule entered Oxford University as a student in 1851. He left without taking the Bachelor of Arts degree, transferring to Cambridge University in 1854. He left in 1857 again without taking the lower degree, though embarrassment was avoided by the award of MA for his prize essay.⁴ I have discovered nothing concerning Moule's education to add to the work of Michael Millgate, but it is worth noting here that he attended these universities during the years of agitation for reform led, as we have seen, by the Liberal Anglicans.

On returning to his father's vicarage in Fordington, Dorchester, in 1858, Moule set about founding a career as man of letters. He saw his *Christian Oratory* through the press and began to help with teaching in the school which his father ran as an adjunct to his ministry. Moule no doubt regarded all this as a stop-gap. Aspiring to the higher journalism, he sent poems and articles to various journals, and soon established footings in two prestigious periodicals, *Fraser's Magazine* and the *Saturday Review*.⁵

In the meantime, as part of his contribution to his father's school, he took on the presidency of the Fordington Times Society, a literary and debating club attended by the Moule family, their friends and senior pupils. In 1859 he edited for private circulation a small volume entitled *Tempora Mutantur* – 'The Times Are Changing'. It reproduced reports of debates, poems and essays with which the members had entertained one another.

I have shown elsewhere how Moule's contributions to the little volume reflect his Liberal Anglican response to the changing times.⁶ This is to be seen in their contrasting of material and moral – that is, Christian – progress and in the Christian imperialism of his poem on the Indian 'mutiny' (72).

It was just about this time, moreover, that class tensions reappeared in England, in the form of a new trade union militancy and the associated campaign for manhood suffrage.⁷ True to his Liberal Anglican views, Moule was troubled by these signs of factionalism and crisis, as can be seen in two poems of this time. In 'On Idylls of the King', he gave thanks for the hero, Arthur, who upheld Christianity against the barbarian hordes, and for Tennyson's wisdom, much needed now, to still 'the hubbub of our lives' (49).

Moule's poem on Cromwell (1861)⁸ also reveals his yearning for a strong Christian ruler who would rise above social conflict and carry through the reform of church and state. He represents Cromwell as a

warrior-statesman, guided by faith, standing high above the ruck of religious faction before the battles of Dunbar and Worcester, when his people are near to panic and despair. The need of his and Moule's times is pointed up by Cromwell's prayer:

Even now behold us where we battle still,
And toil, and – toiling – see not yet the end,
But barren wrangling, apathetic will,
With friend and *foe* commingled, foe and friend.
Strike one strong ray on our bewildered kind,
Meting sure limits for true men and good,
For wise men and for foolish, rich and poor:
Until we wonder, simpler grown, to find
State-knots resolved and Parliaments renewed. . . .

Young Thomas Hardy must have been struck by these ideas, for they remained with him all his life, as we shall see when we consider his views on home rule for Ireland and the 'New Imperialism' of the 1890s. Deploring the factionalism into which that event plunged British politics, the older Hardy yearned for a strong leader to emerge above the ruck of politics to unify a distracted England.

Meanwhile, it is worth lingering a moment longer to consider Moule's views on university extension classes for adult education. Back at Dorchester from 1857, he threw himself into campaigning for this reform, which Liberal Anglicans had advocated. Thus he became a champion of the Dorchester Working Men's Mutual Improvement Society, founded in 1856. It was exactly the kind of action favoured by the university radicals for building social harmony between the classes. A Dorset landowner, H. C. Sturt, financed the purchase of its premises and Dorset Members of Parliament donated newspapers and periodicals for its reading room. By 1861 over 200 evening classes were held. Regular public lectures were given on scientific and literary topics.

Moule became a star turn as a lecturer to the members and his chosen topics reflected the Liberal Anglican theory of social renewal. For example, in his first lecture, entitled 'Oxford, Past and Present',⁹ he referred to the 'great movement' for reform of the university, notably the introduction of the local entrance examinations. In characteristic Liberal Anglican terms, he traced the history of the university from the twelfth century, when it was open to poor students, to the introduction of the college system, which shut them out by granting a monopoly to the noble and rich. This

took him to the new proposals for university extension at Oxford, on which he commented: 'The advantages of Oxford, before this new scheme set on foot, were only for the class who could afford to send their sons into residence. Residence would always remain a benefit which admitted of no substitute, but examination might be extended to the vast middle class of this country, and the university was now coming forward to do so.'

As we shall see, Hardy remembered Moule's account of Oxford's past and inscribed a much darker version of it in *Jude the Obscure*. By then it was clear that Moule had been over-optimistic in his assumption that university extension to the middle class would also allow for working-class inclusion. In the upshot, the Oxford plan was stillborn.¹⁰

Even less did Moule have any conception of adult education based on the class interest of labour, later pioneered by the Workers' Education Association. Like Thomas Arnold, he thought that working people must earn social inclusion by adopting the culture of their betters. He shared this underlying distrust of the working classes with many of the university radicals¹¹ and tended to lecture them on the need for self-improvement rather than legislation. Returning thanks to the chairman after his lecture on Oxford, he observed lamely that 'there was much talk in the present day about reform, he urged upon all, especially his younger hearers, to pay attention to reform in their own individual case, and there would be less need of parliamentary or university reform'.¹²

In time, as biographers have shown, young Thomas Hardy came to resent this patronising attitude and proved capable after 1865 of striking out in his own political direction. Yet, though Hardy was to become radical on issues of lifestyle, he adhered to Moule's distrust of class antagonism and always held to a class-collaborative ideal in British politics.

For the moment, however, he was under Moule's spell as they talked about books in their walks around Dorchester. We know nothing about these conversations, except that Moule recommended two books – Bagehot's *Estimates* and *Essays and Reviews*, which Hardy recalled as 'impressing him much'. We can only know what this amounted to by examining these books. This will show that they suggested an accommodation between science and faith which would lead both men into difficult territory. The difficulties were to place intolerable stress on Moule, contributing to his suicide in 1875. Hardy was also troubled, but he survived by jettisoning providentialism from the Liberal Anglican idea of history. To that process we now turn.

NOTES

1. H. Moule, *Christian Oratory: An Inquiry into Its History during the First Five Centuries* (Cambridge, 1859): www.archive.org/details/christianoragory00moule.
2. All quotations in this chapter are from the three-volume edition, 'new and revised', of 1867.
3. He gives the citation *Manual of the History of Philosophy*, p. 165, n. 1.
4. Millgate, *Hardy Revisited*, p. 66.
5. Millgate, *Hardy Revisited*, p. 54.
6. See F. Reid, 'Horace Moule and Thomas Hardy in the Age of Palmerston', *Hardy Society Journal*, VI, 2, 2010, pp. 58–68, where I discuss the relevance of Moule's writing for Hardy's admiration of Palmerston. It does not consider, as I do in this study, Moule's debt to the Liberal Anglican idea of history.
7. Finn, *After Chartism*, pp. 142–226.
8. For the idealisation of Cromwell, see J. P. D. Dunbabin, 'Oliver Cromwell's Popular Image in Nineteenth-Century England', in J. S. Bromley and E. H. Kossman (eds), *Britain and the Netherlands* (The Hague), pp. 141–63, at pp. 160–61.
9. DCC, 11 November 1858.
10. See J. F. C. Harrison, *Learning and Living: A Study in the History of the English Adult Education Movement* (London, 1961), pp. 249–274.
11. Kent, *Brains and Numbers*, p. 33.
12. DCC, 15 November 1858.

Walter Bagehot and the Writing of History

In this and the following chapter, I show how the reading of Bagehot's *Estimates*¹ and *Essays and Reviews* brought about young Thomas Hardy's loss of faith in Liberal Anglican providentialism.

4.1 HISTORY FOR A COMMERCIAL AGE

At the centre of Bagehot's book is his critique of Thomas Babington Macaulay's *History of England*, published 1849–1861, and his own suggestions for a new kind of historical writing.

What Bagehot found admirable in Macaulay's work was his understanding that history was driven by passion. In the great third chapter of his *History* he demonstrated that the rise of English commerce was

'one of those noiseless revolutions' whose progress is rarely indicated by what historians are pleased to call important events. They are not achieved by armies, or enacted by senates. 'They are sanctioned by no treaties, and recorded in no archives. They are carried on in every school, in every church, behind ten thousand counters, at ten thousand firesides. The upper current of society presents no certain criterion by which we can judge of the direction in which the under current flows.' (433)

Yet Macaulay, Bagehot argued, fell short as a historian because he understood only one of the passions that sway human nature, the passion for business. This allowed him to write history for a 'commercial

age', but blinded him from an understanding that human nature was often swayed by other passions.

Underlying this limitation was Macaulay's mistaken belief that the business motive was rational, not emotional. Bagehot was convinced that it was the latter and that 'Deep under the surface of the intellect lies the *stratum* of the passions, of the intense, peculiar, simple impulses which constitute the heart of man; there is the eager essence, the primitive desiring being' (428).

This view led Bagehot to a remarkable anticipation of the postmodern characterisation of historical writing. He considered it ought to be written more like fiction. Macaulay's *History* made everything seem too predictable. His style is 'too omniscient' (448). He fails to understand that historical judgment is only a matter of 'probability':

This is hardly the style for history. The data of historical narratives, especially of modern histories, are a heap of confusion. No one can tell where they lie, or where they do not lie; what is in them, or what is not in them . . . history is a vestige of vestiges; few facts leave any trace of themselves, any witness of their occurrence; of fewer still is that witness preserved; a slight track is all anything leaves, and the confusion of life, the tumult of change sweep even that away in a moment (448).

Where, then, should modern readers turn to see history written as Bagehot desired? His answer was to poetry, especially the poetic drama of Shakespeare. This, for Bagehot, was the lesson taught by the Romantic movement.

4.2 SHELLEY

The Romantic poets interested Bagehot as men who, unlike businessmen, were never schooled to practicality and who were, in consequence, carried away by their passions to pursue fantasies and utopias. The most extreme in this regard was Shelley, whom young Thomas Hardy admired as 'our most marvelous lyrist'.² It could hardly have escaped his notice that Bagehot, despite his strictures, shared this estimate. Shelley's youthful resistance to his father's patriarchal view of marriage led him to challenge the conventional Christian view of sexual love. This led him to the sceptical philosophy of David Hume, which he read as justifying his own atheism (298).

Bagehot could sympathise with Shelley because he also had read Hume and Kant in his youth: 'I confess', he wrote, 'that I am one of those who am unable to refuse my assent to the conclusions of those philosophers who assert that "nothing exists but as it is perceived".' What he admired in Shelley was his quest for some ground of belief from which to resist this vertiginous scepticism. Like Shelley, he wished to believe that the whole of nature is a unity, that 'I... who now write and think... am but a portion of the one mind' (298).

But banker Bagehot, whatever he felt in his youth, now believed that Shelley had gone too far. Commercial society could not survive, let alone progress, if the Shelleys prevail. Society cannot bear too much liberty. Atheism and hedonism must end in the masque of anarchy. How, then, are men to be taught to curb their passions?

At one level Bagehot is attracted by the Liberal Anglican answer that reason is the product of maturation, alike in the 'individual' and in 'history' (292). Yet he could not finally convince himself that theology could be effective as the cement to hold English society together in the nineteenth century. The French and industrial revolutions had spread scepticism among practical men (184). Evangelicals and Tractarians were trying to hold it back with the weapon of 'Truth', the former with the literal truth of the Bible, the latter with the truth of Catholic authority. But dogmatic theology could never win universal assent from practical Englishmen, steeped in the scientific principle that knowledge could only come from the experience of the senses. Ultimate truth about nature and God was inaccessible. Nor was the Liberal Anglican accommodation any more effective. Dr Arnold had made his pact with science on behalf of faith, but when it came to the test in Rugby school, morality it seemed was to be inculcated by hammer blows.³

Practical men, Bagehot concluded, must be won for law – civil, moral and religious – through their imaginations. This had been the project of the Romantic poets. Unfortunately their work would fall on deaf ears: 'the million won't read it. Why should they? – they could not understand it, – don't put them out, – let them buy and sell, and die' (362).

4.3 COLERIDGE AND SHAKESPEARE

Fortunately, as Bagehot saw it, there was a Romantic substitute for theology. Coleridge, in his lectures on Shakespeare, had pointed to a poetic repository of symbols that could win the hearts and minds of the practical Englishman. This was the poetic drama of Shakespeare, their national bard.

For Bagehot, Shakespeare appealed to practical men because his was an ‘experiencing nature’. He went about the world and learned how things stood by direct observation and imagined himself into their inner feelings. In his plays, soldiers, shepherds and fools muse upon their experience of life, the unpredictability of war, the vicissitudes of the seasons, the dragging driving of time as melancholy swings to cheerfulness. ‘Great imaginative works’ (252) always spring from this kind of sensibility. Nor is its fancy limited by Christian revelation. Shakespeare can revel in the pagan world outlook, dwelling alike on the passionate love of Venus from classical mythology and the sprite of mischief from English fairy tales.

The best thing about Shakespeare for Bagehot was his English sense of religion. He had no time for what some Victorians have come to over-value in religion: repression of pleasure, earnestness, sabbatarian reverence for ‘pews and altar cloths’ (270). His object of worship was ‘the underlying and almighty essence of this world’, and England was its embodiment:

This England lay before Shakespeare as it lies before us all, with its green fields, and its long hedgerows, and its many trees, and its great towns, and its endless hamlets, and its motley society, and its long history, and its bold exploits, and its gathering power; and he saw that they were good. (270)

4.4 CONCLUSION

As Hardy began writing *Life and Work* around 1917, he had no doubt that the early reading of Bagehot’s *Estimates* had been a life-changing experience. No one familiar with Hardy’s fiction can find it difficult to see why. It led him, as Tom Paulin noted,⁴ to Hume’s dictum, ‘Reason is, and ought only to be the slave of the passions’. It is hardly likely that he grasped all the philosophical implications of this immediately. As *Life and Work* makes clear, they grew with time in his mind. It refers frequently to his belief that human action was mostly irrational. In 1921, for example, he replied to a letter from a correspondent: ‘He thinks he could show that no man is a rationalist, and that human actions are not ruled by reason at all in the last resort’ (432). Back in 1884 he wrote, with reference to Hegel and others:

Query: Is not the present quasi-scientific system of writing history mere charlatanism? Events and tendencies are traced as if they were rivers of voluntary activity, and courses reasoned out from the circumstances in

which natures, religions, or what-not, have found themselves. But are they not in the main the outcome of passivity – acted upon by unconscious propensity? (175)

It seems safe to suggest, then, that even in 1860, Hardy could think that historical change might be driven more by blind instinct and chance than by a providential logos or human reason. This might lead to moral relativism. At the very least, pagan views of life were as valid as Christian ones. Historical writing grounded on any postulate of essential truth must be regarded with scepticism. Fiction, as Bagehot argued, might be a better guide to the passions and therefore to philosophical history. The times required a novelist who, like Shakespeare, was close to the experience of ordinary people and agnostic about religious doctrine. Such a novelist might find his material in contemplating England and its people – especially its country people.

All this called into question the fundamental belief of the Liberal Anglican historians that universal history was fulfilling God's providence. Hardy found further support for this view in the other book he singled out as impressing him much, *Essays and Reviews*. To this I now turn.

NOTES

1. W. Bagehot, *Estimates of Some Englishmen and Scotchmen: A Series of Articles Reprinted Principally from the National Review* (London, 1858).
2. *Life and Work*, p. 22.
3. Arnold had an unenviable reputation in his own day for beating pupils severely. See T. Copley, *Black Tom, Arnold of Rugby: The Myth and the Man* (London, 2002), pp. 117ff.
4. T. Paulin, *Thomas Hardy: The Poetry of Perception* (London, 1975), p. 17.

Essays and Reviews, Frederick Temple and Baden Powell

Life and Work coupled *Essays and Reviews* with Baghehot's *Estimates* as works which impressed young Thomas Hardy. The book is a collection of essays by seven Liberal Anglican theologians. It has received much recent scholarly attention and is well known in Hardy criticism. Yet the opening essay by Frederick Temple and Baden Powell's essay on the relationship of science to Christian faith will repay further study in this chapter. The former reworked the cyclical theory of progress propounded by the Liberal Anglican historians and is therefore strong evidence that Hardy was well acquainted with that philosophy of history. The latter acknowledged David Hume's scepticism about religious belief and is further evidence that Hardy made early acquaintance with the Scottish sceptic. Both essays, as I will show, influenced Hardy's turn to agnosticism, the first by reaction, the second by conviction.

In [Sections 5.1](#) and [5.2](#) of this chapter, therefore, I review the essays in turn. In [Section 5.3](#) I show how the introduction to Hume influenced Hardy's reaction to J. H. Newman's defence of his own early Liberal Anglicanism. I conclude in [Section 5.4](#) by suggesting that this and the previous chapter together identify the 'theological study' which undermined Hardy's belief in Christian providence.

5.1 FREDERICK TEMPLE ON THE EDUCATION OF THE WORLD

Temple was the third successor to Thomas Arnold as head of Rugby school. Though drawn to the Oxford movement in early manhood, by the time he took up his post in 1857 he was deeply committed to the Liberal Anglican idea of history. Not surprisingly, then, his opening contribution to *Essays and Reviews* draws heavily on it. As the modern editors of *Essays and Reviews* point out, understanding of this tradition is essential to the reading of a difficult and convoluted text.¹

Temple began his essay by attacking materialism. Against it he presented the organicist theory of social development inherited by the Liberal Anglicans from Coleridge and the German Romantics. Change in material phenomena, he allowed, could be imagined as ‘a succession of cycles’, eternally repeating ‘the same changes in a fixed order of recurrence’ through millions of years (137). Such a universe, however, would be ‘a dead machine’ driven by ‘an iron rule which guides to nothing and ends in nothing’ (ibid.).

This materialism, Temple went on, was possible to ‘the logical understanding’ (ibid.), but not to the spiritual component of the human personality. Here he was drawing on a basic Romantic dichotomy between two powers of the mind. By understanding, it could analyse nature into parts. By reason, or what Temple called ‘spirit’, it could synthesise nature as a whole, showing how it developed teleologically under the law of an invisible power. It followed that we ought to expect progress in the spiritual world even as we expect fixity in the material.

This was what we did find in the history of the human career. The education of the world was nothing other than the developing knowledge of a process, analogous to the development of an individual. For Temple, the human species was a unity, a ‘colossal man’ (ibid.), which ‘grows in knowledge, in self-control, in visible size, just as we do and his education is in the same way and for the same reason precisely similar to ours’ (ibid.).

Temple went on to sketch an account of this universal history which is by now familiar to us. In the childhood of the race, humans were almost lawless, swayed by their most selfish passions. They could only be made more law abiding by an appeal to their conscience; that is, their imagination. This was the work of great religious teachers.

The Jewish nation was selected by God for this kind of education. Its prophets taught the growing nation to quell selfish passions and live for ‘love and brotherly kindness . . . truth and justice’ (141). In this way,

it was disciplined to accept the two cardinal points of their religion: 'a settled national belief in the unity and spirituality of God, and an acknowledgment of the paramount importance of chastity as a point of morals' (142).

Humans thus learn to choose between government and anarchy, both in their own soul and in the world. The crucial difference, for Temple, between monotheism and polytheism is that the latter imagines 'Gods many and lords many, with bodily appetites and animal passions' (*ibid.*). Pagan religion had to be trampled down because it justified violence and in chastity.

Here Temple was embracing the Evangelical wing of the Church of England. During the 1790s its leading moralists, William Wilberforce and Hannah More, had argued that the catastrophe of the French revolution had been preceded by the scepticism of the *Philosophes*.² This had led the French upper classes to reject the Christian revelation and pursue pleasure rather than holiness. Wilberforce and More warned the English upper classes against imitating the levity of the French. The lower classes could only be taught patient submission to their hard lot if they saw their betters living sober and chaste lives under Christ's yoke. As Temple saw it, the upper-class youth of England were to be taught this lesson in their public schools.

The education of the Hebrews, Temple proceeded, must be fulfilled in the spiritual development of the human race, as manifested in the history of the church. It passed through three stages, each developing under the inspiration of a great teacher. After the first childhood stage came youth, a transition between childhood and manhood which began with the coming of Jesus Christ. The crucial difference between the two stages was that Moses taught discipline by law, Jesus taught it by example.

Liberal Anglicans had recognised a third, or manhood, stage in church history. As with the individual, the mature church comes to accept law through the process of 'reflection' or reason. The greatest gain of this stage is that the church learns not to 'attempt the solution of insoluble problems'. Faced with doctrine like the Trinity, it 'confesses its own weakness' (156).

At this point the reader may wonder if Temple is throwing Christian teaching open entirely to private judgement. But any such reading is immediately checked. The freedom Temple is offering is the freedom to judge under divine rule. The mature person must obey the voice of conscience, which is the voice of God's law.

In this third stage of its maturity, therefore, the church 'is left to herself to work out, by her natural faculties, the principles of her own action' (159), discarding obsolete dogma and developing the Barbarian principle of liberty into that of Toleration. Protestant and Catholic in the Church of England, Temple argued, were coming to adopt this principle, however hesitantly and timidly. Science, history and a wider knowledge of the world had enlarged their philosophical boundaries: 'There are found to be more things in heaven and earth than were dreamt of in the patristic theology' (*ibid.*).

This, for Temple, was the real lesson of the Bible, but to use the Bible as a guide to action, it must be subjected to rational criticism. This accommodation of faith to science was 'The immediate work of our day' (164). The errors and blunders of past interpretation must be cleared away and its message understood in the light of modern science.

The foregoing review of Temple's essay, I suggest, confirms my hypothesis that young Thomas Hardy was familiar with the Liberal Anglican idea of history. We do not know for certain that Hardy read Moule's essay on Christian oratory (as opposed to listening to Moule talking about it). But we do know from *Life and Work* that Hardy read *Essays and Reviews* and that it impressed him greatly. Temple's essay impressed him so much that, when writing *The Dynasts* many years later, he put into the mouth of the Spirit of the Pities Temple's synecdochic trope of humanity as a colossal man, with potential, like the individual, to develop reason:

Men gain cognition with the flux of time,
And wherefore not the force informing them,
When far-ranged aeons past all fathoming
Shall have swung by, and stand as backward years?³

And there is surely a glance back to the attraction of Temple's idealism, when Hardy, now long schooled in sceptical philosophies, has the Chorus of the Years respond: 'You almost charm my long philosophy out of my strong-built thought, and bear me back to when I thanks gave thus.'⁴

Yet to a young man who was also impressed by Bagehot's *Estimates*, there must have been something jarring in Temple's essay. This was its narrow Evangelical view of human nature. For Temple, humankind was enslaved to original sin, the violent passions which prompted Adam and Eve to disobey God. Temple could not have approved Bagehot's warm

endorsement of love as ‘the most pure and eager of human passions’. He adhered to what one historian has called the conservative strand in the sexual ideology of Christianity.⁵ Before very long, as we shall see, Hardy was to encounter an altogether different view of human sexuality, very sympathetic to Shelley, whom he already considered the greatest of English lyric poets.

Nor was this all that Hardy acquired by reflection on *Essays and Reviews*. Baden Powell’s contribution would have reinforced Bagehot’s challenge to Liberal Anglican dogma.

5.2 BADEN POWELL AND THE EVIDENCES OF CHRISTIANITY

If Temple’s essay was supportive of the Liberal Anglican idea of history, Baden Powell’s took a Humean scalpel to cut out its providentialist heart. This had been propounded in the writings of Thomas Arnold’s mentor at Oriel College, Richard Whately.

Whately’s views were presented in three works which stood high among liberal churchmen in the nineteenth century. The first, *Historic Doubts Relative to Napoleon Buonaparte*, appeared in 1819. Whately argued against Hume that to disbelieve the reports of the resurrection on the ground that such events lay outside experience was unreasonable. If it were true that the miraculous events of Jesus’s life and resurrection were so extraordinary as to seem incredible, the same conclusion must be reached concerning Napoleon. What could be more improbable than ‘the very extraordinary nature of those [Napoleon’s] exploits’⁶ as reported in newspapers at the time and histories since.

The second work was his *Elements of Logic* of 1826.⁷ Here Whately argued (also against Hume) that God’s existence was no mere matter of probability. True to his Oriel training in Aristotelian logic, Whately held that deduction from a first principle, syllogistic reasoning, could provide a valid proof. He illustrated with the following example: ‘Whatever exhibits marks of design had an intelligent author; the world exhibits marks of design; therefore the world had an intelligent author.’⁸

In the third work, *Lectures on Political Economy*,⁹ Whately argued that the new science of political economy provided inductive support for the view that civilisation arose under the direction of a wise providence. God had so made humans that they had to exchange commodities and create

markets in order to live. In so doing, each individual has only their own survival in view, yet unconsciously creates a vast city like London as inevitably as individual bees produce the hive.

Whately denied the contention of eighteenth-century Rationalists that this division of labour arose spontaneously from competition in the first savage state of humankind. Civilisation, he insisted, had been a gift from God and the arts must have been given to humanity by divine revelation. Indigenous Australians, for example, could never have invented the boomerang by themselves. This was nothing short of a miracle.

In Whately's view, then, syllogistic logic proved the existence of God by deductive reasoning from a first principle. Scientific or inductive reasoning as found in political economy worked to the same end, proving to a high degree of probability that modern commercial civilisation must have grown up in accordance with the providential plan.

What evidence is there that young Thomas Hardy was familiar with Whately's writings? Millgate has shown that Hardy possessed a copy of Whately's *Logic*, probably the gift of Horace Moule. Moreover, when Hardy came to represent Bathsheba Everdene in *Far from the Madding Crowd*, he remembered what he had read and inscribed the view that syllogistic logic could be just as unconstructive as the passions: 'Many of her thoughts were perfect syllogisms; unluckily they always remained thoughts. Only a few were irrational assumptions but, unfortunately, they were the ones which most frequently grew into deeds' (131).

Furthermore, the close resemblance between Whately's urban commerce and Hardy's Casterbridge strongly suggests familiarity with the very popular *Lectures on Political Economy*. Not only does Casterbridge recall Whately's comments on Mandeville's analogy between a beehive and the urban market, it also deals with a situation Whately had already analysed:

corn-dealers in particular are often exposed to odium, as if they were the cause of the scarcity; while in reality they are performing the important service of husbanding the supply in proportion to its deficiency, and thus warding off the calamity of famine. (107f)

Returning now to Baden Powell's essay, the Oxford Professor of Mathematics, who was married to Whately's sister, had for some years contended against Whately's lines of reasoning. He did not pull his punches in *Essays and Reviews*. Hume, he argued, had been right to find

the evidence for miracles extremely unconvincing. That something extraordinary had happened may well have been the case. But the reports of eyewitnesses to the resurrection and other miracles were open to inductive explanation, either in terms of mythology, as in David Strauss's *Life of Jesus*, or in terms of self-delusion, such as is familiar enough in modern times.

In the 'present day', therefore, as Baden Powell went on to argue, Christians must recognise that science and faith stood on completely different grounds. Every educated person knew enough about science to understand that physical events followed one another in a sequence so regular as to be supposed the result of some antecedent cause. As Hume and Kant had shown, there was no way of going behind this to gain knowledge of the first cause.

And if science and theology stood on different grounds, the attempt to bring them together must be discarded. Here Baden Powell singled out Whately's *Historic Doubts Relative to Napoleon Buonaparte* for withering scorn: 'these delightful parodies on Scripture (if they prove anything), would simply prove that the Bible narrative is no more properly *miraculous* than the marvelous exploits of Napoleon I, or the paradoxical events of recent history' (258).

Theologians, therefore, should stop insisting that any physical event was impossible. Until recently physiologists had denied the possibility of evolution. But, as Powell pointed out, Darwin had just published a book showing that species could evolve out of other species through natural causes. Previous denials of this were possible only because knowledge was then imperfect, and Whately's claim that savages could not have civilised themselves was a similar case, based on 'very little knowledge of savages' (258).

Finally, Powell accepted that Christian faith in the nineteenth century rested not on any kind of rational demonstration, but on what David Hume had called the passion of hope.

5.3 HARDY, HUME AND NEWMAN

With this we arrive at the central significance of *Essays and Reviews* for young Thomas Hardy. Together with Bagehot's *Estimates*, it moved Hardy towards Hume's view of Christianity, as developed in his *Treatise of Human Nature* and repeated in his *Dialogues on Natural Religion*. Hume argued that all knowledge is derived from experience. Knowledge

of God does not rest on experience, since no one has seen God, and cannot be proved by reasoning from first principles. The so-called proofs of natural religion are no better than guesses, resting on weak reasoning by analogy.

Whether Hume himself was an atheist has been disputed, but what many readers received from the *Dialogues* was not atheism. Hume takes up finally the position that T. H. Huxley, in the 1860s, would dub 'agnosticism'. The agnostic must ask what rational grounds there are for religious belief. Hume admits that there are some, but denies that they amount to proof. It is reasonable to believe in a first cause of the universe, but 'superstition' to 'anthropomorphise' it as omnipotent, just, cruel or benign. There is no more reason to believe in the loving Father-God of Christianity than in the divinities of Olympus.

This line of argument could be devastating to young people like Hardy. It left no possibility of continuing to believe in the simple pieties of childhood. Further, it undermined the confident Christian optimism of such men as Richard Whately that society was designed for the ultimate good of humankind, like a warm, nourishing beehive.

What evidence is there in *Life and Work*, besides the cryptic reference to Bagehot and *Essays and Reviews*, that Hardy was especially influenced by Hume's philosophy to discard providentialism? We have a clue in the notebook entry on Newman's *Apologia Pro Vita Sua*. It has been quoted very often, but the Humean context and language of the comment should be made explicit.

Newman published his *Apologia* in 1864 to defend himself against charges that he had dishonestly concealed his attraction towards Roman Catholicism for years before suddenly announcing his conversion in 1845.¹⁰ He referred to his early reading of Hume (89), yet he had never succumbed to infidelity. Rather, his faith had grown through a long series of thought experiments from childhood 'sympathies' to rational understanding. The *Apologia* was his introspective recapitulation of this process, somewhat in the manner of Wordsworth's 'Prelude'. He endeavored to show that the outcome was the resultant of 'converging probabilities' (101). One of these was his personal growth in philosophical understanding, guided at first by his friend and mentor Richard Whately, at Oriel College. The other was 'the whole course of Christian thought, from the first years of the Catholic teaching up to the present day', which had 'a unity and individuality' as demonstrable as 'a mathematical curve' which 'has its own law and expression' (240).

This accommodation of inductive logic to Christian truth was very similar to the Liberal Anglican thought in which Newman had grown up at Oriel. The only difference was that it led him out of the Church of England to Rome. It was not so far either from Hume's method of ascending from an examination of sensation to 'the capital' of the moral sciences.¹¹ The only difference was that Hume would not have acknowledged theological truth as one of the probabilities, like the rise and set of the sun, by which human beings would be wise to live.

Viewed in this context, Hardy's notebook entry should not be dismissed as the light inconsequence of a clever young man.¹² It reveals a mind that was seriously engaging with the issue between Newman and Hume, and coming down on the side of agnosticism, because it cannot accept probability as a reason for believing dogma.

July 2 (1865). Worked at J. H. Newman's *Apologia*, which we have all been talking about lately. A great desire to be convinced by him, because H. M. M. likes him so much. Style charming, and his logic really human, being based not on syllogisms but on converging probabilities. Only – and here comes the fatal catastrophe – there is no first link to his excellent chain of reasoning, and down you come headlong.¹³

5.4 CONCLUSION

This and the previous chapter, I suggest, have brought into clearer relief the significance of Hardy's cryptic reference, in *Life and Work*, to 'some theological study',¹⁴ which influenced him when he considered abandoning architecture for the church. The process had begun, at the prompting of Moule, before his departure for London. He read Bagehot's *Estimates and Essays and Reviews*, and discussed them with his friend during 'walks in the fields'. They led him to Hume and, 'on examination',¹⁵ he found himself to be at least agnostic about God and quite unable to accept the providentialism that was integral to Liberal Anglicanism. Henceforth his belief in the progress of humanity towards the rule of loving kindness would require a logic that was 'really human...based not on syllogisms but on converging probabilities.'

As he pondered this possibility, he was influenced by writers in the new naturalistic discourse of evolution: Charles Darwin, Auguste Comte, George Drysdale and John Stuart Mill. The influence of Darwin needs no special treatment in this study. Thanks mainly to the work of Gillian

Beer,¹⁶ it is now well understood. She demonstrated that Darwin's *Origin of Species* neither endorsed pessimism about human history nor stymied optimism. It left Hardy free to draw melioristic conclusions from the new science of social evolution that was given wider recognition in the 1860s by the new English translation of Auguste Comte's *General View of Positivism*, to which I turn in the next chapter.

NOTES

1. V. Shea and W. Whitla (eds), *Essays and Reviews: The 1860 Text and its Reading* (London, 2000), p. 51.
2. F. K. Brown, *Fathers of the Victorians: The Age of Wilberforce* (Cambridge, 1961); W. Hague, *William Wilberforce: Life of the Great Anti-Slavery Campaigner* (London, 2008).
3. T. Hardy, *The Dynasts* (London, 1910), 'Afterscene', p. 522.
4. *The Dynasts*, p. 524.
5. J. Maynard, *Victorian Discourses on Sexuality and Religion* (Cambridge, 1993), p. 33.
6. R. Whately, *Historic Doubts Relative to Napoleon Buonaparte* (London, 1819) p. 3.
7. R. Whately, *Elements of Logic, Comprising the Substance of the Article in Encyclopedia Metropolitana Additions, &c* (London, 1826).
8. Whately, *Logic*, p. 28.
9. R. Whately, *Introductory Lectures to Political Economy* (London, 1831).
10. J. H. Newman, *Apologia Pro Vita Sua: Being a Reply to a Pamphlet Entitled 'What, then, does Dr Newman Mean?'* (London, 1864).
11. D. Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature, I: A Critical Edition*, ed. D. F. and M. J. Norton (Oxford, 2007), p. 5.
12. Pite, *Hardy*, pp. 211f.
13. Hardy, *Life and Work*, p. 50.
14. Hardy, *Life and Work*, p. 53.
15. Hardy, *Life and Work*, p. 53.
16. G. Beer, *Darwin's Plots: Evolutionary Narrative in Darwin, George Eliot and Nineteenth-Century Fiction* (London, 1983), esp. pp. 236–60.

Auguste Comte

Young Thomas Hardy's interest in Comte will come as no surprise to anyone in the least familiar with Hardy criticism. It was to be lifelong, as indicated throughout *Life and Work*. Comte's influence on Hardy has been the subject of considerable scholarly study. I suggest nevertheless that more remains to be said. In [Section 6.1](#), I show how Comte's Positivism would have struck a young man already interested in literature and familiar with the Liberal Anglican idea of history. In [Section 6.2](#) I show what Hardy would have reacted against in Comte, and in [Section 6.3](#) I summarise my conclusions thus far.

6.1 A LIBERAL ANGLICAN VIEW OF POSITIVISM

In the light of foregoing chapters, we can now see that Comte responded to the age of revolution in ways that were very similar to Liberal Anglicanism. He had first set out his philosophy of history in a course of lectures, published between 1830 and 1842 as *Cours de Philosophie Positive*.

Comte argued at the end of the *Cours* that the French revolution of 1789 had failed to unite France, and that the imperialism of Napoleon had plunged western Europe into a state of spiritual 'anarchy'. Like his early mentor, Le Duc de St Simon, he believed that the progress of industrialism intensified this process, plunging the period 1815–1848 into class conflict and political factionalism.

In these circumstances men turned to false speculations: on one hand to the Catholic followers of Joseph de Maistre who romanticised the Middle Ages (somewhat in the manner of the Oxford movement in England); on the other to the Communists, followers of Charles Fourier in France and Robert Owen in England.

The Liberal Anglican historians, as we have seen, made a similar diagnosis, and, like Comte, rejected both cures, the first because it vainly tried to reverse the material progress of society, the latter because it presented a false and immoral idea of human nature.

In the *Cours*, Comte pronounced himself an atheist and rejected the idea that human progress was the outcome of divine providence. For this Christian teleology he substituted a wholly secular one, in which progress was seen as determined by the operation of human reason. Human understanding of natural phenomena, he argued, had progressed through three stages, from the theological, through the metaphysical to the scientific or 'positive'. This last stage saw humans extending their understanding from the sciences of nature to the science of society, for which Comte coined the term 'sociology'.

Comte's atheism obscured other resemblances between his philosophy of history and the Liberal Anglican idea. Both were based on an organic view of social development.¹ Like Thomas Arnold, he argued that society was a living organism, without which individual human beings could not exist. Sociology must investigate it as physiology investigated other organisms. It would proceed in two ways. First, social statics would demonstrate that societies were sustained by social classes or 'organs' of the social system. Second, social dynamics would investigate the laws of natural development of the whole system. This dual procedure would show that each of the parts or groups had a distinct function in sustaining the whole and that it developed like the individual human beings of which it was composed. Thus Comte, like the Liberal Anglicans, imagined a development of humanity in accordance with a synecdochic trope, appealing to an exact analogy between the individual and the social whole.

By 1848 Comte had come to think that this sketch in the *Cours* was too dry and intellectual to appeal to everyone who should live by it. He therefore set about a revision of his social thought, which he published in four volumes. On Moule's recommendation, Hardy read the first of them in 1865, when J. H. Bridges published an English translation entitled *A General View of Positivism*.²

Comte's new departure in the *General View* was to argue that 'social regeneration' (iv) required a reconstruction of the human religious outlook. This must accommodate the progress of science and industry while upholding the moral principle of order against the chimera of revolution. It must be spread by education through 'every department of private and public life'. It would thus constitute a 'spiritual power' (v), which would satisfy people's emotional need to worship a superior being and their experience of the natural world.

As much as Milman, then, Comte was now convinced that most people were spiritual beings, ruled by their emotions rather than their reason. Positivist sociology, therefore, must identify an emotion which could be accepted as universally rational. Judeo-Christianity had called this 'loving kindness'. Comte called it 'altruism', a term he claimed to have invented. Altruism, he now argued, would be realised not by divine providence, but by the natural evolution of reason, in accordance with the law of the three stages.

The terms in which Comte presented this evolution as history also bore close resemblance to the Liberal Anglican idea. In the earliest stage, he argued, humans had to satisfy their material means of life by giving rein to their violent passions. This was the 'military' stage – 'feudal', as the Liberal Anglicans called it – when great chiefs ruled over warrior clans. Comte believed that civilisation consisted in progress towards an ever more peaceful regime, as violence was checked by the softer passions. In the European Middle Ages, Comte, like Milman, argued that the rule of feudal lords had been mitigated by Christian chivalry. As the feudal gave way to the modern age, industrial activity had come to predominate. But even this, the most peaceful mode of social existence hitherto, was driven by the egotistical passions. The man of business necessarily put forth his energy for selfish ends, as did soldiers, parliamentary politicians, lawyers and professional scientists. All were devoted to getting wealthy by the scientific practice of their arts. The health of society weighed little in their calculations.

In the *Cours*, Comte had relied on Positive philosophers of the future to persuade humanity of these truths of reason. Believing now that philosophy was too abstract for this purpose, he appealed in his *General View* to a new concept of effective social agency. These new agents were the altruistic classes, who proved of acute interest to young Thomas Hardy, powerfully attracted as he was to the biblical ethic of loving kindness.

Comte now argued that three ‘social groups’ (54) were naturally prone to the feelings of love and sympathy. These ‘altruistic classes’ were workers, women and artists.

Workers, for Comte, were naturally solidaristic. Social feeling with them was called forth by ‘their personal experience of the miseries of life’ (139). Yet their social feeling was limited by the hurly-burly of economic production, where they must struggle for existence.

Women, by contrast, were the true agents of the gentler emotions (219f). Naturally weaker, intellectually and physically, they had to limit male power by exercising their superior faculty for affection. Men recognised this natural superiority as appropriate in the domestic sphere, as opposed to the economic. Positivists must therefore associate women with their work of ‘social regeneration’.

Artists, for Comte, were the third altruistic class. Their art had always represented the highest moral type of human being according to the understanding of the age in which they worked. The artists of the future, taught by Positivism, would surpass the ancients in the representation of the highest moral type as a being subordinated ‘to the laws of social development as revealed by history’ (303).

By contrast to earlier ages, poetic fiction would be the leading art of the new era. It could best represent ‘history as a continuous whole’ (324) and the successors of Corneille and Scott would ‘range over the whole region of the past and even of the future’ (324).

6.2 REASON AND THE PASSIONS

As Comte believed, it was the chief task of Positivists to reform society by measures of improvement, chiefly educational. These, he thought, would increase the influence of the altruistic classes over the selfish and so promote the growth of solidarity. In support of this view, he drew upon his general theory of human nature. ‘The intellect’ he wrote, ‘never acts independently of feeling, be that feeling good or bad.’ Comte knew and admired David Hume’s writings.³ Unsurprisingly, therefore, his statement recalls the Scottish philosopher’s dictum that ‘Reason is, and ought only to be the slave of the passions’. Comte, however, modified Hume’s dictum: ‘the intellect is to be the servant of the heart, never its slave’ (20). At first sight, the reformulation may seem to anticipate present-day developments in evolutionary cognitive philosophy, which explores the question of the inter-relationship between brain science, environmental circumstances and

the development of sympathetic emotions in the human species.⁴ Comte, however, was not so modern. His Positivist sociology held that monogamy should last until death. His doctrine was challenged, as we shall see, by George Drysdale and John Stuart Mill. The point is important to register here, since Hardy, as we shall also see, was to sympathise with the challenge.

6.3 HARDY AND POSITIVISM

It is now possible to give a fuller explanation of the attraction of Comte to young Thomas Hardy. Like his mentor, Moule, he could respond to the many beliefs which Comte's social evolutionism shared with the Liberal Anglican idea of history. For both, society was an organism, developing through stages of infancy to maturity. Each understood western Europe to have reached a point of crisis in the manhood stage, when it was threatened by war, revolution and the return to barbarism. To overcome this, a new religion would be required, preaching the core values of Christian morality, but expressing them in a new symbolism. The propagation of the new religion would be, for Liberal Anglicans, following Coleridge, the work of a Christian clerisy. For Positivists, it would be produced by a scientifically educated priesthood, the Positivist philosophers.

For Comte, France would be the leading nation of humanity, pointing the way to a western republic and international solidarity. The Liberal Anglican historians, on the other hand, saw England as the leading nation, champion of constitutional liberty and Christian imperialism. But they feared political factions and class conflict every bit as much as Comte, and thought like him that manhood suffrage should be postponed until education had fitted the working class for it.

Even Comte's atheism and scientism were not insurmountable barriers to followers of the Liberal Anglican historians. Although some English Broad Churchmen, like Benjamin Jowett, bluntly dismissed Comte's new religion, others, like Charles Kingsley, were willing to entertain him as a leading modern philosopher who was striving for an accommodation between faith and science. Horace Moule, who had expressed admiration for Kingsley in his essay on Christian oratory, was also seeking such an accommodation. It is therefore unsurprising to find him recommending *A General View of Positivism* to his protégé.

Hardy was also attracted by Comte's idea of moral progress guided by scientific reason. It compensated for his loss of faith by allowing him to retain the idea of progress as an upward-moving cycle, a 'looped orbit',

as Hardy would call it. Attractive also must have been Comte's allocation of a vital part to poets in the making of the Positivist future. Hardy would never write a social utopia and would use his fiction to undermine many of Comte's cherished ideas about love and marriage. Yet he must have been struck by the idea that the novelist should represent history as 'a continuous whole' and his belief that women had a stronger faculty for loving-kindness than men.

For all that, Hardy was not to be a lifelong follower of Comte. This, I suggest, was because he found that Comte's idea of relations between the sexes jarred with his own experience in the 1860s. At the same time, he encountered two of Comte's English critics. In George Drysdale and John Stuart Mill he found writers who agreed with much of Comte's religion of humanity, but disagreed with his views on love and marriage. I turn first to Drysdale in the next chapter, and then to Mill in the final chapter of Part I.

NOTES

1. S. Andreski, *The Essential Comte: Selected from the Cours de Philosophie Positive* (London, 1974), p. 128.
2. J. H. Bridges, *General View of Positivism, Translated from the French of Auguste Comte* (London, 1865); Millgate, *Hardy Revisited*, p. 88.
3. Pickering, *Comte, III*, p. 160.
4. J. Haidt, *The Righteous Mind: Why Good People are Divided by Politics and Religion* (London, 2012), esp. Notes to Ch. 2, p. 380, n. 5.

George Drysdale and the Radical Hardy

The possibility of Hardy's youthful radicalism has often been suggested, partly on the basis of his remarks about *The Poor Man and the Lady* in *Life and Work*. These hinted at a link between sexual and political radicalism, an objection to class privilege as a barrier to natural love. Evidence of this link has been thought hard to come by, but two recent biographers have offered interesting suggestions.

Clare Tomalin noted that one of Hardy's working-class cousins 'seems to have been a radical, possibly even a republican'. Hardy, she went on to observe, knew of the Reform League, whose office was located beneath his own at Adelphi Terrace. Some of its members sympathised with republicanism and it campaigned for the extension of the vote to working men. On the day of a reform demonstration at Hyde Park, where the crowd turned violent, Hardy 'wrote the words "Hyde Park-morning" around the title of Shelley's revolutionary poem *The Revolt of Islam*, in his own recently acquired copy.'¹

This hint that Hardy, like Shelley, coupled protest against class oppression with sexual repression has received further support from the demonstration by Ralph Pite² of the intense eroticism in a notebook Hardy kept around the age of 25. This was inflamed, as Pite noted, by Hardy's reading of Algernon Charles Swinburne's *Poems and Ballads*. Pite thought it unlikely that Hardy, as a young man committed to Victorian respectability, slept with any of his girlfriends in the 1860s.³ He may be right, yet it is undeniable that young Thomas Hardy, in his

novel, *Desperate Remedies* (1871),⁴ could write of love in a way that strongly suggests personal experience of the sexual act:

They rowed that evening... Cytherea always sitting in the stern with the tiller ropes in her hands. The curves of her figure welded with those of the fragile boat in perfect continuation, as she girlishly yielded herself to its heaving and sinking, seeming to form with it an organic whole.⁵

Leaving aside the issue of experience versus imagination,⁶ the question I am asking here is: what influences helped to form young Thomas Hardy's views on sexuality? Lennart Bjork adduced evidence of links between Hardy and the French utopian communist, Charles Fourier, whom Hardy encountered in or about 1863, and considered in his *Literary Notebooks*.⁷ As we shall see, *A Pair of Blue Eyes* and *Far from the Madding Crowd* contain coded links to Fourier's writings. As Bjork allowed, however, there were undoubtedly other influences. In [Chapter 12](#), I offer evidence that the English communitarian socialist Robert Owen was one of those. The problem, however, about regarding Hardy as either Fourierist or Owenite is that he was liberal in politics, not socialist. By the 1860s, moreover, the influence of Fourierism and Owenism was all but dead in England. In this chapter, therefore, I offer evidence that Hardy was influenced by a current version of sexual liberation inspired by classic English liberalism, which he could absorb more easily. This was the writing of George Drysdale.

7.1 LIBERALISM AND REPUBLICANISM

Hardy grew up, as Tomalin pointed out, in a family that held liberal views on politics. *The Early Years of Thomas Hardy* points to strong sympathy with the campaign for repeal of the Corn Laws in 1846.⁸ After that, the cause of liberalism became associated with the Whig party in English parliamentary politics. In 1860 it adopted the title 'Liberal' for the first time.⁹ That Hardy took more than a passing interest in this development can be seen in his enthusiasm for the career of the Whig leader, Lord Palmerston, whose funeral he attended in 1865. He wrote an effusive letter on Palmerston's career to his sister Mary, which was inserted posthumously into his pseudo-biography.¹⁰ I quote from it at length in [Chapter 14](#). Here it is enough to note that Hardy had no

difficulty in identifying Palmerston and his successor as Prime Minister, Lord John Russell, with an ongoing liberal movement in English politics.

Less clear is the answer to the question: what did Hardy think a reformed Parliament ought to do? For answer we must look further into the context of popular politics in the later 1860s.¹¹

As mentioned above, the office of the Reform League was situated below that of Hardy's employer at Adelphi Terrace, London. The Reform League, which campaigned for extension of the franchise in 1865–1866, had a radical wing which looked beyond reform to social improvement through legislation. In 1866 Charles Bradlaugh was already prominent as a leader of this more radical wing.¹² In his youth he had been converted to secularism by George Jacob Holyoake. He founded the National Secular Society and linked it to his newspaper, *The National Reformer*. In its pages he campaigned for the radical causes of the time, beginning with franchise extension. He went on to serve on the Council of the Reform League during the agitation of 1866, but resigned in opposition to the compromising tactics of its secretary, George Howell. Beyond parliamentary reform he advocated social republicanism.¹³ That is to say, he attacked class privilege and called for land nationalisation, as well as abolition of the monarchy.¹⁴

At the same time Bradlaugh opposed Karl Marx and those 'social' republicans who tried to promote revolutionary class struggle. He wanted the working people to raise themselves and their class by self-improvement and economic enterprise, assisted by land reform and state education. In the meantime, he urged, working people could do much to mitigate their own poverty by limiting the size of their families. For this reason he supported 'Neo-Malthusianism', or the limitation of population by birth control. Along with his friend Annie Besant, he was to win fame and notoriety in the 1870s, when they were prosecuted for publishing a manual of birth-control instruction, *The Fruits of Philosophy*. That campaign lay in the future, but it originated in 1861, when Bradlaugh opened the pages of the *National Reformer* to the leading Neo-Malthusian theorist, Dr George Drysdale.¹⁵

Drysdale was the author of a treatise on reform of relations between the sexes by means of birth control.¹⁶ Entitled *The Elements of Social Science*, it appeared first in 1854 and ran through many editions, selling 100,000 copies by 1914.

Life and Work nowhere mentions Drysdale or the birth-control campaign. Yet a careful reading of Drysdale's text reveals many points of contact between his writing and Hardy's early fiction. In the next

section of this chapter, therefore, I review Drysdale's *Elements*. I then proceed to consider clues in *Life and Work* which suggest that Hardy was influenced by him and the republican movement with which he was associated.

7.2 GEORGE DRYSDALE AND THE GOSPEL OF THE BODY

Drysdale's *Elements of Social Science* was a work driven by moral outrage against the personal unhappiness he had experienced in early life under what he called the 'Victorian sexual code' (175). By its terms, he pointed out, 'all love except married love, is considered sinful', and marriage was defined as a legal relationship which bound men and women together for life, 'without leaving them the power of indulging in any other sexual intimacy, or of divorce from each other, unless either the husband or wife commits adultery' (178).

Drysdale argued that this idea of love and marriage was based on an unscientific view of human sexuality, as Thomas Malthus had shown in his *Essay on Population* (1798). Malthus understood the sex drive to be ineluctable for most people. It followed that men could not stabilise population by restricting the size of their families. Sexual desire drove most couples to produce as many children as they naturally could. This was the law of population, as fundamental to the dynamics of population growth as the law of gravity to the movement of solid bodies.

Drysdale went on to show that Malthus had conceived two further laws and demonstrated their operation by reference to historical statistics. The first followed from the law of population itself. Since sexual desire drove each couple to reproduce right up to the natural limit, population increased at a geometrical rate. Second, since the soil yielded diminishing returns to cultivation, the supply of food increased only arithmetically. It seemed to Malthus therefore that men were fated to struggle for existence, competing for the diminishing resources necessary to sustain the families they were driven to produce.

In the first edition of his *Essay*, Malthus saw no possibility of avoiding this fate. There were only two ways in which over-population could be reduced. There were what he called positive checks. These were war, famine and plague. There were also preventive checks, which had been practised historically. These included *coitus interruptus*, masturbation, abortion and homosexuality. As a clergyman of the Church of England, Malthus dismissed the preventive checks as 'vice'. He had therefore been

very pessimistic about the alleviation of poverty without mass extermination in a Christian country. In later editions, however, he accepted the criticism of fellow Christians, who insisted that God had given men the power of reason by which they could see the benefits of abstinence. They could therefore limit population by postponing marriage until a family could be supported by labour, and practising abstinence within marriage when the birth of further children would tend to poverty. Such behaviour was not 'vice' but 'moral restraint', reconciling God's commandment to 'be fruitful and multiply' with the Protestant ethics of work and prudence.¹⁷

Drysdale rejected this prescription as contrary to nature. Abstinence, he argued, could only be practised at a 'fearful price' (169). Deprivation of sexual satisfaction caused unhappy marriages and mental illness, as well as adding prostitution and venereal disease to the miseries of war, hunger and toil. Far from guaranteeing 'real progress in human society' (170), it left life as a struggle for sex and food, in which no one could gain advantage without causing misery to others.

'Mankind', Drysdale wrote, using a metaphor that was to appear in Hardy's fiction, 'are like a forest of trees too thickly planted. All indeed suffer more or less, but the more robust struggle upward, and in so doing destroy their weaker neighbours' (170).

Fortunately, Drysdale insisted, there was hope. Modern technology afforded for the first time in history effective means of birth control or, as Drysdale called it, 'preventive sexual intercourse'. He explained the use of the sheath and the sponge, and recommended the latter because it was more pleasurable in use and under the independent control of the female partner.

When Robert Owen had proposed the same solution back in the 1830s, he had been attacked by Christian preachers for advocating promiscuity. Drysdale countered with the argument that Christianity was a false religion, an outworn survival from the barbaric religion of the ancient Hebrews. It held to the false belief in the superior value of the spirit over the body. As a matter of experience, Drysdale responded, there was no evidence that 'pure spirit' existed. Mind 'is invariably found in connection with brain' (3).

Christianity, therefore, must be replaced by a new religion, which Drysdale proclaimed as physical, sexual and natural. Its foundation lay not in dogma concerning the soul, but in the modern science of physiology, which confirmed Malthus's insight that the sex drive was ineluctable and

demonstrated that it required regular satisfaction. As Drysdale put it in the opening sentence of his book: 'There is nothing from which mankind in the present day suffers more, than from the want of reverence for the human body' (1).

Besides attacking religion, Drysdale satirised romantic novelists and poets for imposing on young people false ideas of love and marriage, which 'led them to indulge in a day-dream' (180), very misleading and dangerous if applied in real life. In such fictions, young men and women fell 'desperately in love with one object' and yielded to despair when they could not obtain 'full and sole possession of this' (180). Or again:

The most intense jealousy . . . is fostered among us, by the exclusiveness of marriage. Lovers paying their addresses to the same girl, or girls who are rivals for the affection of a man, are consumed with jealousies and anxieties; for they know that it is a question of all or nothing, and their whole happiness in life seems bound up in the issue. (180)

Child bearing, moreover, was a curse not a happiness, especially for working-class mothers:

there is about as little pleasure in begetting the swarms of legitimate children, as could well be extracted from venereal intercourse; and when we go beneath our little surface of society, and look at married life among the poor, we find it full to the brim with misery; cares, ill-usage, drunkenness, children a burden to their parents, and especially to their hard-worked mother; the wife generally sick of all sexual pleasures, which have loaded her with such cares, and perhaps submitting to them only from fear of her husband. Alas! Do not let us mock such fearful evils with the name of 'Holy and blessed institution.' (181)

No one, Drysdale insisted, would gamble their life's happiness on such an irrevocable contract but for the denial of any other way of honourably satisfying sexual desire. Men were already beginning to repudiate it, increasingly remaining as bachelors, not from want of means but from antipathy to irrevocable marriage.

Fanciful too was the romantic idea of love in courtship. Young people were represented as falling in love with the ideal partner with whom to set up in marriage for life. As Drysdale saw it, the reality of young love was very different. Like all other human passions, he argued, love was liable to change and benefited from it: 'Youth, when the passion is strongest, is

especially prone to change, according to the beautiful command of Nature, who intends that our experiences should be varied, and our different faculties and emotions called forth' (178).

To deplore youthful inconstancy as perversion or sin was to place our understanding above 'the wisdom of Nature' (178). Guided by 'natural religion', people would come to understand that

A young man and woman at puberty, when their new senses are awakened, fall in love with the first tolerably fair face they meet. It is ten chances to one that were they to marry this first object, in a few years they would bitterly repent. How can they tell, without experience of love, how many objects of greater attraction and congeniality they may yet encounter; they, who know as yet scarcely anything of character, even of their own? (178)

Drysdale went on to demand the abolition of all marriage laws. This would permit free love between the sexes and easy separation for people who found themselves incompatible. This 'revolution' (216), Drysdale argued, was already under way. George Jacob Holyoake was promoting rationalism through secular societies, which were attracting working-class support. Christianity, which upheld 'the divine right of marriage' as strongly as it once upheld 'the divine right of kings' (189), would have to yield to the new science of physiology as surely as it had yielded to astronomy. Freed from its dogma, moral science could at last be aligned with the real needs of human beings.

For this 'new and natural faith' (225) to prevail, Drysdale argued, a great enlargement of liberty by political and social reform was required. He advocated political measures that would be taken up in the late 1860s in the name of republicanism: universal suffrage, disestablishment of the church, abolition of all titles of nobility, an end to monarchy. He also embraced measures which historians have come to distinguish as 'social republicanism'. The laws of primogeniture should be abolished to free up land for enterprise. This would increase peasant proprietorship and industrial co-operatives, by means of which working people could gain emancipation from wage labour.

Such reforms, by removing 'pernicious class-barriers' and 'class prejudices', would enlarge the liberty and independence of citizens, who would use their democratic rights to campaign for the new sexual ethic. Legislation for easy divorce and the end of illegitimacy would be required, but the prior need was the reform of education to include the new science

of physiology. It should be given to girls and boys before puberty and include instruction in the new sexual ethic. This would teach them ‘that the true path of virtue lies in moderation, and in a due and healthy exercise of their new powers’. Such teaching was very far from promiscuity. Rather, it represented a healthy moderation, ‘abstinence on the one hand, and excess or lasciviousness on the other, being alike shunned’ (189).

At the same time, sex education would impart knowledge of birth control, making it possible for men and women to obey the supreme commandments of natural religion: first, that everyone should limit themselves to the production of two, or at most three children; and second, that all parents, men or women, should work to provide children with a comfortable home, nourishment and education that would enable them to provide in their turn for the next generation.

Thus would arrive the ‘golden age’ (201). Poverty would be abolished and there would be no need to uphold lifelong monogamy and chastity as safeguards against it. Everyone would be able to enjoy the natural pleasure of sexual love without fear of adding to the miseries of modern civilisation. Women, freed from early marriage and excessive child bearing, could work for gain as men did. Finally, it would be irrelevant whether parents were married or not. Those who preferred a relationship of mutual fidelity would be at liberty to practise it, while nothing would stand in the way of those who needed change and variety. So would vanish the deceit of adultery among the married of the present time.

Unless this came about, Drysdale contended, the present system must arouse determined and possibly violent opposition. In terms that must suggest the ending of *Tess of the d’Urbervilles*, he wrote: ‘Human nature could not harbour an offended sense of justice without disorder’ (213).

7.3 HARDY AND DRYSDALE

We can now turn to the question of evidence that Hardy knew of and sympathised with Drysdale’s sexual radicalism, examining some hitherto undetected clues.

We may begin with the poems which Hardy wrote in the second half of the 1860s, as indicated in [Chapter 3](#) of *Life and Work*.¹⁸ These often seem to see love and marriage in Drysdale’s way. In ‘At a Bridal’, the speaker regrets that the woman who would have been the perfect match for him is ‘wed as slave to mode’s decree’.¹⁹

In 'Postponement', love is not fairly distributed between rich and poor. Society exerts pressure on a poor man to forgo love rather than marry imprudently. No such pressure prevents a rich heir from 'cheerily mating'.²⁰

The speakers in these poems learn to see with Drysdale that Victorian sexual ethics are out of alignment with human nature. Constant, changeless love is very rare between two individuals. As in 'Neutral Tones', those who count on lifelong fidelity will be taught by 'keen lessons that love deceives'.²¹ In 'Revulsion', the poet acknowledges that he wastes the watches of the night 'framing words to fetter/Some unknown spirit to mine'.²²

Such romantic illusions have guided the female speaker of the 'She to him' poems. The woman's reproaches might be addressed to a lover with Drysdale's views. She had expected lifelong exclusive possession of a man she loved purely and unselfishly. She would 'die to spare you touch of ill'. But he, she complains, has loved her only for her looks, not the quality of her mind. Evidently he protested against her possessiveness, to which she can only defend herself by asserting that 'love is lovelier/The more it shapes its moan in selfish-wise'.²³

These poems, then, seem to show awareness of Drysdale's critique of Victorian marriage law and customs. Two other passages in *Life and Work* point in the same direction. Their interpretation requires some elucidation of the counter-culture of sexuality which flourished in London during the nineteenth century. This included a trade in books like Drysdale's *Elements* and Knowlton's *Fruits of Philosophy*, as well as a great number which respectability branded 'obscene'. With this went a related trade in birth-control devices and abortifacients, many of which were advertised in the newspaper press, suitably disguised behind ambiguous phraseology.

The centre of this trade was in Holywell Street, one of a dense network of narrow alleyways off the Strand, which was close to the office in Adelphi Terrace where Hardy worked as an architect's clerk.²⁴ Some of the buildings in the street dated back to Elizabethan times. In the 1860s many of them were given over to the sale of erotic prints and literature. The notoriety of the street, however, was not solely due to this kind of transgression. It was also infamous on political grounds. It was home to the literature of bawdy publishing aimed at exposing the hypocrisy and immorality of the ruling classes.²⁵ The booksellers of Holywell Street were therefore exposed to frequent police raids, prosecutions and confiscations under the Obscene Publications Act of 1857.

It was in such shops ‘of a low moral character’,²⁶ Drysdale said, that works like his had to find an outlet. The customers came from every level of society, from artisans and clerks to gentlemen of the professional, business and upper classes.²⁷

In *Life and Work* Hardy refers to Holywell Street in two places. The first is a notebook or diary entry of 1879, the year after the conclusion of the Bradlaugh–Besant trials. The entry is an amusingly satirical anecdote about a curate in a ‘low bookshop’:

January 30. 1879. In Steven’s book-shop, Holywell Street. A bustling vigorous young curate comes in – red-faced and full of life – the warm breath puffing from his mouth in a jet into the frosty air, and religion sitting with an ill grace upon him.

‘Have you *Able to Save*?’

Shopman addressed does not know, and passes on the inquiry to the master standing behind with his hat on: *Able to Save*?

‘I don’t know – Bboi! (to boy at other end). Got *Able to Save*? Why the devil can’t you attend?’

‘What, Sir?’

‘*Able to Save*!’

Boy’s face a blank. Shopman to curate: ‘Get it by to-morrow afternoon, Sir.’

‘And please get *Words of Comfort*.’

‘*Words of Comfort*. Yes, Sir.’ Exit curate.

Master: ‘Why the H don’t anybody here know what’s in stock?’

Business proceeds in a subdued manner.²⁸

The satirical implication of this anecdote seems clear enough. Hardy suspects that the curate has come on an errand connected with the real trade of the shop. Seeing another customer present, he conceals his purpose by asking for *Able to Save*, a well-known work of evangelical piety. The staff are wrong-footed, but act out the farce of treating his enquiry as entirely serious. It is remarkable that Hardy, in his guarded account of his life, was willing to risk the revelation of his presence in Holywell Street. It is difficult not to read the passage as a hint that the roots of his sexual radicalism lay in the underground culture of the late 1860s and early 1870s.

The second neglected reference to Holywell Street offers an even more explicit hint: ‘July 11, 1886. “In evening to bookstalls in Holywell Street known to me so many years ago.”’²⁹ This may not seem much to go on

unless we notice its position just before Hardy's comments on the cross-examination of Sir Charles Dilke in the Crawford divorce hearing of 1886.

He was in court for part of the time during which the Crawford–Dilke case was proceeding. He makes no comment on the case itself, but there is a general remark on the court:

The personality which fills the court is that of the witness. The judge's personality during the cross-examination contracts to his corporeal dimensions merely. So do they all save that of the pervasive witness aforesaid. . . . The witness is also the fool of the court. . . . The witness's little peculiarities supersede those of all the other personages together. He is at once king and victim.

As to the architecture of the courts, there are everywhere religious art-forces masquerading as law symbols! The leaf, flower, fret, suggested by spiritual emotion, are pressed into the service of social strife.³⁰

Sir Charles Dilke was the correspondent in the divorce proceedings of Mr and Mrs Crawford, which proved disastrous for his political career. He had been in high government office under Gladstone and was widely regarded as likely to succeed him as prime minister. The case fascinated newspaper readers in 1885–1886 for three reasons: the salacious allegations against Dilke; his reputation as an extreme radical, which dated from his outspoken republicanism in the early 1870s; and his high position in the Gladstonian government.

Mrs Virginia Crawford alleged that Dilke had been her lover, that he had also had sexual relations with two of his female servants, and that he had introduced one of them into his bed, along with herself. Her husband was granted a divorce in February 1886, after a brief trial in which Dilke, on the advice of his lawyer, did not enter the witness box. In granting the divorce, the judge commented that there was not a shadow of a case against Dilke and dismissed the charge against him with costs. The press did not believe this judgment and alleged a cover-up by Dilke and his friends in the government. Dilke, who had always protested his innocence, applied to the Queen's Proctor to bring an action to overturn the divorce decree on the ground that new evidence had come to light, throwing grave doubt on Mrs Crawford's claim that he had been her lover.

At this second hearing, Dilke was subjected to a withering cross-examination by Mr Crawford's counsel on 16 July 1886, the day on which Hardy was present. The transcript of the hearing shows that Dilke

did indeed look foolish under questioning.³¹ This was widely reported as supporting Virginia Crawford's allegations. The judgement of recent historians,³² however, is that Mrs Crawford had lied about her liaison with Dilke in order to protect her real lover, a certain Captain Forster.

The language of Hardy's comment on the proceedings is reminiscent of Drysdale. Dilke is a 'victim', persecuted by a law code based on Christianity. The architectural ornaments of the courtroom enforce this message: 'religious art-forces masquerading as law symbols!' The emotion they suggest is 'spiritual' and it is 'pressed into the service of social strife'. There can be no doubt of this reality. As Drysdale always insisted, the code of sexual respectability was upheld by the establishment in church and state. In 1885–1886 that establishment felt its values to be very much under attack. Dilke had been at Gladstone's right hand in pushing through the Third Reform Act in that year. Many, therefore, took intense satisfaction in the humiliation of the notorious republican and radical leader, but Hardy refuses to treat the conduct of the victim as anything more than 'little peculiarities'.

These comments on Holywell Street suggest, therefore, that Hardy did not discover sexual radicalism in the 1880s, but in the 1860s.

7.4 CONCLUSION

This chapter has presented evidence that Hardy was influenced by George Drysdale's *Elements of Social Science*. As I will show in Parts II and III of this study, many passages in Hardy's fiction are consonant with his attack on the Victorian sexual code. That is not to say, however, that Hardy wished to see all marriage and family law swept away. Such a revolution would destroy the rights of children, fathers and other biological relatives, along with wives. Drysdale ignored this problem. One commentator who did not ignore it was John Stuart Mill. It is therefore to his views on marriage as they relate to his philosophy of history that I turn in the final chapter of Part I.

NOTES

1. C. Tomalin, *Thomas Hardy: the Time-Torn Man* (London, 2006). pp. 74, 175. For a modern analysis of this event, see C. Hall, K. McClelland, and J. Rendal, *Defining the Victorian Nation: Class, Race, Gender and the British Reform Act of 1867* (Cambridge, 2000), passim, esp. pp. 1–56, 179–233.
2. R. Pyte, *Thomas Hardy: The Guarded Life* (London, 2006), ch. 8.

3. Pyte, *Guarded Life*, p. 125.
4. Thomas Hardy, *Desperate Remedies*, Oxford World's Classics, ed. and intr. P. Ingham (Oxford, 2003).
5. Thomas Hardy, *Desperate Remedies*, Oxford Worlds Classics, ed. and intr. P. Ingham (Oxford, 2003), p. 40.
6. For another suggestion, see the interesting article by M. Rabiger, '“My Dear Tom”: Hardy and Moule', *The Hardy Review*, 13, 2, 2011, pp. 122–143.
7. Bjork, *Psychological Vision*, pp. 30–44.
8. Hardy, *Early Years*, p. 27. This passage was relegated to an appendix in Millgate's *Life and Work* as an insertion unauthorised by Hardy.
9. For this development, see J. Vincent, *The Formation of the British Liberal Party, 1857–1868* (London, 1966).
10. Hardy, *Early Years*, pp. 67f. This letter was also deleted by Millgate from *Life and Work*.
11. Finn, *After Chartism*, pp. 188–261. This excellent survey does justice to Charles Bradlaugh's role in the republican movement, but does not deal with the contribution of George Drysdale to the new phase of sexual radicalism with which it was associated.
12. E. Royle, *Radicals, Secularists and Republicans: Popular Free Thought in Britain, 1866–1915* (Manchester, 1980), pp. 2–35.
13. For the distinction in Britain between 'democratic' and 'social' republicanism, see R. Harrison, *Before the Socialists: Studies in Labour and Politics, 1861–1881* (London, 1965), pp. 212ff. D. Nash and A. Taylor (eds), *Republicanism in Victorian Society* (Stroud, 2000), valuably extends discussion beyond metropolitan republicanism. It does not, however, seem to invalidate the contextualisation of Drysdale's writing in this chapter. Some historians may object to my extension of 'social republicanism' to include Bradlaugh. They would confine the term to those who opposed laissez-faire economics and advocated class struggle. I extend the term here to bring out the fact that Bradlaugh supported social measures such as land redistribution as the complement to self-help in the manner advocated by J. S. Mill and Henry Fawcett. See F. A. d'Arcy, 'Charles Bradlaugh and the English Republican Movement, 1868–1878', *Historical Journal*, 25, 2, 1982, pp. 367–383.
14. Royle, *Radicals*, pp. 192–217.
15. Royle, *Radicals*, pp. 246ff, p. 254.
16. G. Drysdale, *The Elements of Social Science: Physical, Sexual and Natural Religion* (London 1st edn 1854, facsimile of the 23rd edn, 1904). www.archive.org/details/elementsofsocialscienceoodrysdale. For Drysdale's life and influence, see M. Benn, *The Predicaments of Love* (London, 1992).
17. R. A. Soloway, *Prelates and People: Ecclesiastical Social Thought in England, 1783–1852* (London, 1869), pp. 93–100.
18. Hardy, *Life and Work*, p. 55.

19. J. Givson (ed.), *The Complete Poems of Thomas Hardy*, No. 6 (London, 1976).
20. *Complete Poems*, 7.
21. *Complete Poems*, 9.
22. *Complete Poems*, 13.
23. *Complete Poems*, 17.
24. *Hardy, Life and Work*, p. 47.
25. L. Nead, *Victorian Babylon: People, Streets and Images in Nineteenth-Century London* (London, 2000), p. 178.
26. Drysdale, *Elements*, p. 67.
27. I. McCalman, *Radical Underworld: Prophets, Revolutionaries and Pornographers in London, 1795–1840* (Oxford, 1993), p. 236, quoted in Nead, *Victorian Babylon*, p. 182.
28. Hardy, *Life and Work*, p. 128. *Able to Save* was an evangelical tract written by J. C. Ryle (1816–1900), Bishop of Liverpool 1880–1899. See J. C. Ryle, *A Self Portrait: A Partial Autobiography*, ed. P. Toon (1975). He was a prominent evangelical, who wrote some 200 tracts which sold over 12,000,000 copies.
29. Hardy, *Life and Work*, p. 239.
30. Hardy, *Early Years*, pp. 239f.
31. There are relevant extracts from the transcript in R. Jenkins, *Sir Charles Dilke: A Victorian Tragedy* (London, 1959, revd edn 1965), pp. 263–283.
32. Jenkins, *Dilke*, p. 370; D. Nicholls, *The Lost Prime Minister: The Life of Sir Charles Dilke* (London, 1995), p. 180. T. Fisher, *Scandal: The Sexual Politics of Late Victorian Britain* (Phoenix Mill, 1995), pp. 96–113.

John Stuart Mill

There can be no doubt that the writings of John Stuart Mill strongly influenced young Thomas Hardy. In *Life and Work* Hardy reproduced a notebook entry of 1868 written ‘after a time of mental depression over his work and prospects’. He mentioned three readings as ‘Cures for despair’, of which one was the chapter on ‘Individuality’ in the essay *On Liberty*. Later in the same work, he reproduced his letter to *The Times* of 1906, in which he recalled hearing Mill speak in Covent Garden during his candidature as Member of Parliament for Westminster. It referred to Mill as ‘one of the profoundest thinkers of the last century’ and *On Liberty* as a work ‘which we students of that date knew almost by heart’.¹

We now know that Hardy’s knowledge of Mill’s work extended beyond the essay *On Liberty* (1859).² He certainly knew in the 1860s, at least at second hand, of Mill’s foundational text, *A System of Logic* (1843).³ This is revealed by Michael Millgate’s Online Catalogue of Hardy’s library at Max Gate.⁴ It shows that Hardy acquired in 1863 a copy of Samuel Neil’s *The Art of Reasoning*.⁵ This volume drew explicitly on Mill to set out the principles of inductive logic, while defending the epistemology of Christian intuitionists like Coleridge, which Mill’s *Logic* attacked. It was in Book Six of the *Logic* that Mill set out his principles of method in social science, which he conceived of ultimately as a philosophy of history. In a series of polemical books, which included *On Liberty*, he applied his philosophy as a guide to action in addressing the problems of ‘civilisation’ in mid-nineteenth-century England.

In [Section 8.1](#) of this chapter, therefore, I outline Mill's philosophy of history. In [Section 8.2](#), I offer a reading of *On Liberty* which considers it as a guide to its practical application. [Section 8.3](#) is a reprise of Part I, which closes with a glance forward to Part II.

8.1 MILL'S PHILOSOPHY OF HISTORY

In Book Six of his *System of Logic*, Mill pointed out that although the sciences of inorganic and organic nature had been extensively reduced to general laws, 'the laws of psychology and, even more, those of society' were far from established. He claimed that these laws could be discovered by the general method of scientific investigation analysed in the first five parts of his treatise. By their aid, he wrote, 'we may hereafter succeed . . . in looking far forward into the future history of the human race' (525), and guiding its course for the better.

Every nation, Mill argued, had its own 'character'. Social science should be capable of demonstrating how it could be improved by the voluntary action of its individual members. This was the ultimate aim behind the project of philosophical history, as pioneered by Herder and others. All superior minds in Europe agreed, Mill wrote, that 'a philosophy of history' would form 'at once the verification, and the initial form, of the philosophy of the progress of society' (526).

In attempting to sketch the logic of this scientific philosophy of history, Mill began from the assumption that human beings possessed enough freedom of will to enable an individual or a group to change its own character by volition. Neither was free to do so just as they liked. They had to accept the circumstances inherited from the past, such as the constraints of human physiology and geography. Nevertheless, a voluntary change of character was possible in principle.

Mill went on to argue that such a change could be controlled if the laws of human nature could be discovered. Just as Newton had explained the movement of solid bodies by reference to the law of gravity, so, by analogy, individual and social change must be deducible from a universal law, whose operation could be demonstrated even though its ultimate cause could never be known. This ultimate law was, for Mill, the principle of utility, the law that human beings always sought happiness and avoided pain.

Comparative social studies, Mill continued, were daily increasing our knowledge of the types of society which actually existed. This should be understood as the basis of a new science which could show how the

numbers of desirable types could be increased and undesirables reduced in accordance with the principle of utility.

Mill gave this new science the name 'political ethology' (493) to distinguish it from Comte's 'sociology'. Political ethology, he warned, was still in its infancy. Comte's greatest error had been to think that sociology was already complete and that conclusions could be drawn prematurely about the development of all humanity before its social units had been sufficiently understood. This was mere quackery. There was no law of social phenomena so universal that it could predict the future of humanity for thousands of years. The phenomena and causes of social change were just too complicated for that.

But it was not chimerical. Mill went on to hope that something less ambitious might be done in social science. Given the present condition of Europe, for example, we could understand by what causes it had come to be as it was, whether it was in a process of change, and by what means the change could be promoted or retarded as was thought desirable.

Political economy had already shown what could be achieved in this way and it was high time to develop political ethology in a like manner. It should study the laws of formation of national character. The character of a people – its 'opinion, feelings and habits' (496) – developed largely from the state of society that preceded it and would, in turn, produce the character of the society that followed. The fundamental problem in social science was, therefore, to find the laws by which one state of society produced another. This might be done by studying the reciprocal interaction between human beings and their environment.

Hitherto, Mill observed, two views had been held concerning this interaction. The most ancient view was that change must be cyclical, a process of *corso* and *ricorso* without progress. The modern view, expounded correctly by Comte, was that history was 'progressive' (506), cyclical but cumulative. Mill shared this optimism, writing that 'the general tendency is, and will continue to be, saving occasional and temporary exceptions, one of improvement; a tendency towards a better and happier state' (507).

Comte had also been correct to divide social studies into social statics and social dynamics. Social statics sought to explain why societies so often remained coherent over large tracts of time. One of the most important causes in any society, he suggested and Mill agreed, was the institution of education, by which the individual was disciplined to subordinate his personal interest to that of the whole community. Hitherto this had sustained social solidarity by inculcating religious belief in a god or a human leader

who was supposed to have sacred significance. But in the future, Mill argued, such loyalty is only likely to be inculcated successfully by appealing to 'the principles of individual freedom and political and social equality'. Such institution, he added, 'as yet exist[s] nowhere, or exist[s] only in a rudimentary state' (517). To this feeling must be added that of sympathy, a sense of identity between all members of the human community, which would in future replace patriotism and the hatred of other nations.

By studying history, Mill went on to argue, we gain knowledge of the laws of social dynamics. This was not achieved by poring over the kind of history that focused exclusively on princes and battles. That was now being replaced by history that investigated the economic, social and cultural tendencies whose interaction brought about change. It had been Comte's great achievement to discover that element in human nature which ensured that the process would produce an increase of social solidarity. This was the faculty of reason. By reason, human beings learned that their greatest happiness would be achieved through co-operation or altruism rather than subservience to the selfish and violent passions.

Comte's great error, however, had been to think that the progress of reason was guaranteed by the facts of history. He had failed to understand that science dealt exclusively in judgements of fact, 'is' statements, whereas judgements about the ends of life dealt with duties, 'ought' statements. The latter belonged to ethics, not science. Ethical values could not be demonstrated scientifically. Standards of morality had to be chosen by people exercising their free will.

But if there could be no scientific proof that utility should be the common aim of social life, were not human beings doomed to moral relativism and endless strife over the desirable goals of life? Mill argued that co-operation for the greatest happiness of the greatest number was a moral principle increasingly acceptable to human beings as a result of experience. They were learning that they could not claim the right to pursue their own happiness without recognising that right for everyone else, and by applying this principle impartially and consistently. This had been 'summed up most completely in "the golden rule" of Jesus of Nazareth: 'do as you would be done by and love your neighbour as yourself'.'⁶

This argument brought Mill to question the idea of teleology as held hitherto by philosophers, including Comte. However, it is important to my argument in this study that his questioning did not amount exactly to rejection. Rather, Mill sought to redefine the term 'teleology', reallocating it to that department of moral discourse which dealt with the choice of ends.

Individuals in any society who wished to change it must gain general assent to the end they proposed. In the past this process had been imposed by more or less despotic rulers. In future, social sympathy must be promoted by discussion. Acceptance of this principle was already increasing through the expansion of representative government. In a representative assembly, men and women (and Mill, famously, demanded representation of women) would thrash out consensus as to moral ends. They would then refer to social scientists the practical question of how these ends could be promoted.

8.2 ON LIBERTY

Some two decades after his *Logic*, Mill published four works as a guide to action in the application of his philosophy of history. *Utilitarianism* (1863) reworked the greatest happiness principle, redefining happiness as the pursuit of individual moral improvement. This was what future society ought to promote. *On Representative Government* (1861) analysed the kind of assembly best fitted to produce general consent to utilitarianism. *On Liberty* (1859) pronounced individual freedom as the principle necessary to its progress. Finally, *The Subjection of Women* (1869) fiercely condemned the exclusion of half the human species from these considerations. *On Liberty* was the only one of these later works which Hardy noted in *Life and Work*, though as a ‘student’ of Mill he was no doubt acquainted more or less with the others.

On Liberty applied Mill’s philosophy of history to analyse the civilisation of mid-Victorian England. The history of humankind, he claimed, had been a struggle between the spirit of ‘liberty’ and the spirit of conformity to ‘tradition’ or ‘custom’. Where this struggle was active, so also was the progressive principle (78). In certain ages and in certain places the struggle had died out, most notably in the Orient, the greater part of the world. These nations had once been ‘populous, lettered and versed in many of the arts of life’ (78). They had made themselves among the greatest powers of the world. Yet now they were the colonial subjects of people whose ancestors had roamed the forests of Europe, when they built ‘magnificent palaces and gorgeous temples’ (79). This indicated the cyclical nature of human progress. A people might be progressive for a certain length of time and then cease to progress when it ceased to possess individuality.

This fate, Mill went on to argue, threatened the civilisation of modern Britain. Englishmen flattered themselves that they were the most progressive nation in the world. Certainly they continued to ‘make inventions in

mechanical things' (79). But in morals they were mostly ruled by public opinion, enforced chiefly through the press. This inculcated the morality of a commercial age: that a man's highest duty consisted of pursuing material gain and, on that basis, upward social mobility.

What had preserved the European nations from the fate of the Orient was not any racial superiority, but 'their remarkable diversity of character and culture' (80). However, in the nineteenth century they were 'already advancing towards the Chinese ideal of making all people alike' (81). This was to be seen clearly in England, where ranks, neighbourhoods, trades and professions, who formerly lived in different worlds, 'now read the same things, listen to the same things, see the same things, go to the same places, have their hopes and fears directed to the same objects, have the same rights and liberties, and the same means of asserting them' (81). These influences, Mill thought, were hostile to personal self-development or individuality, and would tend to continue in operation because common education, faster communications and competition in commerce and manufactures were making the ambition of rising in society universal.

In Mill's view, the only possibility of changing this headlong descent towards conformity and decline was to make the intelligent part of the public value diversity. If the claims of individuality were to be asserted, Mill wrote, 'the time is now, while much is still wanting to complete the enforced assimilation' (82). The shackle of conformity must be broken and 'there should be different experiments of living' (63).

On Liberty, then, was a broadside against the character of an age which repressed individual freedom of thought and action. Mill touched on a wide range of conduct disapproved by respectable public opinion, but there can be little doubt that his main target was the Victorian law and custom of marriage. In taking this aim he was motivated to write by experience arising from his relationship with Harriet Taylor.⁷ It was formed while she was still married to her first husband, with whom she continued to live on the understanding that she and Mill would try to avoid scandalous gossip. For this reason, it has been suggested, *On Liberty* was less than candid about Mill's views on marriage and sexuality.⁸

This judgement, true in the main, should be qualified. Mill hinted clearly enough as to his main targets, the restriction of personal liberty by the Victorian code of sexual respectability and the Christian moral teaching which upheld it. This teaching, Mill argued, was derived not from the Gospels, but from the writings of the Church Fathers, themselves

a negative reaction to pagan sensuality. Patristic views of the spirit and the flesh had been, Mill observed, modified by Protestantism less ‘than might have been expected’ (55). The resulting Calvinistic morality of modern times was to be contrasted unfavourably with the Greek ideal of sensuality: ‘It may be better to be a John Knox than an Alcibiades, but it is better to be a Pericles than either’ (70). Pericles was, of course, the leading statesman of Athens, the ‘educator of Helas’, in the fifth century BC. As Mill, who was steeped in the ancient classics, well knew, he never married but formed a lasting relationship with a cultured woman of the city-state.

Even people who were not formally followers of Calvinism, Mill went on, accepted its religious teaching that obedience to authority should be their guide to life. As a result, their natures became ‘cramped and dwarfed’, like trees ‘clipped into pollards, or cut out into figures of animals’ (69). Christians should take a better view of God, seeing that he gave human beings their faculties to be ‘cultivated and unfolded, not rooted out and consumed’ (69). On this view, human beings were created to increase ‘their capabilities of comprehension, of action, or of enjoyment’ (69).

The only justifiable ground for restraining a person’s choice of his own lifestyle, Mill concluded, was to prevent harm to others. People were highly variable in character and one size did not fit all. Yet in his time, wrote Mill, ‘from the highest class of society down to the lowest, everyone lives as under the eye of a hostile and dreaded censorship’ (68).

8.3 CONCLUSION TO PART I

Part I of this study has focused on the ideas of history which young Thomas Hardy encountered during the years of his intellectual and aesthetic maturation, roughly 1857–1873. Horace Moule, as *Life and Work* suggests, introduced him, during their conversational walks, to the Liberal Anglican idea of history. Hardy became more acquainted with it by reading Walter Bagehot’s *Estimates and Essays and Reviews*.

The Liberal Anglican philosophy of history represented the human career as a series of cyclical oscillations between barbarism and civilisation, in which progress towards the Christian ethic of loving-kindness was guaranteed by divine providence. In the course of universal history, each civilisation had developed, like the individuals who composed it, from infancy to maturity, only to collapse in a late-manhood crisis, brought about by empire, war, religious decay and worship of materialism, leading to class alienation and revolution. To the end of his life, as this study

attempts to show, the progressive cyclical idea was to survive as a fundamental concept in Hardy's own idea of history.

The reading of Bagehot, Temple and Baden Powell, Part I has further suggested, was the core of the 'theological study' which led Hardy to the agnosticism of David Hume. It produced the crisis of faith after which he could no longer believe in divine providence. If belief in progress were to be retained, it must be on the basis of a naturalistic explanation. Auguste Comte's *General View of Positivism* promised to supply exactly that. It preserved the cyclical idea of historical progress. It equated the biblical ethic of loving-kindness with Comte's concept of altruism. It substituted for the Liberal Anglican idea of a clerisy the notion of workers, women and artists as the altruistic classes which, guided by Positivist philosophers, would play the leading part in developing a new spiritual force, the religion of humanity.

These were the central ideas in Comte's philosophy of history, which young Thomas Hardy could easily absorb because they demanded no sharp break with the central Liberal Anglican ideas. Yet, as Ralph Pite and others have suggested, something in both philosophies of history jarred with the intimate experience of a young man struggling to advance in his chosen profession of architecture. He wanted to marry, yet social barriers stood in the way of his promotion to the level of salary which would secure him and a wife from a life dominated by pursuit of material gain. Comte's view of human nature subordinated the desire for sexual love to a concept of reason every bit as ascetic as that advanced by the Church Fathers in the Roman empire or by the saints of medieval Christendom. Hardy, I have suggested, was liberated from these constraints by his encounter in London with the republican movement of the 1860s. Scholarship has overlooked the evidence in *Life and Work* that young Thomas Hardy was a regular patron of the bookshops in Holywell Street, where works on sexual ethics could be purchased along with erotic literature. Here was to be encountered the then old-fashioned works of Fourier and Owen. More up to the minute, however, was *The Elements of Social Science*, Dr George Drysdale's broadside against Christian asceticism, Malthusian abstinence and Smilesian self-help. This substituted for the almost defunct communitarian programmes of Owen and Fourier an individualistic ideal of free love, based on the principle of natural religion. It celebrated sexual love as a healthy activity and a high moral duty. Drysdale went on to advocate the abolition of all marriage laws and the Victorian sexual code on which they rested, as restraints on the greatest happiness principle. Hardy's earliest poetry, along with his remarks on the trial of Sir Charles Dilke, are evidence of a close acquaintance with

the basic idea in Drysdale's *Elements*, the injustice of an ideology which required all but the rich to postpone marriage and preserve chastity.

Drysdale's views must now be recalled in the light of the present chapter. He read Book Six of Mill's *Logic* as outlining the possibility of a social science based on the known laws of population, fecundity and 'ethical science' (228). Taken together, he argued, Mill's writings demonstrated that society had only to recognise the lessons of economics and physiology to see that the 'great social evils of old countries' arose from the law of population increase and could be overcome by birth control and the abolition of marriage laws.

As we have seen in this chapter, Mill provided no authority for such a conclusion. On the contrary, Drysdale was falling into the fundamental error as characterised in Book Six of the *Logic*, the error of deriving morality from fact, 'ought' from 'is'. Mill did not think it followed from the science of physiology or the law of population that marriage laws flew in the face of human nature and ought to be abolished. He acknowledged with Drysdale that 'the various instincts of animals, and the portion of human nature which corresponds to those instincts' had 'as positive, and even as direct and immediate, a connection with physical conditions of the brain and nerves, as any of our mere sensations have' (441).

Nevertheless, Mill insisted that the sex instinct, though a powerful motive force of the will, was not entirely beyond voluntary control. It was an indisputable fact, he pointed out, 'that these instincts may be modified to any extent, or entirely conquered, in human beings at least, by other mental influences, and by education' (ibid.).

Furthermore, Mill placed little store personally by the sex drive in human beings. He thought modern female sexuality 'a hot-house and stove cultivation',⁹ a form of behaviour exaggerated by social conventions surrounding marriage. With the spread of self-cultivation through society, the sex factor in marriage would yield primacy to mental companionship between husband and wife.

At the same time, Mill did not object in principle to Drysdale's original call for freedom to experiment with forms of sexual partnership. He simply denied that any natural law required the abolition of all legal restraints. He even went so far as to tell a friend that he saw no need for experiments in free love to be widely undertaken until the reformation of marriage had been tried and failed.¹⁰

Nevertheless, Mill approved of experiment in family law reform. He supported divorce so that women could escape from abusive marriages and

he wanted them to be educated for gainful employment as well as marriage. He did not discuss whether children would be happier if parents stayed married or if they separated, or what rights fathers should have of access to children after divorce. No doubt he hoped such questions might rarely arise because freer laws might make for more happy and stable marriages. But, in principle, these were outcomes that could be tested by the methods of social science outlined in his *Logic*.

Parts II and III of this study will show how this debate of the 1860s over the idea of history and its implications for the future entered into Hardy's fiction. The late-manhood crisis of modern civilisation is never far from his mind and its symptoms – luxury, class alienation, scepticism and imperialism – are increasingly represented. Meliorism, the idea of progress, is everywhere tested. Comte's idea of a looped orbit is brought under interrogation. Drysdale's sharp attack on the Victorian sexual code frames the loves of the leading characters. The debate over abortion or reform of marriage laws is encoded in the later tragedies. Finally, the dark vision of *Jude the Obscure* is related to the feminine wisdom that, as a matter of historical fact, opposed birth control then and well into the twentieth century.

NOTES

1. Hardy, *Life and Work*, pp. 59, 355.
2. J. S. Mill, *On Liberty and Other Essays*: Oxford World Classics, intro. J. Gray (Oxford, 1991).
3. J. S. Mill, *System of Logic, Ratiocinative and Inductive: Being a Connected View of the Principles of Evidence, and the Methods of Scientific Investigation* (2 vols, London, 1843), Vol. II, Book VI, pp. 411–553. All quotations in this chapter are from the sixth edition of 1865.
4. M. Millgate, *Thomas Hardy's Library at Max Gate: Catalogue of an Attempted Reconstruction*, www.library.utoronto.ca/fisher/hardy.
5. S. Neil, *The Art of Reasoning: A Popular Exposition of the Principles of Logic, Inductive and Deductive, with an Introductory Outline of the History of Logic* (London, 1853).
6. J. S. Mill, 'Utilitarianism', ch. 2, of A. Ryan (ed.), *J. S. Mill and Jeremy Bentham: Utilitarianism and Other Essays* (London, 1987), p. 288.
7. For the history of their relationship see R. Reeves, *John Stuart Mill: Victorian Firebrand* (London, 2007), pp. 138–140, 148–154.
8. Reeve, *Mill*, p. 263.
9. J. S. Mill, *The Subjection of Women* (London, 1970), p. 22.
10. Reeve, *Mill*, p. 437, n. 99.

PART II

Putting His Satire in Edgewise

The Poor Man and the Lady

This short chapter has two functions. First, it will serve as an introduction to Part II. Secondly and complementarily, it will review what Hardy wrote about his first novel, which was never published and scarcely survives in manuscript. It is worth spending a little time on what Hardy had to say about it, however, since his remarks can be seen in retrospect to anticipate much that was to characterise his novelistic career.

As *Life and Work* records, Hardy began to write his first novel in 1867, eventually entitled *The Poor Man and the Lady by the Poor Man*. His recollections in *Life and Work* yield some interesting insights as to his thinking about philosophical history at the time:

The story was, in fact, a sweeping dramatic satire of the squirarchy and nobility, London society, the vulgarity of the middle class, *modern Christianity, church restoration, and political and domestic morals in general*, the author's views, in fact, being obviously those of a young man 'with a passion for reforming the world' – those of many a young man before and after him, the tendency of the writing being socialistic, not to say revolutionary. (62f; italics added)

What did Hardy mean by calling the novel 'socialistic' and even 'revolutionary'? We are given a clue in the name of Hardy's hero, Will Strong, which echoes the 'strong social instincts' which Comte attributed to the workers in his *General View of Positivism*.¹ Comte, as we saw in [Chapter 5](#), looked to the working class to support a peaceful and gradual revolution of

society, and was often described by his followers in England as a 'socialist', to distinguish his scheme from the revolutionary class struggle associated with French 'communism'.

Life and Work reveals that Hardy, in writing *The Poor Man and the Lady*, showed awareness of these two facts. It tells us that Will Strong addressed a demonstration for franchise reform in Trafalgar Square. Such a demonstration actually took place, organised by the Reform League. It was intended to be, and actually was, a peaceful demonstration.² As *Life and Work* also reveals, Hardy was well aware of the League's campaign and probably knew that it had a moderate leadership, drawn from the respectable trade unions, as represented by the 'worthy resident secretary, Mr George Howell'.³ This leadership was at odds with an extreme 'republican' wing, also referred to by Hardy and represented by Charles Bradlaugh, which demanded nothing less than universal manhood suffrage and opposed Howell's tactics of compromise with middle-class Liberals in Parliament. To avoid alienating their support, the moderates organised the Trafalgar Square meeting as a purely peaceful action. The republicans, by contrast, led another demonstration to Hyde Park, to protest against a government ban on meeting there. Confronted by locked gates, the demonstrators clashed with the police and broke down the railings to gain entrance.

In the writings of Comte, such violent eruptions were to be avoided by gradually applied measures of Positivist reform. For the French sage, revolution was to come about gradually. Hardy undoubtedly sympathised. As Clare Tomalin noted, that was 'surely the day that prompted Hardy to write the words "Hyde Park-morning" around the title of Shelley's revolutionary poem *The Revolt of Islam* in his own recently acquired copy'.⁴ This surely indicates that Hardy, like Shelley, saw reform of 'political and domestic' morals as crucial to the avoidance of violent reaction against repression. So the comments quoted above from *Life and Work* meant that his 'socialistic' novel was revolutionary in this sense: reform was the only prophylactic for violent revolution. It would be prevented in England by the strong will of the moderate workers, peacefully demonstrating for their political rights. And these would have to be accompanied by reconstruction of the Victorian sexual code. As Hardy put it, the novel satirised 'modern Christianity...and political and domestic morals in general' (62f).

Hardy submitted his manuscript to the publisher Alexander Macmillan, who gave it a mixed reception. Himself a sympathiser with the Broad

Church movement,⁵ he thought that ‘Will’s speech to the working men is full of wisdom.’⁶ He acknowledged too that the satire of upper-class attitudes to the working class had ‘some ground of truth’, but considered that it was taken to excess, a drawback fatal to the success of the book. His reader, the Positivist John Morley,⁷ agreed and the manuscript was rejected.

Hardy next took his novel to Chapman and Hall, where he had no better luck. Its reader, George Meredith, warned Hardy that if he published so pronounced a satire in a first book, ‘he would be attacked on all sides by the conventional reviewers, and his future injured’.⁸

In the letter to Alexander Macmillan which accompanied Hardy’s original submission, the young writer had defended his attack on the manners of the upper classes. The letter shows that he had been hoping to get away with it because the satire had been ‘inserted edgewise, so to say’.⁹ Not edgewise enough, apparently, as the publishers’ responses made clear. Yet the phrase is a vital hint to Hardy’s early aim as a novelist. He wanted to arouse his readers to consciousness of the blots of evil of the time. By putting satire in edgewise, he would teach them that, far from living at the highest point of civilisation the world had ever seen, they were living in what Drysdale had called an ‘old country’, encrusted by class prejudice, deformed by extreme inequality, emotionally stifled by Christian respectability.

In this second part of my study, then, I continue by offering readings of Hardy’s first three published novels, chiefly with George Drysdale in mind. I attempt to show how Hardy experimented with combinations of literary forms to question orthodox beliefs about love and marriage, and communicate with radically minded readers. These were the novels of his most optimistic years when, like Mill, he anticipated a forward movement of progress under the Liberal government of William Ewart Gladstone. That optimism, I go on to suggest, was very seriously checked by the Franco-Prussian war of 1870, and his fourth published novel, *A Pair of Blue Eyes*, reveals a darkening vision and a substratum of Liberal Anglican thought about late-manhood civilisation.

NOTES

1. Comte, *General View*, p. 136.
2. See F. Reid, ‘“That must be the Poor man”: *Alton Locke* as a Model for *The Poor Man and the Lady*’, *Hardy Society Journal*, V, 2, 2009, pp. 70–78.
3. *Life and Work*, p. 43.
4. Tomalin, *Hardy*, p. 175.

5. For the friendship of the Macmillan brothers with J. C. Hare and F. D. Maurice, see the entry 'Macmillan Family' in *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* Online.
6. Quoted in *Life and Work*, p. 60.
7. For Moreley's Positivism see Kent, *Brains and Numbers*, esp. pp. 117–135.
8. *Life and Work*, p. 62.
9. Millgate, *Hardy Revisited*, p. 110.

Desperate Remedies and Under the Greenwood Tree

In *Life and Work*, Hardy reproduced a notebook entry of 30 June 1870. It reads: ‘What the world is saying, and what the world is thinking: It is the man who bases his action upon what the world is thinking, no matter what it may be saying, who rises to the top.’¹ Here, as so often in his pseudo-biography, an apparently random entry offers a clue to an important theme of the text. The entry indicates that we are to read his early fiction with a radical interpretive community in mind. The clue is critical for this study.

10.1 SATIRE AND SENSATIONALISM: *DESPERATE REMEDIES*

Thanks to modern criticism, Hardy’s next move in the literary marketplace is clear. Following Meredith’s advice, he turned in *Desperate Remedies* (1871) to the sensational novel, popularised by Wilkie Collins and others. This turn to a commercially acceptable form was not merely cynical accommodation to fashionable taste. Rather, Hardy was pursuing his aim of inserting his satire edgewise. To that end he experimented with innovative techniques, including what postmodern literary theory recognises as semiotic coding, dialogical narration and destabilisation of plot. This allowed him, with less risk of attack by reviewers, to question the same targets as Drysdale, romantic love, the Victorian sexual code, and the damage they did to young people entering adult life.

The novel was grounded, to a considerable extent, on his own personal experience. The hero, Edward Springrove, is, like Hardy himself, a

struggling young architect's clerk. He moves from a West Country practice to try his fortunes in London and finds employment 'in the neighbourhood of Charing Cross' (173). As the son of a small farmer, similarly situated to Hardy's own father, he expresses frustration in much the same terms as Hardy would employ in *Life and Work*. Advancement does not depend on mastering the art of architecture, but in energetic pursuit of useful connections for which Springrove, as a devotee of poetry, is ill fitted.

As already mentioned, Hardy also employed the conventions of sensational fiction, which offered the reader stories of crime, sex and mystery, with a complicated plot. He followed these conventions enthusiastically. There is a vulnerable heroine, Cytherea Graye, orphaned and penniless. There is a villain, Aeneas Manston, who schemes to marry her after killing his wife. There is transgressive sex among the upper classes. Manston is the illegitimate son of an aristocratic lady, Miss Aldclyffe, who assists in his schemes out of guilt for abandoning him in infancy. After her many perilous adventures, the strong hero rescues Cytherea from the clutches of Manston and takes her to a place of safety. Still there is more to come. Manston continues to pursue Cytherea relentlessly. He is caught in an attempt at rape, escapes, is hunted down and is condemned to death. He evades the noose by suicide and leaves a confession clearing up the mystery. His guilt-stricken mother dies. Her great house and estate pass, through the offices of the good Parson Raunham, to the hero, who at last marries the heroine. In the words of a minor character, 'the romance has ended well' (379).

Despite this conventional closure to a sensational plot, Hardy contrived to insert into *Desperate Remedies* much Drysdalean satire of Victorian ideals of love. Poetry has given Springrove romantic notions of finding love with a perfect soul-mate. For a time he fancies he has found the ideal in his cousin, Adelaide Hinton, the sweetheart of his Arcadian youth. They become engaged. Gradually, romantic illusions yield to mundane reality. Springrove realises that the practical Adelaide is not an exceptional being and concludes that such people are only to be found in romances. He must be satisfied 'in more homely matters . . . with his cousin' (173).

Yet the novel is not allowed to rest there. As in Drysdale, the mutability of youthful love is demonstrated and romantic love is shown to be an illusion, fostered by art. This is true of all three lovers. In the contrived romantic setting of a coastal watering-place, Springrove falls in love with Cytherea as if a goddess had 'appeared in the sky' (173). All his idealistic

dreams revive: he has found his Amaryllis. Likewise, Cytherea falls in love with Springrove by reading his poems and imagines that their love will survive a long separation. Similarly, the youthful Aeneas Manston falls in love with a 'third rate actress, marries her to licence his passion and grows to dislike her when they have been married a week' (156).

Desperate Remedies, of course, was never intended as a work of propaganda. Hardy makes no direct reference to George Drysdale's libertarian remedies for the predicaments of mutable love. Yet the strategy of inserting 'edgewise' references to radicalism and republicanism is very clear to anyone in a position to understand them. Thus in [Chapter 3](#) of the third volume, Springrove goes to the Charing Cross post office to send off the evidence incriminating Manston in the murder of his wife. Having observed this act, Manston 'rushed along the Strand, through Holywell Street, and on to Old Boswell Court. Kicking aside the shoeblacks who began to importune him as he passed under the colonnade' (298). Thus the passage signals that Hardy is very familiar not only with Holywell Street, but also with the fact that the customers of the 'low booksellers' who sold Drysdale's *Elements of Social Science* along with pornography were often 'gentlemen' targeted by shoeblacks. There is therefore a nod here to the sexually radical literature that could be bought in the street.

There is another nod to Drysdale in [Chapter 5](#) of Volume II. As we saw in [Chapter 6](#) of this study, Drysdale presented his natural religion as an alternative basis to the Christian ideal of lifelong monogamy. Among the leading characters, it is Cytherea, intelligent as well as beautiful, who comes closest to interpreting her experience in Drysdale's terms. When she agrees to marry Manston, she feels that it is her Christian duty to marry in the interests of her brother. Yet she knows that her decision is a violation of her nature, forced upon her by ill fortune. Awaking from her tortured nightmares, she finds that winter ice has devastated the trees in the grounds of Knatwater House, all but blocking the way to her wedding. We should recall here Drysdale's warning that violation of the natural laws of love would bring punishment by 'nature', personified as a female ruler of the world. Cytherea's thought on the morning of her marriage to Manston echoes Drysdale: 'On this morning I am to be married – unless this is a scheme of the great Mother to hinder a union of which she does not approve' (228).

Another way in which Hardy signals his sympathy with Drysdale's views is the use of dialogic narration to point up Drysdale's conception of the conflict between romance and natural law. Hardy uses his rustic characters to hint at

Drysdale's subversive views, a technique which will be further developed in *Under the Greenwood Tree* and fully realised in *Far from the Madding Crowd*. Here the rustic characters already hint at an alternative pagan outlook. The parish clerk, Richard Cricket, 'a kind of Bowdlerised rake' (119), says that marriage is like playing with fire (377). Christian marriage, he opines, flies against natural wit, 'for wit's nothen without a faint shadder o' sin' (378).

There is also direct reference to free thought and republicanism in *Desperate Remedies*, occurring in [Chapter 4](#) of Volume III. The country postman, his tongue loosened by Manston's brandy, reflects on the decline of Christian belief among church goers and the spread of republicanism among the skilled working class:

[Postman] 'Ah, you may depend upon it they'll do away wi' Providence altogether, afore long, although we've had him over us so many years.'

[Manston] 'There's no knowing.'

[Postman] 'And I suppose the Queen will be done away wi' then. A pretty concern that'll be! Nobody's head to put on your letters; and then your honest man who do pay his penny will never be known from your scamp who don't. Oh 'tis [dam]nation!' (302)

The final remark here makes it seem that the postman is a loyalist who opposes republicanism but, as the brandy undermines his caution in talking to an apparently respectable gentleman, he bursts into an unmistakably republican song:

He flung his mallet against the wall,
Said, 'The Lord make churches and chapels to fall,
And there'll be work for tradesmen all!
When Joan's ale was new, My boys,
When Joan's ale was new.'

This is from the stone-mason's verse in a country drinking song, 'The Seven Trades'.² The postman tells Manston, 'I was originally a mason by trade', and adds apologetically, 'no offence to you if you be a parson?' (303). The apology would have been intelligible only to an interpretive community of readers who knew that stone-masons were prominent in radical and atheist circles such as secular societies.

The ending of *Desperate Remedies* seems to veer away from radical notions, recalling to the reader a good deal of Comte on love and

marriage. Masculine reason and womanly love are united in the marriage of Springrove and Cytherea. The community, shaken by mechanical progress in the form of the railway (118), is to be renewed by the wealth of Miss Aldclyffe, wisely administered by a priest who cares nothing for it as personal property. Springrove, Cytherea and the good parson Raunham have broken the mechanical cycle of civilisation, represented by the waterfall and pumping engine (61, 87). The regeneration of civilisation may be inferred.

Yet many radical and republican readers would have understood the satirical subtext of the novel and seen the utopian ending for what it was, a sensational turning of the wheel of fortune quite inadequate to overcome the cycles of society. Women like Miss Aldclyffe will still grow bitter and cynical at the hypocrisy which condemns them for bearing a child out of wedlock (80). Penniless young women like Cytherea will still have to work as maids at the whim of imperious mistresses (65, 77). Young lovers will still be expected to mate for life as if they were swans (206, 381). Middle-class young men who undertake marriage will still have to bid goodbye 'to the last infirmity of noble mind' and take 'to house hunting and consols' (31). The romance has indeed ended well, but it remains a romance for all that.

10.2 SATIRE AND PASTORAL: *UNDER THE GREENWOOD TREE*

Hardy undertook a very different kind of experiment in his second published novel, *Under the Greenwood Tree* (1872).³ This time he mixed satire into an Arcadian or pastoral tale, derived ultimately from the *Georgics* and *Eclogues* of the Roman poet Virgil. He also drew on Shakespeare's *As You Like It*, taking the title of his novel from a song in the play, in which Arcadian love is threatened by powerful and sinister interests operating from outside the Forest of Arden. With a different kind of experiment, the underlying purpose remained the same: to satirise romantic love as a basis for Victorian marriage.

The plot of *Under the Greenwood Tree* turns on the wooing of Fancy Day by Dick Dewey. Their social circumstances are widely separated. Dick is the son of a small farmer, who combines cider growing with an 'irregular' business as a country carrier. Fancy is a village schoolteacher, brought up and educated in refined ways by her father, the upwardly mobile Geoffrey Day, who has risen from gamekeeper to steward on the estate of the Earl of Wessex, while working a large, 500-acre farm on his

own account. Dick falls in love with Fancy when he beholds her framed like a painting in her candlelit window and worships her as a divinity.

The falseness of such romantic love as a basis for marriage is pointed up by the representation of attitudes among the small tradesmen in the Melstock quire, and their wives. This representation is based, as *Life and Work* pointed out (95), on the lives of Hardy's own family and their neighbours in the parish of Stinsford, Dorset, during the 1830s and 1840s. The Melstock rustics make it clear that marriage is founded for them, as for Hardy's parents, on anything but romantic ideals. Their union has to be undertaken with Drysdale's two chief duties in mind: first, poverty should be avoided by limiting the number of children born to the couple, and second, they must work to provide a comfortable home and suitable education for the children they have.

The first obligation is indicated in several set pieces in the novel, where the quire is on view. In Part I, [Chapter 2](#), the Dewey family of five children is represented as 'graduating uniformly' at four-yearly intervals from Dick aged 20 to the youngest aged 4. The ensuing conversation between Mrs Dewey and Mr Penny about his daughter, who is pregnant, points up the problem of a fatalistic approach to married love:

'Indeed! – poor soul – And how many will that make in all – four or five?'
'Five – they've buried three. Yes five! And she not much more than a maid yet. She do know the multiplication table unmistakable well.' (18)

The case of Thomas Leaf's mother reinforces the moral. That 'romantic' woman (77), as Reuben Dewey calls her, had 12 children one after another, and they all miscarried or died very young, except for Thomas, who grew up with intellectual disabilities. To add to her misfortune, one of the dead children was Thomas's brother Jim, who might have been a stay to her had he lived. 'She'd never have had to work in her old age if he had continued strong,' said Thomas (*ibid.*).

The rustics return to these themes in Part V, [Chapter 2](#):

'I tell ye, neighbours, when the pinch comes,' said the tranter. 'When the oldest daughter's boots be only a size less than her mother's, and the rest o' the flock close behind her. A sharp time for a man that, my sonnies; a very sharp time' ...
'You've no cause to complain, Reuben, of such a close-coming flock,' said Mrs. Dewey; 'For ours was a straggling lot enough, God knows' ...

‘And if they come together they go together,’ said Mrs. Penny, whose family had been the reverse of the tranter’s. ‘And a little money will make either fate tolerable.’ (196)

Finally, we should note the general views of love and marriage which tranter Dewey proffers his son in Part II, [Chapter 7](#). Marriage for him is a practical business of satisfying instinct and reproducing the community, and romantic love is likely to be a snare. As he tells his son:

I can’t see what the nation a young feller like you, wi’ a comfortable house and home, and father and mother to take care o’ thee and who sent ’ee to a school so good that ’twas hardly fair to the the other children, should want to go hollering a young woman for, when she’s quietly making a husband in her pocket, and not troubled by chick nor chiel, to make a poverty-strick’ wife and family of her, and neither had cap, wig, nor waistcoat to set ’em up with: be drowned if I can see it, and that’s the long and short o’t my sonny! (108)

With his romantic view of marriage, Dick cannot understand these strange ideas:

Dick wondered how it was that when people were married they could be so blind to romance; and was quite certain that if he ever took to wife that dear impossible Fancy he and she would never be so dreadfully practical and undemonstrative of the passion as is father and mother were. The most extraordinary thing was that all the fathers and mothers he knew were just as undemonstrative as his. (62)

To Fancy, however, love appears in a different light. As a young woman with her own home and occupation, she is uneasily aware that marriage to Dick must lead to a loss of freedom for her. She feels this when Dick lifts her masterfully into his spring cart to take her home from Budmouth: ‘Smart [the horse] jogged alone, and Dick jogged, and the helpless Fancy necessarily jogged too; and she felt that she was in a measure captured and made a prisoner’ (118).

As Drysdale argued, the Victorian sexual code allowed freedom in love for a young woman like Fancy only to choice of a marriage partner. The choice made, moreover, there is no going back on it. Thus Fancy is sharply disillusioned by her attempt to exercise free choice between Dick and Parson Maybold as a suitor. Maybold is a gentleman of education and refinement who can offer her far wider prospects than Dick. For 24 hours

she allows herself to believe that she is free to reject Dick and take the parson, only to discover that a true Christian gentleman must accept her prior engagement as binding.

So Fancy submits to what she now sees as her fate, encouraged by the advice of those who, like Mrs Penny, have gone before:

‘Well, thinks I, ’tis to be, and here goes! And do you do the same: say, ’tis to be, and here goes!’

‘Is there such wonderful virtue in ’tis to be and here goes?’ inquired Fancy.

‘Wonderful. Twill carry a body through it all from wedding to churching if you only let it out with spirit enough.’

‘Very well then,’ said Fancy blushing. ‘Tis to be and here goes!’ (183f)

Rereading the novel for the edition of 1912, Hardy felt constrained to reflect that

the realities out of which it was spun were material for another kind of study of this little group of church musicians than is found in the chapters here penned so lightly, even so farcically and flippantly at times. But circumstances would have rendered any aim at a deeper, more essential, more transcendent handling unadvisable at the date of writing (4).

The circumstances were, of course, the censorship exercised by reviewers in the periodicals and the purchasers for the circulating libraries. They placed severe limitations on the representation of wooing as competition for sex and sustenance.

As we have seen, this is how Drysdale represented it. He did not have to wait for Darwin’s *Origin of Species* to recognise ‘the struggle for existence’, as he had already described it in the metaphor of woodland life: ‘Mankind are like a forest of trees too thickly planted. All indeed suffer more or less, but the more robust struggle upward, and in so doing destroy their weaker neighbours.’⁴

There is a hint of this metaphor in the opening pages of *Under the Greenwood Tree*:

To dwellers in a wood, almost every species of tree has its voice as well as its feature. At the passing of the breeze the fir-trees sob and moan no less distinctly than they rock: the holly whistles as it battles with itself: the ash hisses amid its quivering: the beech rustles while its flat boughs rise and fall. And winter, which modifies the note of such trees as shed their leaves, does not destroy its individuality. (11)

Again, the themes of competition for food and sex are very cleverly linked in Part IV, [Chapter 2](#), ‘Honey-taking, and afterwards’. As Farmer Shiner and Dick battle each other for the approval of Fancy, father and daughter reflect on the competition of man and bees for honey:

‘Those holes will be the grave of thousands,’ said Fancy. ‘I think ’tis rather a cruel thing to do.’

Her father shook his head. ‘No,’ he said, tapping the hives to shake the dead bees from their cells, ‘if you suffocate ’em this way they only die once: if you fumigate ’em in the new way they come to life again, and die o’ starvation; so the pangs o’ death be twice upon ’em.’

‘I incline to Fancy’s notion,’ said Mr. Shiner laughing lightly.

‘The proper way to take honey, so that the bees be nither starved nor murdered is a puzzling matter,’ said the keeper, steadily.

‘I should like never to take it from them,’ said Fancy.

‘But ’tis the money,’ said Enoch musingly. ‘For without money man is a shadder.’ (146)

The point is reinforced later in the chapter when Keeper Day turns down Dick in favour of Shiner as a suitor for his daughter: ‘The stillness was disturbed only by some small bird that was being killed by an owl in the adjoining wood, whose cry passed into the silence without mingling with it’ (152).

At the time he wrote the 1912 preface, Hardy would have been mentally comparing *Under the Greenwood Tree* with his later novel, *The Woodlanders*, which dealt more overtly with these themes. This led him in that preface somewhat to disparage their handling in the earlier woodland tale. Yet there was enough in the earlier text for radical and republican readers to understand his satirical purpose without his incurring the drubbing which *Desperate Remedies* had suffered in *The Spectator*. In any case, such readers would have enjoyed the deftness with which this apprentice to fiction inserted his satire edgewise.

NOTES

1. *Life and Work*, p. 80.
2. Hardy, *Desperate Remedies*, ed. P. Ingham (Oxford, 2003), p. 302n.
3. T. Hardy, *Under the Greenwood Tree*: Oxford World’s Classics, ed. and intr. S. Gatrell (Oxford, 1989).
4. Drysdale, *Elements*, p. 170.

The Franco-Prussian War

Hardy began to write *Life and Work* during the First World War of 1914–1918. In it he blamed Germany for launching that war, and strongly implied that Prussia's war against France in 1870 had marked the beginning of the German aggression which brought about decline and fall in European civilisation.¹ From the point of view of this study, however, it is important to note that this was not his view of that war when it broke out in 1870. As this chapter will show, he took an optimistic view of Prussia at that time as a liberal partner in the long struggle for constitutional liberty against dynasts. After the war, however, progress seemed to go into reverse. A new empire was created in Germany. Violent revolution and reaction broke out in France. In Britain, Gladstone's Liberal government was defeated and a Conservative majority returned to Parliament for the first time since 1841. The new Conservative Prime Minister, Benjamin Disraeli, proclaimed Queen Victoria Empress of India in 1876. Far from diminishing, the late-manhood crisis of European civilisation seemed to be taking a further plunge and the English symptoms of it were inscribed, as we shall see, in Hardy's next two novels.

11.1 THE RISE OF PRUSSIA

The view that the rise of Prussia represented an advance for liberal principles was commonly held in England.² This was a misreading of Prussian politics in the 1860s. Germany then was a loose federation of states,

dominated in foreign policy by Austria. Prussia in the 1860s aimed at replacing Austria as the leading German state. As it worked through this policy, English liberals believed that Prussia was steering Germany in the direction of their cherished principles of national self-determination and constitutional monarchy.

There was some evidence to support this view. The Prussian liberals of the Progress party had won a majority at the polls in 1863. Admittedly, the King of Prussia, Wilhelm I, was a hard-line absolutist, prepared to govern without reference to Parliament. His son and heir, however, was married to a daughter of Queen Victoria and was thought to be a liberal who would initiate constitutional principles on his accession which, given the King's age, might be imminent.

From the same standpoint, Otto von Bismarck, the Prime Minister appointed by the King over the head of Parliament in 1862, also seemed equivocal. He had been a leading reactionary among the Junker landlords of Prussia. He ignored Parliament and governed by royal decree and press censorship. Nevertheless, he skilfully played on nationalist sentiment among German liberals by proposing in 1863 that the assembly of the Confederation of German states be converted into a national Parliament (Reichstag) elected by universal male suffrage. By making this proposal, Bismarck aimed to exclude Austria from the Confederation, since the empire of the Habsburgs, he believed correctly, would oppose a democratically elected Reichstag. Bismarck went on, in 1864, to use military force to prevent the incorporation of the Germans of Schleswig-Holstein into Denmark, an action which won him increased support among patriotic liberals. They saw it as a step towards the unification of all Germans in one state.

Bismarck now saw the possibility of a quarrel between Prussia and Austria as to which of them should rule in Schleswig-Holstein. In 1866 he invaded Holstein, provoking Austria into a declaration of war. Prussia won a decisive victory at the battle of Koniggratz. Austria then had to agree to dissolution of the German Confederation and the establishment of a North German Federation under Prussian leadership. The possibility of an ethnically homogeneous and unified Germany, excluding the multi-racial Austrian empire, was held open.

Victory over Austria and the promise of German unification was rapturously received by patriotic liberals in Prussia. The Progress Party split. The patriots formed the National Liberal party and the Progressists were reduced to a rump at the next general election.

The National Liberals praised Bismarck for having carried out 'revolution from above'.³ After all, he had overthrown long-standing absolutist rulers to create the North German Federation. More than this, in 1867 he provided this new Federation with a Parliament (Reichstag) elected by universal male suffrage. These were enduring aims of all liberals. Most of them were prepared to overlook the fact that the Reichstag could not control military expenditure and could not dismiss the Chancellor, who was Bismarck himself.

11.2 HORACE MOULE AND NAPOLEON III

In London, neither the Liberal nor the Conservative government was concerned at the rise of Prussian power. The Liberals saw advantage in the humiliation of Austria, which was at last forced out of Italy by the peace settlement. Later, the Conservatives saw advantage in the emergence of a strong North German bloc which would hinder co-operation between Britain's traditional rivals, Russia and France. As for public opinion, English Protestants favoured Lutheran Germany over Catholic France,⁴ and radicals saw Prussia as the leader of a German nation rightly struggling to be free. They viewed the Emperor Napoleon III and his Second Empire as a far greater insult to liberalism than the King of Prussia.

Horace Moule shared this view. He had been an undergraduate at Oxford and Cambridge during the rise of university radicalism and Positivism there.⁵ National self-determination was a shibboleth of these movements and the Emperor Napoleon III of France was their *bête noire*. In his early efforts to gain entry into journalism, Moule advertised his belief in these liberal causes. In the *Dorset County Chronicle* he published an article on the career of Cavour,⁶ the Prime Minister of Piedmont and Savoy, praising him as the architect of a united Italy. Earlier he had attacked Napoleon III in a public lecture, delivered in Dorchester town hall in 1859 and reported almost verbatim in the *Chronicle*.⁷ It was a dire warning against the Emperor's imperialistic and dynastic ambitions.

By that time Moule was the author of *A History of the Roman Republic*, a crammer for schoolboys which summarised Arnold's interpretation of the history of Rome. Not surprisingly, then, his lecture began by invoking an Arnoldian analogy between ancient and modern history:

Rome was the France of those days, and Carthage was the England. Rome was the military power, alert, vigorous, aggressive, always looking abroad to

see where the next step should be taken. Carthage was the maritime power, rich, commercial, confident in the command of the sea.

The Carthaginians, Moule argued, had under-estimated the possibility of a Roman invasion by sea. They were defeated in the first engagement with a new Roman navy and, 'within a hundred years, the proud city was levelled with the ground.'

Moule went on to document the naval threat to England posed by the modern Rome:

Between 1850 and 1858 the French Emperor has built 20 new ships of the line; 20 frigates of the 1st class; and from 40–50 of lower rates, besides corvettes, small craft, floating batteries and iron transports, each constructed to carry 1,000 troops.

The threat was even greater than in the time of Napoleon I, Moule argued. Steam and the electric telegraph had made it incomparably easier for France to invade England. Add to this the fact that the French had a large conscript army, and it was easy to see how the imperialistic and dynastic ambitions of the first Napoleon were being revived by his nephew.

Moule gave his support to Palmerston, who was resisting the demand of his finance minister, Gladstone, for retrenchment of military expenditure. Palmerston advocated formation of Rifle Corps; fortification of the south-coast ports; and construction of a Channel fleet. Moule agreed and went on to argue that a rearmed Britain was required in a Europe where the balance of power was threatened by the clash of empires. 'What hindered Russia', he asked,

from occupying the long-coveted shores of the Bosphorus, and France from advancing to the Rhine frontier? England was notoriously the obstacle in either case; nor was it possible to imagine anything which would be more directly to the advantage of the great northern Power, than that France should undertake the task of humiliating England.

Concluding on a Palmerstonian note, Moule reminded his audience of England's historic destiny as the friend of constitutional government, asking it to keep in mind 'the great institutions . . . that we, as a country, have to uphold and defend'. He sat down to prolonged applause.

11.3 THE FALL OF FRANCE

If government in London was relaxed about the rise of Prussia, the government in Paris was not. Unable to prevent the demotion of Austria, Napoleon III schemed in the ensuing years to hinder Prussia by diplomacy. But he was no match for Bismarck. Following the defeat of Austria, Napoleon demanded 'compensation', the annexation of Luxembourg by France. Bismarck resisted and a London conference conferred neutrality on the tiny state. Napoleon felt tricked and resolved to resist any further extension of Prussian power.

Bismarck, who suspected Napoleon of designs on the Rhineland, was prepared to provoke war with France. His opportunity came in 1869 when a new regime in Spain offered its throne to a prince of the ruling house of Prussia, the so-called Hohenzollern candidature. The French government strenuously resisted, demanding not only that the prince turned down the offer, but that King Wilhelm of Prussia abjure it forever. The King politely refused to surrender the interest of his dynasty. He set out his views in the notorious 'Ems telegram' which he drafted for Bismarck to approve and send on to Paris. Before sending it, Bismarck altered the text to make it seem much more defiant and so provoke Paris to declare a war in which France looked like the aggressor and Prussia the victim.

France declared war on 19 July 1870. Bismarck's strategy worked. The south German states joined the war on Prussia's side. Austria held aloof. Britain was alienated from France by Bismarck's publication of a draft treaty which revealed that Napoleon had proposed to annex Belgium in 1866. Russia was still alienated from France by its defeat in the Crimea, and Italy was grateful to Prussia for securing Austrian withdrawal from the peninsula.

France was thus isolated and had to stand alone, ill prepared and badly led. Even so, the French soldiers fought stubbornly against the invaders. The outcome hung in the balance until 19 August, when the French were decisively beaten in the battle of Gravelot. Disaster followed. On 1 September their army was decimated at Sedan. Napoleon III was captured by the Germans and deposed by the French.

A government of national defence was set up, negotiating secretly with the Prussians for an early ceasefire. In Paris, however, republicans, backed by working and lower middle classes and long repressed under the Empire, came out strongly for resistance to the siege which the Prussians now threw around the capital.⁸ This alarmed the business class and right-wing

republicans like Thiers who, in January, negotiated an armistice in order to hold national elections. The election in February produced a majority for Thiers's peace policy. By this time, however, left republicans in Paris were demanding a 'Commune' for the capital, to continue resistance and promote social-democratic policies. Thiers's right-republican government, determined to resist what it called the 'Communist' movement, demanded surrender of the city's canon. This provoked a violent popular revolt. A Commune was proclaimed in March and a populist majority elected to govern it. Its red flag flew over the Hotel de Ville until May, when Thiers sent in troops to crush it. More than 20,000 'communards' were shot with or without trial by courts martial. The conservative character of the new Third Republic was thus ensured for a decade.

Meanwhile, in the Hall of Mirrors in the Palace of Versailles, Bismarck, who had already negotiated a union of north and south Germany, proclaimed the establishment of a German Empire (Reich) under William I of Prussia, now entitled 'Kaiser' or Emperor. A humiliating treaty was imposed on France, by which Germany annexed Alsace-Lorraine, and France agreed to pay a huge indemnity for allegedly provoking the war.

11.4 HARDY AND THE WAR

Throughout the war, Horace Moule upheld the liberal view of Prussia and France, as can be clearly seen in his articles in *Fraser's Magazine*. In one of them he wrote that the war was a struggle between two opposing principles, that of dynastic empire versus nationality. 'Can any rational being', Moule asked, 'pretend to believe that a variety of nationalities can nowadays be welded together into one state or empire in the interests of any dynasty?'⁹

By contrast, Hardy's brief comments on the war in *Life and Work* are somewhat ambiguous and have given rise to doubt about his ultimate support for Moule's views. When the war began he was anti-French, as might be expected of a young man from Dorset, who remembered that his grandfather volunteered for the militia raised against the threat of invasion by the first Bonaparte. On the other hand, his current employer, the architect Raphael Brandon, was something of a Francophile. *Life and Work* recalls that, during the early weeks of the war, Brandon would 'go into the Strand for every edition of the afternoon papers as they came out, and bring them in and read them to Hardy, who grew as excited as he'.¹⁰

But on 6 August Hardy was sent down to St Juliot, in Cornwall, where, the previous year, he had been placed in charge of church restoration. This enabled him to renew his courtship of the rector's sister-in-law, Hardy's future wife, Emma Lavinia Gifford. It has been suggested that during this visit, Hardy sobered up about the war and came to doubt Moule's judgement of it.¹¹ Yet the evidence can be interpreted another way. *Life and Work* reproduced a notebook entry containing the following quotation from the Roman poet Horace: '*Quicquid delirant reges, plectuntur Achivi*!'¹² ('Whenever monarchs err, the people are punished!') From the perspective of the First World War, this may look like an objection to war in general but, in the context of 1870, it reads more like a critical comment on Napoleon III. After all, Moule's articles, which Hardy was reading in Cornwall, strongly allege that the French Emperor had for years been waging war to the detriment of his unwilling subjects.

That Hardy rejoiced in the overthrow of Napoleon III and the opportunity it created for liberal progress in Europe is also suggested by a drawing made by Emma at this time. As Millgate put it, she 'lightheartedly drew her lover as he sat on a fence with a makeshift flag in his hand'.¹³ A flag looks like celebration, not agony over the horrors of war. But what flag could this have been? The Union Jack would not have been in point, given Britain's neutrality. A Prussian flag is also unlikely – more so a French. However, we may speculate on Positivist symbolism here. In *A General View of Positivism*, Comte had forecast that the French revolution of 1848 would quickly take on the internationalist project of 1789, which had been disrupted by subsequent conflict between the reactionary powers and Napoleon. Positivists, Comte argued, should encourage this by forming an international committee to work for the creation of a 'western republic', comprising five nations: France, Germany, England, Italy and Spain. It would have a common currency, its own navy and a single flag.¹⁴ It seems likely that Hardy would have discussed Comte's ideas with his fiancée and that she would have pleased him by depicting him holding up the Positivist flag in the moment of Napoleon III's downfall.

When he came to write *Life and Work* in 1915–1918, however, Hardy was in an anti-German mood and projected the feeling back to this episode in 1870. He pointed out that his recent poem 'In Time of the Breaking of Nations' grew from some jottings made in his 1870 visit to Cornwall. Yet the lines in themselves were quite compatible with his hope at that time that Prussia's defeat of the French dynast would lead to a renewal of progress. The scene he represented seems

to symbolise a rusted old world, the hard lot of labour, the consuming fire of war and the hope of an upward renewal of progress: 'Sc. Rusty harrow – behind that rooks – behind them, two men, hoeing mangel, with bowed backs, behind that a heap of couch smoking, behind these horse and cart doing nothing in field – then the ground rising to plantation.'¹⁵

11.5 PROGRESS REVERSED

In the late 1860s, Hardy could believe that European civilisation was progressing towards democracy, individual liberty and national self-determination. This belief could last until the fall of Napoleon III. That dynasty gone, France had once again a republican form of government. British politics also seemed to be tending in a progressive direction. Gladstone's Liberal Party was in power. The Church of Ireland was disestablished. The movement to disestablish the Church of England was gaining support in Parliament. Aristocratic privilege was yielding to liberal reforms: land-tenure reform in Ireland, the abolition of the purchase system which bolstered aristocratic monopoly of military commissions, and the opening of the civil service to competitive examination. Even republicanism seemed to be gaining ground. Queen Victoria had made herself unpopular by shutting herself away after Albert's death. This, together with scandal around the Prince of Wales, gained increased votes for Charles Dilke's motions in the House of Commons to reduce financial provision for the monarchy, known as the 'civil list'.

Yet in 1874 all these radical hopes seemed to collapse in ruin. Gladstone went down to ignominious defeat in the general election of that year. His conqueror, Benjamin Disraeli, had prepared the ground carefully for a Conservative victory. In two well-publicised speeches in 1872, at Manchester and the Crystal Palace, he set out a narrative of England enfeebled by Liberal rule. They had alienated working men by refusing to decriminalise peaceful picketing. They had done nothing to clean up the city slums. They had threatened the Church of England with disestablishment. They had weakened the empire by granting self-government to Australia and Canada. Disraeli enlarged on this last theme. England and the colonies should have been consolidated into a political federation, a military alliance and a customs union.¹⁶

Most historians believe that Disraeli had no intention of doing these things himself. He was only talking up the empire in response to the

threats of the new balance of power in the world, represented by the new German Reich, the advance of Imperial Russia through central Asia towards India, and the hostility of the United States towards British colonies in the Americas.¹⁷ However that may be, the results of his campaign disturbed people like Hardy.

In the election of 1874, English middle-class voters rallied to Disraeli. This was not because they approved of imperial federation. But they agreed with the two main allegations which Disraeli levelled against Gladstone. First, he had been passive in response to the changing world order, standing aloof in the Franco-Prussian war and ignoring the advance of Russian naval power into the Mediterranean. Second, he had bowed to radical pressure for church disestablishment and attacks on the property rights of landowners. As it seemed to them, it had been the Irish church and the Irish landowners last time. Next time it would be the Church of England and the broad acres and businesses of England, hard pressed by the world economic depression.

Consequently, the Conservative party was returned with a clear majority for the first time since 1841. As Prime Minister, Disraeli lost no time in flaunting England's status and position as an imperial power. He proclaimed Queen Victoria 'Empress of India' and purchased Egyptian government shares in the Suez Canal, the short route to India. Simultaneously, he showered honours on General Wolseley when he returned from a successful war against the Ashanti in West Africa. Commentators on the radical wing of English liberalism deplored this 'flashy' imperialism, the adulation of monarchy and the by-passing of Parliament by the use of royal prerogative to carry them out. Prominent among them were the Positivists John Morley and Frederic Harrison, and the republican Charles Dilke.¹⁸

All three were known to Hardy at this time. Yet of Hardy's views we know nothing directly. *Life and Work* is silent about political events in the early 1870s. There may be more than one explanation for this. If we recall his strong preference for gradual over violent revolution, it is easier to understand his silence about the Commune. He was hardly likely to defend it like some of the English Positivists did.¹⁹ We should also recall that one aim of the pseudo-biography was to guard his early life (and Horace Moule's) from intrusive biographical investigation. Accordingly, the early chapters of *Life and Work* are the most elliptical in the book. If, however, we read his next two novels, *A Pair of Blue Eyes* and *Far from the Madding Crowd*, with the political context in mind, we will readily see Hardy's growing concern that progress was threatened by reversal. In the next chapter I consider the first of these two novels.

NOTES

1. *Life and Work*, p. 50.
2. Finn, *After Chartism*, pp. 273–283.
3. V. Ulrich, *Bismarck: The Iron Chancellor*, tr. T. Beech (London, 2008), p. 66.
4. R. Millman, *British Foreign Policy during the Franco-Prussian War* (Oxford, 1965), pp. 36f, 42ff.
5. Kent, *Brains and Numbers*, esp. pp. 3–68. Wright, *Religion of Humanity* pp. 40–61.
6. DCC, 17 October 1861.
7. DCC, 15 December 1859.
8. For discussion of the Commune, see R. Magraw, *France, 1814–1945: The Bourgeois Century* (London, 1983), pp. 197–208, upon which this paragraph relies.
9. *Fraser's Magazine*, Sep. 1870, p. 387. The article is unsigned, but the opinions and the style are clearly Moule's.
10. *Life and Work*, pp. 16, 81.
11. Pite, *Hardy*, pp. 177f.
12. Horace, *Epistles I*, 2, 14, quoted in *Life and Work*, p. 81.
13. Millgate, *Hardy Revisited*, p. 119.
14. Comte, *General View*, pp. 409, 410–414.
15. Millgate, *Hardy Revisited*, p. 119.
16. For the content, see R. Koebner and H. D. Schmidt, *Imperialism: The Story and Significance of a Political Word, 1840–1960* (Cambridge, 1964), pp. 102ff.
17. Koebner and Schmidt, *Imperialism*, pp. 118ff; C. Eldridge, *England's Mission: The Imperial Idea in the Age of Gladstone and Disraeli, 1868–1880* (London, 1973), pp. 175ff. J. Vincent, *Disraeli* (London, 1990), however, takes a positive view of Disraeli's imperialism.
18. For the views of Morley, see Kent, *Brains and Numbers*, pp. 117–135. For Harrison, see M. S. Vogeler, *Frederic Harrison: The Vocations of a Positivist* (Oxford, 1984), pp. 94–140. For Dilke, see Nicholls, *The Lost Prime Minister*, pp. 66ff.
19. Vogler, *Harrison*, pp. 100–103.

Satire and Romance: *A Pair of Blue Eyes*

In *A Pair of Blue Eyes* (1873),¹ Hardy attempted a more complex fiction than the two previously published, combining satire with romance. The plot concerns the romantic love between Elfride Swancourt and two suitors, Stephen Smith and Henry Knight. Elfride is the daughter of a widower, the vicar of Endelstow parish in Cornwall. Having grown up motherless in a remote country parsonage, she has little experience of love or the world. Her first serious encounter with the former occurs with Stephen, an architect's clerk, who comes to restore her father's crumbling parish church. From the outset, Hardy represents them as two of Drysdale's impassioned *ingénus*. Elfride at 19 is a girl of unformed character, 'scarcely woman enough for the situation'. Stephen at 20 is 'but a youth in appearance, and not yet a man in years' (15). They fall in love, virtually at first sight, Stephen with Elfride's looks, modest accomplishments and seemingly free spirit, Elfride with Stephen's boyish figure and kissable lips. Knowing nothing more of each other's character, they long for exclusive possession of one another. Each is jealous of imaginary rivals, past, present or future, and immediate engagement to marry soon becomes irresistible.

Like Drysdale, Hardy represents this as a passion fed by poetry – romantic tales of courtly love in which the true knight pledges love and service to his lady fair. Elfride, who has been writing a romance set in the time of King Arthur, soon wants Stephen to do her 'knight service' (56). He in turn declares her to be his 'queen', for whom he would die. Elfride

is carried away with the illusion of conquest: 'She was ruling a heart with absolute despotism for the first time in her life' (58).

After the 'mad action' of their elopement (116), the pair continue to harbour unrealistic illusions. Elfride, though in reality immature and changeable, vows to wait three years to marry Stephen on his return from India. Stephen, for his part, believes that Elfride will be staunchly true to him 'to the end of her life!' (130). These romantic hopes prove illusory when Elfride falls in love with Knight during Stephen's absence in India.

If Stephen's love for Elfride is the product of youthful passion and circumstance, Knight's seems at first very different. At 32 he is much older than either. He does not fall in love with Elfride at first sight. Rather, on his first visit to the Swancourt, he forms the opinion that she is 'weak', her looks 'good: no more', her conversation 'not noteworthy' and her chess playing that of 'a rather conceited child' (184). How to account, then, for the fact that the idea of her becomes 'sublimated in his memory' during his Irish trip (184)? The narrator speculates that 'Knight loved philosophically rather than romantically' (185).

12.1 HENRY KNIGHT AS COMTEAN MAN OF CHIVALRY

To understand what Hardy had in mind by loving philosophically, we must recall *A General View of Positivism*. In [Chapter 4](#), Comte set out his view of ideal marriage and ideal womanhood for which the Positivist philosopher should strive. It would resemble the culture of the European Middle Ages, purged of what he regarded as the evils of Catholic Christianity: its other-worldliness and its low view of marriage as a lesser state which the majority must endure.

Guided by Positivism, the modern age would rise to a nobler conception of religion and matrimony. The latter would be seen as the site from which universal love would grow. In thus remaking marriage, Positivism would teach husband and wife to understand the natural difference between the sexes: that the male is stronger than the female 'in all kinds of force, whether physical, intellectual, or practical'.² Yet it was also a law of nature that women were superior to men in their capacity for loving affection.

Comte thought of love as something higher than sexual gratification. That had been the natural motive of men for the establishment of marriage as a social institution, and was still the main incentive for

most. 'But woman,' Comte went on, 'with her more loving heart, has usually far less need of this coarse stimulus than man.' She could therefore use the influence of her purity to elevate her husband above the ruck of toiling humanity. The Positivist philosopher would promote marriage of this higher kind, seeing that it would be 'the most powerful instrument of moral education; and therefore . . . the basis of public or individual welfare'.³

The chief social agency for promoting such marriages would be Comte's new religion of humanity. Like medieval chivalry, it would aim to foster 'the worship of woman' by men. Similarly, modern chivalry would be purged of its medieval predecessor's other-worldly obsession. The medieval knight had to 'choose between God and his lady'. Modern chivalry would be based on a secular value: 'a voluntary combination of the strong for the protection of the weak'.⁴

In promoting this new ideal of marriage, Comte was confident that Positivist philosophers could rely on natural law. Thanks to the superior capacity of women for affection, men learned to value them in the home, 'first as mother, then as wife'. Consequently on this experience alone, every man could find some woman to elevate, by an act of 'powerful imagination' into the object of his devotion.⁵

In the light of *A General View of Positivism*, then, it is easy to see that Knight represents the Comtean ideal of love and marriage. His name suggests chivalry. His Oxford background, legal vocation and activity in the higher journalism suggest the English Positivists of the 1860s, such as Frederic Harrison. Recognisable Comtean assumptions are inscribed in the text throughout his encounter with Elfride. From the start he adopts an air of intellectual superiority and a manner of imperious command. His comments on the romance she has written are condescending. His way of playing chess with her is like a cudgel fight between two unequally matched opponents. Above all, after her accident on the church tower he adopts the part of the strong, protective male, controlling the weak and giddy female.

Knight's ideal woman, like Comte's, must be pure, untainted by the coarseness of sex. He has elaborated this theory of woman in his periodical essays and imposes it upon Elfride, imagining that she 'had hardly looked upon a man till she saw me' (186).

Like Comte, Knight formulates this desire in religious terms: 'a religion was building itself upon you in my heart', he tells Elfride after learning about her past with Stephen (325). The medieval Catholic root of that religion is

indicated by his choice of places to visit: the 'romantic spot' of Killarney in Catholic Ireland (234) and the 'Continental antiquities' of Europe (240), including the cathedrals and abbeys of Amiens, Chartres and the rest.

Lennart Bjork suggested that Hardy, in writing fiction from *Desperate Remedies* to *Far from the Madding Crowd*, was undergoing a brief period of commitment to 'utopian Positivism'.⁶ The approach taken in this study suggests that another interpretation is possible. I believe that Hardy undermines the Comtean ideal in four ways.

First, there are the ironies of the plot, which expose the vanity of Knight's chivalric imagination. This occurs most clearly on the terrible cliff without a name. The escape of Elfride and Knight from death is represented as an achievement of two comrades. Elfride's courage, ingenuity and strength are as efficacious as Knight's coolness in the face of danger. Yet Knight fails to learn this lesson and, after the first rush of gratitude for her supreme act of friendship, quickly resumes his 'position of ruling power' (214).

Second, there is the characterisation of Knight. Personal disposition and circumstances foster his vanity. The narrator suggests that his psychology has been formed partly by the accidental circumstances of his life and partly by poetry. Circumstances have made him a slave of 'the writing age' (53, 127). The required 'lonely study' has deprived him of experience with real women (297). Consequently, he cannot understand that his 'sentiments' are 'only the ordinary ones of a man of his age' (186), bolstered by the prejudices common to men of 'his kind'. To circumstances have been added the influence of 'several years of poetic study, and, if the truth must be told, poetic efforts'. All this has fostered in Knight unhealthy emotions, developing in his unconscious mind like 'plants in a cellar', which grow to 'preternatural size' (297).

Third, love is represented as naturally changeable, a mutability which is uncontrollable by Victorian Christian precepts. Hardy represents the reasoning mind as slave to the passion. The latter overwhelms the former, as with Elfride after rescuing Knight on the cliff:

An overwhelming rush of exultation at having delivered the man she revered from one of the most terrible forms of death shook the gentle girl to the centre of her soul. It merged in a defiance of duty to Stephen, and a total recklessness as to plighted faith. Every nerve of her will was now in entire subjection to her feeling – volition as a guiding power had forsaken her. (215)

A reasoning, scientific mind, the novel suggests, would recognise love as naturally mutable, like the many changes of sky, sea and weather. They suggest that nature is constantly in flux. Orthodox Christianity has erected a barrier between people and this idea of nature. This is symbolised by the old church tower, which hid the sea from view, leaving the congregation to gaze upon stained glass windows where 'saints and angels vie with each other in primitive surroundings of landscape and sky' (307).

Fourth, we are given a multi-perspectival view of Elfride's character which questions the judgements of Stephen and Knight when they become aware of her history. They see her as fickle and deceitful, but Hardy suggests the possibility of an alternative judgement, more consonant with the general view of nature outlined above: 'Perhaps there was a proneness to inconstancy in her nature', but those who regard her from a point of view beyond inconstancy see a nature 'exquisite . . . in its plasticity and ready sympathies' (248).

Through the crises of the action after his abandonment of Elfride, Knight is brought to see her from this point of view. Thus, in the 'dreadful conflict' caused by her flight to him in London, he dimly perceives that her unreserve is 'artless' (332). But he is as yet too cynical about women to go over to her. Later, when her true relationship with Stephen becomes clear, Knight is 'wretched and conscience-stricken' (353), understanding that it was his own imperiousness that prevented him from seeing her innocence.

Even yet, however, he has a long way to go in the journey to understanding. His race with Stephen to reach Elfride and renew his suit exemplifies Drysdale's theory of 'The selfishness of love and the cruelty of jealousy' (357). Both men furiously denounce Elfride as 'false' on learning of her marriage to Lord Luxellian (367). But, as they stand under the rain by the roadside, their jealous passions cool and understanding begins to dawn. Knight, his voice as gentle as a child's, tells Stephen: 'She is beyond our love, and let her be beyond our reproach. Since we don't know half the reasons that made her do as she did, Stephen, how can we say, even now, that she was not pure and true in heart?' (367).

Elfride's former maid, Unity, completes their conversion by telling how Elfride found love and friendship with Luxellian, who proved to be the kind of husband the narrator had wished for her during her persecution by Knight: 'one of the great mass of bustling mankind, little given to introspection, whose good nature might have compensated for any lack of appreciativeness' (298). It is noteworthy here that 'unityism' was the

term which Fourier and Owen both gave to the ideal of friendship as the binding principle of all social relationships.⁷ When Knight and Stephen find Luxellian grief-stricken over Elfride's coffin in the family vault, their re-education is tragically completed. They can only turn and walk away, sadder and wiser men.

12.2 LOVE IN AN OLD CIVILISATION

It remains to show how Hardy inscribed Mill's philosophy of history into *A Pair of Blue Eyes*. In the core of *On Liberty* (Chapters 2 and 3), Mill argued that the necessary condition for the progress of civilisation was freedom of the individual from restraint in matters that concerned only himself. This was because no one person knew the whole truth about the ends of social existence. It was therefore to the advantage of all to allow 'different experiments in living' to be made. This was what Mill understood as 'culture'.⁸ Spontaneity was the absolute necessity to its development, both in the individual and in society.

Mill went on to claim that moral and social reformers generally looked upon spontaneity with suspicion, 'as a troublesome and perhaps rebellious obstruction' to the improvement of humankind.⁹ They placed their trust in obedience to customary ways, as laid down by religion and social conventions. But a person, Mill argued, who always conformed to law and custom would be an automaton, not a human being.

He allowed that liberal reformers had upheld the right of the individual to deviate from the norm, for example in religious belief, but most strongly disapproved of liberty for the desires and impulses of human nature. 'Desires and impulses', Mill countered, were 'as much a part of a perfect human being, as beliefs and restraints'. They were in fact the 'raw material' of human nature, the source of the 'energy' which powered individual and social development.¹⁰ They could be productive of evil when given free licence, but of good when guided by conscience.

Yet modern civilisation, Mill argued, 'has now fairly got the better of individuality; and the danger which threatens human nature is not the excess, but the deficiency, of personal impulses and preferences.' In modern times, he claimed, 'every one lives as under the eye of a hostile and dreaded censorship'.¹¹ People

do not ask themselves – what do I prefer? Or, what would suit my character and disposition? Or, what would allow the best and highest in me to have

fair play, and enable it to grow and thrive? They ask themselves, what is suitable to my position? What is usually done by persons of my station and pecuniary circumstances? Or (worse still) what is usually done by persons of a station and circumstances superior to mine?¹²

Mill, like Fourier, Owen and Drysdale, identified Christianity as the main ideology crushing spontaneity. Calvin had insisted that the individual will must always be subordinated to the will of God. In modern civilisation this version of Calvinism had been mitigated, but moral standards were still prescribed by authority (such as parents, preachers and moralists). Modern Christians should learn from the pagan Greek ideal of self-development: 'It may be better to be a John Knox than an Alcibiades, but it is better to be a Pericles than either.' The richness, diversity and beauty of humanity, Mill concluded, was best ensured 'not by wearing down into uniformity' individuality, but 'by cultivating it and calling it forth, within the limits imposed by the rights and interests of others'.¹³

However, wearing down into uniformity, Mill contended, was exactly what modern civilisation was doing. Many trends accounted for this: middle-class public opinion, as formed by newspapers, common education, faster communications and commercial competition. Differences between ranks, neighbourhoods, trades and professions, who formerly lived in different worlds, were thus being obliterated.

According to Mill, the only remedy for this state of things was to enlarge the field of freedom. The progress of humanity was the history of the struggle between the despotism of custom and the spirit of liberty. The English must be alerted to this before the trend towards uniformity became irreversible.

It is now possible to see how Hardy inscribed Mill's Germano-Coleridgean philosophy of history into *A Pair of Blue Eyes*. Endelstow parish is remote, but not untouched by modern civilisation. Agriculture, based on 'increased richness of soil', here 'showed signs of far more careful enclosure and management' than the surrounding moorland (11).

Modern uniform culture has arisen on this basis of improving agriculture. It is upheld by Lord Luxellian, scion of a nouveau-riche nobility created under Charles II, and by his client, Parson Swancourt at the Rectory (218). They follow the cultural standards of the metropolis, its newspapers and periodicals, its fashions in dress and literature, its snobbery of rank and property.

In contrast, John Smith, stone-mason, is represented as an independent country craftsman who has survived the division of labour. He 'had too much individuality to be a typical working man' (87). His son Stephen, however, is of a different constitution, 'one which, rare in the springtime of civilisations, seems to grow abundant as a nation gets older, individuality fades, and education spreads' (92).

The views from Knight's windows at Bede's Inn display the contrast of luxury and misery which, according to the Germano-Coleridgeans, overtakes old civilisations. At the front, 'a bustling thoroughfare speaking only of wealth and respectability': at the back, 'as crowded and poverty-stricken a network of alleys as are to be found anywhere in the metropolis' (126).

It is this civilisation, in reality a struggle for existence, which crushes the spontaneity of Elfride Swancourt. Having grown up as a free spirit on the moors and cliffs of Cornwall, she is manipulated by her wealthy stepmother to attract a respectable husband. Imbibing the fashionable Comtean philosophy from Knight, she is turned into a docile creature, quite unlike the resourceful young woman who saved him on the cliff. Given such an opportunity, the narrator comments, no doubt with an eye on Drysdale and Mill, men 'Learn to play the tyrant . . . A slight rebelliousness occasionally would have done him no harm, and would have been a world of advantage to her. But she idolised him, and was proud to be his bond-servant' (298).

Knight's rejection crushes Elfride's last act of independent will. Suicidal and guilt racked, she resolves to marry for the benefit of her family, 'so as to turn my useless life to some practical account' (368). Her marriage to Lord Luxellian works quite well as a settlement but, as Unity says, 'she was not the girl she had been' (370). She sickens and is too weak to survive a miscarriage.

A Pair of Blue Eyes, then, continued Hardy's purpose to use fiction in the cause of liberty and social experiment. Unlike *Desperate Remedies*, however, this romance has not ended well. No doubt this was Hardy's intention. Elfride Swancourt's tragic story was meant to waken the Victorian middle class from zombie obedience to custom. It is the arch-rebel, Eaneas Manston, who points out this feature of human society in his 'last words': 'When we survey the long race of men, it is strange and still more strange to find that they are mainly dead men, who have scarcely ever been otherwise.'¹⁴ In this, his third published novel, Hardy has Parson Swancourt point, as Mill had done, to the classical pagan alternative. He quotes the Roman poet Catullus, justifying girls' 'chartered right to change their minds' (252).

This is not much more than opportunistic flippancy for Swancourt; for Hardy it is wisdom. Educated Victorians, he implies, would benefit more

from their classical than from their Pauline Christian inheritance. If Hardy ever believed that church restoration was the key to moral regeneration, the abandonment of that belief was signalled in *A Pair of Blue Eyes*. Parson Swancourt's neo-Gothic plan for rebuilding Endelstow church is only futile nostalgia for the Catholic Middle Ages: 'by this time . . . one of the cuckoo-cries which are heard but not regarded' (307).

12.3 CONCLUSION

Looking back over Hardy's first three novels, we discern a darkening trend. The utopian ending of *Desperate Remedies* is not repeated in *Under the Greenwood Tree*. The romance of the marriage at its end is, as has often been observed, qualified by Fancy's 'thought of a secret she would never tell' (198). Yet this ending is cheerful when compared to Elfride's fate and its attribution to the shortcomings of an old civilisation. In his next novel, *Far from the Madding Crowd*, Hardy would go further in his critique of Victorian civilisation by extending it to include the dangers of imperialism and class alienation. This, I suggest, was due to the aftermath of the Franco-Prussian war. It is, then, to that novel that I turn in the next chapter.

NOTES

1. Thomas Hardy, *A Pair of Blue Eyes*. Oxford World's Classics, intr. A. Manford (Oxford, 1985).
2. Comte, *General View*, p. 225.
3. Comte, *General View*, pp. 251, 256.
4. Comte, *General View*, pp. p. 273, 274.
5. Comte, *General View*, pp. 276, 280.
6. Bjork, *Psychological Vision*, p. 24.
7. Bjork, *Psychological Vision*, p. 35.
8. J. S. Mill, *On Liberty and Other Essays*, ed. and introduction, J. Gray (Oxford, 1991), p. 63.
9. Mill, *On Liberty*, p. 64.
10. Mill, *On Liberty*, pp. 66, 67.
11. Mill, *On Liberty*, pp. 68, 69.
12. Mill, *On Liberty*, p. 69.
13. Mill, *On Liberty*, pp. 70, 71.
14. Hardy, *Desperate Remedies*, p. 370.

‘Lead Kindly Light’: Satire and History in *Far From the Madding Crowd*

It is a long time since any critic has interpreted *Far from the Madding Crowd* (1874)¹ as a simple pastoral tale, based on scenes from a real Wessex, an English Arcadia, vanishing in the author’s lifetime.² The story is hardly one of rustic innocence. It tells of the financial ruin of a small farmer, the seduction and death of a single parent and her baby, and the downfall of a prosperous man driven by jealousy to insanity and murder.³

The change of critical approach is due, in large measure, to the re-evaluation of ‘pastoral’ associated with Raymond Williams. In *The Country and the City*, he showed ‘pastoral’ to be a more complex genre, when viewed historically, than once was thought. He pointed to a tradition of ‘counter-pastoral’, running from the ancient Greek poet Hesiod through Virgil to Crabbe in the eighteenth century. It could contrast harsh winter and grinding toil with gentle summer and joyous love. Most pertinently for my purpose here, he cited George Puttenham, who wrote in 1589 that the eclogue was devised ‘not of purpose to counterfeit or represent the rustically manner of love or communication: but under the veil of homely persons, and in rude speeches, to insinuate and glance at great matters’.⁴

In this chapter I will attempt to show how *Far from the Madding Crowd* insinuates and glances at great matters. These are the symptoms of a civilisation in late-manhood decline, which are by now familiar to us as religious decay, luxury, class alienation and excessive respectability.

At the outset, this attempt must prompt an obvious question. Where in *Far from the Madding Crowd* do we find any reference to the crisis in the Church of England, to class alienation or to Disraelian imperialism? A common critical response is that they are 'absences'. The answer, I suggest, must be sought in the language of the text. It refers obliquely, for example, to theological disputes over liturgy and dogma which, as Liberal Anglicans saw it, were undermining middle-class support for the Church of England. It draws on long-standing radical criticism of the church, especially that of William Cobbett, to point up satire. It deploys tropes of empire and metaphors of light and dark to signify the violent passions that are driving civilisation towards decline and fall. It is my first endeavour, therefore, to show how Hardy uses these resources of language for his satirical purpose.

13.1 THE CHURCH IN CRISIS

In February 1874, when the Cornhill published the second number of its new serial, *Far from the Madding Crowd*, Britain elected a Conservative majority for the first time in over 30 years and its first ever Jewish prime minister, Benjamin Disraeli. His first session of Parliament was dominated by controversy over Anglican doctrine and liturgy as the government struggled to carry a Public Worship Regulation Act. This had been promoted by Archibald Campbell Tait, the Archbishop of Canterbury, and was aimed at curbing the advance of ritualism in the church.

Ritualism was the Anglo-Catholic response to the shock of the religious census of 1851, which seemed to show that half of the population attended no church whatever, while the Church of England attracted a little less than half of those who did.⁵ As we saw at the end of [Chapter 1](#), ritualism aimed from the late 1850s to introduce practices, thought to be medieval Catholic ones, into the liturgy and worship of the Church of England. These practices included the wearing, by priests conducting services, of rich and colourful clothing, known as 'vestments', and 'ornaments', such as rings. Along with these went the elaborate adornment of churches with candles and other objects. This display of 'the beauty of holiness' flourished at first among some fashionable congregations, but it was also carried to the slum districts, where its introduction by High Church clergy produced a Low Church reaction against 'Popery', which took violent form in demonstrations and riots.

Archibald Tait, Archbishop of Canterbury from 1868 until 1882, was a devotee of Thomas Arnold, whom he had succeeded as head of Rugby school. Like his mentor, Tait wished to purge the Book of Common Prayer of outdated doctrine, as seen from the Broad Church point of view. He thus hoped to enhance the church's appeal to men who were indifferent to doctrinal controversy, yet who valued the antique dignity of the religious Establishment. During the first Gladstone ministry of 1868–1874, Tait had become entangled in a dispute with the High Church party over the Athanasian Creed. This, enshrined in Anglican doctrine along with the Apostles' and Nicene Creeds, was thought by Broad Churchmen to be of doubtful antiquity, perhaps even a forgery dating from the time of Charlemagne. In any case, it was distasteful to those who sympathised with F. D. Maurice, since its so-called damnatory clauses threatened with everlasting punishment those who rejected its teaching on the Trinity. Tait therefore saw it as a glaring example of those outdated creeds and formularies which deterred rational and practical men from church membership.

Also in accordance with Arnoldian 'comprehension' were Tait's views on ritualism. He valued the *via media* of the Elizabethan settlement, which the Book of Common Prayer was thought to have established in matters of liturgy. He had no objection to the moderate use of candles, for example. The Book of Common Prayer either sanctioned such usages or was silent about them. But Tait believed that enthusiastic ritualists, who adopted elaborate vestments and ornaments and practised confession, were dragging the Church of England too far towards Rome and stirring up a Low Church reaction which threatened irremediable division and disestablishment.

Accordingly, Tait had been pressing Gladstone to enact a law empowering bishops to ban ritualistic practices that were not in conformity with the Book of Common Prayer. Gladstone, himself a High Churchman, was not keen on 'excessive' uniformity in the church and fended off Tait's proposal, pending a general election. When Disraeli emerged as victor, Tait saw his opportunity. As leader of the opposition, Disraeli had promoted the Conservative party as defender of the established church. Tait now suggested to him that its future could only be secured by legislating to uphold the Book of Common Prayer. He therefore put before the Prime Minister detailed proposals for a Public Worship Regulation Act that would give a bishop power to deprive a clergyman of his living if he did not conform to his ruling on matters of liturgy.

Tait introduced the bill in the House of Lords in April 1874. It provoked a storm of controversy within the Church of England. Ritualists opposed

the bill outright because it aimed to muzzle them. Some High Churchman, like Gladstone, who thought many ritualists went too far, nevertheless feared that the bill would be unenforceable and would merely provoke ritualists to further resistance. Moreover, as he pointed out, lavish ornamentation of services had its own appeal. Even non-conformists were to be seen using 'Crosses on the outside of chapels, organs within them, rich painted architecture, that flagrant piece of symbolism, the steeple, windows filled with subjects in stained glass, [and] elaborate chanting'.⁶

We need not enter here into the details of controversy over the bill or the violent passions it stirred up in the High and Low factions. These can be studied in relevant works of church history.⁷ It is enough to say here that the bitter religious controversy is the first target of Hardy's satire in *Far from the Madding Crowd*.

The kind of Anglican which the Broad Church aimed to attract is represented on the first page of the novel by Farmer Oak:

On Sundays he was a man of misty views, rather given to a postponing treatment of things, ... upon the whole, one who felt himself to occupy morally that vast middle space of Laodicean neutrality which lay between the Communion people of the parish and the drunken section, – that is, he went to church, but yawned privately by the time the congregation reached the Nicean creed, and thought of what there would be for dinner when he meant to be listening to the sermon.⁸ (9)

Oak is the kind of layman whom Tait, and Thomas Arnold before him, hoped to win for the service of the church. Like the members of the ancient church of Laodicea, he is 'lukewarm and neither cold nor hot' in matters of doctrinal controversy.⁹ As his career progresses through the novel, he becomes a stalwart of the parish, assuming the office of church warden and singing regularly in the choir.

Upper-class Anglicanism is represented, in the homely speech of Cainy Ball, as ritualistic:

'And I went to grand churches and chapels. And how the parson would pray! Yes; he would kneel down and put up his hands together, and make the holy gold rings on his fingers gleam and twinkle in yer eyes, that he'd earned by praying so excellent well! – adh yes, I wish I lived there.'
... 'Oh - and the new style of pa'sons wear moustaches and long beards,' continued the illustrious traveller, 'and look like Moses and Aaron complete,

and make we fokes in the congregation feel all over like the Children of Israel.’ (220)

Like Gladstone, Cainy sees little distinction between church and chapel:

‘And there’s two religions going on in the nation now – High Church and High Chapel. And, thinks I, I’ll play fair; so I went to High Church in the morning, and High Chapel in the afternoon.’

‘Well, at High Church they pray singing, and worship all the colours of the rainbow; and at High Chapel they pray preaching, and worship drab and whitewash only.’¹⁰ (220)

By contrast, Weatherbury parish follows the third way of Parson Thirdley and the Broad Church. It is moderate in its use of ornaments, as we learn from Cainy’s respondents:

‘Our poor Parson Thirdley can’t get no money to buy such rings,’ said Matthew Moon thoughtfully. ‘And as good a man as ever walked. I don’t believe poor Thirdley have a single one, even of humblest tin or copper. Such a great ornament as they’d be to him on a dull a’tnoon, when he’s up in the pulpit, lighted by the wax candles! But ’tis impossible, poor man. Ah, to think how unequal things be.’

‘Perhaps he’s made of different stuff than to wear ’em,’ said Gabriel, grimly. (220)

With the controversy over the Athanasian creed in mind, the authorial comment on the great barn in Chapter 22 takes on a pointed contemporary significance:

The fact that four centuries had neither proved it to be founded on a mistake, inspired any hatred of its purpose, nor given rise to any reaction that had battered it down, invested this simple grey effort of old minds with a repose, if not a grandeur, which a too curious reflection was apt to disturb in its ecclesiastical and military compeers. For once medievalism and modernism had a common standpoint. (143)

Ritualism was one side of factionalism in the crisis of 1874; the Low Church was the other. The latter’s grievances went wider than matters of liturgy. It objected, for example, to state grants to Church of England schools under the Education Act of 1870.¹¹ The religious education it

delivered was, it held, often based on church texts like the Catechism and the Psalter. Broad Church Anglicans supported this, arguing that these texts contained antiquated doctrine. Progressive educationists also objected, on the ground that morality could not be inculcated by rote.

Far from the Madding Crowd picked up this issue in Chapter 44. Bathsheba has fled from her marital home and spent the night out of doors in a swamp, in a state of violent emotional disturbance. She is awakened next morning by passers-by, one of whom is

a schoolboy, with a bag slung over his shoulder, containing his dinner, and a book in his hand. He paused by the gate, and, without looking up, continued murmuring words in tones quite loud enough to reach her ears. 'O Lord, o Lord, o Lord, o Lord, o Lord': that I know out o' book. 'Give us, give us, give us, give us': that I know. 'Grace that, grace that, grace that, grace that': that I know.' Other words followed to the same effect. The boy was of the dunce class apparently; the book was a psalter, and this was his way of learning the collect. (296)

In such passages, then, Hardy inserted edgewise satire of Anglican beliefs and practices that were irrelevant to intelligent lay people.

13.2 CLASS ALIENATION

At first sight there is no allusion in *Far from the Madding Crowd* to class alienation. The parish of Weatherbury seems a model of paternalism that would have delighted Thomas Arnold. Parson and laity co-operate in the care of the poor and the enforcement of moral discipline. Thirdley organises a village club to encourage saving and alms are distributed to 'the second best poor folk' (58). The two leading farmers of the place, Boldwood and Bathsheba, attend church twice each Sunday, surrounded by their servants (96). Boldwood has raised two orphans of the parish, Fanny and Troy, at his own expense. Bathsheba feels responsible for Fanny's moral welfare and is shocked to think she will be buried by the Poor Law authorities.

Like Thomas Arnold, Hardy dislikes the new Poor Law, describing the workhouse at Casterbridge as 'a mere case to hold people in', its shell so thin that 'the grim character of what was beneath showed through it, as the shape of a body is visible under a winding sheet' (262). Arnold thought the welfare of the poor would be better undertaken by local Christian paternalists than utilitarian bureaucrats in London. In this spirit, Bathsheba does

better by Fanny's remains than do the Poor Law authorities. She sends her spring cart to bring the body back to Weatherbury, bedecked with flowers, and pays a shilling to have the church bell rung for the funeral (ch. 42).

The employment relations of farmers and work folk are also paternalistic. Bathsheba provides 'mild liquor . . . bread and cheese' when 'serious work' is 'the order of the day' (143), and there is a gift of ten shillings to each worker when she enters upon her tenancy of Upper Weatherbury farm (ch. 10). The year is punctuated by the traditional community celebrations: harvest and shearing suppers, and Christmas parties.

K. D. M. Snell has seen in this representation of Weatherbury as a 'Wessex nook' reassurance for the employing class, masking their exploitation of the Dorset labourer.¹² But there is much in the novel which undercuts this.¹³ The capitalist agriculture practised by Bathsheba and Boldwood is represented realistically. They are engaged in innovative high farming for the supply of a national market. Wool is produced for 'the winter enjoyment of persons unknown and far away' (146). Boldwood is experimenting with Leicesters, a new variety of sheep bred for mutton and the urban market (ch. 22). Farmers speculate on the grain trade in the newly rebuilt corn exchange at Casterbridge, and high farming is facilitated by the country banks.

Hardy drew on the writings of William Cobbett to question the paternalism of these farmers to their work folk.¹⁴ In his *History of the Protestant Reformation in England and Ireland*, Cobbett denounced the Church of England (of which he was himself a member) for abandoning the medieval Catholic doctrine that the first duty of a Christian was to feed the poor. In his *Rural Rides* he fiercely denounced the poverty of farm labourers which he observed in Wiltshire, a county bordering Dorset, in the 1830s: 'This is the worst-fed people on the face of the earth. Dogs, hogs and horses are treated with more civility, and the labourers would gladly change places with them in consideration of their food and lodgings.'¹⁵

In *Far from the Madding Crowd*, horses are indeed better treated than labourers. The steady munching of oats and hay that can be heard from Boldwood's stable is the sound of his fine mounts 'busily sustaining . . . warmth and plumpness'. Echoing Cobbett, Hardy calls the stable his 'almonry and cloister in one' (121). The same irony is pointed up by the representation of the workers on the Weatherbury farms. Perspiration rains from their brows as they toil at the oat harvest (ch. 33). Cainy Ball gets a holiday to Bath only because he is unfit for work and there has to lunch off 'a penneth of the cheapest and nicest stales that were all but blue mouldy but not quite' (219).

In countless contemporary texts, Hodge was noted for his voicelessness. Depending on the observer's political outlook, it was attributed to patience or ignorance. Snell and other historians have shown that it was the effect of social alienation. The effect is clear in *Far from the Madding Crowd*. At the shearing supper, for example, farmers and servants sit apart – the work folk outside, the farmers indoors – instead of sharing the meal in the farmhouse, as Cobbett recorded them doing in the eighteenth century. Boldwood is said to carry around with him 'a social atmosphere of his own' (146), which suppresses the workers' conversation in his presence. Bathsheba rages at them when anything goes wrong: "Mighty me! Won't miss's storm and call us stupid when she comes back!" moaned Maryann' (207).

The rustics provide a dialogic commentary on this growing alienation, which also echoes Cobbett. Bathsheba's uncle, they observe, 'used to measure his money in half pint cups', but his niece has 'business at every bank in Casterbridge' (51). Jan Coggan could drink in this uncle's farm kitchen when he came courting the dairymaid (ch. 8). By contrast, Bathsheba's workers ask for their 'bit and a drop' to be sent down to Warren's Malthouse (53). At Warren's their comments on opulent lifestyle are Cobbettian:

'Got a pianner?'

'Ay. Seems her old uncle's things were not good enough for her. She've bought all but everything knew. There's heavy chairs for the stout, weak and wiry ones for the slender; great watches, getting on to the size of clocks, to stand upon the chimbley-piece.'

'Pictures, for the most part wonderful frames.'

'Long horse-hair settles for the drunk, with horse-hair pillows at each end,' said Mr. Clark.

'Looking-glasses for the pretty.'

'Lying books for the wicked.' (106)

13.3 IMPERIALISM

Weatherbury, then, is enmeshed in a system of capitalist high farming and proletarianisation of the workforce. Besides this economic nexus, there is another web of a politico-military character. This constitutes not merely the internal colonialism of the metropolis over the rural periphery, but the global imperialism that sent British troops to the Ashanti war and many

others. As Linda Bownas has pointed out, this is indicated by the trope of the Roman empire. In the early chapters, frequent allusions connect Wessex to ancient Rome. In [Chapter 4](#), Gabriel sets out to court Bathsheba with ‘hair oiled to a novel colour between that of guano and Roman cement’ (30). We are reminded in [Chapter 5](#) that the shepherds of Wessex call to their sheep in Latin. We are told that Boldwood’s features are ‘Roman’ and the clock on his fireplace is surmounted by a ‘spread eagle’, the symbol of empire inherited from ancient Rome (99).

These and other allusions serve to remind the reader that Britain is also an imperial power. Troy says of his aristocratic father’s watch that it has ‘regulated imperial interests in its time’ (175). Casterbridge, once a Roman fort, is now a garrison town serving the global military needs of the British state. This is at war and the ‘11th Dragoon Guards’ move from Casterbridge to take the place of another regiment that has gone to war (83).

But there was another imperial trope very much on Hardy’s mind at the time and this introduces the theme of decline and fall. As the novel proceeds, the weight of reference shifts, taking on a more topical significance. Just when Britain is electing a Jewish prime minister, Hardy rewrites the biblical story of King David, Bathsheba and Uriah the Hittite. This is not a technique of close mapping onto the biblical story, in the manner of Joyce’s *Ulysses*. Rather, Hardy alludes, I would suggest, to H. H. Millman’s *History of the Jews*, of which the third edition appeared in 1863. As shown in [Chapter 1](#), Millman re-presented the scriptural history of the reigns of David and Solomon. Each reign sees a rise to imperial splendour, succeeded by decadence, brought about by the personal folly and corruption of the rulers. It will be recalled that Millman, after recounting the story of David and Bathsheba, commented: ‘So far unexampled splendour and prosperity had marked the reign of David: the remainder was as gloomy as disastrous. His own crime was the turning point of his fortunes.’ And of Solomon he wrote: ‘Hence the decline of the Jewish kingdom . . . was as rapid as its rise. Solomon died after a reign of forty years, and with him expired the glory and the power of the Jewish Empire.’

In *Far from the Madding Crowd*, Hardy presents the dominant values of modern ‘Wessex’ as decadent, compared with those of the rustics, or at any rate with the values that survive from the rural past in their conversation and lifestyle. The decadence and the contrast are made most explicitly by the use of light and dark signifiers. Sunset is the main metaphor of decline, employed in the shearing supper and in

Boldwood's angry confrontation with Bathsheba in Chapter 31. But its most significant use occurs in Chapter 51:

the moon having risen, and the gig being ready, she drove across the hill-tops in the winding ways which led downwards – to oblivious obscurity, as it seemed, for the moon and the hill it flooded with light were in appearance on a level the rest of the world lying as a vast shady concave between them. Boldwood mounted his horse, and followed in close attendance behind. Thus they descended into the lowlands, and the sounds of those left on the hill came like voices from the sky, and the lights were as of a camp in heaven. (340)

13.4 REASON AND THE PASSIONS

I now wish to integrate this contrast between 'Wessex' past and present with the main theme of *Far from the Madding Crowd*, which, as Ian Gregor pointed out, is 'passion'.¹⁶ I see no reason to question his judgement. But I think he misses an important distinction when he characterises all passion as a violent and destructive force which, in this novel, is checked only by the discipline of work, of which first Gabriel and then Bathsheba learn the saving power. The distinction I have in mind was Drysdale's, between the natural, pleasurable passion of love and its distortion into its opposite, the passion or will to possess another human being. For Drysdale, as we have seen, this was the effect of severe sexual competition, dominant in all 'old countries' and made worse by the operation of their marriage laws, underpinned by Christianity.

In Hardy's novel this distorting effect of modern civilisation is indicated, as in the passage just quoted, by metaphors of darkness, while the older attitude to love, more generous and tolerant, is voiced by the rustics and associated with metaphors of light. Hardy employs this signification skilfully in three dramatised scenes which, though they have received much attention, will repay further examination. These are the Malthouse chapters, 13 and 15, and the Buck's Head chapter, 42, with their rich dialogic story telling.

Hardy opens Chapter 13 by representing the Malthouse as an alternative source of light to Christianity, but one whose setting rays are almost concealed from the surrounding world:

From the walls an overhanging thatched sloped up to a point in the centre, upon which rose a small wooden lantern, fitted with louver-boards on all the

four sides, and from these openings a mist was dimly perceived to be escaping into the night air. There was no window in front; but a square hole in the door was glazed with a single pane, through which red rays now stretched out upon the ivied wall in front. (56)

Gabriel Oak, soon to become a pillar of the church, is likened to 'Elymas-the-Sorcerer' (I, 85) as he pushes inside. Elymas was a pagan blinded by the Apostle Paul for his unbelief in Christ. The irony here is significant, because this Christian is blind to the light of paganism which he encounters inside.

Inside the Malthouse, Oak discovers a scene which represents an alternative religion. The rustics sit in a circle and drink from a common cup, like communicants at an alternative sacrament. All gaze meditatively into the kiln, whose rays are likened to 'the setting sun' (55). On Oak's entry, they scrutinise him critically, 'as if he had been a light too strong for their sight' (56).

The rustics do not form a monolithic group, like a Greek chorus.¹⁷ We are present at a conversation, now lighthearted, now serious. From it, however, a more generous attitude to sex and marriage emerges, which exposes the cramped Christian observances of the outer world. They pity Joseph Poorgrass's shyness with women: "'Tis terrible bad for a man, poor soul," said the maltster' (I, 92). The ostentatious piety of Bathsheba's uncle is ironically mocked in the light of his previous attitude towards his wife:

'Coggan,' he said, 'I could never wish for a handsomer woman than I've got, but feeling she's ticketed as my lawful wife, I can't help my wicked heart wandering, do what I will.' But at last I believe he cured it by making her take off her wedding-ring and calling her by her maiden name as they sat together after the shop was shut, and so 'a would get to fancy she was only his sweetheart, and not married to him at all. And so as soon as he could thoroughly fancy he was doing wrong and committing the seventh, 'a got to like her as well as ever, and they lived on a perfect example of mutel love. (64)

The attitudes expressed in this anecdote are connected, by repeated reference to the kiln and its setting rays, to a dying worship of fire, reminiscent of Heroclitus. The rustics look on erotic desire as a pleasure, arising unbidden and deep rooted in nature. After listening to Eli Everdene's

story, they all engage in a silent meditation on chance, a meditation which appears to be 'the result of a slow convergence of forces that had commenced their operation in times far remote' (I, 98).

The Maltster, who sits in the middle of the circle like its presiding elder, endorses the claims of nature over the injunctions of Scripture: "True," said the maltster. "Nature requires her swearing at the regular times, or she's not herself; and unholy exclamations is a necessity of life" (I, 100).

Some readers at least can have been in little doubt that this was an alternative wisdom to the Judeo-Christian morality of Victorian respectability. It is reinforced by reference to the song of multiple courtship, 'Dame Durden'. Hardy, of course, cannot quote from such an explicit folk song, but he takes care to leave a track of reference for readers to follow up, as modern students of folk song have.¹⁸

When Hardy returns to the Malthouse in [Chapter 15](#), he specifically represents it as a 'rival' (103) source of light, which the threatening red sunrise cannot penetrate. This time the story telling reveals the forces of change in the countryside that are extinguishing their own light. As the farmers prosper, the small producers vanish. At Norcombe, Dicky Hill's old wooden cider house has been pulled down and his cottage just above it, and Tomkin's old apple tree has been uprooted.

The comment of the maltster expresses a shocked sense of loss: 'Dear, dear – how the face of nations alter' (108). The independent small producers have been replaced by the 'attached' work folk of Weatherbury, who are dependent on the rural elites and must conform to their discipline. As Mark Clark puts it in the Buck's Head inn, itself a relic of vanishing times: 'what with the parsons and clerks and school-people and serious tea-parties, the merry old ways of good life have gone to the dogs' (188).

These surviving pagans have no respect for Christian spirituality. They value the church only when it attends to the salvation of the body:

'Chapel-folk be more hand-in-glove with them above than we,' said Joseph, thoughtfully. 'Yes,' said Coggan. 'We know very well that if anybody goes to heaven, they will. They've worked hard for it, and they deserve to have it, such as 'tis. I'm not such a fool as to pretend that we who stick to the Church have the same chance as they, because we know we have not. But I hate a feller who'll change his old ancient doctrines for the sake of getting to heaven. I'd as soon turn king's-evidence for the few pounds you get. Why,

neighbours, when every one of my taties were frosted, our Parson Thirdly were the man who gave me a sack for seed, though he hardly had one for his own use, and no money to buy 'em. If it hadn't been for him, I shouldn't hae had a tatie to put in my garden. D'ye think I'd turn after that? No, I'll stick to my side; and if we be in the wrong, so be it: I'll fall with the fallen! Well said – Very well said,' observed Joseph. (279)

It is not only the dialogues of the rustics which refer to this contrast between civilised and naturalistic attitudes to love. The narrative voice echoes Drysdale's critique of competition for sex, which makes love 'an extremely exacting usurer' (29).

Without reference to the tradition of sexual radicalism, it would be easy to miss a very significant example of this. Drysdale's *Elements of Social Science* had recalled the critique of marriage put forward by Robert Owen in the 1830s. Owen had denounced legally enforced monogamy as 'satanic'.¹⁹ Hardy indicates his agreement with this radical tradition when he represents Gabriel Oak peering into the cow shed from above: he saw Bathsheba 'as Milton's Satan first saw Paradise' (18).

This satanic desire for exclusive possession is reinforced by Judeo-Christian morality. Hardy represents it as too abstract to guide Bathsheba in the matter of love and marriage. The biblical Book of Ruth confronts her as 'wisdom in the abstract' (96). Equally irrelevant is the abstract logic taught as a complement to Christianity by theologians like Richard Whately: 'Many of her thoughts were perfect syllogisms; unluckily they always remained thoughts. Only a few were irrational assumptions but, unfortunately, they were the ones which most frequently grew into deeds' (131).

The plot questions the assumptions underlying 'unluckily' and 'unfortunately'. Neither Christianity nor deductive reasoning offers wisdom relevant to Bathsheba's situation. Each would relegate her to be 'the humbler half of an indifferent matrimonial whole' (268). As a penniless orphan she has no interest in marrying Oak, struggling on the margins of capitalist agriculture. Later, as 'absolute mistress of a farm and house' (130), she has no incentive to marry Boldwood. Love, the 'understood incentive' (130), is absent in both cases. When, on the appearance of Sergeant Troy, it strikes as an irresistible force of nature, abstract morality offers the equally bad options of abstinence or marriage to a worthless man. Driven to jealousy and distraction in the marriage market at Bath, Bathsheba is forced to make the latter choice.

Finding herself trapped in marriage to a tyrant, she thinks of turning to Oak for advice. But a moment of vision in Chapter 43 makes it clear to her, and the reader, that Oak would have nothing to offer but the Christian prescription of patient submission. The scene neatly reverses the Gospel text 'knock and it shall be opened unto you'²⁰ (imaged in Holman Hunt's painting *The Light of the World*). Bathsheba cannot knock and enter into the Christian light as symbolised by Oak at prayer. She cannot make 'a truce with trouble by any such means' (288).

13.5 SOCIAL REGENERATION

If, then, there is no wisdom in Judeo-Christian scripture or syllogistic logic, and the paganistic wisdom of the rustics belongs to a way of life that is dying out, does Hardy indicate a form of wisdom more relevant for modern times? Lennart Bjork suggested the utopian positivism of Comte.²¹ There are certainly some grounds for viewing the marriage of Bathsheba and Oak in this way. One is the close resemblance between the authorial comment at the end of the penultimate chapter and Comte's description of Positivist marriage in his *General View*. Hardy's comment runs:

He accompanied her up the hill, explaining to her the details of his forthcoming tenure of the other farm. They spoke very little of their mutual feelings: pretty phrases and warm expressions being probably unnecessary between such tried friends. Theirs was that substantial affection which arises (if any arises at all) when the two who are thrown together begin first by knowing the rougher sides of each other's character, and not the best till further on, the romance growing up in the interstices of a mass of hard prosaic reality. This good fellowship – camaraderie – usually occurring through similarity of pursuits, is unfortunately seldom superadded to love between the sexes, because men and women associate, not in their labours, but in their pleasures merely. (383f)

There is a fairly close parallel between this passage and Comte's description of ideal Positivist marriage, in which friendship is the only lasting basis for lifelong monogamy:

It is true that sexual instinct, which, in man's case at all events, was the origin of conjugal attachment, is a feeling purely selfish... But woman, with her more loving heart, has usually far less need of this coarse stimulus than man.

The influence of her purity reacts on man, and ennobles his affection. And affection is in itself so sweet, that when once it has been aroused by whatever Agency, its own charm is sufficient to maintain it in activity. When this is the case, conjugal union becomes a perfect ideal of friendship.²²

Bjork described Oak as Hardy's 'most successful "Positivist" hero'.²³ To his listing of Oak's virtues – modesty, honesty, disinterestedness, loving-kindness – we might add that he ends up like one of Comte's ideal modern entrepreneurs. He advances by the application of scientific method to agriculture, becoming the owner of a vast business. The combined Weatherbury farms of 2,000 acres indicate the trend towards large-scale organisation which Comte thought would transform private property into trust, and it is easy to imagine Oak practising paternalism in employment relations.

On this reading, then, utopian Positivism might be seen as the guiding wisdom of this novel. But this approach is only tenable if we resist all the claims of postmodern criticism,²⁴ which looks to find such ideological language contradicted in the text.

There are two main ways in which Hardy undercuts it in writing the ending. The first is linguistic, using the metaphors of light and dark. We must note their use carefully from the moment when the singing of Newman's famous hymn, 'Lead Kindly Light', initiates Bathsheba's regret for 'the garish day' when 'pride ruled my will' (378). Her grief is felt 'rather as a luxury than as the scourge of former times' (377). It is a luxury because Gabriel is acting as her unpaid steward in running Weatherbury farm. She is jolted out of her complacency by the news that he is to emigrate to California and reproaches him for desertion. It is rather a blow to her romantic conceit that he would be forever her 'disciple' (379).

This does not read like the pure affection of a Comtean woman. Rather, it seems like yet another expression of the vanity which has so often directed Bathsheba's actions. This propensity to imagine herself 'Queen of the Corn-market' to whose beauty every man must kneel, now makes her see Oak as 'the ringleader of the recusants' (380).

When Bathsheba visits Oak in his cottage, she has no intention of marrying him. Her motive is to win back if she can 'the only true friendship she had ever owned' (380). Hardy's use of the light/dark signifiers in the cottage scene makes it clear that the marriage is the product of possessive passion on both sides. It is negotiated in the firelight. Firelight was Plato's metaphor for passion by whose flickering gleams human beings lived, like prisoners in a cave.²⁵ Philosophers in his allegory succeed in leaving the cave

to live in the true light of the mountainside. Bathsheba, we are told, seemed to live emotionally on a 'mountain' before her marriage to Troy and in a 'cave' thereafter (285). By the light of the fire she rejects a proposition which strikes her as 'absurd', marriage to Oak (382). When she realises that this reaction will confirm Oak in his resolve to leave, she immediately denies having used the word. Gabriel tries to search her face for the truth, 'but the fire light being faint there was not much to be seen' (383), and he allows himself to believe that she was his first sweetheart, a fact not entirely confirmed by reference back to [Chapter 4](#).

Not surprisingly, then, the Comtean summary in the penultimate chapter is undermined in the last. The marriage takes place on a 'foggy morning' (388), and this dark metaphor is reinforced by two related ones. First, Bathsheba goes to church with her face hidden by an umbrella and, second, Oak is again wearing a coat like Dr Johnson's (9), the sage who was notorious for slighting women preachers.

The other tactic for undercutting the harmony of Chapter 57 is reference to village custom. As historians familiar with the work of E. P. Thompson will easily recognise, the rustics greet the marriage of Bathsheba and Oak with 'rough music'.²⁶ This was a form of ritual mockery, directed against those who broke community norms. It drew attention to them by setting up a loud clamour. Hardy represented it most famously as the skimmington ride in *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, but it is usually overlooked in the ending of *Far from the Madding Crowd*:

Oak took up the light and went into the porch, followed by Bathsheba with a shawl over her head. The rays fell upon a group of male figures gathered upon the gravel in front, who, when they saw the newly-married couple, in the porch, set up a loud 'Hurrah!' and at the same moment bang again went the cannon in the background, followed by a hideous clang of music. (389)

Historically, rough music was often directed against a stranger who entered the community and married a widow for her fortune. Oak has violated this norm on a spectacular scale. The rustics have long suspected him of hanging around to marry Bathsheba and take possession of her farm. They are under no romantic illusions about the marriage:

'Faith,' said Coggan in a critical tone, turning to his companions. 'The man hev learnt to say "my wife" in a wonderful naterel way, considering how very youthful he is in wedlock as yet – hey neighbours all'

‘I never heerd a skilfull old married feller of twenty years’ standing pipe “my wife” in a more used note than ‘a did,’ said Jacob Smallbury. ‘It might have been a little more true to nater if it had been spoke a little chillier, but that wasn’t to be expected just now.’

‘That improvement will come with time,’ said Jan, twirling his eye. (342)

John Goode proposed another way of reading the authorial summary. As a Marxist, he took it to be ‘a revolutionary relationship’,²⁷ the sublimation of desire by common labour. As a postmodern Marxist he saw it as negated by the dialectic of the plot, which is to say that it is a Communist utopia rather than a Positivist one. The problem with this reading is that Hardy was never sympathetic to Communism of any variety. I prefer to read the authorial comment as Comtean and to see it as undercut by signifiers consonant with the radical tradition of Drysdale and Mill. This allows us to see that there is an alternative wisdom in the novel which readers might employ as a guide to action at the time of writing.

The first hint at such an alternative occurs in [Chapter 2](#) where, as we have already seen, Oak is gazing on Bathsheba like Milton’s Satan. One of the cows tended by the women in the shed has a day-old calf. Oak sees it

looking idiotically at the two women, which showed that it had not long been accustomed to the phenomenon of eyesight, and often turning to the lantern, which it apparently mistook for the moon, inherited instinct having as yet had little time for correction by experience. (19)

In the early 1870s Hardy was acquiring first-hand knowledge of David Hume’s *Treatise of Human Nature*.²⁸ Hume thought human understanding of the world could only be derived from sense experience. Sense experience could, of course, be misleading, but it could also be corrected by repeated trial and error. This faculty for gaining what they desired by experiment, human beings shared with animals.²⁹ In [Chapter 2](#) we are given to understand that the calf turns towards light by inherited instinct, but will learn by experience to distinguish artificial from natural light. Moreover, in gazing ‘idiotically’ at the two women, it is behaving not very differently from Oak, as Hardy makes clear a little further on:

Oak, upon hearing these remarks, became more curious to observe her [Bathsheba’s] features, but this prospect being denied him by the hooding effect of the cloak, and by his aerial position, he felt himself drawing upon

his fancy for their details. In making even horizontal and clear inspections we colour and mould according to the wants within us whatever our eyes bring in: had Gabriel been able from the first to get a distinct view of her countenance his estimate of it as very handsome or slightly so would have been as his soul required a divinity at the moment or was ready supplied with one. Having for some time known the want of a satisfactory form to fill an increasing void within him, his position moreover affording the widest scope for his fancy, he painted her a beauty. (20)

This passage follows very closely Hume's idea of human understanding: 'Reason is, and ought only to be the slave of the passions. All sense impressions, that is to say, are affected by emotion. If a man feels the sensation of 'an increasing void within him', his fancy will paint a young woman whose face and figure he cannot see as a beauty.

John Stuart Mill's *Logic* gave Hume's epistemology a twist which can be used in support of a feminist reading.³⁰ Like Hume, he saw private judgement based solely on a person's sense impressions as literally idiotic. What converts private judgement based on sense experience into reliable judgement is confirmation by reference to the experience of others. In the physical sciences the others are the community of qualified scientists. But in matters of moral judgement, judgement of the ends for which we ought to live, the community must be widened to encompass everyone in society.

In questions of wisdom in love, the answer depended heavily upon the respondent's understanding of the nature of woman. Mill was certain that men knew very little about their nature because women were not at liberty to speak honestly about themselves.³¹ Bathsheba signals this to Boldwood as, in their descent from Greenhill fair, he presses his marriage proposal upon her. 'It is difficult', she responds, 'for a woman to define her feelings in language, which is chiefly made by men to express theirs.' (342)

We have already seen in *A Pair of Blue Eyes* the kind of response Bathsheba would have made to Boldwood had she been at liberty to express her feelings. In the words of Parson Swancourt, translating Catullus, 'girls have a chartered right to change their minds'.³² But, since women are not free to speak like this, how are men to gain understanding of their nature? In *Far from the Madding Crowd*, Hardy begins to inscribe the coded answer which will characterise so much of his later fiction: we must rediscover the survivals of pagan times. The ancient classical myths represented the nature of women and men in stories about the gods, the moon for women, the sun for

men. Hardy, as recent criticism has made clear,³³ was already familiar with the emergent discourse of cultural anthropology. And, as we have seen, there was another survival of pagan wisdom closer to hand, the vanishing voices in the village community. Viewed from Mill's perspective, however, modern marriage could not simply return to the values of the rustics. The voices in the Malthouse are the voices of men; and these men, who mock the uxorious Laban Tall as 'Susan Tall's husband' (69), are misogynistic. They are no better in this respect than the rustic men in *Under the Greenwood Tree*, when they deplore the introduction of female singers into church music.³⁴ But it is surely significant that, when we leave the exclusive male theatre of the pub and view the common labour of men and women in the great barn, we hear Maryann reveal the needs of the female body in a remarkably frank way:

'Do any body know of a crooked man or a lame, or any secondhand fellow at all that would do for poor me?' said Maryann. 'A perfect one I don't expect to get at my time of life. If I could hear of such a thing 'twould do me more good than toast and ale.' (150)

NOTES

1. T. Hardy, *Far from the Madding Crowd*, Oxford World's Classics, intr. L. M. Shires (Oxford, 2002).
2. For example, I. Howe, *Thomas Hardy* (London, 1968), p. 1.
3. I. Gregor, *The Great Web: The Form of Hardy's Major Fiction* (London, 1974), p. 49.
4. R. Williams, *The Country and the City* (London, 1973), ch. 3, pp. 13–34, esp. 21.
5. For discussion of this religious census, see K. T. Hoppen, *The Mid-Victorian Generation, 1846–1886* (Oxford, 1998), pp. 430ff.
6. W. Gladstone, *The Church of England and Ritualism* (London, 1875), p. 24, quoted in P. T. Marsh, *The Victorian Church in Decline: Archbishop Tait and the Church of England, 1868–1882* (London, 1969), p. 116 n. 12.
7. Marsh, *The Victorian Church in Decline*, esp. pp. 158–241. See also O. Chadwick, *The Victorian Church: Part II 1860–1901* (London, 1970), esp. pp. 322–366.
8. All references are to *Far from the Madding Crowd*, ed. and introduced, L. Shires (Oxford, 2002).
9. The Book of Revelations, III: 16, in *The Holy Bible*, King James Version.

10. See Raymond Chapman, "Arguing About the Eastward Position": Thomas Hardy and Puseyism,' *Nineteenth-Century Fiction*, 42, 1987, pp. 275–94.
11. Marsh, *Victorian Church*, pp. 75f.
12. Snell, *Annals of the Labouring Poor*, p. 392.
13. For a fuller treatment of this issue, see F. Reid, 'Art and ideology in *Far from the Madding Crowd*', *Thomas Hardy Annual*, No. IV, ed. N. Page (London 1986), pp. 91–126.
14. On allusions to Cobbett, see Reid, 'Art and ideology', esp. pp. 105ff.
15. Cobbett, *Rural Rides*, quoted in Reid, 'Art and ideology', p. 106.
16. Gregor, *Great Web*, p. 51.
17. E.g. T. R. Wright, *Hardy and the Erotic* (London, 1989).
18. E.g. C. Jackson-Houlston, 'Thomas Hardy's use of traditional song', *Nineteenth-Century Literature*, 44, 1989, pp. 300–34, esp. 325ff.
19. R. Owen, *The Marriage System of the New Moral World, with a Faint Outline of the Present Very Irrational System as Developed in a Course of Ten Lectures by Robert Owen* (Manchester and London, 1839), Lecture First.
20. *The Holy Bible*, King James Version, Mat., 7: vii.
21. Bjork, *Psychological Vision*, pp. 79f.
22. Comte, *General View*, pp. 251f.
23. Bjork, *Psychological Vision*, p. 94.
24. As Bjork does in *Psychological Vision*, pp. 11–22.
25. Plato, *The Republic*, tr. B. Jowett (Project Gutenberg online edn.), Book V.
26. E. P. Thompson, 'Rough music: Le Charivari anglais', *Annales*, xxvii, (1972), pp. 286, 294; reprinted in E. P. Thompson, *Customs in Common* (London, 1991), pp. 467–531.
27. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, p. 26.
28. Paulin, *Thomas Hardy*, p. 17.
29. Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature*, p. 118.
30. Annette C. Baier has suggested such an application of Hume, but she does not cite Mill as one of her forerunners. See her 'Hume: the reflective women's epistemologist?', in A. J. Jacobson, *Feminist Interpretations of David Hume* (Pennsylvania State University, 2000), pp. 19–38.
31. Mill, *Subjection of Women*, p. 21f.
32. Hardy, *Blue Eyes*, p. 252.
33. Radford, *Thomas Hardy*, pp. 6–9, 24–29. See also Zeitler, *Representations of Culture*, pp. 8f.
34. *Under the Greenwood Tree*, pp. 44f.

PART III

Empire, War and Revolution

Hardy and Patriotism

In the previous chapter, I showed how Hardy's narrative strategies in *Far from the Madding Crowd* pointed his readers towards the need for experiment in relationships of love and marriage. His earlier novels had done this to a more limited extent, but in his 'pastoral' novel of 1874 the need is accentuated by the satirical representation of England as a society undergoing a late-manhood stage of decline, marked by increasing spiritual anarchy, class alienation and imperialism. This, as I suggested in [Chapter 10](#), was the result of the Franco-Prussian war and the imperialistic rhetoric with which Disraeli responded to it. The war and its aftermath delivered a profound shock to Hardy's youthful meliorism. The optimism of rationalists like Comte and Mill, who believed that altruistic feeling was in the ascendancy over the violent passions, now seemed less convincing. As Hardy's own optimism degraded, the substratum of Liberal Anglican historical thought was laid bare to his mind. The history of human progress was indeed a cycle of light and dark ages. Rather than moving upwards to ever greater illumination, humanity was once again descending into 'encircling gloom'. Hardy could not, of course, console himself by returning to the providentialist explanation of the Liberal Anglican historians. If way to the better there be, it must be sought, as Comte, Drysdale and Mill had taught him, in a naturalistic study of humanity. The violent passions, in other words, must be fearlessly examined by the light of inductive reason.

The evidence so far reviewed suggests that Hardy had believed, since writing *The Poor Man and the Lady*, that this was a proper task for fiction. As is now well established, Hardy turned in *The Return of the Native* (1878) to a more serious examination, which he saw as an experiment in tragic fiction. This is revealed by an entry in *Life and Work*:

April [1878] – note. A plot, or tragedy, should arise from the gradual closing in of a situation that comes of ordinary human passions, prejudices, and ambitions, by reason of the characters taking no trouble to ward off the disastrous events produced by the said passions, prejudices, and ambitions. (123)

The note, in context, is clearly an attempt to sum up succinctly Hardy's intention in writing *The Return of the Native*. In that novel the life of the protagonist, Eustacia Vie, is represented as tragically curtailed by the interplay of her ambition, her passions and the prejudices of society against those who break the rules of the Victorian sexual code. As is also well established, Hardy would return to these 'tragic' themes in his four later novels, *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, *The Woodlanders*, *Tess of the d'Urbervilles* and *Jude the Obscure*.

What I wish to suggest in the final part of this study is that the return to experiments in tragic fiction is related to Hardy's perception of a further darkening outlook for modern civilisation. This perception, which set in during 1885–1886, followed an interval of renewed optimism stimulated by the revival of the Liberal party. Accordingly, in this chapter I trace Hardy's responses to the Liberal revival, which began in 1877–1878 with Gladstone's campaign against Disraeli's policy towards the 'eastern question' and ended with the catastrophic Liberal party split over Irish 'home rule' in 1886. In [Chapter 15](#) I show that the latter event intensified Hardy's concern with the late-manhood crisis of modern civilisation. These responses, in my view, have not been accurately evaluated in Hardy criticism, mainly because Hardy's intense English patriotism has been under-estimated and his opposition to war and imperialism has been over-stated. In tracing more precisely Hardy's political development over these decades, I hope to provide a context which supports my interpretation, in [Chapters 16](#) and [17](#), of the signification of meliorism in his later novels.

14.1 HARDY AS PALMERSTONIAN PATRIOT

The Liberal Anglican historians started from the patriotic assumption that victory over Napoleon Bonaparte had been a great advance for English civilisation. *Life and Work* participates in this assumption, in that Hardy's history and that of his immediate forebears are set within the larger historical framework which he calls the 'great struggle' (53). He tells that his grandfather 'had been a volunteer till the end of the war, and lay in Weymouth with his company from time to time waiting for Bonaparte who never came' (16).

He recalls that, among his earliest reading was

A History of the Wars – a periodical in loose numbers of the war with Napoleon which his grandfather had subscribed to at the time . . . The torn pages of these contemporary numbers with their melodramatic prints of serried ranks, crossed bayonets, huge knapsacks, and dead bodies, were the first to set him on the train of ideas that led to *The Trumpet-Major* and *The Dynasts*. (21)

As Reginald White emphasised,¹ the immediacy of such oral and written traditions ensured that the clash with France was a living experience for young Thomas Hardy and remained so for the rest of his life.

So much is widely accepted in Hardy scholarship. What is less widely recognised is that Hardy always regarded England's struggle with France as a source of patriotic pride. This feeling underlies the ambivalence and hesitation of his reactions to the crises we are about to consider. The first upsurge of that sentiment, so far as we know, is his recorded reaction to the funeral of Lord Palmerston. This is somewhat muted in *Life and Work*, where Hardy recalled that, while writing *The Dynasts*, he remembered hearing Palmerston speak in the House of Commons shortly before attending his funeral in Westminster Abbey. To his regret, he had been able to find only one notebook entry concerning these events, which gave little more than the bare facts:

Oct 18. [1865] Wet evening. At Regent Circus coming home saw the announcement of the death of Ld. Palmerston, whom I heard speak in the House of Commons a year or two ago.

Oct 27. – To Westminster Abbey with Mr Heaton and Lee. Took up a position in the Triforium, from which spot I saw Ld. Palmerston lowered into the grave. Purcell's service. Dead March in Saul. (53)

As Michael Millgate has shown, Hardy's close friend Sir James Barrie realised, on reading over the text of *Life and Work* for posthumous publication, that this was revealing testimony to Hardy's political outlook. He asked Florence Hardy to enquire of the family whether any of Hardy's letters survived from that time. This produced the letter to his sister Mary, which Florence inserted into the text of *The Life* at Barrie's behest. Modern Hardy scholars are in danger of overlooking it because Millgate had to relegate it to an appendix, in accordance with his aim of producing a purely 'Hardyan' text of *Life and Work*.

Yet the letter is biographically important, as Millgate acknowledged, and should be read in context. Although I have already alluded to it in relation to domestic politics in [Chapter 6](#), it is worth reproducing at some length here as evidence of young Thomas Hardy's patriotism:

Saturday, Oct. 28. 1865.

My dear Mary,

Yesterday Lord Palmerston was buried... I and the Lees got tickets through a friend of a friend of Mr. B's, and we went of course...

Where I have put the X in the section is where I stood; over the [mark] on the plan. The mark is where the grave is, between Pitt's and Fox's and close by Canning's. All the Cabinet Ministers were there as pall bearers. The burial service was Purcell's. The opening sentences "I am the resurrection, etc" were sung to Croft's music. Beethoven's Funeral March was played as they went from the choir to the vault, and the Dead March in Saul was played at the close.

I think I was never so much impressed with a ceremony in my life before, and I wd. not have missed it for anything. The Prince of Wales and Duke of Cambridge were present. Ld. John Russell, or Earl Russell as he is now, is to be Prime Minister in Pam's place. Only fancy, Ld. P. has been connected with the govt, off and on for the last sixty years, and that he was contemporaneous with Pitt, Fox, Sheridan, Burke, etc. I mean to say his life overlapped theirs so to speak. (67f)

There can be no mistaking the intense patriotic feeling in this letter. The perspective in which Hardy views Palmerston's career is the 'Whig interpretation' of history, to which most English historians were committed in the nineteenth century.² Shortly after Hardy's death it was attacked by Herbert Butterfield for imposing a pattern of inevitable progress on the narrative of English history and for nominating the actors as heroes or villains in the drama.³ Hardy, the son of a Liberal father, had no problem

in recognising the heroes. Regardless of formal party titles, they included Pitt and Burke, Fox and Sheridan, Canning and Russell. The Liberal Anglican historians were no Whigs, but believed just as firmly in the 'great struggle' between English constitutional liberty and Napoleonic dynasticism. The letter is valuable because it shows that Hardy admired Palmerston as a statesman who both defended England's interests and portrayed it as the champion of constitutional liberty on the national and international stage. In the complexities of political affairs which prevailed after 1870, this Palmerstonian patriotism was strained, as we are about to see, by a Gladstonian concern for peace in Europe. This tension is the key, I suggest, to Hardy's responses in the ensuing crises of national and international politics.

14.2 HARDY AND GLADSTONIAN LIBERALISM

In *Life and Work* it is easy to overlook Hardy's brief mention of his attendance at the great meeting in St James's Hall (116) held in 1876 to protest against Disraeli's handling of the eastern question. Yet it marks the beginning of his loose attachment to the Gladstonian Liberal party. His presence was recorded in a notebook entry: 'During a visit to London in December Hardy attended a conference at St. James's Hall, and heard speak Mr Gladstone, Lord Shaftesbury, Hon. E. Ashley, Anthony Trollope, and the Duke of Westminster' (116).

What is striking about this entry is that Hardy makes no comment on the issues at stake between Gladstone and Disraeli, giving the impression that the only thing he took away from the meeting was amusement at the discomfiture of Anthony Trollope:

Trollope outran the five or seven minutes allowed for each speech, and the Duke, who was chairman, after various soundings of the bell, and other hints that he must stop, tugged at Trollope's coat-tails in desperation. Trollope turned round, exclaimed parenthetically 'Please leave my coat alone,' and went on speaking. (116)

What Hardy's silence suggests is an ambivalence between the policies of Disraeli and Gladstone. Russia had invaded European Turkey in 1877 to halt the massacre of Bulgarian Slavs by irregular troops of the Ottoman Empire. In 1878 it imposed on Turkey the Treaty of San Stefano, which freed Bulgaria from the empire and established it as an independent state

under informal Russian protection. Disraeli feared that Russia would use the new Bulgaria to gain access to a warm-water port on the Mediterranean, and that its army would now go on to occupy Constantinople. The fall of the Turkish capital would open the Straits of the Bosphorus, which had been closed to Russia's Black Sea fleet by Palmerston's Treaty of Paris at the end of the Crimean war in 1856. Access to the Mediterranean, Disraeli believed, would enable Russia to mount a naval attack on the Suez Canal, the shortest sea route to India. Alternatively, occupation of Constantinople would open up the short route overland to the Persian Gulf.⁴ Accordingly, Disraeli insisted on upholding the integrity of the Ottoman empire and threatened war with Russia unless it withdrew the treaty. This policy aroused warlike sentiment in a section of public opinion, dubbed 'jingoist' after the music hall song: 'We don't want to fight. But by jingo if we do/we've got the ships, we've got the men, we've got the money too.'⁵

Gladstone had denounced 'the unspeakable Turk' for the 'Bulgarian atrocities' and condemned the jingo response to Disraeli's warlike threats. He insisted that the protection of the Balkan Slavs should have been secured by agreement of the European great powers, including Russia, and the conference at St James's Hall was a grand protest in support of his campaign against Disraeli's bellicosity.

Hardy, as we shall see, came to admire Gladstone, but his silence on the Bulgarian question suggests a certain reservation. He could not have forgotten Horace Moule's enthusiastic endorsement of Palmerston's response in 1860 to the danger of Franco-Russian collaboration against England. 'What hindered Russia', Moule had asked in his speech at Dorchester,

from occupying the long-coveted shores of the Bosphorus, and France from advancing to the Rhine frontier? England was notoriously the obstacle in either case; nor was it possible to imagine anything which would be more directly to the advantage of the great northern Power, than that France should undertake the task of humiliating England.⁶

This danger that Franco-Russian collaboration would threaten England's empire was to resurface when Gladstone returned to power after his Midlothian campaign in the election of 1880. He stood on a policy summed up as 'peace, retrenchment and reform'. This meant that the peace of Europe would be maintained by settling disputes in

congresses of the great powers. This in turn would make possible retrenchment of expenditure on armaments and reduction of taxation. Finally, a third reform bill would give the vote to agricultural workers, thus abolishing forever the domination of domestic politics by Tory landowners who alone, Gladstone alleged, sought to benefit from imperialism and war.

From the beginning, Gladstone's grand strategy was compromised by international events. The overthrow of the government of Egypt by a nationalist uprising under Arabi Pasha threatened British investments and the Suez route to India. France and Britain were jointly responsible under international treaty for the security of European loans to Egypt. France accordingly decided to send a fleet to stand off Alexandria. Britain, concerned alike for its investments and to keep France away from the Suez Canal, sent a fleet to accompany the French. A change of government in Paris resulted in recall of the French fleet. Left to its own devices and greatly alarmed by the revolutionary nationalism of Arabi, the British government ordered its fleet to bombard Alexandria and went on to occupy Egypt in 1882.

Gladstone insisted that the occupation was temporary and that Britain would withdraw as soon as peace and stability could be restored in Egypt. This did not prevent France from thinking that Britain had blocked its imperialist ambitions in North Africa. Such rivalry was to be sharpened because peace and stability proved extremely elusive. Almost immediately, occupation brought Britain up against an Islamic revolt further south in Sudan. It was led by a messianic leader, the Mahdi, who aimed at establishing a Caliphate, purifying Muslim religion and driving the infidels out of Egypt. In 1884–1885, Mahdist forces besieged Khartoum. A jingo clamour for invasion of Sudan sprang up in London. Gladstone pursued a wait-and-see policy. He sent General Gordon to assess the danger to the British legation there. Gordon ignored his orders to avoid engagement with the Mahdists and was killed while resisting their siege. This stirred up a storm against Gladstone in the British jingo press.

Once again, it is striking that *Life and Work* is silent about the occupation of Egypt. Nor is it mentioned in Hardy's private correspondence.⁷ It is highly unlikely that silence meant indifference. Hardy had just written *The Trumpet Major* and was giving much thought to an epic work on the career of Napoleon (152), who had invaded Egypt in 1798 with a view to conquering India. The probability is that Hardy sympathised with the Gladstonian desire for peace, but did not object to the occupation to

lock France out of Egypt. When complications arose in Sudan, he probably approved Gladstone's wait-and-see stance.

Such an inference is compatible with Hardy's note on the death of Gordon, when he, like the more moderate Conservatives, deplored the jingo attacks on the Prime Minister. *Life and Work* records Hardy's contact with these Conservatives, whom he met at one of the 'society crushes' to which he was now admitted through a kinship connection of his wife.

At one of these crushes in the early part of 1885, probably Lady Carnarvon's,⁸

they found themselves on a particular evening amid a simmer of political excitement. It was supposed to be a non-political 'small-and-early', but on their arrival the house was already full to overflowing; and a well-known Conservative peeress of that date, who had lately invited Hardy to her friendship,⁹ came up to him as if she must express her feelings to somebody, and said, 'I'm ashamed of my party! They are actually all hoping that General Gordon is murdered, in order that it may ruin Gladstone!' It seems to have been this rumor of Gordon's death, which had just been circulated, that had brought so many brilliant and titled people there. Auberon Herbert,¹⁰ who was also there, told Hardy privately that it was true. Presently another and grimmer lady, the Dowager Viscountess Galway,¹¹ said to him that she half-believed Gordon was still alive, because no relic, bloody rag, or any scrap of him had been produced, which from her experience of those countries she knew to be almost the invariable custom. So the crowd waited, and conjectured, and did not leave till a late hour, the truth as to Gordon's fate not being generally known till some days after. (179)

What further can be gleaned from Hardy's personal observations on politics in the next two years is that he was not unsympathetic to this emergent Liberal imperialism. It was beginning to colour the views of Joseph Chamberlain, Liberal Member of Parliament for Birmingham. At this time Chamberlain was campaigning to wrest control of the Liberal party from the Whig landowners who dominated it. To this end, he had allied with trade union leaders like Joseph Arch to demand public provision of smallholdings for agricultural labourers.

This is what first caught Hardy's attention. In a letter to his friend John Morley, now Gladstone's Secretary of State for Ireland, he referred to a Radical meeting held in Birmingham and pointed out

the agreement between his own account of the Dorsetshire labourers' condition¹² and Chamberlain's:

Dear Mr Morley,

The Dorset labourer, Mr Joseph Arch, &c. are among the topics dwelt upon in the Birmingham speeches: and Mr Arch has just been attacked in the St. James's Gazette. By a curious coincidence I have a paper on these identical subjects in the number of Longman's Magazine which appears to-day. Though a Liberal, I have endeavored to describe the state of things without political bias: and my description so well harmonises with what was said at Birmingham that I make no apology for drawing your attention to the article. A copy is sent herewith.¹³

Although his ideas on domestic policy were in the foreground at this time, Chamberlain was already moving publicly in the direction that would lead to New Imperialism. He refused to join the veteran free-trader and anti-imperialist John Bright, his fellow Member for Birmingham, in demanding early British withdrawal from Egypt, pointing out that only the French could benefit from such a move.¹⁴

Hardy did not at this stage comment on Chamberlain's attitude to foreign policy. However, in view of the tension between his Palmerstonian patriotism and his Gladstonian desire for peace in Europe, it is not improbable that he shared Chamberlain's view, from which Gladstone certainly did not demur.

Hardy's reticence about these matters, both in *Life and Work* and in his private correspondence, makes it impossible to venture further into conjecture. We move onto firmer ground when we encounter his responses to Gladstone's Irish home rule bill.

14.3 HOME RULE FOR IRELAND

The home rule bill was Gladstone's response to revolutionary nationalism in Ireland, which had been intensified by the agricultural depression in 1873. Impoverished tenant farmers in the west had amassed unpayable arrears of rent. The Irish Land League, led by Michael Davitt, organised resistance by 'boycotting'¹⁵ anyone who collaborated with an evicting landlord. Davitt was at this time a revolutionary nationalist who wanted complete separation of Ireland from Britain.¹⁶ Gladstone, and most other British politicians of whatever persuasion, opposed separation because it

would leave Britain dangerously exposed to Irish collaboration with France.¹⁷ Back in 1798, warships of revolutionary France had landed troops in Co. Mayo to support a rebellion led by the Society of United Irishmen against the British connection.¹⁸ The memory of this was revived during the home rule crisis by events across the English Channel. The minister of war, General Boulanger, acclaimed as a hero of an imperialist war in China, was stirring up the Bonapartists by his plans to re-equip the French army and expand the navy.¹⁹ This coincided with renewed Russian threats to the frontier of British India during the 'Penjdeh crisis' of 1886. In Britain, the jingo press raised the alarm of a war on two fronts and the risk that an independent Ireland would be a weak point in Britain's imperial defences.

Gladstone designed the home rule bill to pacify Ireland by granting devolved powers over domestic affairs, while retaining foreign and imperial policy firmly in London. As he put it in a speech of 1882, he had no objection in principle to 'an Irish Legislative Body to deal with Irish affairs, provided the integrity of the Empire was maintained and imperial questions continued to be dealt with in the Imperial Parliament'.²⁰ By 1886, Gladstone had been secretly informed that Charles Stuart Parnell, the leader of the Irish National party, was prepared to discuss such an arrangement. But he also knew that his government was deeply divided over it. Joseph Chamberlain at the Board of Trade was opposed to a Parliament in Ireland because it must set a precedent for other colonial nations like the Egyptians. Instead, he favoured reconstruction of Irish local government under a central board. This plan was unacceptable to Parnell. Complicating matters further was the implacable opposition of Lord Hartington, leader of the Whig element in the Liberal party, to any form of devolved power for Ireland.

Gladstone underestimated the strength of this resistance – fatally for his project, since the parliamentary arithmetic meant that major defections could cancel out the support of the 86 Irish Nationalists. This was indeed what actually happened. When the Prime Minister laid his plans before his Cabinet, Chamberlain immediately objected to them as an unstable solution that was bound to lead to separation, not least because they excluded Irish representation from the Imperial Parliament. It was an objection which nearly all Conservatives and many Liberals shared. Gladstone and Morley countered that exclusion of the Irish Members from Westminster would end their use of obstruction of business to get their own way. But a

Dublin Parliament so detached would, their opponents retorted, have a strong incentive to seek further powers, leading to independence.

Gladstone had no answer to this conundrum and so the Liberal split grew. The depth of division was made clear when Gladstone summoned a party meeting from which Chamberlain and other opponents of the bill were excluded. He countered by summoning a separate meeting of dissidents, at which he read out a letter from John Bright, opposing the second reading. This sounded the death knell for the bill and the second reading was defeated by 341 to 311.

Life and Work is anything but silent over the home rule crisis. Hardy was intensely interested and attended the debates. The entries he included from his notebooks should be read with the empire and great-power rivalries in mind. What is to be gathered from them is his ambivalence and inability to come down decisively on either Gladstone's or Chamberlain's side:

A critical time politically. I never remember a debate of such absorbing interest as this on Gladstone's bill for Irish government. He spoke lucidly; Chamberlain with manly practical earnestness; Hartington fairly forcibly; Morley with much effect (for him). Morley's speech shows that in Parliament a fine intelligence is not appreciated without sword-and-buckler doggedness. Chamberlain impresses me most of all, as combining these qualities. (184)

As the crisis moved towards its denouement, Hardy showed astute understanding of the social and ethnic complications, both in Britain and in Ireland, which stood in Gladstone's way. Surveying the House of Commons from the gallery on 13 May he noted: 'Saw the dandy party enter in evening-dress, eye-glasses, diamond rings, and c. They were a great contrast to Joseph Arch and the Irish members in their plain, simple, ill-fitting clothes' (184).

He also noted Lord Randolph Churchill, a rising Conservative star, who was stoking up Ulster Protestant opposition to home rule: 'Ulster will fight', he declared, 'and Ulster will be right.' Hardy observed his truculence in the debate: 'Lord Randolph's manner, in turning to Dillon, the Irish member, was almost arrogant' (184).

At the same time, Hardy's coupling of Joseph Arch with the Irish National party suggests that he would have preferred a reformist movement, supported on both sides of St George's Channel, to forward land

redistribution, local government reform and urban development, which was Chamberlain's preference. Yet he must have known that the strength of Irish nationalism made this impossible. For this reason he remained, through all the drama, undecided. Although he found 'The earnestness of the Irish members...very impressive' (184) and greatly admired Gladstone – 'When he smiled one could see benevolence on his face' (185) – Hardy could not bring himself to go with the home rule solution. He recognised that it would solve the problem of Parnellite obstruction at Westminster: 'To realise the difficulty of the Irish question it is necessary to see the Irish phalanx sitting tight: it then seems as if one must go with Morley, and get rid of them at any cost' (185). However, he equally understood the danger that Irish independence would expose Britain's Atlantic flank at a time of international tension. Looking back over his notes when writing *Life and Work*, he clearly formulated the dilemma:

Though he did not enter it here Hardy often wrote elsewhere and said of Home Rule that it was a staring dilemma, of which good policy and good philanthropy were the huge horns. Policy for England required that it should not be granted; humanity to Ireland that it should. Neither Liberals nor Conservatives would honestly own up to this opposition between two moralities, but speciously insisted that humanity and policy were both on one side – of course their own. (184f)

That was Hardy's view when writing *Life and Work* after 1917. But what exactly were his views in 1886? The answer to this question is complex. Hardy's sympathy for Ireland's grievances was real and lasted well into the twentieth century. He met many of the Irish nationalist Members of Parliament at social gatherings (210) and remained in friendly contact with them for many years. Even more significantly, he wrote to the leading nationalist, Lady Gregory, in 1904, telling her that he felt 'in some degree akin to the people', adding 'By the way my great-great grandmother was pure Irish'.²¹

Yet he never expressed decisive support for Gladstone's home rule solution and came to despair of it as the years passed. When the Liberal government of H. H. Asquith reintroduced a home rule measure in 1914 and Ulster Protestants prepared for armed resistance, Hardy wrote to his friend Florence Hennicker expressing his ambivalence:

The Irish question is perplexing and gloomy, but I can hardly think there will be bloodshed. I wish Mr Gladstone had never opened it up. The Irish

temperament, I fear, will not be satisfied for long with any rule, and probably the new rule will work no better than the old.²²

During the First World War, the Dublin uprising of Easter 1916 seemed to confirm his fear that humanity to Ireland clashed with policy for England. He refused to sign a petition for the reprieve of Sir Roger Casement, the British civil servant who was hanged for importing German arms on behalf of the rebels.²³ After the war, when the British government met the revolutionary nationalism of the Irish Republican Army with military repression, he again refused to sign a petition condemning British policy.²⁴

In 1921 the Prime Minister, David Lloyd George, attempted to negotiate a compromise that would concede self-government to the nationalists while keeping Ireland in the British empire. A treaty resulted which in effect partitioned Ireland between six counties in the north and a 'free state' with Dominion status in the British empire. Partition apart, this gave the nationalists what Parnell had demanded. But partition proved unacceptable to the more intransigent nationalists and Hardy sensed that it would be the seed of further conflict. As he wrote wearily to Florence Hennicker: 'I have read very little on the Irish situation lately: it was so worrying that I had to give it up. "Irish Free State" does, as you say, sound unromantic.'²⁵

The later evidence just reviewed seems to confirm the inference suggested above concerning Hardy's attitude to home rule in 1886. He shared Gladstone's sympathy for a nation 'rightly struggling to be free', but his Palmerstonian sense of England's interest rejected Gladstone's proposed solution. That did not mean that he thought the problem utterly intractable. The likelihood is that he thought Chamberlain's approach a more practical way to resolve 'humanity to Ireland' and 'policy for England'. It seemed to Hardy a tragic failure of the British political system that a compromise, giving Ireland devolved government within the empire, proved impossible to reach. More than that, the failure seemed evidence of a deeper malaise, a late-manhood crisis of civilisation, as the Liberal Anglican historians had understood the term. To this deeper understanding we turn in the next chapter.

NOTES

1. E.g., White, *Thomas Hardy and History*, pp. 1ff.
2. For an interesting discussion of Whig historiography, see E. Jones, *The English Nation: The Great Myth* (Stroud, 1998, 3rd edn 2003), chs 1–5, esp. pp. 22–27, 50, 74, 79–50, 187–198.

3. H. Butterfield, *The Whig Interpretation of History* (London, 1931).
4. These were known as the 'short' routes, by contrast with the long route round the Cape of Good Hope.
5. G. W. Hunt, *War Song* (1877), performed by G. W. McDermott (1878), full text reproduced at www.makemonologues.co.uk/musichall.
6. See note 7, p. 108.
7. The silence cannot be attributed to the serious illness Hardy suffered at the time. That began in October 1880, four months after the election, and was over by May 1881, more than a year before the occupation of Egypt. See R. Little Purdy and M. Millgate (eds), *The Collected Letters of Thomas Hardy, I, 1840–1892* (Oxford, 1978), pp. 90ff.
8. Wife of Lord Carnarvon, foreign secretary under Disraeli, 1875–1878.
9. Almost certainly Lady Portsmouth, of whom more below.
10. Carnarvon's son.
11. Wife of the sixth Viscount Galway, Conservative Member of Parliament for East Redford.
12. Reid, 'The Dorsetshire Labourer', in Mallet (ed.), *Thomas Hardy in Context*, pp. 177–187.
13. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, I, pp. 118f.
14. P. T. Marsch, *Joseph Chamberlain: Entrepreneur in Politics* (London, 1994), p. 159.
15. The term was coined when Captain Boycott was murdered for enforcing evictions. See T. W. Moody, *Michael Davitt and the Irish Revolution, 1846–82* (Oxford, 1982), p. 322.
16. Moody, *Davitt*, p. 26.
17. Roberts, *Salisbury: Victorian Titan* (London, 1999), p. 378.
18. This was the second of three attempts at French invasion between 1796 and 1798. The others proved abortive and the 1,000 who landed in June 1898 were rounded up by British troops.
19. J. Nere, 'The French Republic', in F. H. Hinsley (ed.), *The New Cambridge Modern History, Vol. 11* (1962) and Magraw, *France*.
20. R. Shannon, *Gladstone, II: Heroic Minister* (London, 1999), p. 289.
21. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, IV, p. 37.
22. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, V, p. 37.
23. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, V, p. 167.
24. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, VI, p. 95.
25. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, VI, p. 112.

Crisis of Civilisation

In this chapter I consider the question: how did Hardy respond to the crisis of civilisation in late Victorian England? Four issues, I suggest, deeply concerned him, as they had also concerned the Liberal Anglican historians: class alienation, decay of orthodox religious belief, factionalism in politics and the danger of European war.

15.1 THE UPPER CLASSES

At the bottom of the crisis, as Hardy saw it, was the complacent outlook of the upper classes. It seemed to him that they were sleep walking into a dangerous situation created by imperialism, war and revolution. Thanks to his wife's connections and his own growing celebrity as a novelist, he had many opportunities to observe them closely at society gatherings. Again and again, *Life and Work* draws attention to what he saw as their love of opulent display, their pride of empire, their alienation from working people and their cultural banality. He was forcibly struck by this during the celebration of Queen Victoria's Golden Jubilee in 1887. This occasion called forth a lavish display of wealth and imperial pomp, but Hardy also perceived it as vacuous spiritually. He recorded this in a vivid notebook entry:

The remainder of this London season in the brilliant Jubilee-year was passed by the Hardys gaily enough. At some houses the scene was made very radiant by the presence of so many Indian princes in their jewelled robes. At a certain reception Hardy was rather struck by one of the Indian

dignitaries (who seems to have been the Anniwalia of Kapurthala); remarking of him:

'In his mass of jewels and white turban and tunic he stood and sat apart amid the babble and gaiety, evidently feeling himself alone, and having too much character to pretend to belong to and throw himself into a thoughtless world of chit-chat and pleasure which he understood nothing of.' (209f)

In another note he dwelt upon the spiritual poverty of the upper classes:

July 8. A service at St Mary Abbots, Kensington. The red plumes and ribbon in two stylish girls' hats in the foreground match the red robes of the persons round Christ on the Cross in the east window. The pale crucified figure rises up from a parterre of London bonnets and artificial hair-coils, as viewed from the back where I am. The sky over Jerusalem seems to have some connection with the corn-flowers in a fashionable hat that bobs about in front of the city of David. . . . When the congregation rises there is a rustling of silks like that of the Devils' wings in *Paradise Lost*. Every woman then, even if she had forgotten it before, has a single thought to the folds of her clothes. They pray in the litany as if under enchantment. Their real life is spinning on beneath this apparent one of calm, like the District Railway-trains underground just by – throbbing, rushing, hot, concerned with next week, last week. Could these true scenes in which this congregation is living be brought into church bodily with the personages, there would be a churchful of jostling phantasmagorias crowded like a heap of soap bubbles, infinitely intersecting, but each seeing only his own. That bald-headed man is surrounded by the interior of the Stock Exchange; that girl by the jeweler's shop in which she purchased yesterday. (219)

In other entries Hardy linked such observations with evidence of the misery and exploitation of the poor in this vast imperial capital. In 1888, for example, he read a report of the Whitechapel murders of 'Jack the Ripper'. Its account of the treatment of a prostitute by the superintendent of a model lodging-house clearly shocked him to the core:

September 10. Destitution sometimes reaches the point of grandeur in its pathetic grimness: e.g., as shown in the statement of the lodging-house keeper in the Whitechapel murder: –

'He had seen her in the lodging-house as late as half-past one o'clock or two that morning. He knew her as an unfortunate, and that she generally frequented Stratford for a living. He asked her for her lodging-money,

when she said, "I have not got it. I am weak and ill, and have been in the infirmary." He told her that she knew the rules, whereupon she went out to get some money.' (Times report.)

'O richest City in the world! She knew the rules.' (224)

Utter ignorance of the state of the poor Hardy saw as common among the rich. In 1890 the Hardys were invited to meet the Duke and Duchess of Teck and their daughter, the future Queen Mary. He noted again conspicuous display of diamonds and silk in the dress of the women and commented again on its vanity: 'But these women! If put into rough wrappers in a turnip-field, where would their beauty be?' (235). Caged in its own world, Hardy went on, 'Society, collectively, has neither seen what any ordinary person can see, read what every ordinary person has read, nor thought what every ordinary person has thought' (235).

Later in the same year, he recorded the kind of social fact that an ordinary man might encounter on the omnibus to South Kensington. Hardy knew because he actually was the man on the omnibus, as a notebook entry tells. He had just left a 'crush' at the Countess of Yarborough's, 'a woman very rich and very pretty':

On coming away there were no cabs to be got on account of a strike, it seems, and I returned to S.K. on the top of a 'bus. No sooner was I up there than the rain began again. A girl who had scrambled up after me asked for the shelter of my umbrella, and I gave it, – when she startled me by holding on tight to my arm and bestowing on me many kisses for the trivial kindness. She told me she had been to 'The Pav', and was tired, and was going home. She had not been drinking. I descended at the South Kensington Station and watched the 'bus bearing her away. An affectionate nature wasted on the streets! It was a strange contrast to the scene I had just left. (281)

Thus isolated, the upper classes, he concluded, were oblivious to the working men, women and horses, perpetually toiling to drive the vast machine around:

19 July [1891]. Note the weight of a landau and pair, the coachman in his grey great-coat, footman ditto. All this mass of matter is moved along with brute force and clatter through a street congested and obstructed, to bear the petite figure of the owner's young wife in violet velvet and silver trimming, slim, small; who could be easily carried under a man's arm, and who, if held up by the hair and slipped out of her

clothes, carriage, etc. etc., aforesaid, would not be much larger than a skinned rabbit, and of less use. (249)

Crucially for Hardy, such upper-class people were like somnambulists: 'I often view society-gatherings, people in the street, in a room, or elsewhere, as if they were beings in a somnambulistic state, making their motions automatically – not realising what they mean' (190).

15.2 REVOLUTION

What the motions of society meant seemed clear. Civilisation was moving dangerously towards revolution and collapse. In his article, 'The Dorsetshire Labourer', Hardy had warned that the eviction of workers from the countryside would add to industrial unemployment and so increase the danger of a violent reaction:

The system of eviction is much to be deplored, for every one of these banished people imbibes a sworn enmity to the existing order of things, and not a few of them, far from becoming merely honest Radicals, degenerate into Anarchists, waiters on chance, to whom danger to the State, the town – nay, the street they live in, is a welcomed opportunity.¹

Here Hardy's mind was ranging far beyond Dorset. Rural depopulation was a phenomenon in every country of the northern hemisphere. It had contributed to violent acts by anarchists and revolutionaries. The Tsar of Russia had been assassinated in 1881 by Lenin's brother and his accomplices. In 1882 two Ministers of the British Crown were murdered by extremists in Phoenix Park, Dublin. London and other British cities were bombed by Irish terrorists² and, in 1887, some anarchists were executed for a terrorist action in Chicago.

Anarchism was not the only revolutionary response among the working class of Britain and Europe. Another was the formation of Marxist parties aiming at substituting a workers' for a capitalists' state. Britain's first Marxist party grew out of a loose coalition of land radicals, Irish nationalists and socialists in London.³ Set up in 1883, it was captured for a version of Marxism by Henry Meyers Hyndman in 1884 and renamed the Social Democratic Federation.⁴ It aimed at electing a working-class majority in Parliament to enact a sweeping programme of nationalisation of land and industry. There is no evidence that Hardy ever believed in sweeping

nationalisation as the means to social improvement. In the 1860s, as we have seen, he leaned towards the more limited land-redistribution programme of Charles Bradlaugh. Bradlaugh was elected Member of Parliament for Northampton in 1880. He debated with Hyndman over state socialism before a large public meeting in 1890. Hardy attended and his sympathy was not with Hyndman: 'was present at a debate at the St. James's Hall between Messrs Hyndman and Bradlaugh, in which he was much struck by the extraordinary force in the features of the latter' (239).

Once again, Hardy's article 'The Dorsetshire Labourer' throws light on what was at stake. Sweeping nationalisation of all the means of production was unacceptable to him, but state intervention to provide security in the lives of working people was not. In 'The Dorsetshire Labourer' he glanced across the English Channel to the 'Possibilists', or reformist socialists, in Paris, who were proposing land redistribution and municipal ownership of utilities like gas and water. In England, as we have seen, Joseph Chamberlain had been pushing something similar, first as mayor of Birmingham in the 1870s and thereafter as its Liberal Member of Parliament. Even after Chamberlain broke with the Liberal party, many Liberals continued to sympathise with his social policy. In 1891, following the split, the party adopted the Newcastle programme, which sought to marry 'old', Gladstonian Liberalism and 'new', Chamberlainite Liberalism. To this end it combined home rule, Welsh and Scottish disestablishment, with land redistribution and stronger employment rights for workers.⁵

Nor had the Conservative Party been unaffected by social radicalism. In the early 1880s Lord Randolph Churchill had coined the slogan 'Tory democracy', and urged reforms similar to Chamberlain's as a means to win working-class voters away from the Liberal party. Yet the new views advanced very slowly. This was due to factional divisions in both parties after 1886. As we are about to see, Hardy saw political factionalism as yet another symptom of the late-manhood crisis of civilisation.

15.3 FACTIONALISM

The Liberal Party was divided into those who leaned to *laissez faire* and those who looked favourably on social reform. Until his resignation as leader in 1894, Gladstone leaned to the former and opposed the latter. These divisions hindered Liberal commitment to measures of radical state intervention. On the Conservative side, the Prime Minister, Lord

Salisbury, manoeuvred Churchill out of the Treasury shortly after coming to power in 1886. His replacement was the economically orthodox banker George Goschen, an exponent of *laissez faire*. The hapless Churchill, who had been pressing for reduction of armaments expenditure in order to finance social reform, confessed: 'I forgot Goschen.' Meanwhile, Joseph Chamberlain, now leader of a new party, the Liberal Unionists, was welcomed by the Conservatives as a powerful ally against home rule for Ireland, but his social radicalism was so widely distrusted that Salisbury, who sympathised, could not invite him into a formal coalition before 1895.

As we saw in [Chapter 1](#), Thomas Arnold was the leading political thinker among the Liberal Anglican historians. He deplored factionalism in parliamentary politics. While the poor languished in poverty, he complained, politicians wrangled over dogma such as *laissez faire*. Measures, he argued, should be judged not by appeal to abstract principles, but by the stage of historical development reached by the nation. In a late-manhood crisis it mattered not whether reforms were carried by Tories or Whigs. Each should be capable of meeting the situation with constructive legislation.

Hardy's notebook entries in *Life and Work* reveal that his views on the state of party politics after 1886 were very similar to Arnold's in the 1830s. He despised men who looked at politics from a narrow party point of view. In July 1891 he noted:

At another luncheon or dinner at this time 'the talk was entirely political – of when the next election would be – of the probable Prime Minister – of ins and outs – of Lord This and the Duke of That – everything except the people for whose existence alone these politicians exist. Their welfare is never once thought of.' (249)

Like Arnold, he was equally distrustful of Tory reaction and radical egalitarianism. As he noted in 1888:

Jan. 24. I find that my politics really are neither Tory nor Radical. I may be called an Intrinsicist. I am against privilege derived from accident of any kind, and am therefore equally opposed to aristocratic privilege and democratic privilege. (By the latter I mean the arrogant assumption that the only labour is hand-labour – a worse arrogance than that of the aristocrat, the taxing of the worthy to help those masses of the population who will not help

themselves when they might, etc.) Opportunity should be equal for all, but those who will not avail themselves of it should be cared for merely – not be a burden to, nor the rulers over, those who do avail themselves thereof. (213)

In the light of this general outlook, it is easier to understand Hardy's friendships with Conservatives. He was strongly attracted by those who looked for cross-party solutions. As we have seen, he was often a guest at the house of Lord Carnarvon, Disraeli's Colonial Secretary. During the home rule crisis, Carnarvon played the part of intermediary between Salisbury and Parnell, in the hope that he could find a solution to the question that Conservatives could accept. After the Liberal split, Hardy continued to meet him until his death in 1890. He also met Joseph Chamberlain on several occasions, but evidently thought he did not come up to the impression he had given during the home rule debate. At closer quarters, Hardy had difficulty warming to him. On the first occasion he did not care for Chamberlain's appearance and manner, but allowed 'that may have been superficial only' (258). His estimate was only a little warmer when he was invited to the politician's Birmingham home, in July 1893, by Chamberlain's wife (273). Hardy said nothing more about him in *Life and Work*, probably because Chamberlain, as Colonial Secretary after 1895, became identified with jingo imperialism.

Another note indicates some sympathy with the Tory Democrat Randolph Churchill, after his fall from office:

In December [1890], staying in London, Hardy chanced to find himself in political circles for a time, though he never sought them. At one house he was a fellow-guest with Mr (afterwards Lord) Goschen, then Chancellor of the Exchequer, and the 'I forgot Goschen' story was still going about. At another house just afterwards he chanced to converse with the then Dowager Duchess of Marlborough, Lord Randolph Churchill's mother: 'She is a nice warm-feeling woman, and expressed her grief at what had happened to her son, though her hostess told her flatly it was his own doing. She deplores that young men like – [sic] should stand in the forefront of the Tory party, and her son should be nowhere. She says he has learnt by bitter experience, and would take any subordinate position the Government might offer him. Poor woman – I was sorry for her, as she really suffers about it.' (301)

15.4 HARDY'S POLITICAL OUTLOOK

The ambiguities of Hardy's political outlook, as revealed in *Life and Work*, have puzzled critics who rely on literary theory without the benefit of historical method. This study suggests that it is coherent enough if we understand it to be guided by a secularised version of the Liberal Anglican philosophy of history, reformed by the new ideas of George Drysdale and John Stuart Mill regarding human nature. Down to 1886, Hardy hoped that the Gladstonian Liberal Party, reformed by men like Dilke and Chamberlain, would be the vehicle for the advancement of liberty in British society. By that date, however, Dilke's ministerial career had been destroyed in the divorce courts and Chamberlain had stormed out of the Liberal party to what seemed an isolated factional position in politics. After 1886, Hardy's response was to look about for a new leader concerned for 'the people for whose existence alone these politicians exist'. He found candidates in both parties. Among the Liberals he mentions meeting Lord Rosebery and H. H. Asquith, rising stars of 'Liberal Imperialism'. But he was increasingly inclined to think that the kind of reform he favoured was more likely to come from the Conservative rather than the Liberal party. A note dated March–April 1890 shows this clearly: 'Tories will often do by way of exception to their principles more extreme acts of democratism or broad-mindedness than Radicals do by rule – such as help on promising plebeians, tolerate wild beliefs, etc.'⁶

The phrase 'wild beliefs' offers a clue to Hardy's changing orientation between the mainstream parties. As multiple notebook entries in *Life and Work* show, the man who, when young, had haunted the bookshops in Holywell Street, still sympathised with sexual radicalism. He recorded instances of women in widely separated ranks of society questioning the marriage laws, both by their behaviour and in their private talk. Thus in *Life and Work* he set down the details of a story told him in 1882 by an old countrywoman

of a girl she had known who had been betrayed and deserted by a lover. She kept her child by her own exertions, and lived bravely and thrived. After a time the man returned poorer than she, and wanted to marry her; but she refused. He ultimately went into the Union workhouse.

This young woman's conduct in not caring to be 'made respectable' won Hardy's admiration and he further commented:

The eminently modern idea embodied in this example – of a woman's not becoming necessarily the chattel and slave of her seducer – impressed Hardy as being one of the first glimmers of woman's enfranchisement; and he made use of it in succeeding years in more than one case in his fiction and verse. (162f)

On another occasion his mother told him of a woman she knew named Nanny P, who when she married would never be called by her husband's name 'because she was too proud', she said; and to the end of their lives the couple were spoken of as 'Nanny P and John' (211).

Hardy heard the same questioning of Victorian respectability in the houses of his Conservative friends. In 1893 he visited the eminent Conservative peeress, Lady Londonderry, in her London home. His friend of many years, Lady Jeune, called while he was there, accompanied by the Duchess of Manchester:

All four of us talked of the marriage-laws, a conversation which they started, not I; also of the difficulties of separation, of terminable marriages where there are children, and of the nervous strain of living with a man when you know he can throw you over at any moment. (273)

We should note here that the Duchess of Manchester was the mistress of the Liberal Unionist leader, Lord Hartington (later Duke of Devonshire). Their relationship was common knowledge in upper-class circles, for she went about openly with him and both were accompanied on tours abroad by her husband. Hardy, who refers to her here by her first name, clearly admired her, since his note continues:

It may be mentioned here that after the Duchess of Manchester's death a good many years later Hardy described her as having been when he first knew her 'a warm-natured woman, laughing-eyed, and bubbling with impulses, in temperament very much like "Julie-Jane" in one of my poems'. (273)

Mary Jeune was the wife of the divorce court judge and Conservative politician, Francis Jeune (later Lord St Helier). An assiduous philanthropist,

she also struck Hardy as a broad-minded woman. On one occasion he noted her as saying that ‘When she tries to convey some sort of moral or religious teaching to the East-end poor, so as to change their views from wrong to right, it ends by their convincing her that their view is the right one – not by her convincing them’ (216).

As *Life and Work* points out, it was in the houses of such people that *Tess of the d’Urbervilles* often found ardent supporters:

Strangely enough Lord Salisbury, with whom Hardy had a slight acquaintance, was a supporter of the story. Also: ‘The Duchess of Abercorn⁷ tells me that the novel has saved her all future trouble in the assortment of her friends. They have been almost fighting across her dinner-table over Tess’s character. What she now says to them is “Do you support her or not?” If they say “No indeed. She deserved hanging: a little harlot!” she puts them in one group. If they say “Poor wronged innocent!” and pity her, she puts them in the other group where she is herself.’ Discussing the question thus with another noble dame who sat next him at a large dinner-party, they waxed so contentious that they were startled to find the whole table of two-and-twenty silent, listening to their theories on this vexed question. And a well-known beauty and statesman’s wife, also present, snapped out at him: ‘Hanged? They ought all to have been hanged!’ (258)

There were, of course, people of unconventional views in both parties, but the Liberal party was heavily dominated by adherents to the ‘non-conformist conscience’, with its strict sexual morality. In 1890, when Captain O’Shea sued for divorce, citing Parnell as correspondent, they demanded that the Irish Nationalist party repudiate him as its leader. Gladstone supported their demand, which was probably in tune with his own feelings since, unlike Salisbury, he disapproved of *Tess*.

Hardy, then, found sympathy among Conservatives for his unconventional views on sexual morality, and this helps to account for the attraction he felt towards some people in upper-class circles. These should be carefully distinguished from the generality of acquaintance which he paraded in *Life and Work*, not, as is sometimes asserted, out of snobbery, but to establish his credentials as a critic of their shallow, conventional outlook, which was for him a clue to the crisis of civilisation.

15.5 NEW IMPERIALISM

Some critics have found it equally difficult to understand Hardy's ambivalence towards the 'New Imperialists'.⁸ His personal friendships with some of them, such as Rosebery, Curzon, Kipling and Salisbury, seem odd to such critics when set alongside his 1887 *Poems of Pilgrimage*, which dwelt on the vanity of imperial Rome. Once again, reference to the Liberal Anglican idea of history helps to solve the puzzle. Although he did not use the term 'imperialism', Thomas Arnold saw aggressive imperial expansion as a major cause of Rome's decline and fall. Applying the history of Rome by analogy to events around 1840, he worried that wars in Afghanistan and China foretold a similar fate for England's mission of Christian civilisation in the east. Faced in the 1880s with imperialist rivalries in those same regions, Hardy could likewise question the link between imperial expansion and progress. He had brooded on this during his visit to Italy in 1887. At Rome he found

a great spurt of building going on at this time, on which he remarks, 'I wonder how anybody can have any zest to erect a new building in Rome, in the overpowering presence of decay on the mangy and rotting walls of old erections, originally of fifty times the strength of the new.' This sentiment was embodied in the sonnet called 'Building a New Street in the Ancient Quarter'. (196)

And sitting among the sculptures of Florence, he mused on the impermanence of civilisations: 'Everybody is thinking, even amid these art examples from various ages, that this present age is the ultimate climax and upshot of the previous ages, and not a link in a chain of them' (199).

Nevertheless, decline and fall were no more a foregone conclusion for Hardy than for Arnold. Just as the Liberal Anglican historians looked to the reconstruction of Christianity to bring about a *ricorso* of modern civilisation, with England leading the way, so Hardy could look, in the late 1880s and early 1890s, to the leaders of the new imperialism⁹ in both parties as a possible hope for the further development of modern civilisation. If this claim seems startling when set against the debacle of the South African war, we need to guard against retrospective judgement. Hardy did not have the benefit of hindsight. The leading British imperialists insisted that their policies would preserve peace between the great powers and enable constructive development of the British empire. Before 1899 it was

difficult to challenge their claims. The 'scramble for Africa' of the late 1880s and early 1890s was carried out without a shot being fired between the European powers. Disraeli's vision of a federation of the colonies of white settlement was again under discussion. In 1884, Rosebery, for example, told an audience in Adelaide, Australia, that he conceived the empire as 'a commonwealth of nations' and explained that the phrase meant 'a community of free and equal members bound together by the same basic laws'.¹⁰ Chamberlain, as Colonial Secretary from 1895, drew up ambitious plans to promote the economic development of the new colonies in East and West Africa.

Yet it was Salisbury, not Chamberlain, with whom Hardy felt some affinity. It is easy to see why this could extend to politics. As Prime Minister, Salisbury was masterly at keeping the peace between the great powers by diplomacy. He was also adept at rhetorical justification of his practice. In 1897 he told an audience:

You notice that on all sides the instruments of destruction, the piling up of arms, are becoming larger and larger. The powers of concentration are becoming greater, and the instruments of death more active and are improving with every year; and every nation is bound, for its own safety's sake, to take part in this competition. . . . the one hope that we have to prevent this competition from ending in a terrible effort of mutual destruction which will be fatal to Christian civilisation – the one hope we have is that the Powers may gradually be brought . . . to act together on a friendly spirit on all questions of difference which may arise, until at last they shall be welded in some international constitution which shall give to the world as a result of their great strength a long spell of unfettered trade and continued peace.¹¹

Evidence that Hardy did not dismiss entirely the possibility that new imperialism might be progressive is to be found in the short poem 'At the War Office, London'. It compares the first year of the South African war, when lists of killed and wounded were being posted up, with the previous year when he, the speaker, had looked upon 'this world of gaingivings' as 'charged . . . with circumstance that brings/The tragedy of things'. But he goes on:

Yet at that censured time no heart was rent
Or feature blanched of parent, wife, or daughter
By hourly posted sheets of scheduled slaughter;
Death waited Nature's wont; Peace smiled unshent¹²
From Ind to Occident.¹³

The poem suggests that, before the outbreak of war in South Africa, Hardy was thankful for the peace in Europe that Salisbury's diplomacy had preserved. But before we go further and interpret the poem in an anti-war, anti-imperialist spirit, we must note the misleading conclusion of the last line. It simply was not true that 'Peace smiled unshent/From Ind to Occident' in 1898. That year saw the battle of Omdurman, when British artillery slaughtered 12,000 weakly armed Sudanese at the cost of 47 British lives to crush the Mahdist revolt.¹⁴ Once again, the fact must be faced that Hardy did not raise any objection to British imperialism in the valley of the Nile. He would have known that Salisbury ordered the invasion to close Sudan off to penetration by a French expeditionary force, which had reached Fashoda on the headwaters of the river. The British government feared that the French were planning to dam it, so restricting the flow of its vital flood water to Egypt.¹⁵ To prevent this, Kitchener pressed south from Omdurman and faced down the French, who withdrew from Fashoda. The peace of Europe had been preserved at the cost of 12,000 Dervish lives.

15.6 THE SOUTH AFRICAN WAR

It was, then, not war against Egyptians or Sudanese which disturbed Hardy, but war between Europeans. He therefore watched the approach of war between England and the Boers with foreboding. There was a false start in 1895, when Dr Jameson mounted his 'raid' into the Transvaal. It was supposed to spark an uprising of English immigrants (Uitlander) against the government and provide a pretext for British intervention, but it went off prematurely and ended ignominiously in the capture of his force and no uprising. It did spark an international incident, however. The German Kaiser sent a telegram of congratulation to the Transvaal President, which outraged jingo opinion in England. London and Capetown denied all knowledge of the raid, though their implication was widely and correctly suspected. In 1896 a Committee of the House of Commons was set up to investigate the responsibility of Chamberlain, Milner and Rhodes. While it sat, Hardy wrote his poem *In Tenebris II*, countering the breezy optimism of the times with the line: 'if way to the Better there be,/it exacts a full look at the Worst'.¹⁶

There were reasons in his personal life for the dejected mood of the poem – the death of his father, critical attacks on *Tess* and *Jude*, and estrangement from his wife¹⁷ – but the international tension also had something to

do with it, since Hardy placed the following epigraph from the *Book of Psalms* at the head of the second poem: 'Why do the heathen rage, and the people imagine a vain thing?'¹⁸ Though the epigraph was cancelled for publication, it justifies us in reading the poem with the Mahdist uprising and the Jameson adventure in mind. Together these events were straining his hope in the progressivism of the New Imperialists.

The outbreak of war in 1899 confirmed Hardy's worst fear that circumstances wore 'the tragedy of things'. Yet, as with home rule for Ireland, he felt the contradiction between the claims of the Boers and policy for England. The Afrikaans-speaking Boers had long been resisting Carnarvon's policy of uniting them with the overwhelmingly English-speaking Cape Colony in a federation within the British empire. The Boers, confident in the wealth of their gold and diamond mines, were equally determined that the Afrikaners should be dominant in an independent 'United States of South Africa'.¹⁹ But the imperialist Milner, as Governor-General of Cape Colony, backed from London by Chamberlain as Colonial Secretary, was still using the Uitlanders' exclusion from the franchise as a pretext to assert English paramountcy. Of course, they did not present themselves as aggressors. Theirs was the classic jingo position: 'We don't want to fight but by jingo if we do/ We've got the ships, we've got the men,/We've got the money too.'

Hardy's poems of the South African war have been contrasted with the jingoistic poems of Kipling and others.²⁰ The contrast is certainly there, and Hardy himself pointed it out to Florence Henniker: 'My "Soldiers' Wives" song finishes up my war effusions, of which I am happy to say that not a single one is jingo or imperial.'²¹ Yet we must not build too much on this contrast without noting Hardy's ambivalence. His poems voice pity for the suffering of innocent widows, orphans, dead Drummer Hodge and the dumb horses. But he nowhere expressed the radical anti-imperialist and 'pro-Boer' ideas of J. A. Hobson,²² summed up pithily by his wife Emma: 'the Boers fight for homes and liberties – we fight for the Transvaal funds, diamonds, and gold'.²³ Although Hardy wrote to Florence Henniker that he deplored 'the fact that "civilized" nations have not learnt some more excellent & apostolic way of settling disputes than the old & barbarous one, after all these centuries', he immediately added:

But when I feel that it must be, few persons are more martial than I, or like better to write of war in prose & rhyme.

Such a position appears to have been now reached; & the sooner we get at it, & get it done, the better, I think.²⁴

This patriotism should not be explained away as tenderness for a friend whose husband was serving in the field. As we saw in the previous chapter, Hardy had long felt this kind of ambivalence. It had been expressed most recently in a notebook entry at the time of the Jameson affair: 'Why true conclusions are not reached, notwithstanding everlasting palaver. Men endeavor to hold to a mathematical consistency in things, instead of recognizing that certain things may both be good and mutually antagonistic: e.g. patriotism and universal humanity' (299).

As we have also seen, Hardy did not always oppose the use of war as an instrument of foreign policy. There is no evidence that he objected to the invasion of Egypt or Sudan. He had grown up as a patriotic young Englishman who admired Palmerston and distrusted France and Russia. That is the clue to his indecisiveness over Irish home rule in 1886. But Hardy regarded a general war between the European powers as a disaster that might destroy civilisation, to be avoided if at all possible by diplomacy. And it was not only Hardy. With different emphases, this underlay the foreign policies of Palmerston, Disraeli, Gladstone and the New Imperialists who succeeded them. Hardy simply shared this view. He attended Gladstone's great meeting over the eastern question to oppose jingoism. He was no doubt relieved when Disraeli returned from Berlin bearing 'peace with honor' (Hardy certainly thought Disraeli 'unexpectedly urbane' (153) when he met him a little later). And as we saw, his admiration for Gladstone's benevolence was clear during the home rule debate of 1886.

Yet the failure of British statesmen to find a solution to the Irish question and the spread of revolutionary violence over the northern hemisphere made Hardy more apprehensive about the state of modern civilisation. He interpreted it as a late-manhood crisis and cast about for a leader who would restore it to an upward course. Gladstone had failed in this task and Hardy ceased to consider himself a Liberal (260f). In the politics of naked factionalism which ensued, he thought such a leader as likely to come from the Conservative as the Liberal party. Ideally, this leader would steer public opinion away from crude jingoism, develop the British empire progressively and sustain peace in Europe. Salisbury, with his distrust of jingoism and his diplomatic skill in settling great power rivalries peacefully,

perhaps impressed him most. Certainly, Hardy formed a personal friendship with Salisbury's keen admirer, Lord Curzon (278), whom the Prime Minister appointed Viceroy of India in 1899.²⁵

It is necessary, then, to interpret Hardy's Boer War poems in the light of this ambivalence. Van Wyk Smith aligned the personal ambivalence with the verse and, more recently,²⁶ James Whitehead demonstrated that it signifies both Hardy's hope in 'Englishness' and his foreboding that it could succumb to aggressive imperialism.²⁷ Their multi-perspectival interpretation is, I suggest, the more fully intelligible if it is seen in the perspective of the Liberal Anglican idea of history.

15.7 THE IDEA OF HISTORY

Life and Work reveals that Hardy viewed these matters in the light of the Liberal Anglican substratum. In 1880 he noted: 'Discover for how many years, and on how many occasions, the organism, Society, has been standing, lying, etc., in varied positions, as if it were a tree or a man hit by vicissitudes' (150).

In the years immediately after 1870, Hardy began to fear that England was once again descending into a prostrate period, when intellect was counterpoised by ignorance or narrowness. From the later 1870s he recovered some hope from the revival of the Liberal party. There is evidence that he looked to the Positivism of his friends Leslie Stephen, Frederic Harrison and John Morley to strengthen the recuperative role of Liberalism (131), but, by the end of the decade, Positivism seemed to be failing the test of experience. The rich were given over to wealth and display. The organised workers were turning to class politics. 'Democratic government', Hardy thought, would 'probably merge in proletarian, and when these people are our masters it will . . . possibly be the utter ruin of art and literature!' (248).

Hardy could now recall Walter Bagehot's suggestion that history was driven not by science, but by blind passions. It was in 1884 that he wrote down the comment on teleological history quoted in the introduction to this study. Hegel and others, he noted, attributed everything to voluntary agency, but 'are they not in the main the outcome of passivity – acted upon by unconscious propensity?' (175).

This idea was taking hold in his mind. 'Passivity' was being equated with 'somnambulism' or 'automatism' as the chief characteristic of the age. In 1881 he made a note to 'Write a history of human automatism, or

impulsion – viz., an account of human action in spite of human knowledge, showing how very far conduct lags behind the knowledge that should really guide it' (158).

At the same time he was resistant to the idea, then emergent in academe, that historical writing should be relativistic as to moral ends. He had to admit that there were grounds for thinking so. During the Gordon affair, it seemed to Hardy that history was being driven by the unthinking passions of very ordinary men. He noted: 'History is rather a stream than a tree. There is nothing organic in its shape, nothing systematic in its development. It flows on like a thunderstorm-rill by a road side; now a straw turns it this way, now a tiny barrier of sand that' (179).

This note looks on the face of it like a relativistic idea of history. Before accepting this conclusion, however, we should examine the context of the passage more closely. Hardy went on:

The offhand decision of some commonplace mind high in office at a critical moment influences the course of events for a hundred years. Consider the evenings at Lord Carnarvon's, and the intensely average conversation on politics held there by average men who two or three weeks later were members of the Cabinet... Thus, judging by bulk of effect, it becomes impossible to estimate the intrinsic value of ideas, acts, material things: we are forced to appraise them by the curves of their career. (179)

This note, it seems to me, rules out alike historical relativism and linear progress, but allows for the possibility of cyclical oscillations, now towards amelioration, now to the reverse. Like John Stuart Mill, Hardy still believed that social science could predict either to a limited extent. To be sure, the next bend in the river of events may be progressive or regressive, to or from the desired end, but Millite social science could appraise the direction it is taking 'by the curve of their careers'. In other words, there was still a basis in inductive reasoning for a limited meliorism.

As the South African war loomed, however, Hardy had to accept that the curve of England's history just then was anything but progressive. As he recalled, he was 'decidedly pessimistic' at that time.²⁸ Yet this *fin-de-siècle* 'pessimism' cannot be regarded as the context of the later 'tragic' novels. That context is, rather, the years 1885–1895, when, as this chapter has suggested, it was possible to hope that decline and fall might be arrested by wise leaders among the British patriciate. In general, the

upper classes seemed to be sleepwalking into a crisis of imperialism, war and revolution. Yet there still seemed to be time if only they could be awakened to consciousness of their situation.

Comte's writings had encouraged Hardy to think that the literary artist had a part to play in arousing the somnambulists to their danger, but he did not accede to Comte's prescription of utopian fiction. Rather, modern novelists should adapt the tradition of tragedy to this recuperative purpose. Tragic fiction could show how disaster, individual and collective, might arise 'from the gradual closing in of a situation that comes of ordinary human passions, prejudices, and ambitions, by reason of the characters taking no trouble to ward off the disastrous events produced by the said passions, prejudices, and ambitions' (123).

As many scholars have suggested, Hardy had entered upon this narrative strategy with *The Return of the Native*. His 1874 pessimism had been mitigated, however, by the Gladstonian revival, and he did not attempt a tragic novel again until the darkening outlook for progressive politics after 1885–1886. The results were the four 'tragic' novels from *The Mayor of Casterbridge* to *Jude the Obscure*. I consider these novels in the next two chapters.

NOTES

1. Quoted in Reid, 'The Dorsetshire labourer', in Mallett (ed.), *Hardy in Context*, p. 184.
2. See S. Tresize, "'Here's sixpence towards that, please God!': Thomas Hardy, Joseph Arch and Hodge", *THJ*, VI (1990), pp. 48–61.
3. K. Laybourn, *The Rise of Socialism in Great Britain, c. 1881–1951* (Stroud, 1997), ch. 1, esp. pp. 3–12.
4. In this period, 1880–1914, the term 'social democrat' denoted parties which adopted Karl Marx's philosophy of history and sought state ownership of the means of production, peaceably by elections if possible, violently by class conflict if resisted by the ruling class. The historical literature is highly developed (see previous note), but still worth consulting on this point is G. D. H. Cole, *History of Socialist Thought*, Vol. II: *Marxism and Anarchism 1850–1890* (London, 1954) and Vol. III, *The Second International, Part One, 1889–1890* (London, 1956).
5. G. R. Searle: *The Liberal Party: Triumph and Disintegration, 1886–1929* (London, 1992), pp. 24–48, esp. p. 37. As noted above, Finn, *After*

Chartism, esp. 306–324, is indispensable to an understanding of Hardy's relationship to 'New Liberalism'. To my mind, she somewhat exaggerates the legislative and political gains which labour derived from 'social democratic' class collaboration before 1906, but her characterisation of working-class radicalism accurately describes the kind of politics with which Hardy sympathised. Thus he admired such Liberal-leaning trade unionists as Joseph Arch and republicans such as Bradlaugh, but he was out of sympathy with the anti-Liberal, anti-capitalist politics of socialists like Hyndman.

6. Hardy, *Early Years*, p. 294. Millgate deleted this entry in *Life and Work*.
7. Wife of the Marquis of Abercorn, Conservative MP for Co. Donegal, 1860–1880.
8. Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 153.
9. For the leading figures of the 'new imperialism' and their ideas, see Koebner and Schmidt, *Imperialism*, pp. 166–220; for the Liberal Imperialists see H. C. G. Matthew, *The Liberal Imperialists: The Ideas and Politics of a Post-Gladstonian Elite* (Oxford, 1973), pp. 3–36, 150–195.
10. Quoted in Koebner and Schmidt, *Imperialism*, p. 182.
11. Roberts, *Salisbury*, p. 686.
12. That is, unspoiled.
13. S. Hynes (ed.), *The Complete Poetical Works of Thomas Hardy: I* (1982), p. 120.
14. M. Shibeika, *British Policy in the Sudan, 1882–1892* (London, 1952), p. 390.
15. Shibeika, *British Policy in the Sudan*, p. 333.
16. Hynes (ed.), *Complete Poetical Works, I*, p. 208.
17. See J. O. Bailey, *The Poetry of Thomas Hardy: A Handbook and Commentary* (Chapel Hill, USA., 1970), p. 179.
18. *The Holy Bible* (King James version), Ps., 2: 1. For cancellation, see Hynes, *Poems*, p. 375.
19. I. R. Smith, *The Origins of the South African War, 1899–1902* (Harlow, 1996), pp. 14–69.
20. Bailey, *Poetry*, p. 116; E. Boehmber, *Colonial and Postcolonial Literature* (Oxford, 2005), p. 32; Bownas, *Hardy and Empire*, p. 50.
21. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters II*, p. 278.
22. J. A. Hobson, *Imperialism: A Study* (London, 1902).
23. D. Kay-Robinson, *The First Mrs Thomas Hardy* (London, 1979), p. 179. It should be noted that neither Emma nor Hardy expressed concern for the rights of black people in an Afrikaaner-dominated South Africa.
24. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters, II*, p. 232.

25. Curzon sent Hardy a copy of his *Persia and the Persian Question* (1892), which Hardy read with admiration, no doubt for its distrust of Russian designs on Persia and the frontier of British India.
26. V. W. Smith, *Drummer Hodge: The Poetry of the Anglo-Boer War, 1899–1902* (Oxford, 1978), pp. 64ff.
27. See J. Whitehead, ‘Hardy and Englishness’, in P. Mallett (ed.), *Palgrave Advances in Thomas Hardy Studies* (Basingstoke, 2004), pp. 203–225.
28. As he stated in a letter to John Galsworthy in 1923; quoted in Bailey, *Poetry*, p. 116.

Meliorism in *The Mayor of Casterbridge* and *The Woodlanders*

In this and the following chapter, I address the question of meliorism in the later ‘tragic’ novels. These have often been read as expressing Hardy’s pessimism, both cosmic and historical. Such language is easy to identify in these novels, yet it exists in counterpoint with a strain of meliorism – of hope for a *ricorso* of civilisation – produced by courageous defiance of law not grounded in the necessity of things. I wish to suggest that this tension between pessimistic and optimistic inferences can be more fully understood if we read the novels in the context of events reviewed in the previous two chapters, bearing in mind also the Liberal Anglican idea of history, modified for Hardy by the writings of George Drysdale and John Stuart Mill.

16.1 THE MAYOR OF CASTERBRIDGE

Just as it is no longer possible to read *Far from the Madding Crowd* as a simple pastoral tale, neither can we read *The Mayor of Casterbridge* (1886)¹ as an ‘agricultural tragedy’² in which a strong countryman and an organic rural community are overthrown by the invasion of urban forces. At first sight, Casterbridge seems to be what it looks to the naïve newcomer, Elizabeth-Jane: an honest market town, typical of the backward county in which Hardy grew up. Yet as we are drawn closer in, we learn, also with Elizabeth-Jane, that Casterbridge is anything but an ‘honest borough’ (59), untouched by ‘the faintest sprinkle of modernism’ (27). Many critics have

recognised this. What this section further suggests is that the community is in a late-manhood crisis of English civilisation.³ Like the Liberal Anglican historians, Hardy sees the high point of this civilisation as the time when High Place Hall was built, more than a century before the action begins. Then the wealthy inhabitants lived face to face with the yeomen, farmers, tradesmen, shepherds and servants, who mingled in the market-place with the same kind of people from the surrounding villages. As the Liberal Anglican historians saw it, the characteristic of that phase was the growth of reason, as civilisation developed from youth to manhood. This is to be discerned in its survivals at Casterbridge. The architecture of its most imposing dwelling was 'Palladian' (131); that is, classically rational in concept. The contrivances of its streets were marked by a measure of 'reasonableness' (59). Law was administered with concern for the truth, lawyers occasionally throwing in 'strong arguments for the other side' (59). Above all, the Church of England symbolised the accommodation of reason and faith, unifying community and nation by teaching the people what they needed to know of 'scripture history' (12), God's providence and 'the whole duty of man' (64).

As has often been said, however, the scenes of the novel are held in a double gaze and we are not dependent for our understanding on Elizabeth-Jane's perception. Hardy, the philosophical historian-novelist, reads them with informed insight. He represents Casterbridge as a community in an advanced state of decay. Its symptoms are already familiar enough from this study. It has always owed its existence to its military function as a bastion of warfare. In Anglo-Saxon times it was a 'borough', a stockaded fort established by charter for the protection of trade. In Roman times it was a military camp (*castrum*).

The game of chess is, of course, an analogue of war, which the narrator applies to the commerce of Casterbridge. It stands 'like a chess-board on a green table-cloth' (86). On this board, Henchard and Farfrae fight out their battle for survival in the home-corn trade. This is a war which yields the winners great opulence: Henchard's house, 'one of the best' (59), has a garden nearly a quarter of a mile long. The losers, such as those ousted from Weydon Priors, 'drifted or were forced' into proletarian poverty, as Hardy makes clear in his description of Mixen Lane.⁴ Class alienation is well advanced, as evidenced by the festering resentment against Henchard and Lucetta, which turns at once on his growed wheat and her pre-marital intrigue with him. It finally breaks out in the riot of the skimmington ride.

Even before that event, the politics of the seemingly organic community are riven by the factionalism of a late-manhood crisis. Only for the evening of the public dinner do the governing elites put aside 'all those vast political, religious, and social differences which . . . separated them like iron grills' (39).

For Hardy, as for the Liberal Anglican historians, another symptom of decline is the decay of traditional religion, symbolised by the 'grizzled church' with its mortar 'nibbled out' (28f). Top o' town Casterbridge is penetrated by materialism. Hardy employs the synecdochic trope to draw an analogy between the middle-life crisis of an individual and that of a civilisation. In the middle age of an individual, he tells us, 'material things increasingly possess the mind' (139). And as with the individual, so with a whole society. Thus it is striking that, in the chapter with the grizzled church, we read of the elders among the council men at the feast, who are 'sniffing and grunting over their plates like sows nuzzling for acorns'. Moreover, the 'trinity' 'sacred' to the company is not the Christian doctrine, but the three drinks, 'port, sherry and rum' (33). Likewise, Christianity has no relevance for the journeymen at the other end of Casterbridge. Steady churchgoers, they criticise the sermon each Sunday 'as a scientific feat or performance which had no relation to their own lives' (214).

Thus far, Hardy was guided by the Liberal Anglican idea of history, which survived his loss of faith to become a substratum of his thinking. But, as we have seen, the orthodox Christian moral superstructure supported by it had been replaced by the sexual radicalism of George Drysdale and John Stuart Mill. This radical critique is inscribed in the novel. The social function of Christianity in Casterbridge is to support the Victorian sexual code and the respectability it guarantees. So powerful is this code that Henchard must conceal, by an elaborate series of deceptions, the fact that he sold his wife, even though wife selling had long been a customary form of divorce among the common people, 'as too many rural records show' (24). Likewise, Farfrae knows that his business reputation rests upon it. When Lucetta suggests that he follow her in allowing all her servants 'lovers if they want them', he replies: 'I must be a little stricter than that . . . You are a – a thriving woman; and I am a struggling hay and corn merchant' (151).

In the end, Lucetta and Henchard are the victims of a social law which hedges them in on the roads they tramp to dusty death. Henchard accepts his fate, but Lucetta tries to rebel with arguments that seem drawn from

Drysdale. 'Oh, if I had my wish', she expostulates with strong emotion, 'I'd let people live and love at their pleasure!' (151). Like Catullus, as quoted by Parson Swancourt, she insists on a woman's 'chartered right to change her mind' when the man to whom she has promised herself discloses 'some qualities . . . that rendered him less desirable as a husband' (161). After a difficult interview with Henchard she exclaims, 'I won't be a slave to the past – I'll love where I choose!' (166).

Lucetta is one of Hardy's women of strong emotions given to indiscreet expression of them in private writings. That she feels the repressiveness of Victorian respectability is evinced by her concern to conceal her French origins and insistence that 'I am English' (165). Her predicament justly attracts the sympathy of modern critics, but there is none of that to be had among the women of Casterbridge. It is not only Elizabeth-Jane who refuses to grant Lucetta's claim – 'it wants a Pope to settle that' (161) – but also the women in the alternative church of Peter's Finger, reacting to their own repression by people at the top o' town. As Nance Mockridge says with heavy irony, after listening to Lucetta's letters: 'Tis a humbling thing for us, as respectable women, that one of the same sex could do it. And now she's vowed herself to another man!' (239).

Throughout *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, as recent critics have recognized,⁵ Hardy was commenting on England in the 1880s as much as the 1840s. As we saw in [Chapters 13 and 14](#) of this study, he was conscious of living through another plunge in the cycle of civilisation, marked again by imperialism, war and revolution. *Life and Work* also shows that he wished to create a new kind of tragic novel, crafted so as to awaken readers to the crisis besetting them. He was, as 'The Dorsetshire Labourer' shows, fully aware of its economic and political aspects. But, in the years which saw the persecution of Dilke and Parnell by the non-conformist conscience, it was the question of sexual repression that stirred his deepest feelings.

If, however, there is a growing critical consensus about this, there is much disagreement as to the full implication of the novel. Many read it as expressive of Hardy's pessimism about modernity and his rejection of meliorism. For John Goode, the only way out of this pessimism lies in revolutionary class and gender struggle, and he reads the skimmington ride as a Bakhtinian signifier of revolution without which history must always be 'a general drama of pain'⁶ (311). Here as elsewhere, Goode has much to teach about the way the novel interrogates late Victorian social discourses, but it is difficult to endorse his reading without qualification. Quite apart from the disastrous consequence of the skimmington ride for

‘poor Lucetta’ (258), Hardy’s language in representing it seems to refuse such reconstructive significance. It is a ‘demoniac Sabbath’ and the narrator goes no further than Farfrae’s limited exculpation: it was ‘a rough jest’ (260), its fatal consequence neither intended nor foreseen by the ‘thoughtless crew’ who writhe ‘under the heel’ of ‘people who stand at the head of affairs’ (279). Rather than a sign of progress, the skimmington is surely to be read as reactionary. This is the kind of mad anarchy to be expected in a highly repressive society.

For Pamela Dalziel, the novel has a more gradualist optimism, representing progress as a long series of upward cycles, rather like the Comtean ‘looped orbit’ to which Hardy referred in ‘Candour in English Fiction’. In the next chapter I will look more particularly into Hardy’s stance towards Comte. Here I am concerned with the claim that *The Mayor of Casterbridge* endorses Comte’s idea that human history can be read in terms of upward-spiralling ‘phases’. It is true that the marriage of Donald Farfrae and Elizabeth-Jane, like that of Gabriel Oak and Bathsheba Everdene, has a Comtean echo. Farfrae is the scientific entrepreneur with a second wife devoted to domestic management and public philanthropy. She is the representative of Comte’s altruism, his higher form of Christian charity.

But we also saw in [Chapter 6](#) that the sexual radicalism of the 1860s challenged Comte’s philosophy of human nature, and it is as difficult to feel complete satisfaction with Elizabeth-Jane’s marriage as with Bathsheba’s. Hardy’s language in summarising Elizabeth-Jane’s conclusions suggests that he himself felt less than her satisfaction:

in discovering to the narrow-lived ones around her the secret (as she had once learnt it) of making limited opportunities enduring; which she deemed to consist in the cunning enlargement by a species of microscopic treatment, of those minute forms of satisfaction that offer themselves to everybody not in positive pain; which thus handled have much of the same inspiring effect upon life as wider interests cursorily embraced. (309)

Long, involved sentences are usually a sign of Hardy’s discomfort and evasiveness. Taken as a whole, the closing summary of Elizabeth-Jane’s views reads as if Hardy, like his ‘poor only heroine’ (287), felt ‘forced’ to class himself among the fortunate, recognising that no human being ‘deserved less than was given’ to him, while others received ‘less who had deserved much more’ (311).

Elizabeth-Jane's point of view might have satisfied Samuel Smiles. It had hardly consoled Hardy himself, as *Life and Work* more than hints, when he was a frustrated young architect's clerk in the 1860s.

What idea of progress, then, did Hardy want his readers to discern in his tragic novels? Once again, it is possible to take our cue from *Life and Work*. In 1881, about the time when, as his memoirs indicate, he was thinking about history, Auguste Comte and the looped orbit, Hardy set down a much-quoted notebook entry on the art of fiction:

As, in looking at a carpet, by following one colour a certain pattern is suggested, by following another colour, another; so in life the seer should watch that pattern among general things which his idiosyncrasy moves him to observe, and describe that alone. This is, quite accurately, a going to Nature; yet the result is no mere photograph, but purely the product of the writer's own mind. (158)

This passage has often been cited to pinpoint Hardy's understanding of the creative process in fiction. Its image of the texts as a malleable, unfinished structure, more akin to a web than to Henry James's solid and completed house, seems convincing as to Hardy's artistic aim. This reached the heights of achievement in the late tragic novels. Not only do they resist closure, but they read like a tapestry of great complexity, in which readers are free to trace a pattern according to their own idiosyncratic mode of regard.

Furthermore, the passage need not be limited to a description of the fictional text that Hardy wished to produce. It suggests that the metaphor of the web is a more realistic representation of social existence than that of architectural structure, since it represents something provisional because unfinished.⁷ It is 'quite accurately, a going to nature'. And for 'nature' here we can also read 'history'. The historian, in Hardy's view as in Bagehot's, should be tentative in the representation of social life – what Hardy, in his next novel, *The Woodlanders*, will call 'the great web of human doings then weaving in both hemispheres from the White Sea to Cape Horn' (20).

In *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, Hardy displays this tentativeness, offering a variety of ideas of history as threads for his readers to follow. In Hayden White's terms,⁸ there is, first, the 'metonymic' thread. History is represented as driven in a linear motion by a mechanistic force. This is suggested by

several signifiers: wagons, railway, seed drill, hedged-in roads along which men are constrained to move as they pursue their goals in the race of life.

Second, there is the 'synecdochic' thread, by which the whole is identified with the part. Applied to history, the life of an individual becomes a metaphor of the life of a civilisation. Each comes and goes in cycles of birth, life and death. The same trope can be extended, as in Thomas Arnold's and Comte's imagination, to signify the progress of humanity as an upward spiral. In *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, however, this idea of history seems limited to material progress. Each civilisation – Celtic, Roman, and Anglo-Saxon – has proved capable of rising to a higher level of technological sophistication than its predecessor, but the record yields no evidence of cultural growth, the enlargement of justice or 'fair play' (6). This is how Susan Henchard sees life at the beginning of the novel and Elizabeth-Jane sees it at the end.

Third, there is the ironic thread, which represents no pattern, either linear or cyclical, in the movement of history. The journey of human beings through time is like a voyage on the ocean. For any given individual or community it might reach landfall, but it might be shipwrecked by a storm. This 'persistence of the unforeseen' is represented by signifiers of the sea: the signboard of the Three Mariners inn (48); the babble of voices in the market square, 'as of wavelets on a lopping sea' (148); a plot reversal like a 'turn of the tide' (154); Elizabeth-Jane's desire to have a daily glimpse of the sea (284).

Dalziel is undoubtedly right to see Elizabeth-Jane's version of progress as an echo of the Comtean looped orbit. But Hardy had long before rejected Comte's version of reason because it subjugated the claims of the body. The flesh was to be conquered by the spirit. In other words, Elizabeth-Jane remains, like Comte, confined within the Victorian code of sexual respectability. None of the ideas of history so far identified in the novel offers any challenge to this.

Yet there is a fourth thread for the reader to follow which was hardly noticed until recently.⁹ It may be termed the melioristic thread and it is represented by Newson's deeds. Newson brings the values of the seafarer in the age of sail to the predicaments of the other characters. History is indeed a voyage whose outcome cannot be predicted. But such a view prescribes neither fatalism nor all-out competition for survival. Mariners must co-operate as comrades (40), pulling together to keep the ship afloat and adapting to unforeseen events. Thus Newson solves the problem of Susan's marriage to an irascible husband by the transgressive device of the

wife sale. Later he tries to persuade Elizabeth-Jane that the issue of biological paternity is irrelevant to her relationship with Henchard. This is much closer to Drysdale's religion of nature than to the protestant Christian ideal of the whole duty of man or Comte's prescription of celibate marriage.

All this seems to indicate what Hardy is saying about historical change. He was distancing himself from Comte's idea of progress that the character of each age developed towards altruism by a natural law of succession, an upward spiral towards the light of reason and science. He sees no such law in 'nature' or in the *corso* and *ricorso* of civilisations. These are blind operations, like the phases of sunlight and shadow, the motion of planets or the turn of the seasons. 'Justice', as J. S. Mill had argued, is a social end which human beings have to choose and struggle courageously to apply, against 'crookedness, custom and fear'. Nor must they expect a linear advance. Gains will be partial. Temporary reversal is to be expected. Further advance will have to wait until new conditions come round. The character of the Victorian age cannot be changed at a stroke.

This is Newson's experience at Casterbridge. His unorthodox view of marriage and the family falls, like the seed in the parable, on stony ground. He cannot displace completely the ideas of Elizabeth-Jane's 'strict nature' or Farfrae's commitment to respectability (288). Casterbridge rejects the gospel of the body, delivered by the 'new son' or 'sun', leaving him no course but withdrawal to Budmouth to settle in a cottage which affords 'glimpses of a vertical strip of blue sea' visible to anyone 'leaning forward far enough' (305).

However, his leaning points forward to the age of Hardy's preface, when readers are 'accustomed to the sixpenny loaf of the present date, and to the present indifference of the public to harvest weather' (3). Such complacency, some readers understood, was misplaced. Civilisation has yet some storms to meet – economic, cultural and military. Readers are thus invited to think whether Newson's values have any relevance to England in the 1880s. In the mid-1880s, which saw the wreck of Dilke's career by the Victorian sexual code and the crisis of imperialism represented by the Irish home rule question, Hardy's tragedy of an ultra-respectable community and its 'man of character' had a clear message. It was the message of Drysdale's *Elements* and of Mill's *On Liberty*: break the mould of custom or suffer the tragic consequences.

16.2 THE WOODLANDERS

At the opening of *The Woodlanders* (1887), we see the hamlet of Little Hintock through the kind of gaze that first saw Casterbridge. It is the gaze of an outsider, the Rambler, sentimentalising over the 'forlorn' loneliness and 'old associations' of the spot (5). Hardy knew very well that many of his readers were similar tourists in 'Wessex', an interpretive group whose understanding was coloured by Romantic poetry and antiquarian literature. From this point of view, Little Hintock seems like an organic community, surviving from the Elizabethan age; its inhabitants work the timber plantation of the nearby manor, carved out from the natural woods. They co-operate in customary ways, illustrated by the relations of Melbury and Winterborne, who exchange resources and services according to an 'unwritten code' (23), having as little use for money as 'Crusoe's island' (127). Nothing essential seems to have changed over three centuries in this, one of the 'sequestered spots outside the gates of the world' (5).

This reading is undermined by a second historical discourse, the substratum of the Liberal Anglican idea of history. Long before the age of Victoria, the economy of the Hintocks has been shaped by trade and war, producing luxury, poverty and class alienation, rather than the ideal community imagined by Renaissance and Romantic poets. Three fictional techniques especially illustrate the process: representation of architectural features, dialogue between the inhabitants, and inscription of the emergent discourse of economic history.

The use of architectural features may be illustrated by reference to Melbury's house. It typifies a phase of civilisation later than the Elizabethan: the 'early Georgian age', 'respectable, roomy, almost dignified', yet open to the road and adapted for trade. Like that age itself, its character is commercial and the character of its owner, George Melbury, has been formed by its mercantile 'passions' (22). These have driven him to build up a large business in 'timber, bark, and copse-ware', from which the trees of the manorial plantation have gone to build the 'modern . . . line-of-ships' (16) that gave England victory at Trafalgar.

Dialogue amplifies this history. A conversation between Melbury and his daughter reveals that his investments have modernised Little Hintock's communications with the region and the world beyond. He tells Grace that he has 'turn-pike bonds . . . each . . . worth two hundred pounds' and a great stake in 'Port-Bredy harbour bonds . . . because I send off timber

there' (80). Dialogue also shows how this expansion of trade has multiplied class distinction between the inhabitants. Melbury makes Winterborne feel this by speaking 'down to him from a higher plane than his own' (51). Similarly, Winterbourne feels distanced from Grace when she talks over his head about 'French books' (61). And Marty's sense of Giles's superior social status is indicated by her addressing him constantly as 'Mr. Winterbourne'.

As to economic history, the action shows how the passions of a commercial age have undermined the independent status of customary tenants of the manor. Here Hardy could draw upon the emergent practice of economic history, as represented in England by the Broad Church sympathiser, James Thorold Rogers. Rogers documented the class struggle over land ownership, which, he argued, had gone on in England since the fourteenth century.¹⁰ Hardy's 'Facts Notebook' shows that he was well acquainted with Rogers's work. The result is that he can represent, with a precision new to English fiction, the changing power relationships between landowner and tenant in this community. Thus the social position of John South had been that of a 'well-to-do villager, whose tenure was by copy of court-roll' (9). Hardy knows that tenants like these had been induced 'to exchange their old copyholds for life-leases' (90). Consequently it was easier for a landowner in the nineteenth century to terminate the tenancy – as Mrs Charmond's agent does in order to improve access to her property (168). This action reduces Giles to the status of a hired contractor and Marty to that of a cottier.

Commercial development, class formation and alienation have, therefore, gone on at Little Hintock long before the coming of Felice Charmond and Edred Fitzpiers. These should not be seen simply as urban invaders who destroy the organic values of a timeless rural community. Hardy knows that Little Hintock is not insulated from external forces for change. News from the outer world, we are told, 'entered and expired . . . like the exhausted swell of a wave in some innermost cavern of some innermost creek of an embayed sea' (155).

What Hardy wishes to convey is the character of modern English civilisation as it has developed since Tudor times. Moreover, the words 'exhausted swell' convey precisely his sense of its late-manhood crisis, the symptoms of which are the pomp of empire, luxury funded by commerce, class alienation and decline of traditional religion. Hardy points to them repeatedly and only a few instances of the first three need be given here. Felice Charmond brings to the Elizabethan manor 'the somewhat showy

Versaillese furniture and gilding' (225), favoured in the France of the Second Empire. This, her late husband's country retreat, has been purchased with the profits of the 'iron trade in the north' (206). Freed by his death to please herself, she relieves the boredom of Hintock life by returning to the luxury and excitement of continental watering places. Thus she becomes virtually an absentee landowner, taking only fitful interest in the work of her estate.

Modern critics¹¹ have drawn attention to these symptoms of social crisis in *The Woodlanders*. They have also pointed out that Hardy associates them with a Victorian code of respectability which inhibits natural sexuality and enforces lifelong monogamy. What this section suggests in addition is that Hardy undermines these conventions in language that is consonant with that of Drysdale and Mill.

Hardy set the action of his novel in the years during which Drysdale first published his *Elements of Social Science*. Drysdale's argument, that rigid adherence to lifelong monogamy and chastity distorted the natural development of young people, is worked out in the action of the novel, which is structured into four movements.¹² In the first, the focus is on the patriarchal influence which George Melbury exercises over his daughter, Grace. Grace is another of Hardy's young ingénues, like Elfride Swancourt, who are manoeuvred into marriage by family pressure while their characters are still plastic and unformed. At 20 years of age, she is 'elastic in movement' and

Her look expressed a tendency to wait for others' thoughts before uttering her own, possibly also to wait for others' deeds before her own doings. In her small delicate mouth, which had hardly settled down to its matured curves, there was a gentleness that might hinder sufficient self-assertion for her own good. (35)

Thus Melbury easily overcomes her feelings for her childhood sweetheart Giles, when the latter is reduced by the loss of his livelihood to the status of a propertyless man. This opens the way for Fitzpiers's wooing and winning of Grace in the second movement. Fitzpiers is one of Drysdale's young men of the upper classes, facing the battle of life for food and love. He knows that he ought to make a fortunate marriage as a means to advancement in his chosen profession. Hardy follows Drysdale in showing how Fitzpiers is drawn into an inappropriate marriage by his natural instinct and confused reading of Romantic poetry. Deprivation charges up the

erotic desire of young men, like electricity in a Leyden jar (106), so that, as Dr Fitzpiers explains, they are ready to project it

against any suitable object in the line of our vision . . . indifferently. So that if any other young lady had appeared instead of the one who did appear, I should have felt just the same interest in her, and have quoted precisely the same lines from Shelley about her, as about this one I saw. (106)

This had been Drysdale's view of natural human love, but Drysdale thought it incompatible with commitment to lifelong monogamy. Fitzpiers fails to follow the logic of his Drysdalian observation when he yields to the romantic dream of marriage to an idealised Grace in a pastoral setting. In the serial version of the novel, constrained by Mrs Grundy, Hardy used double entendre to expose the desire for exorbitant profit underlying such romantic fantasies. Thus in the bark-ripping episode, where Fitzpiers first yields to the dream of a 'sylvan life' with Grace, the work begins with the removal of the collar, 'an operation comparable to the "little toilette" of the executioner's victim' (122). At the end of the ripping, 'the oak stood naked-legged, and as if ashamed' (122). By the time he published the 1895 version of the novel, Hardy felt able to be more explicit. Accordingly, in the divination rite at Midsummer Eve, Fitzpiers, having first clasped Grace to his heart with a vow of lifelong love, then seizes his opportunity to spend a night with Suke under the hay-cock (135).¹³

Melbury proves incapable of reading these signs and imposes upon Grace, who has read them. It was his paternal pressure, resembling 'the finger of fate', which touched Grace 'and turned her to a wife' (157).

The third movement shows the effect of Victorian marriage on Grace, Fitzpiers and Felice, with whom he becomes infatuated. Here again, Hardy echoes the satirical attacks of Drysdale on exclusive monogamy. Drysdale wrote:

The exceedingly strict rules of sexual morality . . . have given rise to a regular and secret and mercenary intercourse, ingrained into all civilised societies in which human dignity and liberty are . . . degraded . . . Secrecy and deceit are the deadly enemies of liberty and dignity; and as long as the present sexual system lasts, there is no such thing as a dignified life for youth.¹⁴

Mill's essay *On Liberty* supported Drysdale's critique in this respect. Everyone in Victorian England, Mill wrote, 'lives as under the eye of a hostile and dreaded censorship'.¹⁵ In *The Woodlanders* Hardy shows how a young widow of a passionate nature, like Felice Charmond, must live her life under the scrutiny of such censorship, and how the clash between nature and convention forces her into the undignified secrecy condemned by Drysdale. Both at the highest and at the lowest levels of the Hintocks, her morals are the subject of censorious gossip. The church-going cottage folk criticise her low-cut gowns (24); her neighbours in 'society' call her 'atheist' and 'blasphemer' (172).

It is worth digressing here to note that in creating Felice Charmond, Hardy may well have had in mind the widely publicised Robinson divorce case of 1858–1859. Henry Robinson sued his wife Isabella on the grounds of adultery with her physician, Edward Lane, brother-in-law of George Drysdale. He had discovered his wife's private diary, which was cited as evidence in court and quoted in newspaper reports. Isabella Robinson was acquitted of adultery on the ground that her diary was fantasy and no record of anything that actually happened. But her reputation was destroyed by the newspapers, which represented her as a woman abandoned to dreams and wild longings. An editorial in *The Times*, for example, held that 'the solid barriers which separate realities from shadows – truth from fiction – the waking from the dreaming world had no existence. Every wild desire which thrilled through her frame, every vagrant thought which flitted across her disordered brain, was invested with the attributes of personality. She lived in an inner world of her own.'¹⁶

Hardy nowhere referred to the Robinson divorce, but it is interesting to note that the case was the subject of extended comment in *The Saturday Review*, just about the time when he began to read it on the advice of Horace Moule. *The Saturday Review* disapprovingly likened Isabella Robinson to Sappho and complained that newspaper reports of divorce proceedings were disseminating sexual stories as corrupting as the pornography for sale in Holywell Street.¹⁷ We have seen that *Life and Work* suggests that the publications on sale in Holywell Street helped to sharpen young Thomas Hardy's sexual radicalism. The same effect was produced by his attendances at the 'Coal Hole', a theatre of popular entertainment where divorce proceedings were satirised by 'judge and jury mock trials'.¹⁸

The value of the foregoing digression is that it points up the pejorative view of conventional opinion regarding 'wild desire'. It was always to be condemned. Felice fears exactly this kind of censure and protests against it

when she exclaims: 'Oh why were we given hungry hearts and wild desires if we had to live in a world like this?' She goes on to protest in very Drysdalian terms against the cruelty of social law: 'The terrible insistences of society – how severe they are and cold, and inexorable – ghastly towards those who are made of wax and not of stone' (178).

Nothing reveals more clearly the undercurrent of Hardy's sexual radicalism than the way he treats Felice. Far from joining in bourgeois condemnation of her as a woman of easy virtue, he protects her against it. There was, he writes, nothing in her history 'to be ashamed of, and many things of which she might have been proud' (176). Her love for Fitzpiers is represented as a natural force she cannot withstand, however hard she tries. Thus she genuinely wishes to save Grace from the pain of marital breakup. She makes two desperate attempts to overcome her passion for Grace's husband, first by going away to Middleton Abbey. This fails when she succumbs to his persistent wooing. Second, after hearing that Fitzpiers has come to no serious harm through his 'accident' in the woods, she forms a resolve for 'keeping faith with Grace' (238) by going abroad. But to make so heroic a resolution is, in Hardy's view, 'to run mad with discretion' (237). The arrival of her bloodstained lover at her drawing room window arouses her 'passionate solicitude' (238), and she nurses him back to health with the loving kindnesses of 'a fond woman' (239). Still she feels for Grace: his resolution to leave his wife forever 'distressed her beyond endurance', but, as the narrator asks: 'What will not women do on such devoted occasions?' (240).

Just as Hardy protects Felice from the obloquy of conventional spectators, he deflects holier-than-thou criticism of Fitzpiers's conduct. This is represented as the effect of his nature. Hardy opines that men like Fitzpiers can love more than one woman at the same time and still be 'kind and fond' to their wives 'at times', for the love of such men 'is unquestionably of such quality as to bear division and transference' (188). This is radical on the author's part, but Fitzpiers falls short of a Drysdalian hero because he denies the same latitude to wives, feeling intensely jealous when he thinks Grace has slept with Giles in the woodland hut.

It is thus possible to follow a thread of sexual radicalism in the characterisation and plot of *The Woodlanders*. Can we go further and detect in its language Hardy's hope of meliorism through freedom to experiment with lifestyle? I suggest that we can. Here I am not simply relying on the critique of the Divorce Act of 1857, though Hardy obviously inscribed in the novel its double discrimination against the wife. She had to prove that

her husband had committed more than one marital offence, while he had to prove adultery alone. In addition, like Isabella Robinson, she risks greater damage to her reputation from the publicity of proceedings. Significantly, this is Grace's greatest concern when her father turns to the law of divorce.

Hardy's critique goes much further than this, however, showing how Victorian conventions work to stifle the courage of people who wished to challenge them. The novel represents two pairs of lovers, neither of whom can muster enough courage to defy Victorian respectability. Felice and Fitzpiers transgress only in secret. Giles, and especially Grace, show more willingness to defy convention openly. Giles transgresses twice in the open, first when he reaches out to caress the flower at Grace's bosom; second when he kisses her passionately in anticipation of her divorce. But in each case he succumbs to the Victorian norm of chivalry and withdraws, with disastrous consequences. Grace, frustrated finally in her incipient rebellion by Giles's tragedy, opts for the shelter of patriarchy in her husband's rather than her father's home.

When we ask what is the cause of these failures of courage, the novel reveals many threads between which readers may choose. Some critics favour a Social Darwinist explanation. Michael Millgate, for example, saw organic and social life alike as blighted by the struggle for existence. His interpretation was derived from the many signifiers of woodland and urban decay, summed up in the authorial comment that in the Hintock woods, 'as everywhere, the unfulfilled intention, which makes life what it is, was as obvious as it could be among the depraved crowds of a city slum' (48). For Millgate, the struggle in nature does not simply reflect the struggle in human society: both are in the throes of the same struggle.¹⁹

We are thus left with a fiction which offers no hope of social recuperation by human agency. John Goode, once again commendably resisting the pessimistic tendencies of this interpretation, holds that Hardy's multi-perspectival mode of narration forces the reader to question such ideological constructions and to confront the contrast of fact with potentiality.²⁰

Goode, like Mill, refuses to derive 'ought' from 'is', the choice of values from the facts of nature. This is agreeable to readers like myself, who perceive a thread of meliorism in Hardy's later fiction. Yet Goode denies its presence, since meliorism implies gradualist improvement rather than revolutionary transformation. For Goode, the novel offers no such assurance, only the utopian vision of Marty South, symbol of a new age, when

men and women will have rejected 'the attribute of sex for the lofty quality of abstract humanism' (331).²¹

This reading seems to me thwarted by the fact that, except in mathematics, abstract concepts were unacceptable to Hardy. As he wrote in a notebook entry of 1882:

Since I discovered, several years ago, that I was living in a world where nothing bears out in practice what it promises incipiently, I have troubled myself very little about theories. . . . Where development according to perfect reason is limited to the narrow region of pure mathematics, I am content with tentativeness from day to day. (161)

This was Mill's view also. His *Logic*, as we have seen, proposed a probabilistic idea of social science. His essay *On Liberty* rejected essentialising categories of human nature and implied the need for individuals to experiment with forms of social, including sexual, relationship. What I now wish to demonstrate is that a comparative reading of Mill's *On Liberty* and Hardy's *The Woodlanders* reveals that these two texts share a cluster of signifiers derived from these principles. In neither text is human nature seen as immutably determined by natural law. In his chapter on 'Individuality', which Hardy read as a cure for depression, Mill insisted that human nature 'is not a machine to be built after a model, and set to do exactly the work prescribed for it, but a tree, which requires to grow and develop itself on all sides, according to the tendency of the inward forces which make it a living thing'.²²

Yet under the censorship of average public opinion, most men and women grew in a hidebound way, like trees 'clipped into pollards, or cut out into figures of animals'.²³ Hardy had echoed Mill's point before *The Woodlanders*. In Henchard's garden in *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, 'the long-tied espaliers . . . had grown so stout, and cramped, and gnarled that they had pulled their stakes out of the ground, and stood distorted and writhing in vegetable agony, like leafy Laocoons' (72).

A keen botanist himself, Mill thought of personal development as a process of cultivation in which the chief social agency was education. In Victorian England, he complained, education too often produced subservience to custom rather than the natural propensities of individual character. The task of representative government was to promote an educational system which fostered the natural development of a person's 'desires' and 'impulses'. Orthodox Christian education sought to repress

them as 'a peril and a snare' (66). Mill countered that 'The same strong susceptibilities which make the personal impulses vivid and powerful, are also the source from whence are generated the most passionate love of virtue, and the sternest self-control.'²⁴ In other words, the only possible guarantee against violent and licentious passion was, for Mill, the cultivation through education of a reasoned view of what was truly harmful and needed to be restrained.

Turning back, for the last time, to *The Woodlanders*, we note the traces of Mill's key words: education, cultivation, garden, tree, machine, growth. Grace is a victim of her schooling, which has given her artificial cultivation instead of preparing her for self-development: 'Cultivation had so far advanced in the soil of Miss Melbury's mind as to lead her to talk of anything save of that she knew well, and had the greatest interest in developing; herself' (40).

When she begins to see through the false cultivation of her husband and turns back to Giles, Hardy uses the metaphor of a tree released from constraint:

Her heart rose from its late sadness like a released bough; her senses reveled in the sudden lapse back to Nature unadorned. The consciousness of having to be genteel because of her husband's profession, the veneer of artificiality which she had acquired at the fashionable schools, were thrown off, and she became the crude country girl of her latent, early instincts. (186f)

In the dramatic confrontation between Grace and her father over the results of her fashionable schooling, he tries to defend himself by likening her education to plant cultivation: 'You have been well educated, well tended' (201). But Melbury, the highly successful timber merchant who has ripped profit out of the trees, has never had much time for gardening in the woodland, declaring that 'gardens in such a place were no good at all' (129).

The great cultivator in *The Woodlanders* is, of course, Giles Winterbourne, who nurtures young trees as Mill's ideal educator will nurture children, so that they grow up strong, able to resist the blasts that would knock them over: 'He put most of these roots towards the south-west; for, he said, in forty years' time, when some great gale is blowing from that quarter, the trees will require the strongest holdfast on that side to stand against it and not fall' (59).

Again, when Grace overcomes Felice, forcing her to own that her initial account of her relationship with Fitzpiers is false, Hardy again employs the metaphor of natural growth to point up the contrast between the two women: "I question if you will refuse to see him again," said Grace drily, as she bent a sapling back. "But I am not incensed against you as you are against me," she added, abandoning the tree to its natural perpendicular' (215f).

This episode is the beginning of Grace's self-development. She will come to understand that the jealousy of spouses is reinforced by social convention, and that misplaced vows of lifelong monogamy to the wrong person ought to be socially deconstructed. As Grace will observe in the hut, animals know neither law nor sin.

This is the new consciousness that Drysdale and Mill, notwithstanding differences in their approach, wanted to inculcate. Both appealed for a true understanding of human nature as variegated and plastic. Both looked to reformed education, including sex education, as the key to the evolution of a new culture from the old. People must be taught to read human nature as completely as Giles and Marty read the nature of the woods:

The casual glimpses which the ordinary population bestowed upon that wondrous world of sap and leaves called the Hintock woods had been with these two, Giles and Marty, a clear gaze. They had been possessed of its finer mysteries as of commonplace knowledge; had been able to read its hieroglyphs as ordinary writing; to them the sights and sounds of night, winter, wind, storm, amid those dense boughs, which had to Grace a touch of the uncanny, and even of the supernatural, were simple occurrences whose origin, continuance, and laws they foreknew. (297f)

Yet Giles and Marty tragically fail to see the potential for the cultivation of human nature. Nor is this their failure alone. It is the failure of the whole civilisation, which is all too prone to read nature solely as a Malthusian/Darwinian struggle for existence, supposedly driven by the natural laws of production and reproduction. Mill, as we have seen, dissented from this kind of teleology. For him, there was always some scope for human agency.

Mill's view should prompt us to think that for Hardy, the 'unfulfilled intention' was a human intention. And, with Edward Neill,²⁵ we may go behind Mill to Shelley, who declared that poets and prophets were 'the unacknowledged legislators of the world'.²⁶ This famous quotation from

his 'Defence of Poetry' not only reminds us of his inscribed presence in *The Woodlanders*, it also reminds us of Hardy's view that Shelley was 'our most marvelous lyrist' and that the Romantic theory that the lyric was the highest stage of poetry, because it revealed the growth of the poet's mind through its interpretive interaction with nature. Shelley read many signs of decay and death in nature and history. Yet he also felt inspired by nature's plenitude of beauty and believed that it could be improved infinitely by human reason and science. This led him to view history as a succession of tyrannies repeatedly challenged by the will to freedom. The upper-class reaction against revolution in the England of his day was only the latest example. He saw it as the task of philosophy and poetry to reawaken the spirit of liberty in his own times.

To this end, the unwritten second part of his Defence was to have demonstrated that 'we live among such philosophers and poets as surpass beyond comparison any who have appeared since the last national struggle for civil and religious liberty'. There was in his time, he wrote, 'an accumulation of the power of communicating and receiving intense and impassioned conceptions respecting man and nature'. For this reason, anyone who read the best poets of the day must be 'startled with the electric life which burns within their words. They measure the circumference and sound the depths of human nature with a comprehensive and all-penetrating spirit.' Like all poets before them, they were 'the hierophants of an unapprehended inspiration; the mirrors of the gigantic shadows which futurity casts upon the present'. It was this which made them 'the unacknowledged legislators of the world'.²⁷

Where in *The Woodlanders*, it may be asked, does Hardy find Shelleyan inspiration in the signs of nature? Once again, the clue must be sought not in authorial statement, but in metaphor. Just as in *Far from the Madding Crowd* we found Hardy using the metaphor of the hill to suggest the decline and fall of Victorian civilisation, so we find him using another metaphor in *The Woodlanders* to suggest the possibility of renewal by natural energy: 'She looked towards the western sky, which was now aglow like some vast foundry wherein new worlds were being cast' (62).

This metaphor does not stand alone. Again and again in *The Woodlanders*, Hardy stresses the regenerative powers of nature as well as its degeneration. Marty (the 'she' of the passage just quoted) reads the signs pessimistically: "'The weather is almost all they [the pheasants] have to think of, isn't it, Mr. Winterbourne. And so they must be lighter-hearted than we'" (63).

Such an inference, however, is not unavoidable, as Giles has earlier pointed out to Marty, when she comments pessimistically on the breeze sighing in the trees:

‘It seems to me,’ the girl continued, ‘as if they sigh because they are very sorry to begin life in earnest – just as we be.’
 ‘Just as we be?’ He looked critically at her. ‘You ought not to feel like that, Marty.’ (61)

It may be thought that I am here falling into the trap that Mill warned against, deriving ‘ought’ from ‘is’. That is not, however, what I am doing. I wish to suggest that Hardy finds in non-human nature a source of hope as well as discouragement concerning human history. No law of moral progress can be derived from material facts, such as the rotation of the earth, the roll of the seasons, the ebb and flow of the tides. But they may inspire a hope in the possibility of meliorism. The inspiration may prove fruitful or futile, but its potential can be assessed by reference to the data, which is the task of science.

As *Life and Work* shows, Hardy believed that the Romantic poets had seen it as the task of poetry to arouse in the reader hope of a future *ricorso* of civilisation. Victorian poets who came after them had too often fallen, as Hardy thought, into an easy optimism, derived either from Christianity or from transcendental idealism. The task of the modern poet–novelist, however, was to return to the true spirit of the Romantics. As he put it in a note of 1880: ‘Romanticism will exist in Human nature as long as human nature itself exists. The point is (in imaginative literature) to adopt that form of romanticism which is the mood of the age’ (151).

In his next two novels Hardy pressed this revitalisation so far that he seemed to reach the limit allowed by the apparatus of Victorian publishing. In doing so, he had to challenge Comte’s rationalist philosophy of history, which subordinated human emotion to mind. It is to this challenge and its inscription in the last two tragic novels that we turn in the next chapter of this study.

NOTES

1. Thomas Hardy, *The Mayor of Casterbridge*: World’s Classics, intr. P. Dalziel (Oxford, 2004); Thomas Hardy, *The Woodlanders*: Oxford World’s Classics, ed. P. Boumelha (Oxford, 2005).

2. Brown, *Thomas Hardy* (London, 1954, 2nd edn. 1961), p. 42. See also L. Lerner, *Thomas Hardy, The Mayor of Casterbridge: Tragedy or Social History* (London, 1975), pp. 73–99, which introduces the concept of ‘Gemeinschaft’ as a way of understanding Casterbridge.
3. I first discussed this suggestion in ‘Thomas Hardy and Humanism’, *The Thomas Hardy Year Book*, 27, eds, G. Stevens Cox and E. Howitt (Castel, Guernsey, 1998), pp. 26–39, esp. 33ff.
4. See W. Greenslade, *Degeneration: Culture and the Novel, 1880–1940* (Cambridge, 1994), pp. 55–7, for a perceptive explication of Hardy’s classification of the inhabitants.
5. Greenslade, *Degeneration*, pp. 47–64. See also P. Dalziel, ‘Introduction’ to *The Mayor of Casterbridge* (Oxford, 2004), pp. XIII–XXXIV. p. 3.
6. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, pp. 10–14.
7. This point is well made in Gregor, *Great Web*, p. 33.
8. H. White, *Metahistory*, esp. ‘Introduction’, pp. 1–42.
9. F. Reid, ‘Wayfarers and seafarers: ideas of history in *The Mayor of Casterbridge*’, *Thomas Hardy Journal*, 13, 3, 1997, pp. 47–57.
10. For Hardy’s notes on a review of Rogers, see W. Greenslade (ed.), *Thomas Hardy’s ‘Facts’ Notebook* (Aldershot, 2004), p. 3. For Rogers, see A. Kadish and K. Tribe (eds), *The Market for Political Economy: The Advent of Economics in British University Culture, 1850–1905* (London, 1993).
11. M. Millgate, *Thomas Hardy: His Career as a Novelist* (London, 1971), pp. 259f. Gregor, *Great Webb*, pp. 163ff.
12. Like John Goode, I find it helpful to think of the action of this novel in ‘movements’. However, I discern four where he finds only three. In my reading, the first movement is the same as his, the first 15 chapters, in which the plan to marry Grace to Winterbourne is defeated. My second movement, Chapters 16 to 24, deals with the giving of Grace in marriage to Fitzpiers. Chapters 25 to 36 follow, dealing with the problems and breakup of the marriage. Chapter 37 to 48 form a finale in which the marriage is problematically restored. See Goode, *Offensive Truth*, p. 98.
13. For the textual emendation between serial and volume publication, see Wright, *Hardy and the Erotic*, p. 80. Cp. D. Kramer, *Approaches*, pp. 100ff.
14. Drysdale, *Elements of Social Science*, p. 205.
15. Mill, *On Liberty*, p. 68.
16. Quoted in K. Summerscale, *Mrs. Robinson’s Disgrace: The Private Diary of a Victorian Lady* (London, 2012), p. 182.
17. Summerscale, *Mrs. Robinson*, pp. 185–7.
18. Millgate (ed.), *Life and Work*, p. 43.
19. Millgate, *Career*, p. 251.
20. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, p. 94.

21. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, p. 108.
22. Mill, *On Liberty*, p. 66.
23. Mill, *On Liberty*, p. 69.
24. Mill, *On Liberty*, pp. 66, 67.
25. E. Neill, *The Secret Life of Thomas Hardy: Retaliatory Fiction* (Aldershot, 2004), pp. 82–91.
26. P. B. Shelley, 'A Defence of Poetry', repr. H. Adams (ed.), *Critical Theory since Plato* (London, 1971), p. 513.
27. Shelley, 'Defence of Poetry', p. 513.

Stopping Wedding Guests

In *Life and Work* Hardy reproduced the following entry from his notebook, dated 12 February 1893:

A story must be exceptional enough to justify its telling. We tale-tellers are all Ancient Mariners, and none of us is warranted in stopping wedding guests (in other words, the hurrying public) unless he has something more unusual to relate than the ordinary experience of every average man and woman. (893)

In this chapter, then, I attempt to show what Hardy thought he had to tell wedding guests in his last two tragic novels.

17.1 FICTION AND THE READING PUBLIC

Shelley apart, the leading English Romantic poets tended to despise prose fiction. Coleridge, in his *Biographia Literaria*, dismissed it as an unphilosophical form of writing, mechanically produced in the age of printing for mass consumption by a spiritually barren reading public.¹ He offered, as a basis for ‘philosophical criticism’, the German Romantic philosophy of history. According to this idea, the literature of all great nations since the ancient Greeks had passed through a cycle of development, beginning with epic poetry and advancing to tragic drama. The Greeks had Homer and Sophocles, the modern Germanic nations had the Nordic myths and Shakespeare. Under the influence of German transcendental philosophy,

Coleridge further contended, modern literature had gone higher, to develop lyric poetry, represented outstandingly in England by Wordsworth. The lyric poet was vital to the regeneration of Christianity because he examined the growth of the human mind towards a transcendental view of the human relationship to nature and its author, God.

Hardy produced three essays on fiction around 1890: 'The Profitable Reading of Fiction' (TPRF) in 1888, 'Candour in English Fiction' (CIEF) in 1890 and 'The Science of Fiction' (TSOF) in 1891.² From the outset they display an understanding of the Romantic history of literature, as is to be expected in one well acquainted with Horace Moule and the Liberal Anglican historians, who regarded Coleridge and Wordsworth as oracles of wisdom. Hardy, however, introduced from the beginning a major qualification of the Coleridgean idea. He defended the novel as capable of reaching the highest goals of art as understood by the Romantics. He allowed that the bulk of novels were produced mechanically for mass consumption. They were taken by many readers as a kind of 'tonic' (TPRF, 76) to restore a mind over-strained by business cares. When serious people of 'undulled spirits' spoke of gaining 'profit' from fiction, however, they meant 'intellectual or moral profit'; some limited themselves to collecting 'didactic reflections', bits of 'useful knowledge' or 'specimens of the manners of good or bad society', in which the best novels abounded (77). But this, for Hardy, was an illegitimate pretence at scholarship. Such ingredients could be found elsewhere 'in more convenient parcels' (78).

Our true object in seeking profit from reading fiction should be, Hardy went on, 'a lesson in life'. The serious novelist, like the serious poet, construed existence, as Coleridge had claimed, by the special mental faculty of 'imagination'. This was, for Hardy, the crucial respect in which the novel could be read more profitably than prose works of 'logical reasoning', because many people of 'ordinary intelligence' could apply imagination or intuition to life as represented in a work of fiction, whereas logical analysis required specialist training (78).

'Good fiction', Hardy continued, shared the qualities of the epic, the drama and narrative forms of the past. In all ages, the aims of great literature in representing life were the same: 'The higher passions must ever rank above the inferior – intellectual tendencies above animal, and moral above intellectual' (78f).

This language was, of course, quite compatible with the morality of orthodox Christianity and Positivism. Their followers held that art should

show the subjugation of the flesh by the spirit, the passions by the soul. Hardy, however, went on to complicate such responses by inverting the common sense of the passage. He averred, in language which stands much closer to Hume, Bagehot, Drysdale and Mill, that art works by ‘an appeal to the emotional reason rather than to the logical reason; for by their emotions men are acted upon, and act upon others’ (79). The novel should, therefore, open up the meaning of existence to scrutiny by the latest scientific knowledge of nature, human and non-human.

If very few novels had done this, that was because, Hardy wrote, ‘the art of writing them is as yet in its youth, if not in its infancy. Narrative art is neither mature in its artistic aspect, nor in its ethical or philosophical aspect; neither in form nor in substance’ (80).

In ‘Candour in English Fiction’ Hardy pointed to a tendency he discerned in contemporary literature. This was its development of a tragic view of life, ‘setting forth that “collision between the individual and the general” – formerly worked out with such force by the Periclean and Elizabethan dramatists’ (96). This claim went beyond Coleridge and the Romantics to assert the potentiality of the novel. The ‘periodicity which marks the course of taste in civilised countries’ was not, in Hardy’s view, ‘a true cycle of repetition, but what Comte, in speaking of general progress, happily characterises as “a looped orbit” not a movement of revolution but – to use the current word – evolution’ (96f).

Hardy went on to clarify this apparent endorsement of Comte: ‘In perceiving that taste is arriving anew at the point of high tragedy’, he wrote:

writers are conscious that its revived presentation demands enrichment by further truths – in other words, original treatment: treatment which seeks to show Nature’s unconsciousness not of essential laws, but of those laws merely as social expedients by humanity, without a basis in the heart of things; treatment which expresses the triumph of the crowd over the hero, of the commonplace majority over the exceptional few. (97)

This passage, I suggest, makes it impermissible to argue that Hardy’s ‘meliorism’ was a notion developed only after his novel-writing career came to an end. He saw the tragic novelist as engaged in an evolutionary process of raising the consciousness of novel readers, so that they could distinguish between social law or expedients not grounded in the necessity of things, and the ineluctable laws of nature to which they had to submit.

Readers, Hardy claimed, were ‘starving’ for this kind of literature, ‘a literature that honestly portrays life’ (97). Such a literature would inevitably expose the falsity of the Victorian sexual code:

Life being a physiological fact, its honest portrayal must be largely concerned with, for one thing, the relations of the sexes, and the substitution for such catastrophes as favour the false colouring by the regulation finish that ‘they married and were happy ever after’, of catastrophes based upon sexual relationship as it is. (97f)

To this kind of fiction, however, the English book trade posed almost insuperable barriers. Chief among these were the magazines that published novels in serial form and the circulating libraries (which loaned them for an annual membership fee). They had a virtual stranglehold on publication of anything that transgressed the sexual code of the middle class, because they were the cheapest sources through which it consumed fiction – far cheaper than purchase of the three-volume novels, which sold at one and a half guineas, half a week’s salary for the average office clerk.

Behind the book trade, moreover, stood middle-class parents, who insisted on “‘false views” for the reading of their young people’. As a result, the novel which ‘reveals life’ was not encouraged (98). More particularly, it was banned if, like Zola’s fiction, it rejected the orthodox representation of an anthropomorphic, jealous God and acknowledged that people did commit adultery.

We need not here pursue Hardy’s suggestions for amelioration of the book trade. Rather, we pass on to ‘The Science of Fiction’. In this essay Hardy returned to his defence of the Romantic claim that imagination or intuition was the peculiar creative faculty in the production of literature. This it was, he argued, which enabled the novelist to make the reader aware of the inner consciousness of a character, showing how it might be at cross-purposes with social law or conventional wisdom. This ‘illusion’ or ‘magic’ (108) had been the aim of poetry through the ages and should still be the aim of modern romanticism in fiction. In opposition to the older romanticism, modern romanticism would expose alike the hollowness of Christian belief in a providential plan and transcendental idealism aimed at reconciling human beings to non-human nature. It would thus make the reader feel what Hardy would call, in *Tess of the d’Urbervilles*, ‘the ache of modernism’ (129), the awareness that orthodox beliefs were out of kilter with most people’s experience.

Hardy knew that novels written in this way would bring down obloquy upon him, but he was determined to resist self-censorship. There would be no more pulling of punches, no more putting his satire in edgewise:

July 19th. 1883. In future I am not going to praise things because the accumulated remarks of ages say they are great and good, if those accumulated remarks are not based on observation. And I am not going to condemn things because a pile of accepted views raked together from tradition and acquired by installation, say antecedently that they are bad. (166)

And in pursuit of this plan he made a note to 'Write a list of things which everybody thinks and nobody says; and a list of things that everybody says and nobody thinks' (167).

Here Hardy was only reiterating the plan he had formulated as far back as 1870. At that time, however, his position as a young aspirant to the trade of fiction had required him to play a 'scientific game' with its masters. Now he felt sufficiently well established to take it on. In this his aim was, as he said in 'Candour in English Fiction', to produce 'a literature that honestly portrays life', and life, 'being a physiological fact, its honest portrayal must be largely concerned with . . . the relations of the sexes'.

This indeed was a good reason for stopping wedding guests. Hardy wanted to make them see the tragedy brought about by social law not grounded in the necessity of things. Therefore he intercepted them with the tragedies of Tess, Jude and Sue.

17.2 TESS OF THE D'URBERVILLES

Tess (1891) continues the representation of civilisation in a late-manhood stage of development. The Stoke-d'Urbervilles stand for the nineteenth-century plutocracy, formed by the fusion of landed and commercial wealth, which so horrified Thomas Arnold and the Liberal Anglican historians. Their country retreat, 'The Slopes', is characterised by its opulence and idleness. The decay of national religion is indicated in [Chapter 9](#), when Tess presents the birds to her employer. It is a purely secular ritual, but it makes Tess think of the Anglican ritual of 'Confirmation, in which Mrs d'Urberville was the bishop, the fowls the young people presented, and herself and the maidservant the parson and curate of the parish bringing them up' (61). In reality it is nothing more than the hobby-farming pastime of a wealthy woman, and Hardy asserts

his point about its spiritual vacuity by making the old lady blind and seating her 'with her back to the light' (61).

At the same time, the poultry farm represents the historical process of class alienation which has accompanied this spiritual degeneration. The old copyholders 'who now lay east and west in the churchyard' have been dispossessed to create it (60). In place of these independent village producers there has arisen a class of proletarians, 'smock-frocked arithmeticians' (65), dependent on parish relief and abuse of alcohol. Many of these are young women and the varying rates of their exploitation are documented with economic realism. This begins with Trantridge, where it is mainly in the background, goes on to the relatively lighter living-in dairy work at Talbothays, and ends with the much harsher field work at Flintcomb-Ash, where Tess and her companions work like slaves 'in the morning frosts and in the afternoon rains' (279).

The Liberal Anglican concern with imperialism is also evident in Hardy's *Poems of Pilgrimage*, where he had compared London to ancient Rome. It was a commonplace trope and the partly educated Tess is conscious of it in her confused reference to 'centurions' among the 'strange people...Who don't know anything of us, and of where it [their milk] comes from' (188).

Hardy, writing during the years of intense factional politics that prevailed after 1886, alludes also to that symptom of a late-manhood stage. These were the years when Lord Randolph Churchill promoted the Primrose League to drum up support for Tory Democracy among the new rural working-class voters. It was countered by socialist propaganda, spread into the countryside by the touring vans of the land nationalists and the bicycles of the Clarion socialists. Tess expresses the Liberal Anglican animus against political factions when she likens the murmuring of the water channels to the contentiousness of open-air meetings: "It seems like tens of thousands of 'em," said Tess; "holding public meetings in their market-places, arguing, preaching, quarrelling, sobbing, groaning, praying and cursing" (201).

Hardy uses the language of the Liberal Anglican historians to equate this decadent stage of civilisation to the return of barbarism under the empire of 'the "British Queen"' (44), the name for the breed of strawberry which Alec gives Tess at The Slopes. Alec is said to have 'touches of barbarism' (43) in his appearance on that occasion, and the subsequent expansion of his name to 'Alexander' links him to the barbarian conqueror from Macedonia, whose dynasty absorbed the city-states of ancient Greece

before he founded the Hellenic empire. And Hardy draws attention to the flux and reflux of empire when he refers to the sun copying 'the outline of Alexander, Caesar, and the Pharoahs' (111).

If the language of *Tess of the d'Urbervilles* is consonant with the Liberal Anglican idea of history, so is it with the ideas of George Drysdale and John Stuart Mill. We may begin to place *Tess* in the latter context by noting the Drysdale–Mill critique of Malthusianism. We saw in [Chapter 5](#) of this study how Drysdale reworked the economic theory of Malthus to make a radical case against the Victorian sexual code. Malthus prescribed that working-class people should avoid producing large families by late marriage and abstinence from sexual intercourse. Such a prescription, Drysdale argued, was contrary to nature. People – women as well as men – had to satisfy their sexual needs. In the absence of birth control, the natural result was early marriage and over-population, leading to poverty, prostitution and other evils.

In this vein, Hardy makes it clear that Joan Durbeyfield's large family is the result of the sexual attraction she first felt for her husband. She still feels it, if only when drinking with him at Rolliver's Inn: there she 'felt a little as she had used to feel when she sat by her now wedded husband in the same spot during his wooing, shutting her eyes to his defects of character, and regarding him only in his ideal presentation as lover' (27f).

This instinctive behaviour has been disastrous for their children. Seven survivors from nine births are too many to be reared successfully on the income of a weak man struggling with the precarious business of a small country tradesman-cum-farmer.

Tess, on the 'threshold of womanhood' (65), responds to the family predicament as a 'Malthusian' (40). In other words, she thinks that people should avoid early marriage and not bear children they cannot afford to keep. But Hardy, like Drysdale, understands that the sex instinct is so powerful that girls like Tess are at risk of unwanted pregnancies due to early sexual activity. Accordingly, he represents her seduction by Alec as the result not simply of her family's poverty, but also of the sexual desire Alec arouses in her at The Slopes. Tess herself admits to this after they break up: "My eyes were dazed by you for a little, and that was all" (82f).

Drysdale's concept of sexual passion as natural and compulsive is sustained throughout the Talbothays episode (Phases Second, Third and Fourth). Tess tries to deny her sexuality by leading a 'repressed life' (128). But she is compelled into acceptance of Angel because 'The "appetite for joy", which pervades all creation; that tremendous force which

sways humanity to its purpose, as the tide sways the helpless weed, was not to be controlled by vague lucubrations over the social rubric' (191).

Drysdale further attacked the social rubric for insisting that young people were induced to believe that anyone with whom they chanced to fall desperately in love was unique and must be possessed by marriage. Accordingly, he argued, they were plunged into jealousy and despair when they could not obtain 'full and sole possession' (180).

This view of love is experienced by the dairymaids at Talbothays. It is not only 'cruel nature's law' that causes them to sigh for love of Angel Clare (149). Their suffering is made worse by the belief that their sole hope of love lies in winning him as a husband. Retty Priddle's question in the following dialogue makes this startlingly clear:

'We can't all marry him,' said Izz.

...

'Why?' asked Retty quickly.

'Because he likes Tess Durbeyfield best,' said Marion. (140)

For a time this sense of what Drysdale called 'all or nothing' competition is rendered irrelevant by Izz Huett's dismissal of the very idea that any of them could marry Angel: "But how silly all this is" (140). Jealousy and despair are thus temporarily kept at bay by 'common sense', imparting to them 'a resignation, a dignity, which a practical and sordid expectation of winning him as a husband would have destroyed' (150). But matters take a Drysdalian turn on the wedding day, with Tess's innocent request that Angel kiss each of them farewell. The action arouses their intense sense of loss. Tess, looking back, sees that it has 'done harm by awakening feelings they were trying to subdue' (213). The intensity of the feelings is fully revealed later that day, when Jonathan Kail brings news to the married pair that "poor little Retty Priddle hev tried to drown herself." And Marion has been "found dead drunk" (218).

Again, as in earlier novels, Hardy, like Drysdale, satirises the inculcation of romantic love by poetry. Thus one version of pastoral leads Angel to idealise Tess as 'a fresh and virginal daughter of Nature' (124). Angel in turn interpolates Tess into the poetic ideal so that, by her wedding day, 'She was a sort of celestial person, who owed her being to poetry; one of those classical divinities Clare was accustomed to talk to her about when they took their walks together' (211).

Hardy, then, like Drysdale, represents sexual relations as competition for love and subsistence. In keeping with the new imperialism, he goes further, representing this competition as underlying the will to dynastic power. This is signified by appropriate metaphors in Chapter 30, where Angel finally overcomes Tess's resistance to marrying him. As they drive with the milk to the railway station, the summits of Egdon Heath appear 'like battlemented towers'; an old d'Urberville mansion reminds Clare of that family's 'fierce, domineering, feudal renown' (187). Imperialism was seen by the followers of Richard Cobden as a hangover from the dynasticism of feudal society. Tess reveals that her own family history is bound up with its struggles, which saddens her, knowing that "many of the hills and fields I see once belonged to my father's people. But other hills and fields belonged to Retty's people, and perhaps others to Marian's, so that I don't value it particularly" (189).

Summing up so far, it is impossible to exaggerate the Drysdalian character of this novel's attack on the Victorian sexual code. Sexual attraction is dismissed as a universal basis for lifelong monogamy: 'Nature does not often say "See!" to her poor creature at a time when seeing can lead to happy doing; or reply "Here" to a body's cry of "Where?" till the hide-and-seek has become an irksome, outworn game.' Nor can Hardy see any possibility of reconstructing it in accordance with some alternative ideology, such as Comte's:

We may wonder whether, at the acme and summit of the human progress, these anachronisms will be corrected by a finer intuition, a closer interaction of the social machinery than that which now jolts us round and along; but such completeness is not to be prophesied, or even conceived as possible. (46).

It would be wrong, however, to read this authorial statement as a negation of all legal intervention in sexual relationships. The novel can be read as offering a 'lesson in life', drawn from the Drysdale–Mill debate, which points optimistically to the recuperation of modern civilisation. In support of such a reading, we may begin by noting that it offers a much more revolutionary ideal of marriage than was to be found in *Far from the Madding Crowd*. This may be seen from a close examination of Chapter 25. It opens with Angel considering what the consequence should be of his impulsive declaration of his love to Tess. He had not anticipated that a temporary apprenticeship to the dairying business would

change his views of life so fundamentally. Yet, by throwing him into daily labour alongside working women, it has done just that, and he was now responsible for the happiness of a milkmaid. As a 'man with a conscience', he could never think to 'toy' with her love and baulk at taking the next step demanded by his culture, an offer of marriage (158). From a practical point of view this step has much to recommend it. A farmer needs a wife, and a woman who understood farming would be far better than 'a drawing-room wax-figure' (159). Yet, pleasing as this answer is so far as it goes, it fails to silence all his qualms. The question uppermost in his mind as he rides homewards to consult his relations is whether such a marriage will last. Will it withstand their disapproval? What will he himself think about it in a couple of years' time? 'That would depend upon whether the germ of staunch comradeship underlay the temporary emotion, or whether it were a sensuous joy in her form only, with no substratum of everlastingness' (159f).

Like the narrator in *Far from the Madding Crowd*, Angel thinks that 'comradeship' – 'camaraderie' – between a man and a woman will last when it is 'superadded to love between the sexes', and comradeship is best promoted by their common labour. But the narrator in the later novel differs both from Angel and from the earlier authorial statement. In the earlier passage, 'camaraderie' is said to be 'the only love which is strong as death';³ in other words, a basis for lifelong monogamy. Here the narrator withholds such endorsement. Even camaraderie should be regarded as provisional – vulnerable, as Drysdale asserted, to mutability. As Hardy now puts it, 'the great passionate pulse of existence' should be 'unwarped, uncontorted, untrammelled by those creeds which futilely attempt to check what wisdom would be content to regulate' (161). The word 'regulate' is significant. It suggests that Hardy is positioning himself at the Mill rather than the Drysdale end of the discourse on marriage. Drysdale was uncompromising in his vehement opposition to marriage law. Mill was much more cautious. He approved freer divorce as the only way to protect women against tyrannical husbands. But he showed awareness of the rights of children and others in his refusal to go all the way to the abolition of legal marriage. Hardy would take this issue further in *Jude the Obscure*.

If, in *Tess of the d'Urbervilles*, he refrained from detailed consideration of marital law reform, Hardy was not coy about echoing Mill's view that such recuperation required individuals of character to transgress the cramping restrictions of outmoded social law. Once again, his language

recalls Mill's metaphor of silviculture. Thus, in Chapter 28, we again meet the tree contorted out of its natural shape. Tess is struggling with her conscientious belief that agreeing to marry Angel will cause him injury when he discovers her past. She retreats into a thicket of pollard willows, 'tortured out of their natural shape by incessant choppings' (179).

In keeping with Mill's essay *On Liberty*, Tess is a heroine of modern tragedy precisely because she is willing to transgress against such cramping restrictions. This begins when she refuses to remain with Alec as his kept mistress after conceiving his child. It is shown again by her rejection of the church when the vicar refuses to bury Sorrow in consecrated ground. Less consciously, Tess resists marriage to Angel, seemingly preferring 'perpetual betrothal' (200), and she consents with the mental reservation that he might divorce her if he finds the thought of her past intolerable. As each of these positive aspirations is negated in the course of the novel, Tess comes to understand the 'injustice' of men and the social law that upholds their prerogatives. The realisation of what this means – 'Once victim, always victim: that's the law' (320) – at length arouses rage and rebellion, leading first to the assault on Alec with her warrior's glove, and then to her murdering him.

Famously, Hardy signalled his sympathy with Tess's conduct. His novel defies the conventional Victorian condemnation of the 'prostitute', and protests at her execution for a homicide arising from rage at an intolerable situation. Most recent critics have accounted for this by reference to his emotional commitment to Tess. This, they hold, explains not only the quotation marks around 'justice' in the final paragraph of the novel, but also Hardy's late decision to pen the title page for the volume edition published in 1891: 'Tess of the d'Urbervilles a pure woman. Faithfully presented by Thomas Hardy... "Poor wounded name! My Bosom as a Bed shall lodge thee."'

The strength of Hardy's emotional commitment to Tess is undeniable, but historical enquiry once again suggests that there was a concomitant political motive behind his choice of title. The novel appeared as the 'social purity' campaign was gathering force in the late 1880s and early 1890s. This grew out of W. T. Stead's investigative report of 1885 on child prostitution, published in his newspaper the *Pall Mall Gazette* under the headline 'The Maiden Tribute of Modern Babylon'. The Christian churches rallied round Stead in a successful campaign to raise the age of consent to sexual intercourse from 15 to 16. They followed up this victory with a campaign for social purity, by which they meant the enforcement of

'chastity' on all men and women. Their propaganda targeted the poor mainly, though not exclusively. The techniques included open-air preaching and emblazoning buildings with biblical texts against fornication and adultery.⁴ Both activities find a place in *Tess of the d'Urbervilles* – the man with the paint pot and brush and the converted nihilist, Alec d'Urberville, preaching repentance to the agricultural labourers.

The message of the social purity campaigners, then, has been seen as founded on a purely negative view of sexuality, which held it to be a nasty appetite to be curbed at all costs.⁵ Nothing could be further from Drysdale's teaching: 'Nature lays one command on us, "Exercise all thy functions, else art thou an imperfect and sinful being".' Far from condemning prostitutes, Drysdale defended them as martyrs to the Victorian sexual code, condemned and punished by its laws and customs for nothing more than making sexual intercourse available in a repressive society. 'Long, long will it be', he wrote, as if addressing an ideal reader, 'before society receive you to her bosom.'⁶

Drysdale employed this metaphor of the 'bosom' of society no fewer than five times in the second part of his *Elements*. Hardy may have had these pages in mind when he felt the need for an epigraph on his title page. Happily, he recalled that Shakespeare had resorted to the same metaphor.⁷

The closing pages of *Tess* (383f) are replete with other metaphors lingering from Hardy's preoccupations of the 1860s: the Liberal Anglican substratum, Drysdale's 'sexual religion' and Mill's view of 'character'. Thus the cyclical progress of history is represented by Angel and Liza-Lu ascending the hill, away from a location representing the nadir of the late-manhood stage of civilisation. This location is the state prison, a piece of modern architectural 'formalism', contrasted with the 'quaint irregularities' in the architecture of the early-manhood stage, when the local community was thought to be more self-regulating. The former, moreover, kills the body; the latter, represented by the 'hospis', still provides defence for the body – the pilgrim's 'dole of bread and ale'.

The writing is strongly marked by Judeo-Christian symbols – the painting of 'the Two Apostles', Angel and Liza-Lu 'the two speechless gazers' bent in prayer. In keeping with their upward movement, however, it is a radically reformed religion whose symbol they worship: loving-kindness with due regard to nature and nature's daughter, Tess. Walking 'hand in hand', they obey her teaching to transgress the law, civil and divine, against marriage of a man to his deceased wife's sister.

Yet due regard is not absolute submission. Regard for nature must be evaluated by reason. This is the significance of Liza-Lu. She is a 'budding creature', 'a spiritualised image of Tess'. 'Spiritualised' here eschews both a Pauline and a Comtean meaning. Liza-Lu represents neither, but rather the religion of humanity as understood by Mill. This means that the ending undermines the 'fulfilment' of Comte's 'seventh phase' of humanity's development by allowing for the flesh as well as the spirit. The sexual drive, as Mill argued, is compulsive and must have its place in a looser form of the marriage law. But reform of the marriage law must be tested by reasoning on teleology. The new religion, that is to say, should be the product of mind or 'spirit' (French *esprit*), reasoning on values and discarding outmoded prescription 'without a basis in the heart of things'. It cannot be justified by scientific appeals to the law of nature, since 'ought' can never be derived from 'is'. In this sense, these figures in a landscape represent the *ricorso* of civilisation. Rising, they join hands and go on. However, the text offers no vision of rest in Comte's 'normal state' or Bunyan's city on the hill. The pilgrimage of man and woman simply goes on, over the rolling downs of Wessex – 'landscape beyond landscape, till the horizon was lost in the radiance of the sun hanging above it'.

In his next novel Hardy will explore what it meant to try to live out the new values in a late-manhood stage of civilisation.

17.3 JUDE THE OBSCURE

In the opening chapter of the first edition of *Jude the Obscure* (1895),⁸ the Romantic idea of history advanced by the Liberal Anglican historians is represented in language by now very familiar to readers of this study. The situation of Marygreen in an 'undulating' landscape suggests the cyclical concept of history. The hamlet signifies decline from an organic community to a condition marked by the features of a late-manhood stage of civilisation: 'thatched and dormered dwelling-houses', 'many trees...on the green' pulled down to make way for the modern (6). The decline of religion is indicated by reference to the destruction of the village church and the use of its materials for 'road metal...pig-sty walls, garden seats...and rockeries' (6f). The 'German-Gothic' of its successor is alien to the Anglican tradition and utilitarian in execution, with 'ninepenny cast-iron crosses' used to commemorate the dead. All this obliteration is the effect of the uniformity imposed

by a metropolitan culture, one of whose practitioners had, like young Thomas Hardy himself, ‘run down from London and back’ for the purpose (7).

Familiar also is the association of modern commerce with this obliteration. Railways allow such independent rural tradesmen as Jude Fawley to migrate to large towns like Christminster and Alfredston. They demote local ‘fairs and markets’ which, linked by the ancient drove road down to recent times, are giving way to a centralised regional event, the great Wessex agricultural show (363). Much agriculture has been concentrated in large-scale units like the ‘vast’ cornfield of Farmer Troutham. Hardy’s reading in the new discourse of anthropology, moreover, enables him to evaluate the change more specifically as a loss of local culture. A ‘meanly utilitarian’ development has deprived the locality ‘of all history’. Most of the independent producers have vanished and few but the narrator know that ‘in every clod and stone there really lingered associations enough and to spare – echoes of songs from ancient harvest-days, of spoken words, and of sturdy deeds’ (10).

At first sight, the absence of any reference to imperialism and war may seem a striking difference between *Jude* and the three tragic novels already discussed. Yet this is an illusion which would not necessarily have deceived Hardy’s readers, familiar as many were with the source of the epigraph to the first chapter: ‘Yea, many there be that have run out of their wits for women, and become servants for their sakes. Many also have perished, have erred, and sinned, for women . . . O ye men, how can it be but women should be strong, seeing they do thus.’

Read in isolation from its context,⁹ this epigraph seems to be confined to the issue of gender in *Jude*. Reference to the *Apocryphal Book of Esdras*, however, discloses its concern with empire. [Chapters 13](#) and [14](#) tell of a debate held before Darius, ruler of the ancient Persian empire. Three of his advisers dispute the strongest influence over men. The first declares it to be alcohol; the second, military force; and the third, the prophetic Zorobabel, women. The latter’s argument is no crass misogyny and deserves close attention here. He holds that the power of women is often seen to rest upon their sensual appeal. But it has lasting power only as ‘truth’, which he goes on to represent as feminine wisdom:

[39] With her there is no accepting of persons or rewards; but she doeth the things that are just, and refraineth from all unjust and wicked things; and all men do well like of her works.

[40] Neither in her judgment is any unrighteousness; and she is the strength, kingdom, power, and majesty, of all ages. Blessed be the God of truth.¹⁰

Zorobabel advises Darius to reconstruct the temple at Jerusalem in accordance with this feminine wisdom. As this chapter will show, the bearing of feminine wisdom on the late Victorian age of imperialism is a question that is threaded right through *Jude the Obscure*.

For the Liberal Anglican historians, the English institution analogous to the Jerusalem temple was, of course, Oxford University, represented by the fictional Christminster. Young Jude thinks of it as ‘The heavenly Jerusalem’ (18), the ‘headquarters’ (5), as Phillotson calls it, of English culture. The older Jude, newly arrived in Christminster, still sees it in this light. He forms the ambition to join in the labour of its restoration, first as a stone-mason, working on the material restoration of its colleges, and, after long private study, as a scholar engaged on its spiritual renovation. How he sees the latter is indicated by the list of ‘worthies’ he reviews on first entering the city (94). This list is not ‘meaningless’¹¹ when viewed in the Liberal Anglican perspective. Rather, it amplifies the brief list in Horace Moule’s 1858 lecture on the history of Oxford University. It includes most of the men whom the Oxford Noetics saw as heroes in the ‘growth of the human mind’,¹² from the Renaissance through the Enlightenment to the modern innovators in political economy, geology, philology, natural theology and literature.

It does not detract from this Liberal Anglican view of the worthies that Jude himself leans towards the Tractarians. They were also admired by Broad Churchmen, including Horace Moule, who gave them an honoured place in his vision of a comprehensive church.

More significantly for the interpretation of *Jude* that I am developing here, the worthies are all men and represent the masculine wisdom which upholds the theology underpinning the Victorian sexual code. Central to that code, as George Drysdale argued, was the prescription that lifelong monogamy was the only permissible fulfilment for sexual desire. Drysdale countered, as we have seen, that young people like Jude and Arabella became entangled in it after coupling ‘in commonplace obedience to conjunctive orders from headquarters’ (43). As a technically married man, moreover, Jude conforms to the code by rejecting the idea of loving Sue, even though it has already been questioned by feminine wisdom in Part First. Jude’s aunt Drusilla¹³ gives voice to it with the Drysdalian view,

derived from the history of the Fawleys, that marriage does not suit everyone. As she tells Jude: 'The Fawleys were not made for wedlock: it never seemed to sit well upon us. There's sommat in our blood that won't take kindly to the notion of being bound to do what we do readily enough if not bound' (82).

Jude's exploration of ancient classical literature has also called the code into question. His reading of Horace's poem 'Carmen Saeculare' 'introduces him to the opposition between feminine and masculine wisdom' (35). Journeying home at dusk, he observes the sun (in pagan mythology, a masculine deity) setting, and the moon (a feminine deity) rising. Kneeling down with the text in hand, he murmurs a line from the poem in praise of the goddess. For the time being, however, Christminster wins out over pagan religion. Jude ignores the suggestion of a rising female influence to concentrate on the Greek New Testament and the Church Fathers.

Jude's experiences at Christminster bring about a partial break with Christian ideology and the masculine interest it upholds. By the end of Part Second, he is plunged into despair by a twofold failure: his rejection by Bibliol College and his failure in love, represented by the marriage of Sue Bridehead to Richard Phillotson. The break is partial, because it affects his professional but not his amatory ideal. As regards the former, he comes to think that his aspiration to pursue an ecclesiastical career had degenerated into 'nothing more than a mundane ambition masquerading in a surplice'. Like John Stuart Mill, he believes that such ambition is a product of a commercial civilisation, characterised by the spirit of 'social unrest', having 'no foundation in the nobler instincts'. His conversation with the curate at Marygreen offers him the vision of an alternative role in the church, more 'altruistic' than 'emulative'. He aspires to become 'the humble curate wearing his life out in an obscure village or city slum' (157).

Yet if Jude's view of an appropriate role in the church has changed, in the matter of love he is still a prisoner of Malthusianism. This taught men to see life as a race for love and economic success. Winners won both as the prize for pre-marital abstinence and commitment to lifelong monogamy. Jude believes that he has failed in this test of a man. He becomes depressed and Hardy's reflection on his anguish both recalls the 'leafy Laocoons' and reveals his bondage to the ideology:

If he had been a woman he must have screamed under the nervous tension which he was now undergoing. But that relief being denied to his virility he

clenched his teeth in misery, bringing lines about his mouth like those in the Laocoon, and corrugations between his brows. (153)

The Victorian sexual code, to which Malthusianism is, in Drysdale's view, fundamental, is also responsible for Sue's marriage to Phillotson at the end of Part Third. It is institutionalised at the Melchester training college and in Phillotson's quasi-patriarchal influence over Sue, which arises from their relationship as master and apprentice. Like similarly situated Hardy ingénues Elfride and Grace, Sue rushes thoughtlessly towards wedlock and quickly repents her haste:

Before I married him I had never thought out fully what marriage meant, even though I knew. It was idiotic of me – there is no excuse. I was old enough, and I thought I was very experienced. So I rushed on, when I had got into that training school scrape, with all the cocksureness of the fool that I was! (270)

In language which recalls the Liberal Anglican idea of history as cyclical and the late-manhood stage as a return to barbarism, she chafes against the marital code: 'When people of a later age look back upon the barbarous customs and superstitions of the times that we have the unhappiness to live in, what will they say!' (270).

Sue's eyes are opened by feminine wisdom, again provided by Aunt Drusilla, who tells her that marriage without sexual compatibility is impossible for most people and certainly for Sue, who is compelled to acknowledge that 'what she says is – is true!' (238). Meanwhile, mutual attraction grows between her and Jude, and finally delivers its order from headquarters. They kiss 'most unpremeditatedly'. For Jude, this is the moment of decisive break with the Christian ideology of love. He reflects that his 'unlicensed tenderness' for Sue is incompatible with his ecclesiastical ambition. Expressing this thought in free indirect speech, Hardy employs an appropriate masculine metaphor for the Christian in the war of the spirit and the flesh. He is a 'soldier' in 'a religion in which sexual love was regarded as at its best a frailty, and at its worst damnation' (272).

In Parts Four and Five, Jude and Sue transgress the code and begin to work out the ideal of love: friendship achieved through common labour, superadded to love between the sexes. Jude is brought to an understanding of this species of feminine wisdom by Sue. Before this can happen, however, she has to make her own journey from the ideal of sexless union.

Her education begins in her young adult relationship with the Christminster undergraduate who became ‘a leader-writer for one of the great London dailies’. This reference to the higher journalism recalls Henry Knight and his ‘philosophical’ – that is, Comtean – view of love. Sue, however, makes it clear that she herself embraced it. She insisted on a sexless intellectual partnership and they ‘shared a sitting-room for fifteen months’ (183).

This and other passages taken out of context gave rise to a critical tradition (as exemplified by D. H. Lawrence¹⁴) that Sue was ‘sexless’. Feminist and revolutionary criticism, however, has demonstrated the masculine bias of that interpretation. At many points in the novel, not least in the conversation I am here considering, Sue denies the claim: “People say I must be cold-natured, – sexless. . . . But I won’t have it!” (184).

Sue’s problem here is not frigidity but lack of any practical experience of love. She has not, like Jude and Arabella, yet felt its compelling force. She learns through agonised wrestling with ‘logic’ (274) that true friendship for a man she respects intellectually and morally is for her an insufficient basis for marriage. Since, moreover, she is already in love with Jude, she believes that she and Phillotson are committing ‘adultery’ and proposes to ‘cancel’ their contract, ‘not legally . . . but . . . morally’, so that they may remain friends (279).

At this point Sue lacks the ‘courage’ to spell out to Phillotson what kind of relationship she wishes to establish with Jude (280). On the train journey to Aldbrickham, moreover, it becomes clear that her mind is still unsettled as to the balance of friendship and sexual love that she wishes. She has discarded her Comtean notions and Jude’s kisses are not unwelcome. But she is not willing to be taken for granted and rushed into an arrangement in which Jude assumes the prerogative of a husband. Free union may be very well in theory; its practice requires cautious working out, as she makes clear: “My liking for you is not as some women’s perhaps. But it is a delight in being with you, of a supremely delicate kind, and I don’t want to go further and risk it by – an attempt to intensify it!” Understandably, Jude wonders if she means to treat him like ‘the poor Christminster graduate’ (301) and fears ‘such a torturing destiny’ (302) but, loving her above everything, he puts altruism above selfishness and accedes to her wishes.

It becomes clear, however, that such an arrangement cannot be stable. Sue and Jude discover the truth of Drysdale’s observation that love, even the highest, can be mutable. Arabella’s reappearances, therefore, seem

threatening. They drive Sue to fits of distracted jealousy, demanding her imagined rival's exclusion as vehemently as any lawful wife. On the first such occasion, thinking she has seen off Arabella, Sue flatters herself that Jude's love for her is truly Platonic, like that she finds in Shelley's 'Epipsychidion' (306). But in Part Fifth she will learn, with Marcus Aurelius (the ancient philosopher so greatly admired by the sexually ambivalent Horace Moule), that her 'aerial part' is mingled with her 'fiery parts' and is naturally 'overpowered...in the compound mass of the body'.¹⁵

For a little longer, Sue clings to her ideal of a Platonic union: 'It is so much sweeter – for the woman at least, and when she is sure of the man' (249). But the next appearance of Arabella reveals just how unsure of Jude she can be. Her jealousy revives on Arabella's second appearance (253), and her principles collapse into undignified pleading: 'Please, please stay at home, Jude, and not go to her, now she's not your wife any more than I!' (254). Jude counters with the equally undignified riposte that she is rather more wife to him than Sue herself.

I have lingered over this episode because it has been interpreted as Jude consciously pressurising Sue to sleep with him. In context, it seems rather that each is claiming the prerogative of a legal spouse, which is ironic, given their anti-marriage views. Their recriminations reach their nadir when Sue discovers that Jude has failed to meet Arabella, but still wishes to do so. She renews her 'jealous burst of disappointment' (326). Jude's repeated denials that Arabella might still be attractive for him are unconvincing to Sue, who remembers his recent confession of casual sex with his former wife.

In the teeth of sexual competition, Sue's resolve cracks and she at first experiences this as defeat:

'I ought to have known that you would conquer in the long run, living like this!'

She ran across and flung her arms round his neck. 'I am not a cold-natured, sexless creature, am I, for keeping you at such a distance? I am sure you don't think so! Wait and see! I do belong to you, don't I? I give in!'

'An I'll arrange for our marriage to-morrow – or as soon as ever you wish.' (334)

Rather than see this episode as a simple defeat, we should recognise it as a struggle for 'exorbitant profit', which is temporarily resolved during Part

Fifth as 'comradeship', a voluntary union based on common labour and sexual love. The happiness this brings to the pair is clear to see. Little Father Time notices the hallmark of friendship. When Sue asks him 'Do I look like your father's wife?' he replies, 'Well, yes; 'cept he seems fond of you, and you of him' (349). Again, at the Wessex Agricultural Show, amid many signs of the late-manhood crisis – the military band, the jealous gaze of Arabella, the policeman enforcing respectable conduct – the pair exhibit 'That complete mutual understanding, in which every glance and movement was as effectual as speech for conveying intelligence between them' (366). And Sue expresses her happiness and sense of freedom: 'I feel that we have returned to Greek joyousness, and have blinded ourselves to sickness and sorrow, and have forgotten what twenty-five centuries have taught the race since their time' (373).

Hardly are the words uttered than Sue and Jude are jolted out of their 'dreamy paradise' (342) by the impact of law, human and non-human. The human impacts first as what Mill called 'hostile and dreaded censorship'.¹⁶ Jude is forced out of his ecclesiastical stone-cutting business by the bigotry of church-goers. Impersonal law impacts as sickness, forcing him into unemployment and poverty. Economic law shuts the doors of Christchurch lodgings to homeless strangers with little children. The precocious Father Time, convinced that children are out of place in a disjointed world, hangs himself and his siblings from hooks in their bedroom. Sue, shattered by this calamity, retreats into the Victorian sexual code and the Christianity which upholds it. Convinced that they have been punished for transgression of the divine law, she forces herself to return to Phillotson's bed. Jude declines further into illness and despair. He dies, quoting from the biblical Book of Job: 'Let the day perish wherein I was born, and the night in which it was said, there is a man child conceived' (510).

What 'wisdom' could Hardy be trying to convey in this bleak representation? Many Victorian and post-Victorian readers saw in it nothing but pessimism and despair. Educated in the classical rules, they flatly rejected Hardy's version of tragedy. There was no noble protagonist, erring through human weakness, defeated by necessary law, whose fall could produce catharsis. On the contrary, the effect of *Jude* was merely depressing in its representation of life among the lowest classes and its reference to late nineteenth-century theories of degeneration.

Since the late twentieth century, academic commentary has defended Hardy from a number of critical perspectives. In 1971, Michael Millgate

suggested that the sufferings of Jude and Sue had caused difficulty for readers and critics, even perhaps turning them against all of Hardy's fiction. He went on to insist that the dark ending must be balanced by attention to lighter episodes, and saw Hardy as experimenting, as in his other recent fiction, with a mixed form, appropriate to the uncertainty of modern times. The incoherence, in other words, was intended to reflect the intellectual and social chaos of the age.¹⁷

In 1975, Dale Kramer, writing from a Neo-Aristotelian perspective, defended *Jude* as a modern tragedy, which reconciled, to his satisfaction, Aristotle's ideal with the Social Darwinist view of nature. From this point of view, the high aims of Jude and Sue were bound to be defeated, since they challenged a universal necessity of human existence. Their sufferings involved, Kramer believed, no injustice, because they challenged the mysterious forces that shape the conditions of life in Hardy's universe.¹⁸

As we saw in the introduction to this study, feminist and Marxist critics of the later twentieth century rejected such appeals to essential truth as an ideological practice, which masked the function of social conventions that sustained class and gender oppression. Hardy, they argued, sought to unmask it. Central to these conventions was the Victorian ideal of womanliness, which trapped the female sex in the role of wife and mother.

Penny Boumelha suggested that *Jude the Obscure* offers women alternative measures to protect them against the harmful consequences of their natural fecundity, such as celibacy, abortion or independent employment. No alternative, however, is endorsed by the narrator in Hardy's problem novel. Patricia Ingham went further. For her, Hardy was struggling towards beliefs subversive of society.¹⁹

John Goode gave support to these feminist critics from the perspective of revolutionary criticism. Jude and Sue's ideals are baffled in the end, because there is no place for them in a capitalist economy. Hardy, however, reveals this by the Brechtian technique he employs in this theatrical series of seemings. The ending of the novel distances the reader from the performance and releases him/her from illusion. As audience at the spectacle of Christminster (the Christminster of bump boat racing, clashing classes and rotting culture), we are inspired to collective revolt. This hope, not the suffering of a superior individual, is Hardy's substitute for catharsis.²⁰

There is much to be learned from these approaches to *Jude*, but it is surely wide of the mark to recruit Hardy for any idea of revolution which involves the subversion of a whole power structure by class or gender

struggle. Hardy, as this study has emphasised, thought of revolution as a long process of gradual reconstruction, to be achieved by individual experiments, leading to discussion and consensus. As I have attempted to show, he entertained no utopian vision of Communism. Rather he was, as he said, a meliorist, and we should take his self-identification seriously when interpreting his fiction. In ending this chapter, therefore, I wish to clarify the melioristic content in *Jude the Obscure*. I propose to attempt this by returning to Drysdale's *Elements* and setting *Jude* in the context of recent historical writing on the 'long sexual revolution'.

Drysdale, as we have seen, wanted to abolish marriage law completely. Nevertheless, his *Elements* contained a prescription for emancipating all couples from the pains and penalties of child bearing. The key to this was the limitation of family size by the practice of contraceptive methods. Over a long stretch of time, this idea would produce a sexual revolution, in which feminine wisdom turned to preventive intercourse. But in Hardy's day, and for decades thereafter, feminine wisdom reacted differently.

This different response is highly relevant to the novel. As the feminist critics reviewed above pointed out, misery begins for Sue with her pregnancies. The family is already burdened by Jude's sickness and inability to work when the first occurs. When Father Time kills the children, she has three already and a fourth on the way. The precocious boy reproaches her in Drysdalian terms for failing to limit her family to three. "What!" he exclaims. "O God, mother, you've never a-sent for another; and such trouble with what you've got!" (421).

Sue's hesitating response not only breaches Drysdale's injunction to tell children frankly about sexual reproduction, but also suggests her own feelings of guilt at surrender to sexual instinct:

'Y-You must forgive me, little Jude!' she pleaded, her bosom heaving now as much as the boy's. 'I can't explain – I will when you are older. It does seem – as if I had done it on purpose, now we are in these difficulties! I can't explain, dear! But I – it is not quite on purpose – *I can't help it!*' (421; italics added)

If, with John Goode, we dismiss Hardy's claims for *Jude* as tragedy, seeing the killing of the children as little more than an imitation of sensational journalism, we have to overlook its moment of tragic recognition. Hardy thinks that failure by Jude, Arabella and Sue to practise preventive intercourse has brought about the ruin:

The boy's face expressed the whole tale of their situation. On that little shape had converged all the inauspiciousness and shadow which had darkened the first union of Jude, and all the accidents, mistakes, fears, errors of the past. He was their nodal point, their focus, their expression in a single term. For the rashness of those parents he had grown, for their ill-assortment he had quaked, and for the misfortunes of these he had died. (425)

Jude the Obscure is not a tract for birth control, but the possibility of birth control is hinted at in more than one place in the novel. Why did Hardy introduce it? I suggest, to begin with, that he was responding to current debate, just as, in *Tess of the d'Urbervilles*, he responded to the 'social purity' brouhaha. At the time of writing the tragic novels, the birth-control question was rising to greater prominence. This fostered the interpretive community capable of decoding the issue behind these speeches. Not only did Drysdale's *Elements* sell in very large numbers after the Bradlaugh–Besant trial of 1877, it was joined by other highly successful publications: Annie Besant's own *Law of Population* (1884), which sold 175,000 copies by 1891, and Henry Arthur Albert's *The Wife's Handbook* (1886), with over 250,000 by 1900. Once again, juridical action gave prominence to the cause. Albert, a Leeds dermatologist, was attacked by his fellow professionals as 'a huxster and purveyor of salacious material' and struck off the register of the General Medical Council.²¹

Hardy would have taken note of reactions within the Church of England to these Neo-Malthusian publications. As Soloway has shown, for a few years after the Bradlaugh–Besant trial, the church maintained a wall of silence. This was broken in 1885, when the High Churchman Hon. Arthur Lyttelton, Master of Selwyn College, Cambridge, addressed the Junior Clergy Society of London on 'The Church and Neo-Malthusianism'. He favoured reduction of family size to relieve poverty in the slums, but, significantly, rejected use of contraceptive devices in favour of abstinence when the desirable family size was reached. This soon became the limit of church toleration for parish priests who advised the poor on these matters. When Arthur E. Watham, a priest in a London slum parish, spoke up for the new contraceptive methods and described sexual intercourse as a 'pleasant and lawful' gratification of 'sensuous desire', he was driven out of office by his bishop, who was Frederick Temple of *Essays and Reviews*.²²

Abstinence, then, and not contraception was to remain the recommendation of the church well into the twentieth century. Hardy referred

obliquely to this obscurantism when he commented on Jude's inability at Christminster to see that 'Other developments were shaping in the world around him, in which Gothic architecture and its associations had no place. The deadly animosity of contemporary logic and vision towards so much of what he held in reverence was not yet revealed' (101).

Behind this lay the sense that Victorian religion was sorely in need of reconstruction on Drysdalean lines, and it gives amplified meaning to Hardy's Esdras epigraph. As we saw in [Chapter 13](#), he had not given up on the British empire as a force for progress in world history. Sue's kind of feminine wisdom – the wisdom of voluntary union – might yet prevail if promoted by the imperial government, possibly by Conservatives who 'will often do . . . more extreme acts of democratism or broad-mindedness than Radicals'.²³

The kind of act Hardy may have had in mind was abolition of the law of illegitimacy. This was advocated by a new pressure group, the Legitimation League, set up in 1893.²⁴ Launching its journal, *The Adult*, the League wrote to Hardy, among other celebrities, canvassing his support for the measure. Although Hardy replied cautiously that as a novelist he could not take sides on contentious public issues, the communication confirms the impression recorded in *Life and Work* that his fiction was stirring up fierce disputation.

Hardy's further thoughts in this direction were indicated in 1906 by his now often-quoted letter to Millicent Fawcett:

I have for a long time been in favour of woman-suffrage – I fear I shall spoil the effect of this information (if it has any) in my next sentence by giving you my reasons. I am in favour of it because I think the tendency of the woman's vote will be to break up the present pernicious conventions in respect of manners, customs, religion, illegitimacy, the stereotype household (that it must be the unit of society), the father of a woman's child (that it is anybody's business but the woman's own, except in cases of disease or insanity).²⁵

Nothing like this happened in British society during Hardy's lifetime, because feminine wisdom took a different course. As historians of 'the long sexual revolution' have shown,²⁶ modern birth control had relatively few practitioners among married couples in the 1880s, 1890s and for at least a decade thereafter. True, the 'fertility rate' – the average number of babies born per woman of child-bearing age²⁷ – declined steadily over that time. This was brought about not by late nineteenth-century

contraceptive techniques, but by practices of abstinence adopted early in the century: withdrawal; restricted frequency of sexual intercourse; or cessation altogether after the desired family size was achieved.²⁸ Husbands were persuaded to accept these practices by wives in revolt against the risks of repeated pregnancy.

Mainstream feminists like Millicent Fawcett reflected this tendency. They did not object to family limitation, but many were put off the use of birth-control devices, pushed by propaganda which they saw as salacious, dangerous to health and subjugating women to men's carnal desires.²⁹

Imperialists helped to foster this trend. During and after the South African war, they deplored the evidence of fertility decline on the ground that Britain needed manpower in times of intense international rivalry. In the years before and during the First World War, however, many accepted that the decline was inevitable. They thus came to support family limitation, though not birth control, because it would improve the health of mothers and infants, producing the fitter soldiers the empire needed.

Here, then, was the complex of issues – war, empire, class, religion, sexual freedom and feminine wisdom – which Hardy brought together in his final tragic representation of the late-manhood crisis of English civilisation. But his gospel of the body fell on stony ground. Feminine wisdom as a whole championed social purity and resisted birth control as a revolutionary practice likely in the long run to dissolve the bonds of marriage.

This, I conclude, brings us to the significance of Hardy's fiction, alike for history and for historical writing. In his time and long afterwards, literary critics resisted the idea that social questions – such as attitudes to marriage, divorce, illegitimacy, free love and birth control – were fit matter for tragedy. They clung to classical theory, which held that these were too mundane for tragic treatment. The tragic protagonist, so the argument ran, must be an individual of exceptional nobility – that is, of great 'religious moral value' – brought low by immutable law, not social law, which can be modified by human agency. Around 1890 Hardy, like Ibsen, began to take tragedy beyond the classical rules. As his essays on fiction suggest, he broke with them because he understood that the lives of countless ordinary men and women were blighted by 'crookedness, custom and fear'. As Hardy saw it, 'custom' included the laws and conventions of love and marriage which, given Victorian institutions, were as implacable in effect as the laws of matter. Jude and Sue know that, whatever the ultimate future of humanity, they are trapped in a time warp. Hardy was an avant-garde

novelist who could realise the potential tragedies of this situation. It is only in the last generation that historians and literary critics, recognising not Minerva's owl at dusk so much as Shelley's lark at dawn, have shown the pain and suffering which opposition to birth control caused to countless women and men in Britain and the west, and the relief which reform brought to the predicaments of love. In many parts of the world the struggle continues. That is one reason why Hardy's fiction still confronts wedding guests with the question: do things have to be like this?

His fiction, we should remind ourselves in closing, had explored the other human passions which strangled the tender tree of liberty – war, imperialism, luxury, outmoded religion – and fearlessly confronted the frustration and rage which ordinary people felt. Faced with the outcry of classically educated critics against *Jude the Obscure*, however, he gave up writing the kind of novel that honestly portrayed life. Yet he did not fall silent or abandon his idea of meliorism, as his last word on history makes clear.

NOTES

1. J. Engell and W. J. Bate (eds), *The Collected Works of Samuel Taylor Coleridge*, VI: *Biographia Literaria or Biographical Sketches of My Literary Life and Opinions* (London, 1993), pp. 48f.
2. All three articles have been reproduced several times, most recently in M. Millgate (ed.), *Thomas Hardy's Public Voice: The Essays, Speeches, and Miscellaneous Prose* (Oxford, 2001), pp. 75–88, 96–104, 106–110.
3. *Far from the Madding Crowd*, p. 384.
4. E. J. Bristow, *Vice and Vigilance: Purity Movements in Britain since 1700* (London, 1977), pp. 5, 30ff.
5. Bristow, *Vice and Vigilance*, p. 127.
6. Drysdale, *Elements*, p. 77.
7. *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, Act I, Sc. 2.
8. My copy of *Thomas Hardy's Works*, VIII: *Jude the Obscure* (London, Osgood, McIlvaine and Co.) is dated 1896.
9. *The Holy Bible* (King James Version) 1Esdr., IV, 26–27 and 32.
10. 1Esdr. IV.
11. As suggested by Patricia Ingham in her introduction to *Jude the Obscure* (Oxford, 2002), p. 403, n. 76.
12. The concept is Dugald Stewart's. See his *Elements of the Philosophy of the Human Mind* (1792). For a thorough account of Stewart's influence on the Oxford Noetics, see P. Corsi, *Science and Religion: Baden Powell and the Anglican Debate, 1800–1860* (Cambridge, 1988), pp. 83–142. No

'worthies' are named in *Jude*, but Hardy identified them in a letter to Florence Henniker. See Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, II, p. 95.

13. Is it an accident that she is given the same name as the wife of the Roman Emperor Caligula?
14. E. D. McDonald (ed.), *The Posthumous Papers of D. H. Lawrence* (London, 1967), p. 509. See also Millgate, *Career*, p. 320.
15. *Jude the Obscure*, epigraph to Part Fifth.
16. Mill, *On Liberty*. See Ch. 15 above.
17. Millgate, *Career* (London, 1971), p. 324.
18. D. Kramer, *Thomas Hardy: The Forms of Tragedy* (Detroit, U.S.A., 1975), p. 162.
19. Ingham, introduction to *Jude the Obscure*, p. xxi.
20. Goode, *Offensive Truth*, pp. 138–166.
21. R. A. Soloway, *Birth Control and the Population Question in England, 1877–1930* (London, 1982), p. 57.
22. Soloway, *Birth Control*, pp. 90, 92, 94.
23. Hardy, *Early Years*, p. 294.
24. For the Legitimation League, see Benn, *Predicaments of Love*, pp. 154–159. For Hardy's response see *The Adult*, Vol. 1, No. 1, Aug. 1897.
25. Millgate (ed.), *Collected Letters*, III, p. 238.
26. H. Cook, *The Long Sexual Revolution: English Women, Sex and Contraception, 1800–1975* (Oxford, 2004).
27. For this definition and its significance, see Cook, *Long Sexual Revolution*, p. 14.
28. Cook. *Long Sexual Revolution*, pp. 15f, 90–121, 122–142.
29. Soloway, *Birth Control*, p. 134.

Last Word

The ‘Apology’ prefixed to *Late Lyrics and Earlier*, published in 1922,¹ is Hardy’s last word on the melioristic philosophy of history that guided him all his life. It demonstrates the survival in his thought of the Liberal Anglican substratum, with its overlay of natural religion and experimental social science.

He begins by noting that he has often been attacked by Christians for his ‘pessimism’ and anticipates the same response to this volume of poems (52). Getting his retaliation in first, so to speak, he insists once again that he is not a pessimist but a meliorist. The charge of pessimism arises, he infers, from his frequently expressed scepticism about Christian dogma. His defence appeals to his own, and George Drysdale’s, alternative gospel, the gospel of the body. Questioning Christian optimism about the human condition is, he claims, ‘the first step towards the soul’s betterment, and the body’s also’ (52).

‘If way to the better there be’, Hardy continues, quoting himself, ‘it exacts a full look at the worst’ (52.) What he now means by ‘the worst’ is the ‘crisis’ of poetry, which is the chief sign of the fallen condition of postwar civilisation. He proceeds to analyse its causes in terms recognisable from Coleridge, Wordsworth and the Liberal Anglican historians. As Hardy puts it, ‘We seem threatened with a new dark age’: the ‘barbarising of taste in the younger minds by the dark madness of the late war’; the ‘unabashed cultivation of selfishness in all classes’; the ‘growth of knowledge simultaneously with the stunting of wisdom’; and ‘a degrading thirst after outrageous stimulation’ (56). Thus the return to barbarism predicted

by the cyclical idea of history has come to 'our prematurely afflicted century' (52).

Continuing in this Liberal Anglican vein, Hardy looks to a new accommodation between science and religion as the remedy for the crisis. As Coleridge had stressed in *Biographia Literaria*, poetry has a vital role to play in bringing this about. It should express the religious emotion of its age in terms of its most advanced philosophical speculation. As Hardy puts it: 'poetry, pure literature in general and religion... are... often but different names for the same thing'. Perhaps thinking of Bagehot, he calls them 'the visible signs of mental and emotional life' (56f).

The emotion Hardy wishes to uphold is loving-kindness. Modern poetry will represent, as Hardy sees it, the 'becoming' of such a spirit of love, 'even though at present... men's minds appear... to be moving backward rather than on' (57).

In the nineteenth century, Hardy recalls, he thought he had found such a scientific philosophy of history (Coleridge's 'logosophia') in the Positivism of Auguste Comte. But now his saying that 'advance is never in a straight line, but in a looped orbit' (58) seems no more than a forlorn hope, certainly not a prophesy.

Yet if the old-style teleology is dead, Hardy the meliorist insists that is no reason to abandon hope of a new science as a means to social betterment. He refers here to 'evolutionary meliorism'. His verse drama, *The Dynasts*, had raised the possibility that the 'immanent will' or unconscious mind of humankind might evolve to replace egotism by altruism.² It had been the great point of *Life and Work* to defend *The Dynasts* and, as Hardy puts it here, it is still legitimate to enquire how far 'evolutionary meliorism' is possible, so that pain to all living beings will be minimised 'by loving-kindness, operating through scientific knowledge, and actuated by the modicum of free will conjecturally possessed by organic life when the mighty necessitating forces – unconscious or otherwise... happen to be in equilibrium, which may or may not be often' (53).

This was not a deterministic view of history without any function for human agency. *Life and Work*, together with Hardy's published correspondence, reveals that by 'science' he still meant physiology and Millite experiments in social engineering. This is indicated by the friendship he established with the new champion of birth control, Marie Stopes,³ and by his willingness to participate in tribunals to limit food-price increases during the First World War.⁴ Drysdale's twin demands for love and food as the foundation of human happiness were still active in his approach to meliorism.

Hardy's 'Apology', then, demonstrates his continued belief in meliorism, to be promoted by an accommodation between science and altruism. It is also evidence that he derived this hope from the Liberal Anglican substratum in his thought, surviving from the days when he and Horace Moule walked and talked in the fields around Dorchester. That he was thinking of Moule when he wrote the 'Apology' is indicated by the conclusion of his meditation: 'Physical, chronological, and other contingencies keep me in these days from critical studies and literary circles where once we held debate, a band of youthful friends, on mind and art' (57).

The reference to youthful friends is an allusion to Tennyson's 'In Memoriam'. For Hardy, that poem was an emotionally charged reminder of Moule, for he read the Victorian poet's tribute to his dead friend Arthur Hallam soon after his own friend's suicide in 1875. His marked-up copy can still be consulted in Dorset County Museum. Tennyson was himself a follower of the Liberal Anglican historians, and 'In Memoriam' records his sense of an old era of religion dying and a new age of science opening around the time of Hallam's death at sea. The carefully coded reference here is a powerful testimony to the Liberal Anglican undercurrent in Hardy's mind, for which Horace Moule had been chiefly responsible. Thanks to his friend's influence, it had become, and remained, his 'idiosyncratic mode of regard'.

NOTES

1. H. Orel (ed.), Thomas *Hardy's Personal Writings* (London, 1967), pp. 50–58.
2. Keen, *Hardy's Brains*, pp. 164ff.
3. Thomas Hardy to Marie Stopes, 16 Apr. 1926, *Collected Letters*, VII, pp. 16–167.
4. *Life and Work*, p. 417. On the same page, along with his price tribunal work, Hardy mentions his long-standing friendship with Henry Meyers Hyndman, former revolutionary turned advocate of government intervention to regulate the wartime economy.

FURTHER READING

(In the notes at the end of each chapter, full citation is supplied for published and unpublished sources consulted. These are not repeated in the following list, which refers to works that I have found helpful for a wider understanding of Hardy criticism and the history of Victorian Britain. As in the notes, place of publication is in the United Kingdom unless otherwise indicated.)

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